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Introduction - Background and Battleground

Over centuries, the **Bhagavad Gita** has been considered an important spiritual guidebook and has influenced many thought leaders in human history. The **Gita** is a conversational poem and is part of the great Indian epic the **Mahabharata**, which is a story about the families of two brothers who inherit a kingdom from their father. These cousins are known as the 'Pandavas' and the 'Kauravas'. The Kaurava brothers are 100 in number and the Pandavas are 5. The Kauravas, not wanting to share the kingdom with their cousins, invite them to a game of dice. They use dubious means to defeat the Pandavas and annex their kingdom after winning the wager. As per the rules of the wager, the Pandavas complete their stay outside the kingdom and come back to ask for their fair share of the kingdom so that they can rule with dignity. The Kauravas refuse to honor the agreement and even deny the Pandavas a settlement of 5 villages so that they can live in peace. As the Kauravas refuse to budge even an inch, the Pandavas have no choice but to declare war on them to get back their share of the kingdom. During this period, The Lord who has incarnated as Krishna offers the cousins a choice between His army and Himself. But He makes it clear that He Himself would not be participating in the war. The Kauravas choose His army as Krishna would not be fighting, and the Pandavas are happy to just have Krishna on their side. Krishna takes on the role of charioteer to Arjuna's chariot (Arjuna is the third brother among the five Pandavas).

Before the war starts, the two armies assemble on the battlefield, facing each other. At this point, Arjuna requests Krishna to place his chariot in the middle so that he can get a full view of the warring forces. Since this is a war between cousins, Arjuna sees his cousins, uncles, grandfathers, great grandfathers, nephews, friends, classmates etc. on both sides. He is overcome with emotion and grief at the prospect of bloodshed among his family and friends for the sake of a kingdom. He declares his intention to renounce the war and let the Kauravas keep the kingdom, thus

abdicating his responsibility as a prince and a warrior. It is at this stage that Krishna teaches him the **Gita** which is structured as a series of questions from Arjuna and answers from Krishna. Krishna extols the virtue of performing one's duties regardless of the outcome, and not avoiding prescribed duties which may be difficult and unpleasant. As Krishna starts to talk to Arjuna on the virtues of doing one's work (in this case Arjuna needing to fight a rightful war), Arjuna asks a series of questions on the bigger issues of life, individual souls, the Lord Almighty, the universe, the circle of life etc., for which Krishna provides clear, unambiguous answers. He finally convinces Arjuna that his fears were unfounded and that he should fight to free the Kingdom from the Kauravas and provide a just and compassionate administration to his citizens.

At first a battleground is hardly the place for someone to be preaching philosophy. However, many of the questions that we have in life are about the choices we have to make, especially in challenging times. It is interesting to note that Sanskrit verses lend themselves to multiple meanings and in one interpretation, the battleground in the **Gita** is compared to the human body (and mind), and the battle between the Pandavas and the Kauravas is compared to the constant strife between good and evil thoughts that we encounter daily. The **Gita** is indeed a teaching for all of us, with Arjuna acting as an example of an individual at crossroads, desperately looking for guidance and support.

The **Gita** is one of the most widely read and commented upon spiritual works in human history. There are several excellent books on it in various languages. Given that the original work is in Sanskrit, most of the scholarly commentaries have been in Sanskrit or other Indian languages which are closer to Sanskrit. To read and comprehend many of them, one would need some training in Indian spiritual studies, as many of them liberally use Sanskrit words albeit transliterated in English. It was felt that there is a need to present the key concepts of The **Gita** in plain English for everyday folk, minimizing the use of Sanskrit words. These observations led to the development of this manuscript.

While there are many learned commentaries on the **Gita** written over the centuries, this author has been greatly influenced by the authoritative commentary and lucid explanations of difficult concepts by Sri Madhwacharya, the 12th century ascetic who propounded the philosophy of dualistic theism (concept of difference between the almighty Lord and individual souls at all times and places). Sri Madhwacharya's commentary has been further elaborated and summarized by later day savants such as Sri Padmanabha Teertha (13th Century), Sri Jaya Teertha (13th Century) Sri Vadiraja Teertha (16th Century), Sri Raghavendra Teertha (17th century) and others.

The **Gita** consists of 18 chapters with a total of 701¹ verses in Sanskrit. The **Gita** is part of the great Hindu epic **The Mahabharata** and appears as Chapters 25 to 42, in the Book of Bheeshma in the **Mahabharata**. Most of the verses appear in the *anushtap* meter, where each verse has a total of 32 letters with 8 words in each of the four quadrants. Some verses in the 15th chapter appear in *trishtup* meter with 44 words. As per Sri Raghavendra Teertha [GV], the 18 chapters can be broadly classified into 3 sections with 6 chapters in each section. The first section with chapters 1-6 (280 verses) broadly outlines how one can obtain divine, spiritual knowledge (*jnana upaya*), the second section with chapters 7-12 (209 verses) focuses on devotion and divine, spiritual knowledge (*vijnana*) that leads one to liberation, and the third section consisting of chapters 13-18 (212 verses) elaborates on the concepts in the first two sections. It is also believed that the **Gita** conveys at least 10 different meanings, all of which are consistent with one another. An illustration of multiple meanings in the **Gita** will appear in Chapter 2. It is also said that the **Gita** has 3 major interpretations – historical, psychological, and spiritual.

¹ Some texts of Gita indicate a total of 700 verses (omitting the first verse attributed to Arjuna in Chapter 13)

The Gita and the Number 18

Numbers and numerology play an incredibly significant role in Indian theology. In fact, the study of knowledge is termed '*Sankhya Yoga*', with *Sankhya* meaning 'arithmetic'. The world around us is based on numbers. We are constantly measuring, managing, quantifying all our activities with the aid of numbers. We wake up at a certain time, we work/study for certain hours, we travel a certain distance, we consume some amount of food, we transact with certain currency, we perform activities at a certain time, on a certain day, in a certain month, in a certain year etc. And all these numbers and calculations are based on the position and movement of celestial objects such as the Sun, Moon, stars etc.

The number 18 is very special in the **Gita**. Note that every letter has a numerical equivalent based on the position of that letter in the Sanskrit alphabet which has 16 vowels, 25 consonants and 10 semi vowels. Let us review the numerical equivalent for the word '*jaya*' (meaning victory) which is made up of the letters *ja* (consonant in the 8th position) and *ya* (1st semi vowel). Applying the grammatical rule of reading the numerical representations in reverse order, the word '*jaya*' is represented by number 18. *Jaya* which means victory, signifies the triumph of good over evil as depicted in the **Gita** and its parent epic, **The Mahabharata**. Now let us review the significance of number 18 in the **Gita** with the following facts [SBG]-

1. The **Gita** has 18 chapters.
2. The **Mahabharata** of which the **Gita** is a part, has 18 volumes.
3. The great war of the **Mahabharata** which was the backdrop for the **Gita** was fought over 18 days.
4. The armies consisted of 18 regiments with the Kauravas at 11 and the Pandavas at 7

5. Each regiment consisted of 21870 elephants, 21870 chariots, 65610 horses and 109350 soldiers. Each of these numbers sum up to 18. For example, in case of 21870, $2+1+8+7+0 = 18$
6. Duryodhana in his review of the Pandava army names 18 main leaders
7. Sanjaya names the 18 conches sounded by the 18 Pandava leaders.
8. In the **Gita** chapter 10, the Lord describes His divine manifestation (*Vibhuti Roopa*) in 18 verses (10.21 to 10.38)
9. The Lord Almighty's omnipresence in the universe is described via His 18 forms starting with Hamsa, in **Katha Upanishad** (2.2.2), which is the basis for many concepts in the **Gita**.

Overview of Gita Chapters

The **Gita** has 18 chapters, each of which focusses on a specific topic and at the same time builds upon the topics covered in previous chapters. An enumeration of the chapters and a brief description of the contents of each chapter are as follows:

Section 1: The Path to Divine Knowledge, Chapters 1 – 6 (280 verses)

Chapter 1 (47 verses) - *Arjuna Vishada Yoga* (Arjuna's Distress): This chapter sets the stage for the **Gita**. The two armies of cousins, the Pandavas and the Kauravas were assembled in Kurukshetra, ready to start the war. The proceedings in the war were narrated by Sanjaya, an aide to the blind king Dhritarashtra, father of the Kaurava brothers. Before the start of the war, Arjuna looks at both the armies and realizes that on both sides were many of his near and dear ones such as teachers, cousins, uncles, nephews etc. He develops cold feet at the thought of bloodshed between them. He wonders if he is doing the right thing by waging this war as it would not only lead to bloodshed but also result in

societal degradation. He advances many arguments as to why he should avoid this war and find some other way to lead his life. At the end of this chapter, Arjuna who is grief stricken, is seen sitting still in his chariot after dropping his weapons, confused as to the way forward.

Chapter 2 (72 verses) - *Sankhya Yoga* (The Path of Doctrines): In this chapter, the Lord answers Arjuna's basic questions about the purpose of life and related philosophical concepts. Sensing that Arjuna's reservations about fighting the war were due to his fear of losing his loved ones, the Lord delves into the nature of individual souls, the indestructibility of souls, the relationship between individual souls and the Lord Almighty etc., to remind Arjuna that the Lord gave human forms to individual souls to help them in their spiritual journey, and everyone must play their dutiful role in society. The Lord urges Arjuna not to despair over the hurt that may be caused to his loved ones in the war, as they had taken the side of the evil king Duryodhana. Arjuna had an obligation to fight the just war to protect his citizens. Lord Krishna teaches Arjuna to focus on performing his prescribed duty of protecting his citizens as an offering to Him and not let his emotions come in the way. Chapter 2 can be considered a summary of the entire **Gita** as it answers Arjuna's (and through Arjuna, everyone's) basic questions about the purpose of life. The remaining chapters serve to expand on the concepts presented in this chapter.

Chapter 3 (43 verses) - *Karma Yoga* (The Path of Action): In this chapter, the Lord answers Arjuna's questions regarding the paths of duty (*karma*) and knowledge (*jnana*). Arjuna wonders if there is a way, he could focus on acquiring knowledge and traverse the path of knowledge (*jnana*) avoiding this dreadful war. The Lord logically answers Arjuna's doubts to convince him that everyone has an obligation to perform their duties to society and as a prince, it was his responsibility to fight the just war to protect his citizens. To perform one's duty, one also needs to be equipped with knowledge and in that sense, one needs to incorporate both *karma* and *jnana* in one's spiritual journey. Based on one's innate

nature, some may be prescribed a path that is dominant in action, and others may be prescribed a path dominant in knowledge. This chapter also has an excellent discussion on the Cyclic Order of the Universe.

Chapter 4 (42 verses) - *Jnana Yoga* (Wisdom in Action): This chapter is predominantly about the spiritual knowledge that a seeker will need to perform prescribed action (*karma*). Knowledge regarding the individual souls, various deities and the attributes of the Lord are explained to instill devotion in a seeker. The Lord explains that He incarnates in this world from time to time to establish virtue and vanquish immorality. Knowledge about the various types of actions – right action, wrong action and non-action are also covered here.

Chapter 5 (29 verses) - *Sanyasa Yoga* (The Path of Renunciation): Renunciation of rewards from actions is termed *sanyasa* and performing prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord is termed *yoga* (action). In this chapter, the Lord answers Arjuna's questions on some fundamental aspects of the two concepts of *sanyasa* and *yoga*. Arjuna's argument was that if renunciation were a better option than action, he could perhaps adopt the life of an ascetic and avoid waging the war. The Lord however describes the characteristics of a renunciant and clarifies that one must incorporate both these paths to achieve self-realization. The Lord reiterates that Arjuna must focus on performing his prescribed duty of waging war to protect his citizens from the evil Kauravas. This chapter also delves into the importance of detachment and self-control.

Chapter 6 (47 verses) – *Atma Samyama Yoga* (The Path of Self Restraint) or *Dhyana Yoga* (The Path of Meditation): *Yoga* (or action) has two components – external and internal. The external component refers to actions performed as part of one's prescribed duties which would be visible to others. The internal component refers to *dhyana* (or meditation). This chapter has a detailed discussion of *dhyana yoga*. Characteristics of a true *yogi* are described. The physical aspect of meditation such as place, physical pose, breath control etc., are also

described. Requirements for moderation in consumption are also discussed. To a question from Arjuna regarding the condition of those who make a sincere attempt but are not able to successfully implement *karma* and *dhyana*, the Lord teaches that no sincere effort is a waste, and such seekers will get additional opportunities to complete their spiritual journey.

Section 2: Divine, Spiritual Knowledge, Chapters 7 – 12 (209 verses)

Chapter 7 (30 verses) - *Jnana Vijnana Yoga* (The Path of Knowledge and Wisdom): The first 6 chapters were broadly concerned with descriptions of the methods and procedures (both external and internal) to acquire divine, spiritual knowledge. The next 6 chapters describe in more detail such divine, spiritual knowledge about the Lord Almighty, which forms the principle message of the **Gita**. In earlier chapters 2 – 6, there were some discussions on the Lord's attributes which were included contextually, but the next 6 chapters provide more exclusive details about the Lord's attributes. Chapter 7 provides a detailed discussion of the two types of knowledge – indirect (ordinary knowledge) and direct (special knowledge or wisdom). Indirect knowledge (*jnana*) is that knowledge that is gained from scriptural studies and through teachers. Direct knowledge (*vijnana*) is specialized knowledge about the Lord that one obtains after self-realization. The Lord describes His ownership of everything in the universe and stresses that He is responsible for even the intrinsic attributes of objects. The causes of ignorance, the influence of *maya* (delusion) on living beings, and procedures to overcome *maya* are also discussed. The various types of seekers who are devoted to the Lord are identified. This chapter ends with the Lord stating that one who has proper knowledge about *Adhiyajna* (Lord of Sacrifice) and *Adhyatma* (Prime Self), along with that of *Adhibhoota* (Prime Material) and *Adhidaiva* (Prime Deities), and who thinks of Him during the last moments will eventually reach Him.

Chapter 8 (28 verses) - *Akshara Brahma Yoga* (The Imperishable Lord): This chapter starts with Arjuna asking Krishna 8 questions about the topics indicated towards the end of the previous chapter. Arjuna also enquires about the need for and advantages of remembering the Lord during one's last moments. This chapter also details the journey of a soul after leaving the physical body.

Chapter 9 (34 verses) - *Raja Vidya, Raja Guhya Yoga* (Path of Supreme Knowledge and Supreme Secrets): This chapter continues with the description of some of the important and subtle attributes and activities of the Lord. In that sense, it is Supreme knowledge that is taught here. The Lord uses the term 'secretive' to arouse curiosity in Arjuna (and everyone else). While the Lord has infinite auspicious forms, attributes, activities etc., there are eight activities of the Lord that directly impact living beings. They are – creation (*Srishti*), sustenance (*Stithi*), dissolution (*laya*), regulation (*niyamana*), knowledge (*jnana*), ignorance (*ajnana*), bondage (*bandha*) and liberation (*moksha*). Together they are called *Janmadi ashtaka* and they are also covered in this chapter.

Chapter 10 (42 verses) - *Vibhooti Yoga* (Divine Manifestations): No one can fully comprehend the Lord's infinite, auspicious attributes. The Lord, who is responsible for the creation, sustenance and dissolution of the universe, powers everyone and everything. The Lord answers Arjuna's questions about His manifestations and presence in superior entities. The Lord's special presence among both sentient beings (such as various deities, animals) and inert objects (such as mountains, rivers, stars, weapons) bestows superiority on these entities. Divine manifestations are of two types – direct, where the Lord incarnates in different forms such as Rama, Krishna, Vedavyasa etc., and intrinsic, where the Lord's special presence in some objects gives them superiority over other objects (ex: Meru's superiority among mountains, Ganges's superiority among rivers).

Chapter 11 (55 verses) - *Vishwa Roopa Darshanam* (The Lord's Universal Form): Arjuna, after learning about the Lord's innumerable manifestations, requests the Lord to allow him to see His Universal form and is granted divine vision by Him. Arjuna sees the Lord having the brightness of thousands of suns, pervading the entire world with infinite limbs, faces with no beginning or end etc. The Lord's infinite forms are as real as the universe. This chapter also has a soulful prayer by Arjuna on seeing the Lord's universal form. While the Lord had previously taught Arjuna about His greatness and attributes, the act of physically seeing the Lord's universal form completely solidifies Arjuna's faith in Sri Krishna's teachings.

Chapter 12 (20 verses) - *Bhakti Yoga* (The Path of Devotion): The Lord answers Arjuna's questions comparing the worship of Goddess Mahalakshmi and that of the Lord Almighty Narayana. Worshipping Lord Narayana is an easier way to attain *moksha*, while pleasing Mahalakshmi is difficult. Further, Sri Lakshmi operates under the Lord's control. One should propitiate Sri Lakshmi and other deities that are part of the Lord's entourage for maximum effect. *Bhakti* or devotion is focusing one's mind on the Lord. The Lord teaches other ways of devotion using facilities such as intellect, studying scriptures, performing prescribed duties etc. The last 8 verses describe the characteristics of an ideal devotee who is dear to the Lord.

Section 3: Reiteration of Concepts in Sections 1 and 2, Chapters 13 – 18 (212 verses)

Chapter 13 (35 verses) - *Kshetra Kshetrajna Yoga* (The Field and the Knower of the Field): The first section covers the tools and utilities to acquire Divine knowledge which itself was covered in detail in the second section. This third section expands on some of the critical issues briefly covered in the first two sections. In chapter 7, verse (7.4), the Lord briefly speaks about eight-fold nature which operates under His command and control. This chapter details that field or theatre of

operations and the one who knows them. The interaction between the components of nature (sentient and inert) and living beings are also discussed.

Chapter 14 (27 verses) - *Gunatraya Vibhaga Yoga* (Division of Qualities): This chapter has details on the three qualities of nature (*sattv* – piety, *rajas* – passion, *tamas* – ignorance) which define one's personality. These concepts were introduced in chapter 3 (3.5) and are expanded here. Creation of the universe through sentient Mother Nature is described. The ways in which the three qualities bind a person are also explained. The methods to escape from the clutches of the three qualities are described.

Chapter 15 (20 verses) - *Purushottama Yoga* (Theology of the Supreme Being): This chapter is considered by many to have the core teachings of the **Gita**. The **Bhagavad Gita** has 700 verses spread among 18 chapters. Interestingly, this chapter which has 20 verses has 700 letters (15 verses have 32 letters each and the remaining 5 verses have 44 letters each)! This gives credence to this chapter's importance based on numerology. While the Lord had previously described the components of the universe such as living beings, inert objects, and the Lord Almighty, in this chapter the Lord illustrates the interrelations among them using the example of a banyan tree. In verse 15, the Lord explicitly states His presence in everyone and declares that He is the primary subject matter of the **Vedas**. In verses 16-20, the Lord emphatically describes Himself as the Supreme Being intrinsically different from all other beings, thereby convincingly establishing the philosophy of dualism (*dvaita*) which was propagated by Sri Madhwacharya.

Chapter 16 (24 verses) - *Daivasura Sampat Vibhaga Yoga* (The Divine and the Demoniak Nature): This chapter delves deep into the types of human nature. In the previous chapters, there were many references to pious and virtuous people with divine nature and to people with demoniak nature. This chapter provides more details on human traits.

These traits typically are intrinsic to an individual. One cannot judge people based on external appearance, position in society etc. The personality traits of people with divine nature and those with demoniac nature are described in detail.

Chapter 17 (28 verses) - *Shraddhatraya Vibhaga Yoga* (The Threefold Faith): In the previous chapters, especially chapter 14, the nature of individuals influenced by the qualities of *sattv*, *rajas*, *tamas* were stated a number of times. This chapter has more details on the concept of threefold faith with detailed discussion on the impact of these qualities on various issues such as faith, food habits, sacrificial rituals, charitable giving, meditation etc.

Chapter 18 (78 verses) - *Mokshasanyasa Yoga* (Liberation and Renunciation): This chapter starts with a discussion on the subtle differences between renunciation (*sanyasa*) and relinquishment of the rewards of labour (*tyaga*). The types of rewards from actions are also discussed. The five prerequisites required for performing activity are identified. Different types of knowledge, action, doers, intellect, determination, and happiness are also discussed. Additional details on the four societal categories of people are provided (this was briefly indicated in (4.13)). The concept of liberation (*moksha*) is discussed in detail in this chapter. The first 55 verses contain a discussion on the topics identified so far. The Lord concludes His sermon in the next 17 verses. Arjuna responds to Lord Krishna's teachings in verse 73. Sanjaya, who has been describing the proceedings of the war and the Lord's glorious expounding of *dharma* (The **Gita**) to Arjuna, euphorically concludes his commentary in the following 5 verses.

Organization of the Book

This book is primarily based on the interpretation of the **Gita** by Sri Raghavendra Swamy (Sri Rayaru) in his pioneering work, **Gita Vivruti**. Vivruti means 'explanation' and in the **Gita Vivruti**, Sri Rayaru has consolidated unique interpretations on the **Gita** by Sri Madhwacharya (in

his works **Gita Bhashya**, **Gita Tatparya Nirnaya**) and commentaries on these two works by Sri Jaya Teertha (**Prameya Deepika** and **Nyaya Deepika**). **Gita Bhashya** is the very first work of Sri Madhwacharya, where he provided a unique interpretation of **the Gita**. In a subsequent work, **Gita Tatparya Nirnaya**, Sri Madhwacharya provides detailed arguments and the scriptural basis for many of the interpretations of **Gita Bhashya**.

This book has 18 main chapters with each chapter corresponding to the relevant chapter in the **Gita**. In each chapter, the book presents the original Sanskrit verse along with a simple translation in English. At the end of the original text, an explanation of key concepts covered in the chapter is provided, based on authentic commentaries on the **Gita** by Sri Raghavendra Teertha (Sri Rayaru) in his work **Gita Vivruti** and on lectures by Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha. At the end of each chapter, a summary of that chapter is provided. The summary section also refers to relevant verses in that chapter for clarity, and this section can be read ‘stand-alone’ by those readers who want a quick summary of the various chapters. It is hoped that the readers will find this version useful in better understanding the greatest psychological manual ever written – **The Bhagavad Gita**.

Sri Vishnu Teertha from Madinur, a great saint philosopher of the 18th century has identified one verse from each chapter of the **Gita** as a representation of the core tenets of that entire chapter in his work **Bhagavad Gita Saroddhara**. This was done to help devotees who wanted to chant the **Gita** everyday but could not chant all 700 verses. These core verses are highlighted in this book in italics.

This book has 3 annexures. The first annexure contains a section from the epic **Varaha Purana** which describes the glory of **The Gita** and is typically read after completing a reading of **the Gita**. The second annexure has a discussion on the philosophical interpretation of the **Gita** with a sample illustration. The third annexure is about the core tenets of the

philosophy of Sri Madhwacharya and the corresponding verses in the **Gita** that support these tenets.

The last section of this book identifies literature cited in this book. The principal references are the **Gita**, part of the great epic the **Mahabharata** and commentaries on the **Gita** by Sri Madhwacharya, Sri Jaya Teertha and Sri Raghavendra Teertha. The references are indicated by their initials within square brackets. For example, the **Gita Bhashya** is identified as [GB].

àW_@Ú`... - AOZ{dfX`J: Chapter 1 – Arjuna's Distress

‘ “b ûcH\$:

> Xd Zman¶U ZEdm gdXnf{dd{OV ‘ &
n[anU Jê\$íMmZ JrVWm dú¶{ ‘ bfV... &&

Benedictory Verse (Gita Bhashya) : Salutations to the Lord and teacher Narayana (Vedavyasa) who is revealed by the **Gita**. He is ever devoid of defects such as dependence and ignorance. He is not limited by time, space, and attributes. (Even though the **Gita** is full of many meanings, only a simple meaning is told here to aid general readers).

> लक्ष्मीZman¶U ZEdm nU^mYmZ Jê\$Z{n &
H\$_... I rH\$îUJrV¶m ^mî`mÚ°mWgJh_ &&

Benedictory Verse (Gita Vivruti) : After saluting Lord Narayana (consort of Lakshmi), Sri Madhwacharya, and other teachers, we are summarizing the concepts from **Gita Bhashya**, **Gita Tatparya Nirnaya** and related commentaries which offer a unique perspective on the **Bhagavad Gita** taught by Lord Sri Krishna.

Chapter Introduction: Sri Vedavyasa composed the great epic **Mahabharata** which contains all the essential teachings from the **Vedas**, and this allows even those who do not have access or eligibility to learn the **Vedas** to gain necessary knowledge to help them in their spiritual journey. The epic **Mahabharata** is spread over 18 volumes and the **Bhagavad Gita** (or **Gita**, in short), is part of *Bheeshma Parva* (or the Book of Bheeshma). The **Mahabharata** is compared to the divine flower *parijata*, and the **Gita** is like the nectar (or essence) of the flower. Sri Raghavendra Teertha (Sri Rayaru) has composed a unique commentary on the **Gita** titled, **Gita Vivruti** [GV] which is a summary of the two commentaries on the **Gita** by

Sri Madhwacharya namely, **Gita Bhashya** [GB] and **Gita Tatparya Nirnaya** [GTN]. The **Gita** has 701 verses spread over 18 chapters. Sri Rayaru has organized these 18 chapters into 3 sections of 6 chapters each. The first section (chapters 1-6) broadly describes the processes and prerequisites required to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge that one would need in one's spiritual journey. The second section (chapters 7-12) describes the nature of the divine, spiritual knowledge and the third section (chapters 13-18) expands on some of the key concepts covered in sections 1 and 2.

The Bhagavad Gita is a conversation between Arjuna, and Lord Krishna as narrated by Lord Vedavyasa in the epic, **Mahabharata**. The great war between the armies of the Kaurava and Pandava cousins, was witnessed by Sanjaya, the aide of the blind King Dhrutarashtra who was head of the Kaurava dynasty. Sanjaya rushes to Dhrutarashtra soon after the fall of Bheeshma, the commander of the Kaurava army [**Mahabharata**, Bheeshma Parva, Chapter 13]. The stunned Dhrutarashtra wants to know everything that happened on the battlefield from the very beginning. Sanjaya narrates all the events from the beginning of the war. He stays with the king till the end of the war relaying all the events to him. He can do this because Sage Vedavyasa grants him divine vision to remotely view the war and provide him with updates.

All 47 verses in the first chapter and the first 10 verses in the second chapter provide the background and context for Arjuna's apprehensions about the war, and Lord Krishna starts His sermon to Arjuna then onwards.

Dhrutarashtra starts by asking the following question to Sanjaya.

What did my Clan and the Pandavas do in Kurukshetra?

YVamĩ CdM Ĩ-

Y_j Ĩ H\$é j Ĩ g_dV Ĩ ``Ēgd... &

_m_H\$m... nmÉSdmüd {H\$_H\$dV gÄO` ĩ&& 1 &&

Dhrutarashtra said: O Sanjaya! Assembled at Kuru Kshetra, the designated land for committing righteous acts (Field of Righteousness), what did my clan of Kauravas and Pandavas do? (1.1)

Comments: The first verse in the **Gita** starts with King Dhrutarashtra asking the above question to his aide Sanjaya. The first word here is ‘*Dharma*’ which is one of the names of the Lord Almighty who shoulders (*dharana*) the universe. In that sense, the first verse also acts as a benedictory verse of the **Gita**.

The King begins by asking Sanjaya what happened between his clan (Kauravas) and the Pandavas in Kurukshetra which was known as *Dharma Kshetra* or the ‘Field of Righteousness’. This question reveals the King’s apprehensions. He was convinced that the Pandavas with the guidance of Lord Krishna would be invincible (but Krishna had sworn not to take up arms). On the other hand, Bheeshma was also known to be invincible and so the King hoped against hope that his sons would not be defeated in this war that was being fought in an area known as the ‘Field of Righteousness’. Hence, he was surprised to hear that Bheeshma had fallen.

Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha Swamiji in his work **Bhagavad Gita Saroddhara** [BGS] identifies this verse as the central piece of chapter 1. After all, chapter 1 sets the context for the entire **Gita**, and it starts with King Dhrutarashtra’s question. The theatre of war is our body, and the armies represent the angelic and demoniac forces inside each of us. The interaction between them is the context for the **Gita**.

Duryodhana’s Apprehension

gO`CdM -

ÑîQmV nÊSdmZrH\$ î`T> X`mYZñVXm ÿ&

AmM_ngJâ` amOm dMZ_~drV ÿ&& 2 ÿ&&

Sanjaya said: King Duryodhana, upon seeing the formation of the Pandavas' army, immediately rushed to his teacher Drona, and said as follows. (1.2)

Comments: Sanjaya answers Dhrutarashtra's question in the following 9 verses. Sri Sumateendra Teertha in his **Bhava Ratna Kosha** [BRK] draws attention to the use of the word 'tu' as implying Duryodhana's anxiety as soon as he saw the formidable Pandava army ('tu' is normally used to add emphasis). Hence, the Kaurava prince immediately rushes to his teacher Drona. It is interesting to note that Duryodhana approaches his teacher Drona and not the commander of the Kaurava forces, Bheeshma, to give him information about the Pandava army, perhaps to acknowledge the fact that many warriors in the Pandava army were Drona's students.

ní`Vm nmÊÊñîmUm\_mMm`_hVt M__Y&
ì`Tm ÐnXnìU Vd {eî`U Yr_Vm Y&& 3 Y&&

O My Teacher! Look at the formation of the mighty army of Pandavas which has been organized by your clever student Dhrushtadyumna, son of Drupada. (1.3)

Comments: Duryodhana reminds Drona that the formation of the Pandava army has been organized by Dhrushtadyumna, a brilliant warrior who learnt the art of warfare from Drona himself, implying that the Pandavas have a formidable army formation. Duryodhana also refers to the Pandavas' army as mighty, even though his own army was much bigger.

Aì eam_hîdmgm^r_mOZg_m`{Y Y&
`YmZm {damQü ÐnXü_hmaW... Y&& 4 Y&&

YîH\$Vü{H\$VmZ... H\$m{eamOü dr`dmZ Y&
né{OV H\$pvV^mOü eã`ü Zan`d... Y&& 5 &&

`Ym\_Ý`ü {dH\$nyV CÎm_mOmü dr`dmZ Ý&
gm^Ðm ÐmnX`mü gd Ed_hmaWm... Ý&& 6 &&

Possessing heavy weapons are the brave warriors Yuyudhana (Satyaki), Virata, and King Drupada, all *Maharathas*. They are as capable as Bheema and Arjuna. (1.4)

Other brave warriors include Drushtaketu, Chekitana, Kashiraja who are extraordinarily strong, Purujit, Kuntibhoja and Shybhya who are superior among men. (1.5)

Yudhamanyu, the brave warrior, Uttamowja, the strong warrior, Abhimanyu, son of Subhadra, and sons of Draupadi are also here. They too are *Maharathas*. (1.6)

Comments: Duryodhana recognizes and names 18 leaders from the Pandava army whom he considers as being comparable to Bheema and Arjuna in valor. They are – Dhrushtadyumna, Satyaki, Virata, Drupada, Drushtaketu, Chekitana, Kashiraja, Purujit, Kuntibhoja, Shybhya, Yudhamanyu, Uttamowja, Abhimanyu and the five sons of Draupadi (Parativindya, Sutasoma, Shrutakeerti, Shataneeka, Shrutakarma). These leaders were termed '*Maharathas*', meaning they were capable of single-handedly fighting 10,000 enemy soldiers. They were experts in the use of both types of weapons – *astra* and *shastra*. Here, *astra* refers to weapons such as arrows that are launched after praying and invoking a deity, and *shastra* refers to arrows that are launched without such invocation.

Interestingly, Duryodhana does not name Krishna who was charioteering Arjuna. This is perhaps due to Krishna's vow that He would not take up arms in the war. Duryodhana probably thought Krishna did not count if He was not fighting. A big miscalculation!

Añ_mH\$ V {d{eî'm ` VmZ {Z~mY {ÔOmîm_ ÿ&
Zm`H\$m \_\_ gÝ`ñ` gÄkmW VmZ ~dr{ V ÿ&& 7 &&

^dmZ ^rî_ü H\$Uü H\$nü g{qVÄO`... &
AœEWm_m {dH\$Uü gm_X{ÎmñVWd M ÿ&& 8 &&

AÝ` M ~hd... eam 'XW Ë`°\$Or{dVm... ÿ&
ZmZmeóàhaUm... gd `Õ{demaXm... ÿ&& 9 &&

O Drona! Superior among the wise men! Now I will enumerate the great warriors from our side. So, please listen with attention (1.7)

Our side includes yourself, Bheeshma, Karna, Krupa who has won many wars, Ashwatthama, Vikarna and Bhoorishravas, son of Somadatta. (1.8)

Along with them are many warriors ready to sacrifice their lives for my sake. They are all well versed in wars and are armed with heavy weapons. (1.9)

Comments: Duryodhana now names 7 leaders from his side. He indicates that they are all ready to sacrifice their lives for him. Duryodhana is looking at this war purely to justify holding onto the Pandavas' share of the kingdom and believes that everyone in his side is fighting to please him and not for any higher cause. It is interesting to note that while Duryodhana names 18 leaders from the Pandavas, he only rattles 7 names from his side. Further he does not name his brothers such as Dushasana. This points to some doubts in his mind about his brothers' capabilities.

An`má VXñ_mH\$ ~b ^rî_m{^a{j V_ ÿ&
n`má pĕdX_Vfm ~b ^r_m{^a{j V_ && 10 &&

But our army headed by Bheeshma is not strong enough to defeat them. While their army headed by Bheema can defeat us. (1.10)

Comments: After reviewing the two armies, Duryodhana is beginning to have doubts about the capabilities of his army. He knows that his is not a just cause, but as a representation of *Kali*, the evil soul, it is in his nature to adamantly get into a war even when he knows that he is wrong and that his side is not capable of winning. Note that while Dhrushtadyumna is the commander of the Pandavas' army, Duryodhana recognizes that the real leader of the Pandavas is the hugely experienced Bheema.

A`Zf M gdf `Wm^mJ_dpñWVm... Ý&
^rî__dm{^aj ÝV ^dÝV... gd Ed {h Ý&& 11 &&

Hence all of you need to position yourselves in your designated spots in the formations and guard Bheeshma, our commander. (1.11)

Comments: Duryodhana is very particular about protecting Bheeshma as he is worried that Bheeshma's fall would discourage his entire army. The fact that he was worried about the safety of Bheeshma who was the most capable warrior in his side is an indication of his fear.

Bugle Calls

Vñ` gOZ`Z hf H\$édÕ... {nVm_h... Ý&
qghZmX {dZÚm f ... e l XÜ_m àVmndmZ Ý&& 12 &&

To inject confidence in Duryodhana, the very courageous Bheeshma who is the senior most Kaurava, roared like a lion and sounded his conch. (1.12)

Comments: Bheeshma recognizes that Duryodhana is so petrified looking at the strength of the Pandava army that he asks Drona and others to protect him. In fact, it is the duty of Bheeshma, as the commander, to protect the Kaurava army. To instill confidence in Duryodhana and the

other Kauravas, Bheeshma signals his readiness by his lion like roar and the sounding of his conch.

VV... e I mü ^` ü nUdmZH\$Jm _ I m... &
ghgdmä`hý`ýV g eãXñV _bm@^dV ý&& 13 &&

Conch-shells, bugles, trumpets, drums, and cow horns were sounded loudly by the Kauravas which resulted in their sound filling the entire space. (1.13)

Comments: Taking a cue from Bheeshma, other Kaurava leaders sounded various organs to signal their readiness and command their troops to get ready. It is interesting to note that while Bheeshma sounds his conch, a musical instrument with spiritual significance which has a pleasant sound, other leaders sound different instruments, many making harsh sounds not in harmony with each other. Perhaps an indication of disharmony and disunity among the Kauravas.

VV... æVh` `°\$ _h{V ñ`ýXZ pñWVm ý&
_mYd... nmÊSdüd {Xì`m eL I m àXÜ _V... && 14 &&

At this time, Lord Madhava (Krishna) and Arjuna, son of Pandu, who were seated on a magnificent chariot pulled by white horses, sounded their respective divine conch shells. (1.14)

Comments: Lord Krishna and Arjuna sounding their conches while seated in a horse drawn chariot also has a spiritual interpretation. As noted by Sri Vidyamanya Teertha in his GPM, as per the **Upanishads**, the chariot is a representation of the human body. The wandering horses represent the sense organs, and the road travelled represents the objects of sense pleasure. The charioteer (Krishna) represents the intellect, and the leash which controls the horses represents the mind. The charioteer (Krishna) and the passenger (Arjuna) respectively represent the Supreme Soul and the individual soul resident in each body. The conch is shaped like the

primordial symbol ‘Om’ which is the root letter of all scriptures. Hence the conversation between Krishna and Arjuna represents the collective wisdom of scriptures such as the **Vedas**.

n#mOÝ` öfrH\$em XdXÎm YZÄO`... Ý&
nmÊS XU_m_hme I | ^r_H\$_m dH\$mXa... Ý&& 15 &&

AZÝV{dO` amOm H\$ÝVrnÎm `{Y{ða... Ý&
ZH\$b... ghXdü gKnf_{UnîH\$m Ý&& 16 &&

H\$mí`ü na_îdmg... {e I ÊSr M_hmaW... Ý&
YÿÚâZm {damQü gmÊ`{H\$ümnam{OV... Ý&& 17 &&

ÐnXm ÐmnX`mü gde... n{WdrnV Ý&
gm^Ðü _hm~mh... e I XU_... nWH\$ nWH Ý&&18 &&

Lord Hrishikesha (Krishna) sounded Panchajanya, Dhananjaya (Arjuna) sounded Devadatta, and valiant Vrukodara (Bheema) sounded Powndra. (1.15)

King Yudhishtira, son of Kunti, sounded Anantavijaya, and Nakula and Sahadeva sounded Sughosha and Manipushpaka, respectively. (1.16)

The King of Kashi an expert bowman, Shikhandi a great warrior on chariot, Dhrushtadyumna, Virata and Satyaki, unbeaten in a war, all sounded their respective conch shells. (1.17)

Likewise, King Drupada, the son of Draupadi and the strong-armed brave son of Subhadra (Abhimanyu,) all sounded their respective conch shells. (1.18)

Comments: It is interesting to note that while the Kauravas used various instruments to sound their readiness, the Pandavas uniformly sounded their respective conches to the maximum effect to display unity.

g Kmf YmVamimUm öX`n{Z i`Xma`V i&
Z^ü n{Wdt Md V_bm i`ZZmX`Z i&& 19 &&

The vibrations from the massive sound of the Pandava warriors' conch shells echoed across the earth and sky, spreading everywhere, and shattered the hearts of King Dhrutarashtra's sons. (1.19)

Comments: The massive, uniform sound from the synchronized sounding of conch shells by the Pandava leaders cut into the Kaurava hearts as if to warn them of their impending defeat and destruction.

AW i`dmpñWVmZ XîQm YmVamimZ H\${nÜdO... i&
àdîm eógânmV YZéÚâ` nmÊSd... i&& 20 &&

öfrH\$e VXm dmŠ` ' BX_mh_hrnV i&

Looking at King Dhrutarashtra's children who were ready to wage the war, Arjuna, (the one whose chariot bears the flag of Lord Hanuman), just when the time had come to operate the weapons, held up his bow, and spoke to Lord Krishna as follows. (1.20)

Comments: Arjuna wants to take a good look at the armies which consisted of all major, accomplished rulers and warriors of that time. In this verse, a reference is made to the flag of Arjuna's chariot which bears the figure of Lord Hanuman, the great warrior from the **Ramayana**. This indicates that both the Supreme Soul (*paramatma* = Lord Krishna) and the superior soul among all individual souls (*jeevottama* = *vayudeva* = Hanuman) are protecting Arjuna.

Arjuna Inspects the Armies

AOZ CdM -

gZ`mé^`_Ü` aW ñWmn`_@À`V && 21 &&

`mdXVnZ {Z[a j @h `mÖH\$m_mZdpñWVnZ &

H\$_m gh `mÖi` ' Apñ_Z aUg_Ú_ && 22 &&

`mËñ`_mZmZ Adj @h ` EV@ì g_mJVm... &

YmVamĩñ` X~Ö`Ö {à`{MH\$fd... && 23 &&

Arjuna said: O Achyuta! Please position my chariot in between the two armies. I would like to look at those who are assembled here, ready to fight the war, and with whom I will be fighting. (1.21) (1.22)

I would also like to look at those warriors who are here to fight the war to please the evil minded Duryodhana (son of Dhrutarashtra). (1.23)

Comments: After Duryodhana's review of the armies, it is the turn of Arjuna to survey the forces assembled on the battlefield. Arjuna's review and feelings of apprehension about waging the war form the basis for Sri Krishna's sermon (Gita).

gO` CdM &

Ed_°\$m öfrH\$em JSmH\$eZ ^maV &

gZ`mé^`_Ü` ñWmn{`Edm aWmÎm__ && 24 &&

^rî_ĐmUà_I V... gdfm M_hr{ j Vm_ &

CdM nmW ní`VmZ g 'dVmZ H\$e\$Z{V && 25 &&

Sanjaya said: O Bhaarata! (Dhrutarashtra, from the lineage of King Bharata)! Lord Hrishikesha (Krishna), addressed thus by Gudakesha (Arjuna) positioned the grand chariot in between the two armies. (1.24)

Turning the chariot towards Bheeshma, Drona and other kings, Lord Krishna said - O Partha (Arjuna)! Look at all the Kauravas assembled here. (1.25)

Comments: Arjuna is referred to as Gudakesha – the one who has conquered sleep (*gudaka*). Sleep, along with lethargy represents *tamas* (ignorance). Sleep is probably the most difficult state for one to overcome. Thus, anyone who can control sleep is said to have control over sense organs. Hence, Arjuna is most eligible to receive the sermon from the Lord. The Lord is referred to as Hrishikesha, one who has control over everyone's sense organs and indeed on everyone and everything in the universe.

Vìmní`V pñWVmZ nmW... {nVZW {nVm_hmZ ý&
AmMm`mZ _mVbmZ ^mVZ nìmZ nmìmZ g l tñVWm ý&
æeamZ göXüd gZ`mé^`ma{n ý&& 26 &&

VmZ g_rú` g H\$mÝV`... gdmZ ~ÝYZdpñWVmZ ý&
H\$m`m na`m@{dīm {dfrX{pX_~drV ý&&27&&

Looking at both the armies, Arjuna sees warriors who were like his father (father figures), father-in-law, grandfathers, uncles, teachers, brothers, sons, grandsons, friends, and colleagues. (1.26)

Seeing all his relatives assembled there to wage the war, Arjuna (son of Kunti) was overwhelmed by emotion and addressed Sri Krishna with great anxiety. (1.27)

Comments: While Arjuna knew that many of his near and dear ones would be participating in the war, he is overwhelmed when he sees all of

them assembled in one place. Faced with the prospect of many of them dying, regardless of who won the war, Arjuna is overcome with grief and emotion.

Sri Rayaru in GV provides an explanation for the term *vishada* which is used to express Arjuna's emotion. *Vishada* means mental weakness caused by grief, which is a result of delusion, which in turn is caused by the fear of losing loved ones.

Arjuna Develops Cold Feet

AOZ CdmM V&
ÔîQ_ ñdOZ H\$îU ``Ëg g_npñWV_ V&& 28 &&

grXpÝV __ Jmîm{U _ I M n[aeî`{V V&
ddWü eara _ am_hfü Om`V V&& 29 &&

Arjuna said: O Krishna! I am looking at my relatives and friends gathered here to wage the war. (1.28)

Looking at them, my limbs are weakening, my face is crumpling, my body is trembling, and my hair is bristling. (1.29)

Comments: From this verse, till the end of this chapter is a description of Arjuna's anxiety and fear when faced with the prospect of waging the war which would result in the loss of lives of multitudes of people including many of his near and dear ones. Note that Arjuna begins describing his anxiety to the Lord by addressing Him as Krishna. This has a special significance. Sri Madhwacharya in his **Gita Bhashya** [GB] (5th Chapter), interprets Krishna as '*Lokarakshaka*', the one who controls everyone and everything in the universe. By using this term, Arjuna expresses his faith that Lord Krishna will have a solution to his grief.

JmÊSrd ògV hñVmV ĒdH\$ Md n[aXøV ĩ&
Z M eŠZmā`dñWmV ^_Vrd M _ _Z... ĩ&& 30 ĩ&&

{Z{Îm{Z M nÍ`m{ {dnarVm{Z H\$ed ĩ&
Z M I`m@ZnÍ`m{ hĒdm ñdOZ_mhd ĩ&& 31 &&

Z H\$m→ {dO` H\$îU Z M amÁ` g I m{Z M ĩ&
qH\$ Zm amÁ`Z Jm{dÝX qH\$ ^mJOu{dVZ dm ĩ&&32&&

My bow (Gandeeva) is slipping from my hands, my skin is burning, I am unable to even stand, and my mind is blurred with delusion. (1.30)

O Keshava! I am seeing many bad omens. I do not see anything good coming out of killing my own people. (1.31)

O Krishna! I do not aspire for victory, kingdom, or happiness. O! Govinda! What use is this kingdom, luxuries, or even living? (1.32)

Comments: Sri Madhwacharya in his Gita Bhashya [GB], interprets the Lord's name Keshava, as the one who inspires even deities Brahma (*ka*) and Rudra (*esha*). Arjuna, by using this term to address the Lord expresses his complete faith that Lord Krishna who inspires even deities Brahma and Rudra, can surely help him. Arjuna's sensing of bad omens reflects his weak mind (If these omens were indeed predicting bad outcomes, he would have lost the war, which did not happen).

`fm\_W H\$m{→V Zm amÁ` ^mJm... g I m{Z M ĩ&
V B_@dpñWVm `Õ àmUmñĒ`³Ēdm YZm{Z M ĩ&& 33 &&

AmMm`m... {nVa... nÎmñVWd M {nVm_hm... ĩ&
_mVbm... ídeam... nmÎm... í`mbm... gā~pÝYZñVWm ĩ&& 34 &&

EVmP hYV{ ÀNm{ ;ZVm@{n _YgXZ V&
A{n ÌbmŠ`amÁ`ñ` hVm... qH\$ Z _hrH\$V V&& 35&&

The very people for whom we work hard to provide comfort and luxury are here ready to give up their possessions and even their lives. They are like my father, grandfather, uncle, son, grandson, brother, brother-in-law, teacher, and other relatives. (1.33) (1.34)

O Madhusoodana! Even if they hurt me, I do not want to kill them. I would not kill them even if I could win all three worlds by doing so. Why would I kill them just for some land? (1.35)

Comments: Arjuna is overcome with emotion and states that even if his enemies attacked him when he turned away from war, he would not want to harm them. Even if victory would net him all the three worlds, he would not value them if he had to kill his loved ones. Why then would he wage a war just for some land?

Note that Arjuna addresses Krishna as Madhusoodana. Demons Madhu and Kaitabha were born out of Krishna's sweat and in that sense are Krishna's children. As they grew up, they became very evil, and Krishna had no choice but to destroy them. Arjuna indicates here that he does not have such strong will power.

{ZhÈ` YmVamimZ Z... H\$m àr{V... ñ`m, mZmXZ V&
nmn_dm@ I`Xñ\_mZ hEdVmZ AmVWm{`Z... V&& 36 &&

Vñ_mPmhm d` hYV YmVamimZ g~mYdmiZ V&
ñdOZ {h H\$W hEdm g{ I Z... ñ`m _mYd V&& 37&&

O Janardana! What pleasure do we get by killing the sons of Dhrutarashtra? Killing these vandals (*atatayins*) will only result in accumulation of sins. (1.36)

O Madhava! It is not proper for us to kill Dhrutarashtra's sons who are our own relatives. How can we achieve happiness by killing our own people? (1.37)

Comments: Arjuna refers to the Kauravas as *atatayina* which means those who have committed one or more of the following six sins – torching others, poisoning others, using weapons against the unprotected, stealing others' land, money, and women. It is the duty of someone in Arjuna's position to destroy those who commit these sins. It is his duty to preserve and protect the innocent in society. While Arjuna is aware that the Kauravas deserve to be punished, he is worried that doing so would result in collateral damage – that is the death of his relatives, elders and teachers which would result in him accumulating sins.

Arjuna Argues Against War

¶Úß`V Z ní`pÝV b^{m^}mnhVMVg... Ý&
H\$b j`H\$V Xmf { _ÎÐmh M nmVH\$_ Ý&& 38 &&

H\$W Z k`_ñ_m{^... nmnXñ_m{pd{VW_ Ý&
H\$b j`H\$V Xmf àní`{ØOZmXZ Ý&& 39 &&

H\$b j`àUí`pÝV H\$bY_m... gZmVZm... Ý&
Y_Zi`H\$b H\$EñZ\_ AY\_m@{^^dE`V Ý&& 40 &&

AY_m{^^dmV H\$îU àXî`pÝV H\$b{ó`... Ý&
órf Xîng dîU` Om`V dUgLH\$a... Ý&& 41 &&

gLH\$a_m ZaH\$m`d H\$b¿ZmZm H\$bñ` M Ý&
nVpÝV {nVam øfm bá{nÊSmXH\${H\$`m... Ý&& 42 &&

These Kauravas who are greedy for the kingdom have no knowledge of the sins they would accumulate by killing their family members and by betraying their friends. (1.38)

O Janardana! How can we, who understand the perils of destroying families, not be aware of the need to stay away from these sinful acts? (1.39)

With the destruction of the families, traditional familial virtues will perish. When virtuousness declines, unrighteousness will permeate society. (1.40)

O Vaarshneya! The rise of unrighteousness will cause surviving women to stray away from morality. Women devoid of morals result in unholy families. (1.41)

Rise of unholy families will push the lineage of children and grandchildren to hell and departed elders who are deprived of appropriate offerings will also fall into hell. (1.42)

Comments: Arjuna tries to make a case for avoiding the battle by putting forward additional arguments. His initial argument was that the war would result in the loss of many innocent lives, including elders and teachers who were pious and revered. Here he argues that the loss of many men in the war would lead to instability in society and give rise to unholy families. This would result in the loss of compulsory rituals such as offerings to departed elders. Arjuna also says that the Kauravas are blinded by their greed and are unable to see the perils of such a war. But how could the Pandavas who are a lot more knowledgeable about such perils be similarly blinded?

XmfaV... H\$b¿ZmZm dUgH\$aH\$maH\$... Ý&
CËgmÚÝV Om{VY_m... H\$bY_mü emæVm... Ý&& 43&&

CĒgP̄H\$by_mUm_Zî`mUm OZmXZ Ĩ&
ZaH\$ {Z`V dmgm ^dVrĒ`Ze I _ Ĩ&& 44 &&

Ahm ~V _hV nm̄n H\$V î`d{gV̄m d` _ Ĩ&
`XamÁ`g I bm^Z h'V ñdOZ_ÚV̄m... Ĩ&& 45 &&

`{X \_m\_àVrH\$ma\_ Aeó eónmU`... &
YmVamĩm aU h'V`ñV' _ j _Va ^dV Ĩ&& 46 &&

Such sinful deeds by destroyers of families will result in corruption of virtuous classes and decline of virtuous familial traditions. (1.43)

O Janardana! We have heard from elders that people whose virtuous familial traditions are destroyed are sure to fall into hell. (1.44)

Alas! We are about to commit a great sin by killing our own people because of our greed for kingdom and for the sake of happiness. (1.45)

It would be better for me if I relinquished my weapons and offered no resistance while Dhrutarashtra's sons kill me in this war. (1.46)

Comments: Arjuna now summarizes his arguments for staying away from the war. Firstly, he would be committing a great sin by killing near and dear ones which included elders and teachers who were pious and revered. Secondly, the loss of millions of men would lead to instability in society due to straying away from traditions related to a class (*jati dharma*) and traditions specific to families (*kula dharma*). In addition, anyone causing these would accrue sins to their departed elders. Arjuna laments that he is about to commit great sins in waging this war, the purpose of which is to gain the kingdom. He is convinced that it is better for him to relinquish his weapons and let the Kauravas kill him as that would prevent him from accruing sins and in fact may lead him to heavens hereafter for his noble act.

As will be seen later, Arjuna fights the war and the Pandavas successfully rule their kingdom for many years. None of Arjuna's fears come true. The evil clan of the Kauravas and their supporters such as the virtuous but guilty Bheeshma and Drona are vanquished, and society does not fall apart. In fact, Bharat enjoys a long, peaceful and prosperous period under Pandavas' rule. The **Gita** clearly suggests that omens do not have any predictive value and chastise superstitious practices. Arjuna's experience of bad omens reflect his weak mental condition which is caused by his excessive attachment to his near and dear ones.

Arjuna Drops His Weapons

gO` CdM M Ĩ -
Ed_³Edm@OZ_g»` aWmnñW Cnm{deV Ĩ &
{dgÁ` gea Mmn emH\$g{d¾_mZg... Ĩ&& 47 &&

Sanjaya said: Having said thus, Arjuna, stricken with deep sorrow in his mind, drops his bow and arrows and sits still in the middle of his chariot. (1.47)

Comments: While Arjuna indicates to Krishna his anxiety and unwillingness to wage war, his relinquishing of his bow and arrows is a signal to his large army that he is not yet ready to start the war. (The army of course could not have heard the conversation between Arjuna and Krishna). This action has led to their enemies drawing their own conclusions which Krishna indicates later.

Summary of Chapter 1

The Bhagavad Gita is a conversation between Arjuna and Lord Krishna as narrated by Lord Vedavyasa in the epic, **Mahabharata**. The great war between the armies of the Kaurava and the Pandava cousins, was witnessed by Sanjaya, aide of the blind King Dhrutarashtra who was head of the Kaurava dynasty. Sanjaya rushes to Dhrutarashtra soon after the fall

of Bheeshma, the commander of the Kaurava army. The stunned Dhrutarashtra wants to know everything that happened on the battlefield from the very beginning. Sanjaya narrates all the events from the beginning of the war. He stays with the king till the end of the war relaying all the events to him. He can do this because Sage Vedavyasa grants him divine vision to view the war remotely and provide Dhrutarashtra the updates.

The King starts by asking Sanjaya as to what happened between his clan (the Kauravas) and the Pandavas in Kurukshetra (which is known as Dharma Kshetra or the 'Field of Righteousness') (1.1). This question reveals the King's apprehensions. He is convinced that the Pandavas with the guidance of Lord Krishna would be invincible (but, Krishna has sworn not to touch or take up arms). On the other hand, Bheeshma, the very epitome of justice, was also known to be invincible. The King was therefore hoping against hope that his sons would not be defeated, especially in a war that was being fought in an area known as the Field of Righteousness. So, he was shocked to hear that Bheeshma had fallen. Sanjaya responds, saying that initially Duryodhana looks at the Pandava army and rushes to inform his teacher Dronacharya about its strength. He makes sure to let him know that the army is being led by Dhrishtadyumna, a student of Drona himself. Then he goes on to enumerate other great leaders on the side of the Pandavas. These leaders were termed '*Maharathas*', meaning they were capable of single-handed fighting with 10,000 enemy soldiers. In all, Duryodhana enumerates 18 leaders from the Pandavas' side, other than the five Pandava brothers. Interestingly, he does not recognize Krishna as being a part of the Pandava side. This is because Krishna had vowed not to use any arms in the war. Duryodhana obviously did not realize the invaluable advice and guidance that Krishna would be providing to Arjuna. Ultimately, this miscalculation had led to the Kauravas' defeat. This illustrates the peril of ignoring the Lord who is responsible for everything in this universe, just because one cannot physically see Him. (1.2-1.6). Duryodhana then enumerates the great warriors on his side which included – Dronacharya, Bheeshma, Karna, Krupa, Ashwatthama, Vikarna and Bhoorishravas. However, he did not expect the Pandavas to turn up with a huge, well-organized army. He

knows that in addition to the experienced warriors, the Pandava army also included the 5 young children of Draupadi and each of them was brave and capable. He also knows that while Dhrushtadyumna is the commander of the Pandava army, it is really the invincible Bheema who is their star warrior. Duryodhana is now clearly very perturbed. He wants to ensure that Bheeshma is well protected as he sees Bheeshma as extremely critical to his victory. He asks Dronacharya and others to ensure Bheeshma's safety (1.7-1.11). At this time, sensing Duryodhana's worry, Bheeshma decided to instil confidence in him by loudly roaring like a lion and sounding his conch. Other soldiers in the Kaurava army follow by sounding drums, trumpets, bugles etc, and the collective sound seemed to envelope the entire space. Now it is the turn of the Pandavas. Sri Krishna and Arjuna, while seated in their chariots sound their respective conches followed by other leaders in their army. The collective sound of these conches reverberated across earth and sky and seemed to shatter the hearts of King Dhrutarashtra's sons. It is interesting to note that while the Kauravas used various instruments to sound their readiness, the Pandavas uniformly sounded their respective conches for the maximum effect. Lord Krishna and Arjuna sounding their conches while seated in a horse drawn chariot also has a spiritual interpretation. The chariot is a representation of the human body as noted in the **Upanishads**. The horses which pull the chariot represent the sense organs, and the roads travelled represent objects of sense pleasure. The charioteer (Krishna) represents the intellect, and the leash which controls the horses represents the mind. The charioteer (Krishna) and the passenger (Arjuna) represent the Supreme soul and the individual soul resident in each body. The conch is shaped like the primordial symbol 'Om' which is the root letter of all scriptures. Hence the conversation between Krishna and Arjuna represents the collective wisdom of all the scriptures such as the **Vedas** (1.12-1.19). Arjuna requests Krishna to take the chariot to the middle of the battleground so that he can have a good look at both the armies. He recognizes his teachers, cousins, nephews, uncles, grand uncles, children, friends etc., and gets very depressed. He is distressed at the very thought of waging a war where he himself might kill many of his near and dear ones. Arjuna tells Krishna that his body is

trembling, and that he is unable to hold his weapons. He was feeling disoriented and disillusioned. He was further seeing bad omens and felt there was nothing good coming out of this war. He says he does not crave for victory, or a kingdom won after losing so many near and dear ones (1.20-1.39). He reasons that with massive destruction of men, familial values would perish, and unrighteousness would take over society. Arjuna says that such a war has no benefits either here or hereafter. He says he would rather drop his weapons and let the Kauravas kill him rather than be responsible for such a destructive war. Saying thus, Arjuna drops his weapon to the ground and sits in his chariot feeling extremely dejected (1.40-1.47).

The rest of the **Gita** is a sermon from Lord Krishna to Arjuna to help him overcome his distress and doubts. The dropping of weapons by Arjuna is equivalent to one abdicating one's responsibility. At this stage, the following points are worth noting: Duryodhana was also distressed after looking at the Pandavas' army but there is a big difference between the distress of Duryodhana and that of Arjuna. Duryodhana was distressed at the thought of not being able to win the war and thereby usurp the Pandavas share of the kingdom illegally. On the other hand, Arjuna's distress was out of compassion towards his loved ones. Duryodhana shows no such compassion. Arjuna was not afraid of fighting as he had fought many wars before and had won them. But this time it was different. His enemies were people he cared for dearly.

&& B{V àW_m@Ü¶m` ... &&

End of Chapter 1

{ŪVr`m@Úm`... - gm>>¶¶mJ...

Chapter 2 – The Path of Doctrines

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 72 verses is termed *Sankhya Yoga* (The Path of Doctrines). In this chapter, the Lord answers Arjuna's basic questions about the purpose of life and other related philosophical concepts. Sensing that Arjuna's reservations about fighting the war were due to his fear of losing his loved ones, the Lord delves into the nature of individual souls, the indestructibility of souls, the relationship between individual souls and Himself. He reminds Arjuna that He gave human forms to individual souls to help them in their spiritual journey and that everyone must play their dutiful role in society. In verses 2.12 to 2.39, the Lord lectures on the nature of individual souls and the Supreme soul (Lord Almighty). In verse 2.39, the Lord tells Arjuna how to acquire divine, spiritual knowledge which is explained in brief in verses 2.45 to 2.51. In these verses, the Lord discusses the concept of *nishkama karma*, that is, performing prescribed duties without expectations. The Lord urges Arjuna not to despair over the hurt that may be caused to his elders and teachers in the war, as they had chosen to support the evil king Duryodhana and reminds Arjuna that he had an obligation to fight this just war to protect his citizens. Lord Krishna teaches Arjuna to focus on performing his prescribed duty of protecting his citizens as an offering to the Lord Almighty and not let his emotions come in the way. Chapter 2 can be considered the foundational chapter of the entire **Gita** as it answers Arjuna's (and through Arjuna, everyone's) basic questions about the purpose of life. The remaining chapters serve to expand on the concepts presented in this chapter.

gO`CdM -

V VWm H\$`m@{di` AInUmH\$b j U_`&

{dfrXV{X dmŠ`_CdM_YgXZ...&& 1 &&

Sanjaya said: Lord Madhusoodana said the following to grief-stricken Arjuna who was overcome with self-pity and had tears in his eyes. (2.1)

Comments: Sensing Dhrutarashtra's curiosity as to the events that follow Arjuna's dropping of his weapons, Sanjaya continues with his narration of the next set of events starting with Lord Krishna's questioning of Arjuna's actions.

Arjuna, Rise Up and Wage this Just War

Ir^JdmZdmM Ĩ&
H\$VñĒdm H\$í_b{X {df_g 'npñWV_ Ĩ&
AZm`Oĩ\_ñd½`_ AH\$s{VH\$a_OZ Ĩ&& 2 Ĩ&&

The Lord said: O Arjuna! What caused this delusion for you to give up your duties at the time of crisis? This is not expected of wise men, it does not lead to glory, or heavens and it only brings disrepute. (2.2)

Comments: By stating that Arjuna is uttering words unworthy of wise men, Lord Krishna is giving a hint of the concept of '*prajnavada*' which will be elaborated in verse 2.11.

Šbã`\_m ñ\_J\_... nmW ZVîdæ`nnÚV Ĩ&
jĐ öX`Xm~ë` Ē`ŠĒdm{Îmĩ} naYVn Ĩ&& 3 Ĩ&&

O Partha! Do not yield to weakness. This is not worthy of you. O Parantapa (Destroyer of enemies)! Get rid of your heart's weakness, get up and get ready to wage this war. (2.3)

Comments: Krishna asking Arjuna to get up has both literal and figurative meanings. In verse 1.47, it was noted that Arjuna was sitting still in his chariot, refusing to wage the war. Now Krishna is directing Arjuna to

get out of his chariot and wage the just war. It also indicates the need to get into action in pursuance of one's duty. Krishna also refers to Arjuna as *Parantapa* (destroyer of enemies), to remind him that he has waged and won many wars earlier and need not be afraid to fight this war.

Arjuna's Dilemma and Surrender to Krishna

AOZ CdmM Ĩ&
H\$W ^rĥ__h g»` ĦmU M _YgXZ Ĩ&
Bf{^... à{V`mĔñ`m{ _ nOmhd[agXZ Ĩ&& 4 Ĩ&&

Arjuna said: O Madhusoodana (Annihilator of demon Madhu)! How can I direct my arrows at Bheeshma and Drona who are worthy of worship? (2.4)

Comments: Arjuna who is overcome with grief and emotion is not able to relate to Krishna's advice and reiterates his position in 5 verses. Arjuna indicates that even if he were to approach the war as a duty, he could not hurl his arrows at Bheeshma and Drona who have taught him much and are worthy of worship.

Jê\$ZhĔdm {h _hmZ^mdnZ I`m ^m°\$ ^ú`_nrh bmH\$ Ĩ&
hĔdm@WH\$m _mřV Jê\$Zhd ^ÄOr` ^mJmZ é{Yaà{X½YmZ Ĩ&& 5 Ĩ&&

It is better to live by begging for alms than kill our great teachers. How can one enjoy the luxuries of a kingdom attained by waging a war and spilling the blood of these teachers who are of great eminence? (2.5)

Comments: Arjuna argues that it is not worth winning the war which would entail killing his elders and teachers who are pious and God fearing, as that would not lead to any joy in this world and would bring difficulties hereafter also. A better option would be to give up fighting and live by begging for alms.

Z MV{ÛÙ... H\$VaPm Jar`m `Ûm O`\_`{X dm Zm O`...`&
 `mZd hEdm Z {OOr{dfm ñV@dpñWVm... à\_ I YmVamim...`&& 6 &&

I do not know which is better, that we win, or they win over us. We do not desire to live by killing the sons of Dhrutarashtra who are standing in front of us. (2.6)

Comments: Arjuna argues that if he wins the war by killing the Kauravas, it is in a way equivalent to losing, as the war would also entail the death of many near and dear ones. Arjuna, thus is not able to decide the better option. Prior to this verse, Arjuna seemed to have made up his mind that he would not wage the war, but now after reflecting on Krishna's advice he is weighing both the options.

H\$mñÊ`XmfmnhVñd^md... nÀNm{ Edm Y\_gâ TMVm...`&
 `ÀN`... ñ`m{p{üV ~{h VÍ\_ {eî`ñV@h em{Y _m Edm ànp_`&& 7`&&

My natural valor is subdued due to compassion. My mind is conflicted on the issue of duty. I am asking you. Which is the path for ultimate good? I am your disciple. I surrender to you. Please guide me. (2.7)

Comments: Arjuna is clearly conflicted and is not able to make up his mind. He surrenders to Krishna and asks for Krishna's guidance.

Z {h àní`m{\_\_mnZÚmX `ÀNmH\$`ÀNmFU{pYĐ`mUm_`&
 Admß`^\_mdgnEZ\_Õ amÁ`gamUm_{n Mm{YnÊ`\_`&& 8`&&

Even if I achieve unchallenged ownership of this prosperous world here, and supremacy over the deities in the upper worlds hereafter, I cannot see how I can dispel this grief which is draining my senses. (2.8)

Comments: Here again we see that Arjuna is conflicted. He declares that even if he were to follow his prescribed duties and wage the war to protect the citizens from the evil Kauravas, and even if his actions result in him accruing enough good credits to become the leader of heavens, he would be unable to control his grief over the prospect of losing near and dear ones.

gO` CdM M ĩ&
Ed_ŠEdm öfrH\$e JSmH\$e... naYVn... ĩ&
Z `mĒñ` h{V Jm{dYX_ CŠEdm VĩUt ~^d h ĩ&& 9 &&

Sanjaya said: Gudakesha (Arjuna, the one who has conquered sleep), Parantapa (Arjuna - the destroyer of enemies), thus addressed Govinda, (Krishna - the controller of senses). Saying that he would not fight the war (as he is conflicted), he became silent. (2.9)

Comments: Arjuna is referred to as Gudakesha – the one who has conquered sleep. Sleep, along with lethargy represents *tamas* or ignorance. Arjuna has won over these and hence is eligible to receive the sermon from the Lord. Further, Arjuna is termed *Parantapa*, the one who has destroyed enemies in many wars. Sri Rayaru in GV draws attention to the use of the term ‘*ha*’ which indicates surprise. Sanjaya seems to be indicating that it was a surprise to him that Arjuna with such qualities, was in a despondent mood.

V_dmM öfrH\$e... àhg{Pd ^maV ĩ&
gZ`mé^`m_Ü` {dfrXYV{X dM... ĩ&& 10 ĩ&&

O Dhritarashtra of the Bharata dynasty! Lord Hrishikesha smilingly said the following words to the grief-stricken Arjuna who was in the middle of the armies. (2.10)

Comments: Krishna’s smile is a rhetorical reaction to the inconsistent position that Arjuna had placed himself in.

The Soul is Eternal, The Body is Perishable

Ir^JdmZdmM Ĩ&
 AemÀ`mZÝdemMñĒEd àkndmXmü ^mf g Ĩ&
 JVngZJVmgü ZmZemMpÝV npÊSVm... Ĩ&& 11 Ĩ&&

The Lord said: You are grieving over those who do not deserve sympathy and saying whatever is coming to your mind. Learned ones do not grieve over those who are about to die just as they do not grieve over those living. (2.11)

Comments: Elders and teachers such as Bheeshma and Drona, even though worthy of worship, were on the side of evil and so Arjuna should not have been grieving over their impending death. Krishna uses the word ‘*Prajnaavada*’ which has two meanings – one who says whatever that comes to one’s mind and secondly, one whose words are not acceptable to the wise.

Z Ēddmh OmV Zmg Z Ēd Z_ OZmfYnm... Ĩ&
 Z Md Z ^{dî`m\_ gd d`_V... na_ Ĩ&& 12 Ĩ&&

There was no time when neither Me nor you nor any of these kings here did not exist. Even in future there will be no time when any of us will cease to exist. (2.12)

Comments: Krishna goes on to answer three conflicts in Arjuna’s mind which are causing him distress. Is the distress due to a fear of the loss of souls of loved ones? Or is it due to a fear of the loss of their physical bodies? Or is it due to a fear of the loss of their bodies which are equated to their souls?

He answers the first question in this verse where he categorically states that souls are eternal and have no beginning or end. This applies to

Arjuna, to all kings assembled at the warfront (and by extension everyone) and especially to the Lord Almighty, which is indicated using the word ‘*tu*’.

The fact that the Lord is especially eternal is supported by scriptures such as **Katha Upanishad (2.5.13)** which describes the Lord as ‘*nityo nityanam*’ (He is eternal among eternal). While the individual souls are eternal, the Lord’s eternality is superior to that of individual souls. Living beings whose souls are eternal do undergo creation and destruction of their physical bodies (birth and death), but the Lord who has a transcendental body does not experience creation or destruction. Hence, He is said to have superior eternality compared to individual souls. The other two questions are answered in later verses 2.13 and 2.20.

A question that arises at this stage is - how could Arjuna, himself a realized soul as an incarnation of deity Devendra, the king of all deities, harbour such doubts about the nature of the Lord? Sri Madhwacharya answers this question [GTN] by stating that the Lord in the form of Vedavyasa in the great epic **Mahabharata** elaborates the sermon in more detail for the benefit of humanity.

X{hZm@pñ_Z`WmXhH\$m\_ma`mdZ OamV&
VWmXhmYVaàm{áYuañVÌZ_ø{V V&& 13 V&&

Just as one experiences childhood, youth, and old age, one similarly experiences attainment of another body. So, the wise ones do not grieve over the loss of the physical body. (2.13)

Comments: While the verse 2.12 deals with the issue of a soul’s nature, in this verse the Lord describes the nature of one’s physical body. Just as one goes through changes in the physical body in one’s lifetime, death is inevitable in the end. Hence Arjuna has no reason to grieve over the loss of the physical bodies of his loved ones in a just war.

Comments: Arjuna could argue that one way for him to avoid distress would be to avoid waging the war which could result in loss of loved ones. In this case, the issue of attachment does not arise. So, why not avoid the war? Lord Krishna says that waging a just war is Arjuna's duty and the way that Arjuna can avoid distress is by ridding himself of attachment to his near and dear ones. Such an action will also result in Arjuna achieving liberation hereafter.

ZṁgVṁ {dÚV@^ṁdṁ Zṁ^ṁdṁ {dÚV gV... ṽ&
C^`ma{n Ñiṁ@YVñĒdZ`mñVîdX{e{^... ṽ&& 16 ṽ&&

No good comes out of bad deeds. Also, there are no bad results from good deeds. The learned seers who have realized the Lord Almighty are convinced of these two facts. (2.16)

Comments: Arjuna has expressed concern that he will incur sins by killing elders and teachers during the war. However, these elders are on the side of evil and it is Arjuna's duty to fight for justice. In this verse, Krishna says that no sin is incurred by performing good deeds.

There is a second meaning to this verse as stated by Sri Rayaru [GV]- Inert nature is not subject to creation and destruction, and hence is eternal. The Lord Almighty is also eternal and indestructible. These two concepts have been traditionally taught by knowledgeable seers.

How can one say that inert matter and the Lord Almighty are eternal, and not subject to creation and dissolution? Sri Rayaru [GV] provides an answer by referring to the first line of this verse where - *asat* refers to prime material nature, *sat* refers to the Lord Almighty, *abhava* refers to *prag abhava* and *pradhwamsa abhava*, and *na vidyate* means 'does not exist'. This means that prime matter and the Lord Almighty do not have the conditions of the above *abhava* twins. Thus, the two entities are said to be eternal.

What are the *abhava* twins? This can be explained with an example. Before a potter creates a pot out of clay, the pot is said to have the condition of prior non-existence (*prag abhava*). When such a pot is destroyed, the pot is in the condition of post non-existence (*pradhwamsa abhava*). The material cause for the creation of the universe is inert nature. The Lord Almighty is the instrumental cause for the creation of the universe. Inert nature and the Lord Almighty are not subject to the conditions of prior non-existence (*prag abhava*) and post non-existence (*pradhwamsa abhava*), and thus are not subject to creation or destruction.

Sri Rayaru [GV] quotes Sri Narahari Teertha [GBBPN] who in his commentary on the **Gita** had an additional interpretation for the use of the word ‘*api*’ (meaning ‘also’) in this verse. This word when combined with the phrase ‘learned seers’, implies that the eternality of inert nature and the Lord Almighty is known through the traditional teachings of learned seers and through scriptural evidence from the epic **Vishnu Purana**.

Sri Vishwesha Teertha in his **Gita Saroddhara** [GS] provides a third interpretation for the first line in this verse by applying the concepts to living beings – the physical body that is subject to birth is not perishable (as it is perishable) and the unborn soul does not perish.

Eternal, Indestructible Soul reflects the Lord

A{dZm{e V VX{d{Ö `Z gd{X WV_ i&
{dZme_ì`ñ`ñ` Z H\$üV H\$V_h{V i&& 17 i&&

Know that entities that pervade the universe will not perish. No one can cause destruction to the imperishable. (2.17)

Comments: The entities referred to are not subject to decay and hence are imperishable and eternal. These entities include the Lord Almighty, individual souls, space (*avyakrita akasha*) and the letters (the 51 letters in the Sanskrit alphabet). Space is known as *avyakrita akasha* as it

does not undergo transformation during creation or dissolution. It is single, eternal, and self-supporting.

A'Vd'V B_ Xhm {ZÈ`ñ`m°\$m... ear[aU... Ý&
AZm{eZm@à_`ñ` Vñ_mX ¶Ü`ñd ^maV Ý&& 18 &&

O Bharata! It is said that the eternal soul's visible physical body is perishable, but the Lord Almighty, the Supreme Soul, is imperishable (not subject to four-way destruction). Hence, fight this war as worship to the indwelling Lord Aprameya, the one who is not limited by space, time, or attributes. (2.18)

Comments: The individual soul is a reflection of the Lord as in a mirror. Some argue that when the mirror which they consider is *upadhi* (the conditioning medium) is destroyed, the reflection no longer exists. Sri Rayaru [GV] explains that the *upadhi* in the example of a reflection in the mirror is the intrinsic body of the individual soul and not the physical body. The intrinsic body (*swaroopa deha*) of a soul never perishes. The Lord is eternal, has no blemishes, does not experience decay or destruction of body, as His body is transcendental. The individual soul's intrinsic body is also indestructible, and in that sense, the individual soul is deemed to have some similarity with the Lord. Hence the intrinsic body of the individual soul is the *upadhi* in the example of comparing the Lord and the individual soul to the original and the mirror reflection. Also, if the Lord Almighty and individual souls have similar attributes such as indestructibility, then why should one perform duties as a worship to the Lord? Firstly, the individual soul is dependent on the Lord and secondly, the Lord has special characteristics far and beyond those of individual souls. The Lord pervades everywhere. Sri Rayaru also states [GV] that the Lord is not subject to the fourfold destruction – (i) of the body (as His body is transcendental), (ii) of the soul (as He is eternal), (iii) of attributes (as He is full of infinite auspicious attributes and is devoid of any blemishes) and (iv) of happiness (as He is devoid of misery). He is superior to individual souls and hence is worthy of worship.

`EZ d{Îm hÝVma `üZ _Ý`V hV_ Ý&
 C^m Vm Z {dOmZrVm Zm `hpÝV Z hÝ`V Ý&& 19 &&

One who thinks that one person has killed another person and the one who thinks that the second person has been killed - neither has true knowledge. No one can kill anyone else, and no one can be killed. (2.19)

Comments: Arjuna's distress is premised on his assumption that he may kill his elders and teachers in the war. However, no one can independently kill someone or get killed by someone. Further, no one experiences destruction of their soul, and the Lord is the only independent entity. Hence, Arjuna's grief is misplaced.

Z Om`V {`V dm H\$Xm{Mp` ^Edm ^{dVm dm Z ^` ... Ý&
 AOm {ZÈ` ... emceVm@` namUm Z hÝ`V hÝ`_mZ eara Ý&& 20 Ý&&

The soul is not subject to birth and death; it is eternal. It is not that the soul did not exist earlier and was born. It has no birth as it is eternal, and it is not subject to decay. Even when the physical body is destroyed, the soul does not perish. (2.20)

Comments: This verse has origins in the **Katha Upanishat** and provides the scriptural reference to the concepts in the previous verse.

A second interpretation of this verse is as follows: The Lord does not experience bodily birth and death. All His incarnations such as Rama and Krishna are eternal, and from time to time He manifests Himself and makes Himself visible or invisible. The aspect of the Lord manifesting and making Himself visible is generally termed as His birth.

Many scriptures have references to the Lord being in the womb of His mother (for example Krishna being in the womb of Devaki) before being born. The Lord's existence in the womb is incidental to the storyline

where the Lord continues to exist with infinite auspicious attributes and His condition is not like that of mortals who suffer in their mother's womb.

dxm{dzm{ez {ZĒ` ` EZ_O_ì` ` ĩ&
H\$W g néf... nmW H\$ KmV`{V hpÝV H\$ _ ĩ&& 21 ĩ&&

O Partha! One who knows that the soul is eternal, that it does not perish, that it has no birth or death; how can that person cause death to someone and/or kill someone. (2.21)

Comments: The word ‘vinasha’ also means weakness such as hatred which is caused by attachment. The soul does not have these defects intrinsically, but a person gets them due to attachment. A wise person who does not have such defects (*avinashi*) will know the true nature of individual souls and the Supreme Soul and will know that no one can cause death to someone else.

dmgm{g OrUm{Z `Wm {dhm` Zd{Z J†m{V Zam@nam{U &
VWm earam{U {dhm` OrUmÝ`Ý`m{Z g`m{V Zd{Z Xhr ĩ&& 22 ĩ&&

Just as a person lets go of worn-out old clothes and adorns new clothes, a soul leaves a decaying body and takes on a new body. (2.22)

Comments: In this verse, there is further confirmation on the separation of the soul and the physical body. In verse 2.13, it was stated that a soul experiences transformation in a physical body as a person transitions through childhood, youth, adulthood, and old age. However, that was related to the same physical body. In this verse, it is clarified that the same soul will migrate from a decayed body to a new body, just as one discards old, worn-out clothes and replaces them with new, good clothes.

ZZ {NÝXpÝV eó{U ZZ Xh{V nmdH\$... ĩ&
Z MZ ŠbX`ÝĒ`mnm Z emf`{V _éV... ĩ&& 23 ĩ&&

Weapons cannot cut the soul, fire cannot burn the soul, water cannot wet the soul and wind cannot parch the soul. (2.23)

Comments: While it was made clear that the intrinsic body of a soul does not decay or get destroyed over time, some can question whether it would be possible to harm or destroy a soul with physical elements such as weapons (made from mining earth), fire, water, wind etc. In this verse it is clarified that it is not possible to harm or destroy a soul by any of these means. Further, as clarified by Sri Rayaru [GV], it is also not possible to destroy a soul through a curse (as in the episode of *Daksha Prajapati* having his head chopped off due to a curse, there was no destruction of his soul).

AÀNÚ@`\_Xmø@`_AŠbÚ@eî`Ed M Ĩ&
{ZĚ`...gdJV...ñWmUaMb@`gZmVZ...Ĩ&& 24 Ĩ&&

The soul cannot be cut, cannot be burnt, cannot be drowned, and cannot be parched. The soul is eternal, atomic in size, and exists under the purview of the immutable, omnipresent Lord (who is known through the **Vedas**). (2.24)

Comments: The previous verse (2.23) refers to a soul's indestructible nature in current time as well as in the past. This verse further clarifies that a soul's indestructible nature applies to future time also.

Aì`°\$m@`_{MYĚ`m@`_A{dH\$m`m@`_À`V Ĩ&
Vñ_mXd {d{XĚdZ ZmZe{MV_h{g Ĩ&& 25 Ĩ&&

The scriptures say that The Lord cannot be visualized by sense organs, He cannot be comprehended, and He is not subject to decay. Arjuna, knowing this you should focus on performing your duty as an offering to the Lord and quit grieving. (2.25)

Comments: The previous verse indicated that the Lord is omnipresent. If so, and if the Lord is resident in all beings, then why is He not visible? This verse answers this question by stating that no one can comprehend the Lord's attributes and that He is also capable of possessing contradictory attributes.

AW MZ {ZĚ`OmV {ZĚ` d m _Y`g _V_ ĩ&
VWm@{n Ěd _hm~mhm ZZ em{MV_h{g ĩ&& 26 ĩ&&

OmVñ` {h Ydm \_Ě`Yd OY`\_Vñ` M ĩ&
Vñ_mXn[ahm`@W Z Ěd em{MV_h{g ĩ&& 27 ĩ&&

O Arjuna (one with strong arms)! When you know that living beings are born and will inevitably die, there is no point in grieving over them. (2.26)

Death is certain for anyone born and likewise rebirth is certain for anyone dead. There is no point in grieving over an issue that has no solution. (2.27)

Comments: The soul does not perish. However, Arjuna could argue that the loss of the physical bodies of dear ones can also cause grief, as he would not be able to see them. Verse 2.27 answers this question by stating that birth and death of physical bodies is inevitable for everyone and there is no point in grieving over this issue that has no solution.

Aì`°\$mXr{Z ^Vm{Z ì`°\$_Ü`m{Z ^maV ĩ&
Aì`°\${ZYzmY`d VÌ H\$m n[aXdZm ĩ&& 28 ĩ&&

O Bharata! Living beings get a body between birth and death from inert, material nature and the body will merge back with inert nature after death. Why grieve over such a body? (2.28)

Comments: While it was made clear that everyone experiences birth and death due to their physical bodies, what causes birth and death? This verse reveals that birth and death are caused by interaction with material nature. The physical body is made up of a certain proportion of the five basic elements of nature. When a soul gets a body from material nature it is termed as birth, and when it loses the body and is back to material nature, it is termed as death. A soul that is dependent on the Lord has no control over the process of birth and death. So, it is not worth grieving over such a temporary body.

After conquering the snake Kalinga, Krishna and other yadavas were spending a night in the forest. They were faced with the onset of rapidly approaching forest fire. Lord Krishna extinguished this fire by swallowing it. Saint Sri Vadiraja [RV] describes this incident to explain the fact that all elements of nature emanate from the Lord and submerge back into Him.

Amü`dV ní`{V H\$[üXZ_mü`dX dX{V VWd MmÝ`... Ý&
Amü`d f Z\_Ý`... eUm{V IEdm@ß`Z dX Z Md H\$üV Ý&& 29 Ý&&

Some look at the Lord in amazement. Some talk about Him in amazement. Some hear about Him in amazement. No one can completely understand Him even after hearing a lot about Him. (2.29)

Comments: While it was made clear previously that individual souls are not independent, one can ask who they are dependent on. This verse explains that the sole independent entity in the universe is the Lord Almighty. It also answers that there are no other independent entities that can equal the Lord. While many people can claim to know the attributes of the Lord, this verse makes it clear that only some visualize the Lord with amazement. Just as one cannot find any comparison to the sky or the ocean, no one can find any comparison to the Lord. He is truly incomparable. For one to get over grief that may arise from any activity, one must focus on performing one's duty as an offering to the Lord. So, it is important for one to appreciate the true greatness of the Lord.

Xhr {ZĒ`\_dÜ`m@` Xh gdñ` ^maV ĩ&
Vñ_mV gd{U ^V{Z Z Ēd e{MV_h{g ĩ&& 30ĩ&&

O Bharata! The soul inside the physical body cannot be destroyed even if the physical body perishes (as it is protected by the Lord). So, there is no need to grieve over anyone. (2.30)

Comments: In verse 2.12, it was stated that the individual souls are also by their nature eternal. How then can one say that they are dependent on the Lord? Sri Rayaru [GV] explains that the Lord protects and controls all bodies that envelope an individual soul, namely – the intrinsic body (*swaroopa deha*), the subtle body (*linga deha*) and the gross physical body (*sthoola deha*). This verse thus explains another aspect of the Lord's greatness.

Fighting a Just War is Arjuna's Duty

ñdY__ {n Mmdú` Z {dH\$pañV_h{g ĩ&
Yá`m{Ō `ŌmÀN`m@Y`V j {ì`ñ` Z {dÚV ĩ&&31ĩ&

Knowing that fighting a just war is your duty, there is no need for you to be shaken. For a person hailing from a ruling (*kshatriya*) class, there is no loftier duty than fighting for a just cause. (2.31)

Comments: In verse 1.29, Arjuna had said that he was trembling as he was overcome with grief. In this verse, the Lord responds to that condition. Previously He had declared that Arjuna need not grieve over the loss of near and dear ones as their souls never perish. Now Krishna says that in addition, it is Arjuna's compulsory duty to fight the Kauravas to end their misrule and there is nothing more important than this. Thus, there is absolutely no need for Arjuna to feel weak and helpless.

`ÑÀN` m MnnP ñdJÛma_nmdV_`&
g{ I Z... j{Ì`m... nmW b^YV `Õ_rÑe_`&& 32`&&

O Partha! Blessed are those in the *kshatriya* class who get an opportunity to do the right deed by fighting for a just cause. This opens the doors for heavens hereafter. (2.32)

Comments: Not all kshatriyas get an opportunity to wage a just war. So, when such an opportunity has been given to Arjuna without any effort (and by the Grace of the Lord), he should embrace the opportunity which would open for him the doors to heavens hereafter.

AW MV Èd{` Yâ¶ gJm` Z H\$[aî`{g`&
VV... ñdY_` H\$s{V M {hÈdm nmn\_dmßñ`{g`&& 33`&&

In case you decide to relinquish your responsibility to fight for a just cause, you will be guilty of abdicating duty, you will suffer loss of reputation here and accrue sins. (2.33)

Comments: To convince Arjuna that it is a duty, not an option, for him to fight the war, Krishna now indicates the outcome for Arjuna if he does not fight. Arjuna would suffer loss of reputation in this world and accrue sins for abdicating his responsibility, with consequences hereafter.

AH\$s{V Mm{n ^Vm{Z H\$W{`î`pYV V@î``m_`&
gâ^m{dVñ` MmH\$s{V\_aUmX{V[aÀ`V`&& 34`&&

Everyone will talk about your loss of reputation and for a worthy person, loss of reputation is more dreadful than death. (2.34)

Comments: Krishna indicates that the negative effect of refusing to fight is permanent loss of reputation. For someone who is revered among professional peers, a loss of reputation can be worse than defeat and death.

^`mXaUmXnaV \_ñ`ÝV Ěd m _hmaWm... Ý&
 `f m M Ěd ~h \_V m ^Ěd m `mñ`{g b mKd _ Ý&& 35 Ý&&

Great warriors will conclude that you ran away from the battlefield as you were afraid to fight. You will be disgraced in front of those who hold you in great esteem. (2.35)

Comments: This verse responds to Arjuna's argument that his opposition to fighting the war was due to his compassion and not due to fear of losing. Krishna says that Arjuna was held in high esteem as a great warrior based on his winning many battles, and other great warriors can now conclude that Arjuna ran away from the war as he was afraid of facing them. After all, many other participants in this war (on both sides) would also lose their near and dear ones and they had not backed away.

AdmÀ`d mXmü ~hZ d{Xî`pÝV Vd m{hV m... Ý&
 {ZÝXÝVñVd g m _İ` V m X... I Va Z {H\$` Ý&& 36 Ý&&

Your enemies will talk disparagingly about your valor in many unspeakable ways. What is more dreadful than this? (2.36)

Comments: To further convince Arjuna of the perils of backing away from fighting, Krishna says that in addition to other great warriors assembled there, many enemies of Arjuna whom he had defeated earlier could now conclude and spread the word that Arjuna was incapable of fighting a war. This could be extremely insulting, especially for a *kshatriya*.

hV m d m àmßñŦ{g ñdJ {OĚd m d m ^mú`g _hr _ Ý&
 Vñ _mX{Îmð H\$mÝV` `Ōm` H\$V{Zü`... Ý&& 37 Ý&&

If you fight and die in this battle, you are sure to reach heaven. If you win, you will rule this world. O Son of Kunti! Rise up and fight this battle with strong determination. (2.37)

Comments: In verse 2.6, Arjuna had expressed his doubt about whether it was better for the Pandavas to win the war or for the Kauravas to win. Krishna responds to that doubt here. After discussing the impact on Arjuna's reputation for backing away from a just war, Krishna now goes on to convince him that he is in a win-win situation and has nothing to lose by fighting the war. If Arjuna were to win this war, he would get back the kingdom and reach heavens hereafter for adhering to his duties. If he were to lose the war and die, he would surely reach the heavens for his efforts in fighting the evil. Either way, he wins.

g l X... l g_ H\$Edm bm^bm^m O`mO`m y&
VWm `Öm `Á`ñd Zd nmn'dmßñ`{g y&& 38 &&

Treat happiness and sadness, profit and loss, victory and defeat with equipoise and fight for justice. You will not be tainted with sin. (2.38)

Comments: In verse 1.36, Arjuna says that he may accrue sins by fighting the war, as that would result in loss of life to many. Krishna answers that point by stating that performing one's prescribed duty as an offering to the Lord will not attract sins and in fact will help accrue positive credit. One must treat with equanimity - happiness and sadness, profit, loss, victory and defeat in all actions and perform them as offerings to the Lord. Arjuna must get over any sadness due to the loss of near and dear ones and focus on performing his duty.

Instrument to Acquire Knowledge

Efm V@{^hVm gm>>`~{Ö`mJ pEd_m eU y&
~Öçm `°\$m ``m nmW H\$_~Y àhmñ`{g y&& 39&&

O Partha! You have been told about the nature of *Sankhya* (knowledge) so far. Now listen to the ways (*yoga*) to achieve that knowledge which will free you from bondage. (2.39)

Comments: From verses 2.12 to 2.38, Krishna gives Arjuna knowledge (*sankhya*) about the Lord and the individual souls. From now on, He teaches Arjuna the methods and procedures of acquiring such knowledge after which Arjuna would be able to perform his prescribed duties with conviction, realize the Lord, get over worldly bondage and achieve the state of eternal bliss (*moksha*). While previous verses discussed the nature of individual souls and briefly, the nature of the Supreme Lord, from now on till the end of Chapter 6, more details about the methods and procedures to learn about the nature of the Lord are provided. Also, so far, Krishna had addressed Arjuna's specific situation, and from now on, the teachings would turn generic in that they would apply to the whole of mankind.

Zhm{^H\$_Zmem@pñV àĒ`dm`m Z {dÚV Ĩ&
ñdēn_β`ñ`Y_ñ`Ìm`V_hVm ^`mV Ĩ&& 40 &&

Even if one falters in the beginning during the learning of this spiritual knowledge, no effort is wasted. Even a little sincere effort will protect one from great peril. (2.40)

Comments: This verse answers the doubts that some may have about the efforts required to achieve spiritual knowledge. Given the significant efforts required, what would happen if one could not complete the task? The Lord states that no effort is wasted. Even if someone starts the process and for some reason gets interrupted, the efforts will yield positive results. Any sincere effort will please the Lord and through His grace one will be able to achieve spiritual awakening.

ì`dgm`mpĒ_H\$m ~{ŌaH\$h H\$éZÝXZ Ĩ&
~hem I m øZÝVmü ~Ō`m@ì`dgm{`Zm` Ĩ&& 41 Ĩ&&

O Scion of the Kuru Dynasty (Arjuna)! There is only one teaching that leads to decisive spiritual knowledge. There are endless teachings that lead the undecided ones to diverse, wrong knowledge. (2.41)

Comments: There are different teachings (often contradictory) about spiritual knowledge. How then does one know the true path? Krishna in this verse categorically states that only true teaching leads to proper divine and spiritual knowledge. This is based on evidence from revered spiritual texts such as the **Vedas** and is realized from following the Vaishnava path which enunciates the supremacy of Lord Vishnu as the supreme of all souls. In the next few verses (from 2.41 to 2.46), the Lord clears any doubts about the true purport of the **Vedas**.

It is interesting to note that the Lord refers to Arjuna as Kurunandana, meaning ‘Scion of the Kuru dynasty who would bring joy to his lineage’, probably implying that most of the descendants of the Kuru dynasty such as Duryodhana and his 99 brothers belong to the type of people who believe in various, wrong teachings. Arjuna is different and can dispel his doubts and regain the spiritual knowledge he had already possessed.

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥
 दध्नाय नमः ॥ ४२ ॥

हस्त्यै नमः ॥
 {H\$`m{def~hb^mJœ`JqV à{V ॥ ४३ ॥

O Partha! Those with peripheral knowledge of the **Vedas** say that attaining heavens is the only goal of following the **Vedas**, ignoring the lofty goal of liberation (*moksha*). They only focus on temporary worldly riches and pleasures and believe that they are the end goals of conducting Vedic rituals. (2.42) (2.43)

Comments: As the **Vedas** can be interpreted in multiple ways, many focus only on the peripheral interpretation and conclude that the Vedic texts teach only rituals to appease lesser deities, which would result in achieving desired riches and materialistic happiness in this lifetime and enjoying heavenly fruits hereafter. Krishna categorically speaks against this viewpoint and strongly advises that the real purport of the **Vedas** is to help one achieve liberation, the state of everlasting, pure and complete bliss (*Moksha*), and not riches and heavens which are temporary. Using the **Vedas** only to reach the heavens would be like plucking a flower from a tree, without waiting for the flower to fully transform into a fruit (which represents *Moksha*).

^mJæ`àg°\$mZm V`m@növMVgm_ | V&
 ì`dg`mpË_H\$m ~{Ö... g_mYm Z {dYr`V V&& 44 &&

With their minds corrupted with such wrong thinking, they immerse themselves in pursuit of worldly pleasures and will not have the conviction to pursue correct knowledge and the concentration to focus their minds on the Lord. (2.44)

Comments: What is wrong in enjoying the riches achieved by performing Vedic rituals with sincerity? After all these fruits have been earned using legitimate, moral means as enunciated in the **Vedas**. Lord Krishna responds by saying that indulgence in such temporary pleasures will focus their minds only on material issues and their minds will not be able meditate on the Lord. Concentrated meditation is required to gain proper spiritual knowledge.

Vedas – Peripheral and Inner Meanings

ìJÊ`{df`m dXm {ZóJÊ`m ^dmOZ V&
 {ZÛYÛm {ZË`gÎdñWm {Z`mJj_ AmË_dmZ V&& 45&&

O Arjuna! Peripherally the **Vedas** appear to describe rituals that result in attainment of heavenly and worldly fruits made up of the three attributes. Do not aspire for these. Go beyond dualities (such as pleasure and pain). Focus your mind on the Lord Almighty and leave it to the Lord to help you attain your goals and to help you protect goals already attained. (2.45)

Comments: The Lord continues to teach about the real purport of the **Vedas**. In this verse, the Lord instructs that one should not focus on the peripheral meaning of the **Vedas** that appear to provide details of rituals to help achieve worldly fruits. These fruits and even heavens that one may achieve are borne out of material nature which is a mixture of three attributes – *sat*, *rajas* and *tamas*. As such, these are not permanent, and even if one reaches the heavens, one is bound to fall back to earth after expending merits from good deeds. One should detach oneself from *yoga* (striving for proscribed material entities not already owned) and *kshema* (protecting proscribed material entities already possessed). The real purport of the **Vedas** is to describe the nature of the Lord Almighty. One should focus on the Lord who will help one achieve everlasting bliss (*nirvana*).

`m d m Z W C X n m Z g d V ... g a ß b V m X H \$ ÿ &
V m d m Z g d f d X f ~ m ÷ U ñ ` { d O m Z V ... ÿ & & 46 & &

The benefit derived from a small body of water such as a well is better derived from a sumptuous water body such as an ocean. Likewise, benefits derived from following Vedic rituals with proper meaning are surely available for one with special knowledge who has realized the Lord Almighty. (2.46)

Comments: In the previous verses, it was indicated that the real purport of the **Vedas** is in understanding of the Lord and not in transient material benefits including attaining the heavens. It was made clear that one who goes by the peripheral meaning of the **Vedas** and performs rituals only to attain transient material benefits will never achieve everlasting bliss. A

question arises as to whether the seeker who goes by the inner meaning of the **Vedas** and realizes the Lord will be eligible for transient fruits such as the heavens. This verse answers that question through an example. Just as the benefits available from well water are available from a larger body of water such as a lake or an ocean, one who has realized the Lord by proper understanding of the **Vedas** will surely achieve transient benefits such as heavens, even when one is not focused on them.

Sri Raghavendra Swamy in his **Gita Vivruti** [GV] provides an explanation for the words *brahmana* (one who has realized the Lord) and *vijanatha* (one who has special knowledge) where both appear to mean the same thing. Sri Rayaru says that *vijanatha* indicates the one who has *paroksha* (or indirect) knowledge of the Lord and *brahmana* indicates one who has gone a step further and has realized *aparoksha* or direct knowledge of the Lord. In that sense, for one to obtain direct knowledge of the Lord, one must first start by learning the knowledge indirectly (through a qualified teacher, studying Vedic scriptures etc.).

Sri Rayaru provides a second meaning for this verse, by interpreting the Sanskrit terms *samplutodaka* and *udapana* differently. Earlier *samplutodaka* referred to a large body of water (ex: an ocean) and *udapana* referred to a small body of water (ex: well). Sri Rayaru provides a second meaning for these terms. *Samplutodaka* means the ocean that dissolves the universe during the grand dissolution and *udapana* refers to the Lord Almighty who protects the eternal entities in the universe such as souls, time etc. With this interpretation, the verse can also be translated to mean as follows: Whatever advantage (such as *dharma*, *moksha* etc.) is obtained through the Grace of the Lord Almighty who protects everything during the great dissolution of the universe, the same advantage will be accrued by a seeker who has realized the Lord through proper interpretation of the **Vedas**.

Duty is Worship

H\$ _Ê` dñ{YH\$mañV _m \ \$bf H\$XmMZ Ý&
 _m H\$ _\ \$bhV^ _m V g“m@ñĚdH\$_{U Ý&& 47 &&

You only have the right to do your duty, and never to its fruits. Never perform your duties with expectations of outcomes. At the same time, never think about relinquishing your duties. (2.47)

Comments: This is probably the most commented upon verse in the **Gita**. It answers the question as to the purpose of performing ones' prescribed duties when there is no guarantee of getting expected results. Even if someone does not see any immediate material benefits from performing ones' prescribed duties, such actions will please the Lord. They will result in one obtaining true knowledge about the Lord and eventually achieving everlasting bliss. This is implied in the first line of this verse. Another question that one can raise is the purpose of someone performing any action at all, as earlier in verse 2.45, it was stated that one should always focus ones mind on the Lord. The second line of this verse answers this question by stating that in addition to focusing the mind on the Lord, one must perform prescribed duties; otherwise, one will accrue sins due to relinquishing of duties. In addition to the philosophical reasons, we can all appreciate the fact that for a society to function smoothly, every one of us must play our assigned roles with diligence and sincerity. Such activities, especially when performed as an offering to the Lord, will help us receive the Lord's grace to help us in our spiritual journey. Lord Krishna is instructing Arjuna here that he should not shirk from his prescribed duty of fighting for a just cause, just because he is uncomfortable with the thought of losing his loved ones.

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides a second meaning for this verse. He translates the phrase '*karma phala hetu*' (the entity responsible to grant fruits for actions) as the Lord Almighty, as He alone can grant someone the fruits. As per verse 2.45, one should not consider oneself identical to the

Lord as the Lord is supreme and He alone can grant one's wishes. The second interpretation of this verse is as follows: Arjuna! Individual souls can only perform prescribed duties. They do not have the ability to obtain the fruits by themselves. That ability is only with the Lord. Individual souls are quite different and are subservient to the Lord and hence one should never consider oneself as the Lord.

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides convincing responses to many other deep, philosophical questions in his interpretation of this verse. Following is the summary:

- Even those who have already realized the Lord have to keep performing duties.
- For one who has already realized the Lord, any additional credit from performing duties will result in buoyant happiness in *moksha* (the level of bliss in *moksha* is dependent on the innate capabilities of souls, but additional credits will result in buoyant happiness, just like when milk boils over, the amount of milk does not change but the milk exhibits more buoyancy)
- No one is exempt from performing one's prescribed duties
- While this verse indicates that one should not perform duties with an expectation of the outcome, it is not prohibited for someone to perform activities with loftier expectations of spiritual knowledge and the Lord's Grace. One should avoid expectations of temporary, transient, material fruits.
- Although phrases such as '*swarga kamo yajeta*' prescribe rituals for fulfilment of mundane desires, the scriptures do not mandate such actions for fulfilment of desires.
- Major distinction between individual beings and the Lord in the context of duties and fruits:
 - Individual Beings: Have responsibility to perform duties. Cannot grant wishes.
 - Lord Almighty: Has no prescribed responsibility. Can grant wishes.

`mJñW... H\$é H\$\_{U} g“ Ē`³Edm YZO` Ĩ&
{gÕç{gÕçm... g_m ^Ēdm g_Ēd `mJ CÀ`V Ĩ&& 48 &&

O Dhananjaya! On your spiritual path (*yoga*), perform duties without attachments and expectations of results. The real *yoga* is performing one's duties without expectations and with equanimity. (2.48)

Comments: From verses 2.48 onwards, the Lord provides more details on the concept of *nishkama karma* (performing prescribed duties without expectations). In the previous verse 2.47, the Lord instructs Arjuna never to think of relinquishing prescribed duties. This verse responds to the question as to how one should perform prescribed duties. *Yoga* is having no expectations of results from duties performed *and* being equanimous to positive or negative outcomes. These are not two separate definitions of *yoga*.

Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha has provided a detailed description of a *yogi* identified in this verse as –

(i) one whose mind and intellect are transfixed at the feet of the Lord with the knowledge of the Lord's omnipresence, omnipotence, and omniscience.

(ii) one who engages in actions without attachment to the act itself or the fruits of such actions.

(iii) one who engages in all activities only to please the Lord and as a service to the Lord.

(iv) one who, knowing fully well that everything is at the will and command of the Lord, accepts success or failure with equanimity.

XaU øda H\$_ ~{Õ`mJmX YZO` Ĩ&
~Õm eaU_pÝdÀN> H\$nUm... \ \$bhVd... Ĩ&& 49 &&

O Dhananjaya! Performing duties with expectation of the outcome is very inferior to the task of attaining divine spiritual knowledge. Wretched are those whose motive is fruit of the action. Focus your mind on spiritual knowledge. (2.49)

Comments: In 2.46, it was indicated that one should avoid performing Vedic rituals for temporary gains but instead focus on the inner meaning of **the Vedas** to attain proper spiritual knowledge. In that sense, performing duties with expectation of material outcome is inferior to the task of attaining divine knowledge. This verse answers the question as to the reason for this distinction. One who is focused only on activities yielding temporary gains will realize sooner or later that such gains will not last and will start feeling miserable. Hence there is no point in performing activities with such expectations.

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides an alternate interpretation for the second half of this verse in response to a question as to whether someone who has already attained spiritual knowledge can consider himself as one with the Lord. By interpreting the phrase *phala hetava* (the one who grants wishes) as referring to the Lord, Sri Rayaru says that even those who have attained spiritual knowledge will not claim identity with the Lord as such a claim would lead to unending misery.

~{Ö`°\$m OhmVrh C^ gH\$VXîH\$V î&
Vñ_úJm` `Á`ñd `mJ... H\$_g H\$meb_ î&& 50&&

One who has realized the Lord Almighty will be rid of the consequences of good or bad deeds. Therefore, focus on performing your duties with the goal of achieving divine, spiritual knowledge. This is the best path. (2.50)

Comments: In the previous verse 2.49, it was indicated that activities performed with expectations of material gains are inferior to the activities pursued in attaining divine knowledge.

That technique which steers one clear of worldly entanglement and ushers one towards the transcendental is ‘skill in action’ (*karmasu kauśalam*). In this verse, some of the special advantages of these superior activities are outlined. It is indicated that one who has realized the Lord will be rid of the consequences of good and bad deeds which is the essential last step in achieving *moksha*. A question that would arise naturally is about the reason for consequences of even good deeds to be nullified. Sri Rayaru in GV provides an answer. Good deeds are of two kinds – first one that leads to more clarity on divine knowledge and more exuberant happiness in *moksha* (*ishta punya*), and second ones (*anishta punya*) that do not. Credits from good deeds of the second kind must be used up in this world (in current or future births) while credits from the first kind of good deed will be carried forward till one achieves *moksha*. The Lord categorically states that among all activities, those that lead to attainment of divine knowledge are supreme.

Sri Rayaru [GV] provides a second interpretation for the second half of this verse. One can ask the question - If one feels that one can put in all required efforts to attain spiritual knowledge (which is the goal for achieving *moksha*), why should one perform activities without expectations on material outcomes? Sri Rayaru answers saying that only activities that are performed for the sole purpose of pleasing the Lord and obtaining divine knowledge will lead to *moksha*.

Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha Swamiji in his **Gita Saroddhara** [BGS] indicates that this verse reflects the summary of entire chapter 2. This is very appropriate as in this chapter Arjuna in verses 2.4 to 2.8 had expressed the conflict in his mind about his course of action and requested Krishna for guidance. Krishna categorically states in this verse that one needs to perform ones prescribed duty with the goal of achieving divine, spiritual knowledge and that Arjuna needs to engage himself in fighting this holy war to protect his citizens.

H\$ _O ~{Ö`°\$m {h \ \$b È`³Edm _Zr{fU... ĩ&
OY _~Y{d{Z _°\$m... nX JÀNÝÈ`Zm \_` _ ĩ&& 51 &&

The wise who have learnt about the supremacy of the Lord Almighty, dedicate the fruits of their labour to the Lord and acquire direct, divine knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*). They escape the cycle of births and deaths and reach the state of eternal bliss. (2.51)

Comments: In this verse, the Lord provides additional benefits of obtaining proper spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnana* = direct, divine knowledge) which results in attaining *moksha*. One who reaches *moksha* will not only be devoid of sadness or blemishes but will also permanently escape the cycle of births and deaths. Lord Krishna is emphasizing the permanence of *moksha* as opposed to the transitory benefits of heavens. Sri Rayaru in GV explains the reason for interpreting the word ‘*manīṣiṇaḥ*’ as the one with direct, divine knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*). The word ‘*manīṣi*’ means incredibly special knowledge, and direct divine knowledge certainly qualifies for this description.

`Xm V \_mhH\$ {bb ~{Öi`{V[aî`{V ĩ&
VXm JÝV{g {ZdX I mVi`ñ` IVñ` M ĩ&& 52 &&

Once your mind is cleansed of ignorant viewpoints, you will derive full benefits from the teachings you have heard so far and the teachings you will hear in future. (2.52)

Comments: Lord Krishna answers the question as to how and when one will be able to properly understand teachings delivered so far and the teachings yet to be delivered. One must first cleanse one’s mind of ignorant viewpoints which will then allow one’s mind to grasp the teachings properly.

I {V{dà{VnBm V `Wm ñWmñ`{V {Züb... ĩ&
g _mYmdMb ~{ÖñVXm `mJ \_dmñ`{g ĩ&& 53 &&

Once you develop conviction in spiritual teachings, your mind will become steadfast. At that time, you will be able to follow the path of divine knowledge. (2.53)

Comments: In 2.52, it was indicated that one must rid oneself of ignorant viewpoints. In this verse, the questions about what ignorant viewpoints really are and how one could be rid of them are answered. Ignorant viewpoints are those that are not supported by authentic scriptures such as the **Vedas**. Ones who have developed strong conviction about teachings from scriptures such as the **Vedas** will be able to rid themselves of ignorant viewpoints without any doubt. They will then be ready to focus their minds on the Lord which will lead to eternal bliss through the grace of the Lord.

Sri Rayaru [GV] provides a second interpretation of this verse based on Sri Madhwacharya's commentary in GTN where the phrase '*shruti vipratipanna*' is interpreted alternately as '*shruti visheshena pratipanna*' to mean – one with the right viewpoint based on authentic scriptures (*shruti*). Based on this, the verse can be interpreted to mean the following – The one who has realized the Lord based on proper understanding of the **Vedas** will have one's mind firmly placed on the Lord and will eventually attain *moksha* through the Lord's grace.

Equanimity and Mental Tranquility

AOZ CdmM Ĩ&

pñWVàkñ` H\$m ^mf g\_m{YñWñ` H\$ed Ĩ&

pñWVYr... qH\$ à^mfV {H\$_mgrV dOV {H\$‘ Ĩ&& 54&&

Arjuna said: O Keshava! What are the characteristics of a person who has developed unwavering conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge (*Stita Prajna*)? How does that person talk or sit or walk (in other words, why does that person need to engage in any activity)? (2.54)

Comments: This is perhaps one of the most widely quoted verse from the **Gita**. After listening to the Lord's teachings about the need for one to perform prescribed duties without expectations, focusing the mind on the Lord and related topics, Arjuna is now curious to know the characteristics of a person who has developed unwavering conviction (tranquil mind) in divine knowledge. It is interesting that he uses the term '*bhasha*' to mean characteristics instead of the more common word '*lakshana*'. Arjuna, by using the term '*samadhi*' (state of complete mental concentration on the Lord), has himself defined a characteristic (*lakshana*) of a person with deep conviction in divine knowledge. By using the word '*bhasha*', Arjuna is enquiring about the characteristic of such a person when that person is out of *samadhi* and is engaged in normal day to day activities. References to talking, sitting, walking etc., in this verse here imply normal day today activities. In other words, Arjuna wants to know how the person with firm resolve performs day to day activities (when not in state of *samadhi*).

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides a second interpretation for this verse as follows: Why does one who has achieved divine knowledge need to perform activities such as talking, sitting, walking etc.? Here the word '*kim*' is used to mean 'why'. In that sense it is a rhetorical question. Why should someone who has already achieved the state of *samadhi* and has developed unwavering conviction in the Lord indulge in any mundane, day to day worldly activities?

The Lord responds to Arjuna's questions in the remaining verses of this chapter which undoubtedly form the core teachings of the **Gita**.

Ir^JdmZdmM Ÿ&
 àOhm{V `Xm H\$m _mZ gdmZ nmW _ZmJVmZ Ÿ&
 AmĚ_Ÿ`dm@Ě\_Zm ViŸ... pñWVàkñVXmÀ`V Ÿ&& 55 &&

The Lord said: O Partha! One who has conquered mental blemishes such as desire and has focused mind on the Lord Almighty will achieve mental tranquility by the grace of the Lord. (2.55)

Comments: The Lord answers Arjuna's question 2.54, from 2.55 onwards till the end of this chapter. For the rhetorical question in the second line of 2.54, the Lord answers in verse 2.69. While desire is mentioned as a blemish that one needs to conquer, this also applies to other blemishes such as greed, anger, hatred etc. Note that desire here refers to worldly desires and not lofty desires such as achieving divine knowledge. Sri Rayaru [GV] explains the special reason for the use of the word 'manogatan' (mental) in this verse. Blemishes such as desire, greed, anger etc., originate in the mind. That being the case, what is the reason for using the qualifier 'mental' in 'mental blemishes'? The divine knowledge that one would attain by the grace of the Lord also manifests in the same mind. For the same mind to attain divine knowledge, it is necessary to be rid of worldly blemishes. It is to drive home the fact that divine knowledge also resides in the same mind that the qualifier 'mental' is used in this verse.

In verse 2.39, the Lord started out saying that He would teach the path (*yoga*) to obtain divine knowledge. However, in this verse, He is teaching the characteristics of a *yogi* who has already attained divine knowledge. How can this be reconciled? Sri Rayaru [GV] states that for a seeker interested in traversing the path towards divine knowledge, it is important to learn about the characteristics of *yogis* who have already successfully traversed that path.

X... I îdZ{Ô¾_Zm... g l f {dJVñnh... î&
drVamJ^`H\$mY... pñWVYr\_{ZéÀ`V î&& 56 &&

One whose mind is not depressed by distress or elated by happiness and who is devoid of desires or anger, or fear is known as steadfast in consciousness. (2.56)

Comments: In the next 3 verses, the Lord provides more details on the characteristics of a person with mental tranquility. In 2.55, worldly desire was mentioned as example of a blemish. Here that concept is extended to include other blemishes such as obsession, fear, and anger.

`...gdìṁZ{^ñZhñVîṁV àṁṁ e^ṁe^_ ṁ&
Zṁ{^ZÝX{V Z Ū{i} Vñ` àkṁ à{V{ðVṁ ṁ&& 57 &&

One with deep conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnani*) will not have attachment in all dealings and will neither rejoice over pleasure nor experience hatred during distress. (2.57)

Comments: The reason for this equanimity in both pleasure and discomfort in such a person is the lack of attachment to worldly issues.

The previous verse 2.56 identified the absence of anger as one of the characteristics of a person with mental tranquility and this verse indicates the absence of hatred during distress as another characteristic. Sri Jaya Teertha in his PD clarifies that there is no repetition here as the absence of hatred in 2.57 refers to all situations (due to the use of the word *sarvatrāg*) including those where there may be reasons for such hatred.

`Xṁ ghaV Mṁ` H\$_ṁ@“ṁZrd gde... ṁ&
BpÝÐ`ṁUrpÝÐ`ṁWä`ñVñ` àkṁ à{V{ðVṁ ṁ&& 58&&

A person of steady wisdom can easily withdraw sense organs away from objects of senses just as a tortoise withdraws its limbs at will. (2.58)

Comments: A person with mental tranquility can control sense organs from indulging in objects of sensory pleasures such as sound, touch, form, taste, and smell. The image of the tortoise which withdraws its limbs at will is used to signify the ease with which such a person is able to control sense organs.

{df`m {d{ZdV'V {Zamhman` X{hZ... ' &
agdO agm@B`ñ` na ÑîQm {ZdV ' && 59 &&

By fasting, one can reduce the ability of one's body to consume and digest food, but not the cravings to indulge in tasty food. Those cravings can only be diminished by realizing the Lord Almighty. (2.59)

Comments: The next 3 verses are about sense control. By practicing self-discipline such as fasting, one experiences reduced power in the five sense organs of perception such as eyes, ears, nose, tongue, and skin. However, the craving experienced by the mind to indulge in sense pleasures does not diminish. This can only happen when one experiences a vision of Lord Almighty.

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides an alternate meaning to this verse by interpreting the word '*rasa varjam*' to mean desires in objects of all sensory pleasures except taste. This means that by fasting one may experience loss of desire in the objects of sense pleasures such as sound, form, smell, and touch but not in the sense object of taste. This can only be overcome when one experiences a vision of Lord Almighty. This interpretation is also consistent with practical experience as when one ages and loses power and interest in seeing, listening, hearing etc., the desire to taste good food never goes away. In summary, a seeker should strive to achieve control over all sense organs and mind.

`VVm Ø{n H\$m'V` néfñ` {dn{üV... ' &
hpÝÐ`m{U à _mWr{Z hap'V àg^ _Z... ' && 60 &&

O Son of Kunti! It is the nature of sense organs to get attracted to sense pleasures. Despite many efforts, even learned ones experience their sense organs swaying strongly. (2.60)

Comments: If one can understand that one needs to control one's sense organs from indulging in sense pleasures (discipline in consumption -

pratyahara) and focus one's minds on attaining spiritual knowledge, one may be able to conquer their sense organs. In that case why should one undertake difficult activities such as fasting - *nirahara* etc.? This verse answers this question by stating that sense organs are extremely strong and can exert control on the minds of even learned ones. It is the nature of sense organs to cause turbulence in one's mind. Hence, one must undertake difficult rituals such as fasting on special days etc., in addition to spiritual studies and try to overcome the influence of sense organs on one's mind.

The sense organs and the mind are inert objects. A question then arises as to how these inert objects can exert such control over each other. One must remember that the sense organs, while inert, are activated by the Lord resident in every soul based on the innate nature of that soul. So, it is the responsibility of the individual soul to try and control the activities of the sense organs.

Vṁ{Z gdm{U g`â` `°\$ AṁgrV _Ēna... ṽ&
de {h `ñ`pÝĐ`ṁ{U Vñ` àkṁ à{V{đVṁ ṽ&& 61&&

One should control one's sense organs from indulgence with a firm conviction on the supremacy of the Lord. Such a person will indeed attain divine knowledge, (2.61)

Comments: From previous discussions, it appears that one needs to control one's sense organs to attain divine, spiritual knowledge. However, it also appears that one needs to have possessed such divine, spiritual knowledge to be permanently free from the control of sense organs. This appears to be a circular argument and hence is logically untenable (*anyonyashraya dosha*). How can this be reconciled? Sri Rayaru [GV] points to this verse for the answer. One must try and control one's sense organs while at the same time focus mind on the Supreme Lord. This will allow the mind to move towards concentrated meditation (*dhyana*) which allows one to undertake difficult sense control tasks such as strict fasting,

and eventually conquer the sense organs. Such a person is now ready to absorb divine, spiritual knowledge paving the way for *moksha*.

Sri Rayaru [GV] clarifies that for one to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*), in addition to achieving full control over the sense organs, a seeker also needs to conquer emotions such as desire, hatred etc., as described later in verse 2.64.

Dangers in Sensual Indulgence

Ü`m`Vm {df`mZ ng... g“ñVfnOm`V ĩ&
g“mV gOm`V H\$m\_... H\$m\_mV H\$mYm@{^Om`V ĩ&& 62&&

H\$mYmX ^d{V gâ_mh... g_mhV ñ_{V{d^_... ĩ&
ñ_{V^emX ~{ÖZme ~{ÖZmeX àUí`{V ĩ&& 63&&

One who keeps contemplating on sense pleasures develops an attachment and obsession with them, which leads to desire in experiencing such pleasures. This desire in turn leads to anger in the event of not being able to satisfy these desires. Anger leads to delusion and clouds one's mind about right and wrong. This delusion leads one to forget injunctions against forbidden activities. This forgetfulness in turn leads to failure in intellectual judgement. Loss of intellect results in one's downfall. (2.62) (2.63)

Comments: In verse 2.63, it was stated that one should focus ones mind on the Lord while striving to achieve self-control to conquer the sense organs. In verses 2.62, 2.63, 2.64, the Lord outlines the chain reaction that would ensue from loss of self-control and the emotional impact of attachment/aversion or likes/dislikes (*raga/dvesha*) leading to ones downfall (and eventual fall into hell). Understanding of this chain reaction will help one to develop equanimity in likes and dislikes.

The chain reaction is as follows: contemplation on sense pleasures -> obsession -> desire -> anger -> delusion -> forgetfulness -> loss of

intellect -> destruction. Forgetfulness could be of two types. One would be forgetting knowledge about avoiding activities prohibited in the scriptures and the other would be to forget societal norms such as not usurping properties owned by others. As indicated in 2.56, one who has realized the Lord will have conquered these emotions, but a seeker on the spiritual path will have to strive to control these emotions, or else he/she will experience the state indicated in the chain reaction. The primary cause of the chain reaction is the inability to manage *raga*, and *dvesha*. This aspect is further explained in the next verse.

amJÛf{d`°\$ñV {df`m{ZpÝÐ`üaZ Ý&
AmĚ_dí`{dY`mĚ_m àgmX_{YJÀN{V Ý&& 64 &&

àgmX gdX... I mZm hm{Zañ`mnOm`V Ý&
àgPMVg_m øme ~{Ö... n`d{Vð{V Ý&& 65 &&

One, whose sense organs are under control and are not perturbed by the effects of likes/dislikes, attachment/hatred, will partake in just enough sense indulgence for physical health and, through self-control will experience peace of mind. (2.64),

One whose mind is at peace will quickly absorb divine, spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*). Then, such a person will be rid of all miseries. This concept is well known through the scriptures. (2.65)

Comments: These two verses indicate the benefits one would accrue by controlling the emotions of likes and dislikes. The benefits are – victory over sense organs and mental peace. In 2.61, it was indicated that one who has conquered sense organs will attain direct, divine (*aparoksha*) knowledge. However, sense control itself will not directly lead to attainment of divine knowledge. Sense control leads to mental peace allowing one to practice concentrated meditation. This leads to attaining direct, divine knowledge. So the immediate advantage of self-control is mental peace which eventually leads to direct, divine knowledge in a serial

manner. It is also clarified that one who has achieved control over sense organs can indulge in sense activities just enough to maintain physical wellbeing. In verse 2.59, it was indicated that one would need to undertake difficult tasks such as fasting to achieve self-control. Here it is clarified that one does not need to completely avoid consuming foods as one has to ensure physical wellbeing. It is possible to indulge in activities such as consuming minimum amount of required food while still exerting control over the sense organs.

In summary, the sequence of events that would unfold from achieving self-control are as follows: Self-control (over sense organs) -> mental peace -> concentrated meditation -> divine knowledge -> elimination of sadness (due to evisceration of sins) -> liberation.

ZmñV ~{Öa`°\$ñ` Z Mm`°\$ñ` ^mdZm V&
 Z Mm^md`V... em{VaemVñ` H\$V... g l _ && 66 &&

One who does not have control over the mind cannot absorb spiritual knowledge. Such a person also cannot meditate peacefully. How can one achieve liberation without meditation? How can one enjoy bliss without liberation? (2.66)

Comments: The next two verses describe the perils of not being able to control one's mind. If one can achieve divine, spiritual knowledge through scriptural studies and analysis, why would one need to control ones mind? This verse answers by stating that one who does not control the mind will not be able to practice concentrated meditation without which one will not be able to absorb difficult concepts in the scriptures. Also, in this verse it is stated that one who does not achieve liberation (*moksha*) cannot enjoy bliss. One can question the reason for explicitly stating that eternal bliss can only be enjoyed by those in *moksha*. It must be noted that in 2.65, it was stated that when one is liberated, one will be rid of unhappiness. This verse clarifies that in *moksha* not only will one be rid of misery, but one will also enjoy pure bliss.

BpÝÐ`mUm {h MaVm `Ý_Zm@Z{dYr`V Ý&
 VXñ` ha{V àk m dm`Zmd{ dmâ^g Ý&& 67 &&

The mind which follows sense organs that go after sense pleasures will be swayed just like a ship gets swayed in an ocean by strong winds. This leads to loss of intellectual judgement and also knowledge derived through studies. (2.67)

Comments: This verse makes it very clear that even one who has learnt a lot through study of scriptures and contemplation of scriptural concepts will not be able to benefit from such knowledge if one is unable to control the mind and the sense organs. Mere acquisition of scriptural knowledge without exercising control over the senses and the mind amounts to just book knowledge. The mind is easily swayed. If sense organs pursue sense pleasures, the mind will follow them and will sway just like a boat in an ocean and loses direction when faced with strong winds.

The example of a ship getting swayed by strong winds brings to memory an episode in the life of Sri Madhwacharya. Acharya was once meditating on the seashore near Udupi when he saw a ship caught in a violent storm. The people on the ship were crying for help. Acharya waved his holy fabric (*kavi shati*) towards the ship, at which the ship immediately stabilized on the waters and came safely ashore. The travelers on the ship who were rescued by Acharya were very grateful and offered him precious gems on board the ship, but Acharya was content with just a lump of sandstone (*gopi chandana*) that was used to tie the ship's mast. Inside the sandstone was a beautiful idol of Sri Krishna which was worshipped by Goddess Rukmini and Lord Brahma. Sri Madhwacharya carried that idol and installed it in Udupi where it can be seen even today! We can see the relevance of using the example of a ship swaying in the ocean in this verse considering this episode. Our body is like a ship that we are using to cross the ocean of *samsara*. Inside our body, Lord Krishna resides in our hearts just like the idol of Sri Krishna was inside the sandstone. Just as the

travelers on the ship did not know the value of the sandstone piece which had the idol of Sri Krishna in it, we too do not appreciate the presence of the Lord in our hearts. Just as the travelers on the ship faced violent turbulence due to strong winds, we also feel great perturbation in our minds due to strong swaying of our sense organs. The travelers saw Sri Madhwacharya and cried for help. Acharya rescued them immediately. Similarly, if we turn to Sri Madhwacharya (an incarnation of Sri Vayudeva) asking for help in traversing this ocean of *samsara*, he will rescue us and land us safely in *moksha*.

Vñ _mÚñ` _hm~mm {ZJhrVm{Z gde... ĩ&
BpÝĐ`mUrpÝĐ`mWä`ñVñ` àkñ à{V{đVm ĩ&& 68&&

O Mahabaho (Arjuna, one with strong arms)! One who controls the sense organs from straying towards sense objects will attain deep conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge. (2.68)

Comments: In the 4 verses, starting from verse 2.55 to 2.58, the Lord described the characteristics of a person with mental tranquility. In the 9 verses from 2.59 to 2.67, questions about the nature of such a person were answered. This verse is a concluding summary of the above 9 verses. The sequence of stages for such a person to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge are sense-control -> peace of mind -> mental concentration -> spiritual study and contemplation -> conviction in knowledge -> concentrated meditation -> divine, spiritual knowledge.

Characteristics of a Realized Soul

`m {Zem gd^VmZm Vñ`m OmJ{V g`_r ĩ&
`ñ`m OmJ{V ^Vm{Z gm {Zem ní`Vm _Z... ĩ&& 69 &&

On the issue of spiritual knowledge where everyone is in the dark, a realized soul is wide awake (and aware) and on worldly issues on which everyone is wide awake (and fully engaged), the realized soul stays in the dark. (2.69)

Comments: In this verse the Lord is comparing the interests and knowledge of a normal worldly person and a realized person. Most people immersed in daily, worldly affairs are completely in the dark and have no interest in learning about the attributes of the Lord, whereas a realized soul is very much alert, awake, and aware of the attributes of the Lord. Conversely, while most people are focused on worldly matters, indulging in sense pleasure, a realized person stays in the dark (has no interest in such matters).

A realized soul is completely immersed in the Lord and has no interest at all in worldly matters. A question then arises about deities such as Indra, Surya, Agni etc., who are realized souls but have an active role in worldly matters as they activate the sense organs of living beings. If, as realized souls, they avoid taking interest in worldly matters, how can the world function? Sri Rayaru [GV] answers this question by stating that the nature of a realized soul referred to in this verse does not apply to deities. It applies to souls who have achieved self-realization but are not part of the group of deities who have specific roles.

Amn`\_mU'Mbà{Vđ g\_Đ\_mn... à{depÝV`ÛV İ&
VÛV H\$m_m` à{depÝV gd g empÝV_mßZm{V Z H\$m_H\$m_r İ&& 70 &&

Just as an ocean does not rise with constant inflow of water and continues to take in rivers, one who is able to absorb worldly matters without getting attached is destined for liberation. One who is always focused on chasing desires can never achieve peace. (2.70)

Comments: It was stated in verse 2.69 that a realized person has no interest in worldly matters. However, there are instances of such people indulging in sense activities such as eating, hearing, seeing etc. This verse explains this apparent contradiction by clarifying that just as an ocean does not rise with the inflow of river waters, a realized person who indulges in sense activities, purely to maintain physical wellbeing, does not get attached to such consumption.

{dhm` H\$m\_mZ `... gdmZ n_müa{V {Z...ñnh... }&
 {Z__m {ZahH\$ma... g empÝV_{YJÀN{V }&& 71 &&

One who is rid of ego and arrogance and who performs worldly activities without desires will achieve peace and eternal bliss. (2.71)

Comments: In the previous verse, it was stated that a seeker must exercise sense control and partake in consumption activities only to maintain physical wellbeing. In this verse, it is further clarified that even when partaking in such consumption, one should do so with detachment and with firm conviction that one does not have any ownership or independence in action with regard to consumables and consumption.

Efm ~÷r pñW{V... nmW ZZm àmb` {d_ø{V }&
 pñWEdm@ñ`m _ÝVH\$b@{n ~÷ {ZdmU_ÀN{V }&& 72 &&

O Partha! This is the character of one who has deep conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge. Such a person will not experience misery in worldly matters and in due course will reach the Lord's abode. (2.72)

Comments: In verses 2.55 to 2.69, the Lord explains the characteristics of a realized soul in response to Arjuna's query in verse 2.54. This verse is a conclusion of that discussion. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV that a realized soul will reach the Lord's abode only after getting rid of the effects of good and bad deeds (*prarabdha karma*). Sri Rayaru further clarifies that the reference to Brahma here is related to the Lord (*Para Brahma*) and not to the four-faced deity Brahma, based on the use of the qualifier *nirvana* (meaning one without material body = Lord Almighty as *vana* = *bana* refers to material body).

Summary of Chapter 2

With the context for the teachings in the **Gita** established in Chapter 1, the actual sermon of Lord Krishna to Arjuna (and through Arjuna to the

rest of humanity) begins in Chapter 2. Seeing Arjuna in a pitiable condition not wanting to wage the war, Krishna asks Arjuna why he wants to avoid performing his prescribed duties and thereby risk losing respect in society. Such an abdication of responsibility is not worthy of a great prince like Arjuna who had a stellar reputation for fighting for justice all his life (2.2-2.3). Arjuna, who so far wanted to avoid war out of compassion and attachment to his kith and kin, now reasons that Bheeshma, Drona and others are not mere family members and teachers whom he holds in very high esteem. They are also worthy of worship. However, Krishna's questioning opens some doubts in his mind, and he informs Krishna that his mind is conflicted, and he is unsure about the path forward. He surrenders to Krishna, requests to be considered as a student and given guidance (2.4-2.8). Given that Arjuna's doubts are deep rooted, Lord Krishna proceeds to deliver a very detailed sermon to him covering all aspects of life such as the relationship between the Lord and individual souls, responsibilities of everyone in society, concept of devotion to the Lord, transient nature of life, cycle of births and deaths and many more topics which prove to be a summary of critical teachings from all scriptures such as the **Vedas** and great epics such as the **Ramayana**, the **Mahabharata** etc (2.11-2.71).

At this stage, one can expect several questions as to the context and content of the **Gita**. Firstly, why would Krishna get into great details about life, the universe, the relationship between the Lord and individual souls and such spiritual issues when all that was needed was some timely, practical advice to Arjuna to get on with fighting the war. The reason Krishna had to get into such great details is that Arjuna had developed deep rooted doubts about his duties and responsibilities, and he had to be convinced about the need to perform his duties without getting excessively attached to his near and dear ones. Secondly, one would wonder if the battlefield was the right venue for such heavy philosophical discourse which should normally occur in a serene, quiet environment. Again, it is normal for many to seek guidance when they come to a crossroad and are about to implement actions with grave repercussions. These are the very times when one needs proper spiritual guidance. Some would question as to

how such a lengthy sermon can be delivered when millions of soldiers are about to start a war. Krishna's conversation with Arjuna runs quickly as Arjuna is an evolved soul and absorbs the concepts very quickly. Finally, some wonder how Arjuna who is known as an incarnation of deity Indra could be ignorant and develop such fundamental doubts about his duties and responsibilities. At the end of Krishna's teachings, Arjuna responds saying that by Krishna's grace, his doubts have been cleared, his memory is back, and he is clear about his duties and responsibilities (18.73). The fact that his memory was back, implies that Arjuna had proper knowledge about his duties earlier but for some reason his mind was covered with delusion. It was the Lord's Divine Will that Arjuna would undergo temporary loss of memory to set the stage for his doubts and questions, which then gave Him an opportunity to use Arjuna as an instrument to teach the **Gita** to all of the mankind. Lord Krishna then advances many powerful reasons for Arjuna to stop worrying about the harm the war could cause to his loved ones. Firstly, his elders and teachers such as Bheeshma and Drona were not worthy of grieving for as they had supported Duryodhana, the evil king, whose army had to be destroyed to establish order and righteousness. Despite their good nature, these elders were blind to Duryodhana's evil intentions and hence were not deserving of sympathy (2.11). Secondly, if Arjuna was worried that these elders would be permanently destroyed, Krishna reminds him that the body and the soul are separate, and that their souls would live on. Further, based on the good deeds they had performed, they would achieve heaven. So, it was unnecessary to grieve over them (2.12). Thirdly, just as a body undergoes various stages in life such as childhood, youth, old age etc, death is also a natural stage for everybody. As such, these elders would die one day or the other, and no amount of grieving could prevent that (2.13). Fourthly, just as one does not grieve about throwing out old, worn-out clothes as they are replaced by new, good clothes, one should not grieve over a worn-out body that will eventually be replaced by a new one (2.22). Basically, Krishna teaches Arjuna that he must perform his rightful duties and any excuses coming in the way are untenable.

Verses 2.20 to 2.24 give us a description of the nature of individual souls which are indestructible, and have no beginning or end etc. As opposed to individual souls, the nature of the Supreme Soul (Lord Almighty) is briefly described in verses 2.17, 2.25 and 2.29. The Lord who pervades everywhere, is eternal, and does not experience destruction of the body (as His body is transcendental), and is full of auspicious attributes and is devoid of any blemishes. He is superior to individual souls and hence is worthy of worship. One should perform ones prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord without expectations. This paves the way for one's liberation. Coming to the practical aspects of Arjuna's decision to relinquish arms, the Lord emphasizes the need for Arjuna to perform his prescribed duties, as for a *kshatriya*, there is no loftier duty than waging a just war. Arjuna has been handed a great opportunity to perform his duty and he should not waste this chance. If he were to withdraw from war, purely out of compassion to near and dear ones, nothing would prevent his enemies from concluding that Arjuna was afraid to fight, and they could question his valor. Finally, Krishna tells Arjuna that he has nothing to lose by waging the war. If he wins, he gets to rule the kingdom and eventually goes to heaven hereafter for diligently performing his duty. If he loses and dies, he will attain heavens for his conviction and efforts (2.31-2.37). From verses 2.12 to 2.38, Krishna imparts Arjuna knowledge (*sankhya*) about the Lord and individual souls. From verse 2.39 onwards, He teaches Arjuna the methods and procedure (*yoga*) for acquiring such knowledge after which Arjuna would be able to perform his prescribed duties with conviction, realize the Lord, get over worldly bondage and achieve the state of eternal bliss (*moksha*). In verses 2.42 -2.45, the Lord teaches Arjuna the real purport of the **Vedas** - that one should focus on the deeper meanings and not get carried away by peripheral meanings. The real purport of the **Vedas** is divine, spiritual knowledge of Lord Almighty. In verses 2.45-2.51, the Lord discusses the concept of *nishkama karma*, that is performing prescribed duties without expectations. Specifically, in verse 2.50, the Lord categorically states that the best path for one to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge is for one to focus on performing one's assigned duties as an offering to the Lord without expectations on the outcome (*nishkama*

karma). Such a realized soul would be rid of the consequences of good and bad deeds and would be eligible for liberation. Among all activities, those that lead to attainment of divine knowledge is supreme. In verses 2.52 and 2.53, it is stated that in order to absorb proper teachings, one needs to cleanse one's mind of conflicting, ignorant, and inconsistent viewpoints not based on scriptural truths. In verse 2.54, Arjuna asks Krishna about the characteristics of a person with such a tranquil mind. In the 4 verses, starting from verse 2.55 to 2.58, the Lord describes the characteristics of a person with mental tranquility. In the 9 verses from 2.59 to 2.67, questions about the nature of such a person are answered. The Lord concludes the sermon in Chapter 2 by stating in 2.72 that such a person will not experience worldly miseries and in due course will reach His abode.

॥ B{V {ŪVr`m@Ūm`... ॥

End of Chapter 2

VVr`m@Ü`m`... - H\$_¶mJ...

Chapter 3 – The Path of Action

Chapter Introduction: This Chapter of 43 verses is termed *Karma Yoga* (The Path of Action). In this chapter, the Lord answers Arjuna's questions regarding the paths of duty (*karma*) and knowledge (*jnana*). Arjuna wonders if there was a way, he could focus on acquiring knowledge (*jnana*) and avoid participating in the war. The Lord answers all Arjuna's doubts logically to convince him that everyone has an obligation to perform his duties to society, and as a *kshatriya* prince it was Arjuna's responsibility to fight the just war to protect his citizens. To perform one's duty, one also needs to be equipped with knowledge and in that sense, one needs to incorporate both *karma* and *jnana* in their spiritual journey. Based on one's innate nature, some may be prescribed a path that is dominant in action and others may be prescribed a path dominant in knowledge. This chapter also has an excellent discussion on the Cyclic Order of the Universe. In the previous chapter, in verses 2.12 to 2.30, the Lord lectured on the nature of individual souls and the Supreme Soul (Lord Almighty). In verse 2.39, the Lord tells Arjuna how to acquire spiritual knowledge which would guide one to perform right actions. In the verses 2.45 to 2.51, the Lord discusses the concept of *nishkama karma* (performing prescribed duties without expectations) which would liberate one from bondage. In this chapter, that concept is expanded in response to Arjuna's questions that appear in verses 3.1 and 3.2. Thus, chapter 3 is an appropriate follow up to chapter 2.

Which is Better – Action or Knowledge?

AOZ CdmM ¶&

Á`m`gr MV H\$_UñV _Vm ~{ÖÖZmXZ ¶&

VV qH\$\$ H\$_{U Kma _m {Z`mO`{g H\$ed ¶&& 1 ¶&&

ì`m{ I Ud dñŠ`Z ~qÖ _mh`grd _|Ÿ&
 VXH\$ dX {Z{üE` `Z I`m@h\_mßZ`m _|Ÿ&& 2 Ÿ&&

Arjuna said: O Janardana! O Keshava! If you opine that knowledge is superior to action, then why are you pushing me to wage this dreadful war? (3.1)

My mind is confused with this dual talk of superiority between knowledge and action. Please tell me with certainty the correct way which will lead me to the right path. (3.2)

Comments: Sri Rayaru in GV makes a reference to verse 2.49 which spoke about the supremacy of the path of knowledge over the path of action. However, in other verses such as 2.37, Krishna exhorts Arjuna to follow the path of action by waging the just war as that was Arjuna's prescribed duty. Arjuna is now questioning as to which is the superior path. He wonders whether he should renounce everything, become an ascetic and follow the path of knowledge which would lead him to liberation.

Jnana Yogis and Karma Yogis

I r^JdñZdñM Ÿ&
 bñH\$@pñ_Z {Û{dYñ {Zðñ nam àñ°\$ñ _|ñ@ZK Ÿ&
 kñZ`ñJZ gñ>>`ñZñ H\$_ñJZ `ñ{JZñ _|Ÿ&& 3 Ÿ&&

The Lord said: O Anagha (Arjuna, the one without sins)! As explained before, in this world there are two paths towards liberation depending on one's innate nature, talent, and situation. Kings such as Janaka (*karma yogi*) achieved liberation by sincerely ruling their kingdoms (path of action), and sages such as Sanaka (*jnana yogi*) achieved liberation by learning, teaching, and spreading spiritual knowledge to others (path of knowledge). (3.3)

Comments: Lord Krishna clarifies that there are two main paths to liberation, based on one's innate nature, ability, and eligibility. Arjuna, as a ruler, belongs to the *karma yogi* class and hence he should perform his prescribed duty of waging this war to protect his citizens. This answers Arjuna's question in 3.1. It is further clarified in GV that everyone must follow both the path of knowledge and the path of action. However, in *jnana yogis*, knowledge is predominant and hence they should follow the path of knowledge and in the process also follow necessary activities (path of action). Likewise, for *karma yogis* such as Arjuna, the path of action (war, in this case) is the superior path and traversing that path also requires a certain amount of knowledge (path of knowledge). As such, *karma yoga* and *jnana yoga* refer to the aspect of action or knowledge that is predominant in a person's nature. This also means that everyone of us should introspect within ourselves as to the proper path for us to follow, depending on our innate nature, talent, interest, and ability. For one who sincerely prays to the Lord, the path will become clear.

Action (Karma) is Mandatory for Everyone

Z H\$ _Um_Zmaâ^mPîH\$â` néfm@íZV Ý&
Z M gÝ`gZmXd {gqÕ g_{YJÀN{V Ý&& 4 Ý&&

One cannot escape bondage from actions just by relinquishing actions. Also, one cannot directly achieve liberation only by performing duties without expectations (*nishkama karma*). (3.4)

Comments: Krishna instructs Arjuna not to avoid performing prescribed duties. There are three reasons that Arjuna could have for avoiding duties: (a) Once liberated (in *moksha*), there are no compulsions on duties, so in preparation, it may be best to avoid actions (and focus on knowledge) in this world itself; (b) focus on activities might bind one in worldly life and lead to expectations; and, (c) some scriptures say that action comes in the way of attaining *moksha*, based on the phrase –

‘*karmana badhyate jantuhu*’ (one gets bound by activity – in other words, actions come in the way of liberation).

Lord Krishna responds to the reasoning in ‘a’ by using the word *purusha* in this verse which stands for one with a physical body (gross or subtle). The physical body is designed for performing actions. Hence, the existence of the body contradicts the reasoning in ‘a’. The use of the word *purusha* also implies that one has gone through many births. Just because, one decides not to perform any actions in this birth, it does not mean that they did not perform activities in prior births. So, does it mean that one can never achieve liberation? This argument makes the reasoning in ‘b’ untenable. Actions performed with expectations on outcomes do come in the way of *moksha*. This does not apply to all actions, especially actions performed without expectations. Hence, reasoning in ‘c’ is also invalid. Even *nishkama karma* does not, by itself directly lead to *moksha*. This type of action leads to purity in mind which allows one to absorb spiritual studies, eventually paving the way for liberation.

So, the path to liberation is to avoid activities with expectations and perform prescribed activities -> mental peace -> detachment from worldly objects -> concentrated listening, reflection, meditation on the Lord Almighty -> divine knowledge -> liberation. The process involved in these steps are clarified in the following verses.

Z {h H\$[üV j U_{n OmV {VðĒ`H\$_H\$V Ĩ&
H\$m`V ÷de... H\$_gd... àH\$VOJU... Ĩ&& 5 Ĩ&&

One cannot survive for a single second without performing any action. Under the influence of the Lord, everyone is always performing some action or the other due to interaction with material nature. (3.5)

Comments: This verse further clarifies the real meaning of the scriptural phrase ‘*karmana badhyate jantuhu*’ (one gets bound by activity – in other words, activity comes in the way of liberation). Some may use this

phrase to avoid doing any activity. The Lord clarifies that it is impossible for any living being to survive without activity. Even breathing is an activity. Even realized souls, as long as they are alive, will keep performing activities as ordained by the independent Lord Almighty, based on interaction with material nature.

H\$_p\$ÝĐ`m{U g`â` ` AmñV _Zgm ñ_aZ Ý&
BpÝĐ`mWñZ {d\_TmĚ\_m {\_İ`mMma... g CĀ`V Ý&& 6Ý&&

`pñĚdpÝĐ`m{U _Zgm {Z`â`m@a^V@OZ Ý&
H\$_p\$ÝĐ`... H\$\_`mJ_ Ag°\$... g {d{eî`V && 7 &&

One who controls actions of sense organs in pursuing sense objects, but still craves mentally for these objects is an ignorant hypocrite. (3.6)

O Arjuna! The better path for one is to perform prescribed duties using the sense organs of action (hands etc.), while controlling the sense organs of perception (eyes, ears etc.) through the mind. (3.7)

Comments: One can understand that one must perform some activities for the sake of physical well-being, and it is impossible to avoid all activities. But why not avoid other activities such as performing rituals etc.? The Lord answers this question by stating that one must perform prescribed activities such as performing rituals. This is elaborated in later verses. The point being made is that mere performing of activities will not bind someone and come in the way of liberation. It is the mental condition with which one performs action that would bind a person.

{Z`V H\$é H\$\_ Ěd H\$\_ Á`m`m ÷H\$_ U... Ý&
eara`m İm@{n M V Z à{gÕçXH\$_ U... Ý&& 8 &&

You should perform your duties prescribed by society based on your innate nature and talent. Acting on your duties is far superior to

relinquishing duties. One cannot traverse the journey of life without performing prescribed duties. (3.8)

Comments: If it is the mind that comes in the way of one's attaining liberation, and duty is also mandatory, what type of duty should one perform? The answer is – one must perform duties prescribed to one's profession based on one's innate nature, talent, and training. After all, one must perform duties for livelihood in a society.

`kñWñV H\$\_Um@Ý`Ì bñH\$m@` H\$_~ÝYZ... Ý&
VXW H\$_ H\$mÝV` _°\$g“... g_mMa Ý&& 9 &&

O Son of Kunti! Only that action that is not performed as an offering to the Lord will bind one. Perform your duties as an offering to the Lord and it will liberate you. (3.9).

Comments: This verse provides more clarifications on spiritual texts that outwardly seem to indicate that activities will bind and come in the way of liberation. Building on the argument in verse 3.8 that one has to keep performing some activity or the other at least to sustain life, this verse states that the spiritual text quoted in the comments section of 3.5 refers only to those activities that are not performed as an offering to Lord Almighty. The word *yagna* used here refers to Lord Vishnu, as the root word *gna* means knowledge, and Lord Vishnu is omniscient (all knowing). Activities that are performed as an offering to the Lord will not bind anyone and in fact, will lead one to liberation.

Cyclic Order of the Universe

gh`kñ... àOm... gîQm namdmM àOmñ{V... Ý&
AZZ àg{dî`Üd_ Ef dm@pñEdîH\$m_YH\$ Ý&& 10 &&

At the time of creation, Prajapati Brahma created humans and also the sacrificial methods for propitiating deities controlling nature. He

addressed the people thus - by performing these sacrifices you will achieve your desires and these deities will fulfil your desires. (3.10)

Comments: In the four verses from 3.10 to 3.13, the Lord describes the concept of *yagna* (ritual sacrifice) that came into existence at the time of creation of humans. Every aspect of this universe including the elements of nature, the parts of a human body etc., are activated by deities who have been given that power by the Lord Almighty. One must perform ritual sacrifices to propitiate the deities, who, when pleased will fulfill the desires of the citizenry. The concept of *arthavada* is utilized here to convey the importance of performing *yagna*. *Arthavada* is a logical construct that simultaneously uses praise (*stuti*) and admonition (*ninda*) in conveying a concept. Those who perform the prescribed rituals earn the grace of the deities and those who consume riches without sharing them are admonished.

XdmZ ^md`VmZZ V Xdm ^md`ÝV d... Ý&
nañna ^md`ÝV... I `... na_dmbñ`W Ý&& 11 Ý&&

You should continue to worship deities who are the controlling entities for the forces of nature and when pleased with your sacrifices, they will bestow blessings on you. You will prosper from this mutual affection. (3.11)

Comments: This verse indicates the mutual admiration between the deities who are pleased by ritual sacrifices and the citizenry that performs these sacrifices.

BĩmZ ^mJmZ {h dm Xdm Xmñ`ÝV `k^m{dVm... Ý&
VXImmZàXm`ä`m `m ^o\$\$ ñVZ Ed g... Ý&& 12 &&

Deities pleased with your propitiation will fulfil your desires. One who selfishly consumes such fruits earned, without donating back, is indeed a thief. (3.12)

Comments: Those who selfishly consume everything earned from ritual sacrifices without sharing them are admonished as being equivalent to thieves. This strongly worded verse is meant to encourage one to adopt the concept of sharing, which is a foundational pillar of every civilized society.

¶k{eïm{eZ... gÝVm _À`ÝV gd{H\$pe~f... Ý&
^ÄOV V ĒdK nmrnm ` nMÝĒ`mĒ_H\$maUmV Ý&& 13&&

Those, who perform sacrifices to propitiate the deities using riches bestowed on them by the deities and consume only what is left, will be rid of bondage. Those who selfishly consume everything themselves will accumulate sins. (3.13)

Comments: Those who use the riches gained through ritual sacrifices to perform activities as an offering to the Lord Almighty, will not only please the deities but will also move towards liberation. Excessive, selfish consumption of riches earned without giving back to society leads to one's downfall.

AbmX ^dpÝV ^Vm{Z nOÝ`mXpğâ^d... Ý&
`kmX ^d{V nOÝ`m `k... H\$_g_Ød... Ý&& 14 &&

H\$_ ~÷mØd {d{Ø ~÷m j ag_Ød _ Ý&
Vñ_mV gdJV ~÷ {ZĒ` `k à{V{ðV_ Ý&& 15 &&

Living entities come into being through the food chain (rice). Rice grows because of rain and Sun. Vedic sacrifices (to propitiate deities) result in timely rains. The Lord Almighty is responsible for all the activities. The Lord manifests from Vedic hymns and Vedic sacrifices performed by humans. (3.14) (3.15)

Comments: These 2 verses describe the Cyclic Order of the Universe to convey the importance of *yagna* (Vedic sacrifices) that one needs to perform. This cyclic order ensures orderly functioning of the universe and if broken, will result in chaos and anarchy due to the imbalances. Living beings come into physical existence through the food chain, which is represented by rice. Rain (governed by the deity Parjanya – Sun) causes rice to grow. Parjanya, when pleased by the *yagna* performed by the citizenry causes rain. Human beings invoke the Lord Almighty through Vedic hymns (as the Lord is known through the **Vedas**) and the Lord powers humans to perform their prescribed duties (*karma*) and propitiate the deities through *yagna*. This cycle is represented as follows: Rice -> Humans -> Vedic Prayers -> Lord's Grace -> Prescribed duties -> Ritual sacrifices -> Offering to Deities (Parjanya) -> Rain -> Rice.

Yagna, the concept of offering to deities through ritual sacrifices is an especially important aspect of Hindu philosophy and its meaning is described in later verses.

Ed àd{VV MH\$ ZmZdV`Vrh `... V&
AKm`[apYD`mam_m_mK nmW g Ord{V V&& 16 &&

One who does not respect and follow this cycle of life is leading a wasteful life. Such people are interested only in pursuing sense pleasures, and they lead a sinful life. (3.16)

Comments: The Lord teaches that everyone must play his role in the circle of life to ensure proper functioning of the cyclic order of the universe. This order is an interaction amongst its constituent parts namely, the individual souls, the inert matter (material nature) and the Lord Almighty. Even from practical experience, we all know that there is a specific order in nature that one must follow. We witness every day the perils of deviating from this order in terms of global warming, excessive rains, floods, earthquakes, pandemics etc. The **Gita** teaches that everyone must understand their role in the universe and not waste their lifetime by

senselessly pursuing sense pleasures constantly. Some can point out to the instances where even after performing the stipulated *yagna*, one does not see the effects such as rains, sumptuous harvest etc., and question the validity of these claims. One must note that mechanically performing these rituals will not yield results and they must be accompanied with sincerity in purpose and most importantly, as an offering to the Supreme Lord.

At this stage, one may ask a question as to the applicability of these rituals to the population other than married householders, such as students (*brahmachari*), those who have retired from active life (*vanprasthi*) and ascetics (*sanyasis*). After all, not everyone would have access to all material utilities that would be required to perform these rituals. Sri Rayaru [GV] clarifies that *yagna* has different meanings based on one's stage in life. For example, for *brahmcharis*, serving their teachers (*guru*) is the stipulated *yagna*. For ascetics who have renounced all material utilities, *yagna* refers to mental (*manasika*) and vocal (*vachaka*) sacrifices. Studying, teaching, and lecturing about the scriptures is the stipulated *yagna* for ascetics. For *vanaprasthis*, performing activities without hurting any living organism constitutes *yagna*. In other words, *yagna* is mandatory for everyone, but the stipulated activity depends on one's stage in life. Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha indicated the example of some saints who, in addition to *jnana yagna* (sacrifice through knowledge), *dhyana yagna* (sacrifice through meditation), etc., practice the *yagna* of writing poetry on the greatness of the Lord Almighty. For them, poetry (*kavana*) and singing in praise of the Lord is *savana* (*yagna*).

Actions Do Not Bind One Focused on the Lord

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
 अथ कुरुक्षेत्रे भार्गव उवाच ॥ १७ ॥

One who is elated by visualizing the Lord, who is contented in pleasing the Lord, who is happily immersed in the Lord has indeed

achieved the state of ultimate consciousness. There is no prescribed duty or responsibility for such a being. (3.17)

Comments: In verses 3.4, 3.10 etc., the requirements for performing one's stipulated duties were described. Previously, it was pointed out that ascetics perform mental and vocal *yagna* by way of studying, teaching, and lecturing as everyone must perform their assigned duties. A question that arises then is about the case of those who while meditating have reached the state of ultimate consciousness (*asamprajnata samadhi*). In this state they would not even be aware of their surroundings, and they would be fully immersed in the Lord. This verse states that one who is completely immersed in the Lord and has reached the state of ultimate consciousness will by God's grace be fully contented and has no obligations to perform any activities. Such a person will not have interest in any matter other than the Lord.

Zd Vñ` H\$VZmWm ZmH\$VZh H\$üz V&
Z Mmñ` gd^Vf H\$üXWì`nm I` ... V&& 18 V&&

There is nothing to be gained by such a person by performing duties and nothing will be lost by non-performance of duties. Such a person has no need to depend on elders, teachers for any benefit (as that person has realized the Lord). (3.18)

Comments: Everyone has an obligation to perform prescribed duties many of which must be performed at specified times. Is it necessary for one to wake up a person who is in the state of ultimate consciousness to allow that person to perform prescribed duties at specified times? Sri Rayaru in GV answers by stating that, as per this verse, such a person has no such obligations. Further, that person does not have to wake up from the state of deep meditation and ultimate consciousness even to greet elders, teachers etc., as no further benefits will be derived. Such a person has already realized the Lord and hence has no obligation to perform duties.

Vñ_mXg°\$... gVV H\$m` H\$_g_mMa Ý&
 Ag°\$m ømMaZ H\$_ na_mßZm{V néf... Ý&& 19 &&

Only those who have realized the Lord are exempt from obligation to perform duties. But you must perform your prescribed duties without getting attached to the outcome. One who focusses on performing duties without expecting results is sure to reach the Lord's abode. (3.19)

Comments: Those who have reached the state of ultimate consciousness, have realized the Lord and those who are already liberated have no obligations to perform any duties. But Arjuna must perform his prescribed duty to enable him to move towards the Lord's abode.

Arjuna Must Perform His Duties and Fight the Just War

H\$_Ud {h g{g{Õ_ AmpñVVm OZH\$mX`... Ý&
 bmH\$gJh_dm{n gní`Z H\$V_h{g Ý&& 20 &&

Wise emperors such as Janaka achieved salvation through their honest discharge of prescribed duties. You (Arjuna) should perform your duties for the sake of society. (3.20)

Comments: Wise emperors such as Janaka have already achieved divine, spiritual knowledge and are destined to reach the Lord's abode. If so, why did they continue to perform duties? This verse answers by stating that even such people would experience deeper levels of bliss in *moksha* on account of additional duties performed. In addition, they performed duties to set an example to the masses. Likewise, Arjuna needs to focus on duties as he is considered a role model to his citizens. While, attaining *nirvana* requires one to acquire divine, spiritual knowledge, such knowledge accrues only when someone performs prescribed duties without expectations. In that sense the relationship between duty and knowledge is like the one between a yoke and the shoulders of a person using that yoke

to till the land. The yoke is an implement, but the actual effort is from the person's shoulders.

`ÚXmMa{V I ðñVÎmXdVam OZ... Ý&
g `Èà_mU H\$ÉV bmH\$ñVXZdVW Ý&& 21 &&

Whatever actions are performed by superiors in a society, the rest of the population will emulate. Superiors' actions become the rule which others will follow. (3.21)

Comments: The previous verse stated that leaders in a society need to perform activities to guide the masses. This verse further clarifies that concept. While societies may have written rules and regulations for their citizenry, the fine conduct of their leaders provides live examples of action which the masses can emulate.

The Lord Acts but Has No Obligations to Do So

Z _ nmWmpñV H\$Vî` {Ì f b mH\$f {H\$#mZ Ý&
ZmZdmá_dmaì` dV Ed M H\$_{U Ý&& 22 Ý&&

`{X øh Z dV` OmV H\$_Ê`VpÝÐV... Ý&
__ dĚ_mZdVÝV _Zî`m... nmW gde... Ý&& 23 &&

CĚgrX`[a _ b mH\$m Z H\$_m H\$_ MXh _ Ý&
gH\$añ` M H\$Vm ñ`m _ CnhÝ`m{__m... àOm... Ý&& 24 &&

O Partha! There is no prescribed duty for Me in these three worlds. There is nothing I do not own and nothing that I need to own. Even then I engage in activities (to set an example for others). (3.22)

O Partha! If I ever stop energetically engaging in activities, everyone is certain to follow My way. (3.23)

If I ever stop my activities, everyone will lose their way and end up in misery. The resulting anarchy will lead to the growth of an unholy society, and I will be held responsible for it. (3.24)

Comments: These verses answer the question that one may have as to whether the Lord has any obligation to perform any activities. The Lord states that He has no such obligation as He is the absolute owner of all the worlds and has no needs. Even then, He performs activities out of compassion to set an example for everyone. The Lord activates everyone's activities, but He is not impacted by activities of others; like a catalytic agent that causes changes in other objects but itself does not undergo changes. If the Lord stops performing activities, there is a danger that everyone in society, devoid of examples, may also stop performing their prescribed activities, interrupting the cycle of the universe, resulting in societal dysfunction.

The Learned Perform Duties without Expectations

g°\$m... H\$ _Ê` {dÛmgm `Wm H\$dpÝV ^naV Ý&
H\$`mX {dÛmñVWm@g°\$ {ÜH\$sfbmH\$gJh_ Ý&& 25 Ý&&

O Bharata! Just as ignorant people perform duties with expectations, truly knowledgeable people perform their duties without any expectations from larger society. (3.25)

Comments: If it is mandatory for ignorant persons also to perform prescribed duties, what then is the difference between ignorant and wise ones when they perform their duties? This verse answers by stating that wise ones perform activities without any expectations to set an example for society at large.

Z ~{Õ^X OZ`XkmZm H\$_g{“Zm_ Ý&
Om f`V gdH\$\_m{U {dÛmZ `°\$... g_mMaZ Ý&& 26 &&

Let not the wise unsettle the minds of ignorant ones attached to actions performed without proper knowledge. Learned ones should conduct their activities with their minds focused on the Lord and inspire ignorant people through their action. (3.26)

Comments: This verse describes how a wise one should act as a role model to ignorant ones in performing duties. Many times, mere preaching about the need for performing prescribed duties without expectations will not convince ignorant ones who are focused on activities for material gains. Wise ones instead should demonstrate the proper way of performing prescribed duties through action as an offering to the Lord and not through mere words. Through their actions, they should motivate and encourage the ignorant to perform right deeds.

àH\$V... {H\$`_mUm{Z JU... H\$_m{U gde... Ý&
AhH\$na{d_TmĚ_m H\$Vm@h_{V _Ý`V Ý&& 27 &&

Ignorant ones, unaware that the Lord Almighty activates everyone's actions based on their inherent nature and under the influence of material nature, wrongly conclude that they perform actions on their own. (3.27)

Comments: This verse provides further explanations on verses 3.25 and 3.26. Sri Rayaru in GV provides an excellent explanation on the inner meanings of the terms *prakriti* and *guna* appearing in this verse which carry 3 sets of meanings. Firstly, *prakriti* and *guna* refer to the Lord Almighty and His 3 attributes, namely, will, knowledge, and attempt. Secondly, the terms *prakriti* and *guna* refer to the three types of individual souls (superior, ordinary, and inferior) and their 3 attributes of knowledge, namely, correct knowledge, mixed knowledge, and false knowledge. Thirdly, the terms *prakriti* and *guna*, refer to inert nature and its 3 attributes, namely *sat* (piety), *rajas* (passion) and *tamas* (ignorance). With these interpretations, this verse can be expanded to mean as follows-Lord Almighty is independent and is the instrumental cause for activities performed by everyone based on their innate attributes using inert nature as

the material cause and their sense organs as the instruments. The attributes of inert nature impact the actions performed by the sense organs. Ignorant ones think that they are performing the actions on their own using their sense organs of action.

Vîd{dîm _hm~mh JUH\$_{d^mJ`m... ý&
JUm JUf dVYV B{V _Edm Z g,mV ý&& 28 &&

O Arjuna, The one with strong arms! Learned ones, aware of the distinction in the attributes and activities between the Lord and ordinary souls, know that their sense organs perform their activities as willed by the Lord. Such people will not get entangled in worldly life. (3.28)

Comments: The previous verse stated that ignorant ones believe that they act independently, and this verse describes the views of learned ones. The learned ones are aware that the Lord Almighty is independent and causes activity in individual souls based on their innate nature. They have a good understanding of the divisions among attributes (*guna*) and action (*karma*). Attributes here have different meanings depending on the entity. The attributes of the Lord are will, knowledge, and attempt. For the individual souls they are the innate nature of being superior, ordinary, and inferior. The attributes of inert nature are *sat*(piety), *rajas*(passion), and *tamas*(ignorance). Likewise, the actions of the 3 entities are also different. The Lord is independent. Individual souls which are dependent on the Lord act according to their innate nature, and inert nature which is also dependent on the Lord undergoes transformation based on its 3 attributes of *sat*, *rajas* and *tamas*. Sri Rayaru in GV provides two equally meaningful interpretations for the first half of the second line (*guna guneshu vartanta*). First interpretation – The Lord’s attributes (*guna*) initiate actions (*guneshu*) in individual souls based on their innate nature. The second interpretation – Individual soul’s sense organs (*guna*) act on sense objects (*guneshu*) based on the Lord’s will and the individual’s innate nature. In summary, the learned ones understand that they are not independent and with proper

conviction they avoid getting entangled in worldly activities as they are focused on the Lord Almighty.

àH\$VJUgâ_Tm... g ,m'V JUH\$_g Ý&
VmZH\$ĚñZ{dXm _ÝXmZ H\$ĚñZ{dP {dMmb`V Ý&& 29&&

Ignorant ones, unaware of the distinction in attributes and activities between the Lord and ordinary souls, get entangled in worldly pleasures and develop addiction. Learned ones who have proper spiritual knowledge need not waste time teaching them. (3.29)

Comments: Should the learned advise the ignorant ones? This verse answers by stating that ignorant ones who are in constant pursuit of sense pleasures would develop an addiction and the learned ones need not waste their time on teaching them. Souls have innate natures and those who are naturally inclined to be ignorant can never be transformed. For example, nature includes cruel animals such as scorpions, snakes, tigers etc. It is in their nature to be cruel. One cannot transform them. The natural ecology of the universe requires different species to exist and not all species have the same attributes. The Lord does not interfere with the innate nature of souls but allows them to exist and act based on their attributes.

_ {` gdm{U H\$\_m{U gÝ`ñ`mÜ`mĚ_MVgm Ý&
{Zamer{Z__m ^Ědm `Ü`ñd {dJVÁda... Ý&& 30 &&

Submit all your activities to Me without ego and without expectations on the outcome while focusing your mind on Me. Get rid of your fear of losing near and dear ones and fight this just war. (3.30)

Comments: After discussing the ways that learned ones and ignorant ones perform their duties, and differences in their approaches, the Lord summarizes this topic by exhorting Arjuna to perform his prescribed duty of waging the war as an offering to Him. He is to do this without any expectations and without ego, knowing fully well that it is the Lord who is

powering him in his efforts. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that the word *adhyatma* can be derived in two ways – *atmanam adhikrutya sthitam* and *adhikam chaasow atma*, and both mean Supreme Lord. Also, as per **Brahma Tarka**, every activity must be performed as a worship (or an offering) to the Lord Almighty.

This verse is indicated as the summary of the entire chapter 3 by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha Swamiji [BGS]. Given that the backdrop for the **Gita** is Arjuna's refusal to fight the war, in this verse the Lord conclusively directs Arjuna to wage the just war as an offering to Him without ego or any expectations of the outcome (*karma yoga*). Hence, this verse is aptly a summary of chapter 3.

॥ ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥
॥ ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥ 31 ॥

॥ ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥
॥ ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥ 32 ॥

Those who always follow My teachings without disdain and perform their prescribed duties will be rid of bondage and attain salvation. (3.31)

Those who treat this teaching with disdain, with hatred towards Me, and fail to perform their prescribed duties will never gain divine, spiritual knowledge and will fall into misery. (3.32)

Comments: Learned ones perform their prescribed activities without ego and expectations on the outcome. What do others gain by following this? What is the disadvantage for someone who does not follow this? Verses 3.31 and 3.32 answer these questions. Those who always perform their prescribed activities without disdain towards the Lord (disdain is thinking that the Lord is causing them to indulge in difficult activities) will be rid of bondage and will *also* attain salvation. Sri Rayaru in GV provides an interesting explanation for the use of the term *api* (meaning also), in

verse 3.31. This verse states that anyone who follows the path indicated will eventually attain salvation. The use of *api* implies that salvation is assured for those who have achieved self-realization (*aparoksha jnanis*).

Verse 3.32 clarifies that those who do not follow this path due to false knowledge will not only be denied salvation but will be destined to unending misery.

Behaviour is Moulded by Intrinsic Nature

gÑe MĩV ñdñ`m... àH\$VkmZdmZ{n ĩ&
àH\$qV `mpYV ^Vm{Z {ZJh... qH\$ H\$[aĩ`{V ĩ&& 33&&

Even learned ones will behave based on their innate nature. Everyone is bound by their intrinsic nature. What will be accomplished by just controlling the sense organs? (3.33)

Comments: If one is denied salvation for not following the path described previously, why does one not follow this path? This verse answers by stating that everyone behaves based on their predisposition. Even learned ones are not immune to the effects of attachment and aversion. The intrinsic nature of a soul causes one to behave in a particular manner. Mere controlling of sense organs will not be of much help. Verse (3.31) also indicates that one cannot transform others' intrinsic nature.

BpYĐ`ñ`pYĐ`ñ`mW amJŮfm ì`dpñWVm ĩ&
V`mZ de\_mJÀNv Vm øñ` n[anpYWZm ĩ&& 34 &&

Every sense organ has natural attachment and hatred related to the respective sense object. A seeker should not be influenced by the emotions of attachment and aversion, as they are the real enemies which inhibit a seeker's progress on the spiritual path. (3.34)

Comments: In verse 3.30, it was stated that one must perform one's prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord and verse 3.31 stated the advantage of such an action. However, verse 3.33 indicated that one's activities are governed by one's innate nature. If so, how can one then act as instructed in verse 3.30? This verse answers this question by stating that one's activities are modulated by one's emotions such as attachment and aversion. Even though it is extremely difficult to control these emotions, one must make a sincere attempt. The deserving ones will surely succeed.

I`mZ ñdY_m {dJU... naY_mV ñdZ{ðVmV V&
ñdY_{ZYZ I`... naY\_m ^`mdh... V&& 35 &&

It is better for one to perform prescribed duties (in accordance with one's innate nature), even if done imperfectly, than take up duties (even those well executed) against one's innate nature. It is better to die performing one's relevant duties as taking up non-relevant duties will only lead to downfall. (3.35)

Comments: In the beginning of this chapter, in verse 3.1, Arjuna asks Krishna two questions. (i) If knowledge is superior to action, why perform any activity at all? (ii) Since actions such as waging a war can have negative consequences such as killing elders and teachers, why indulge in such a war? Lord Krishna responded to the first question in verse 3.3 and aspects of the second question in verses 3.30 and 3.34 by stating that Arjuna should wage the war as an offering to the Lord without getting influenced by emotions. This verse answers the 'why' aspect of the second question. Everyone is prescribed certain responsibilities in a society based on their personal situations. Arjuna belonged to the ruling *kshatriya* class and had an obligation to protect his citizens. Hence, the best path for him is to wage this war despite its unpleasant consequences, rather than shirk his responsibilities and take up some other vocation such as studying, teaching etc.

Why Do People Sin?

AOZ CdmM ᳚

AW H\$Z à`°\$m@` nmM Ma{V néf... ᳚

A{ZÀN᳚p{n d᳚îU` ~b᳚{Xd {Z`m{OV... ᳚&& 36&&

Arjuna said: O Krishna (from the lineage of Vrushni)! Why does one indulge in sinful activities even when not inclined to do so, as if one was forced to do so? Who prompts this behavior? (3.36)

Comments: In verse 3.34, the Lord instructs that one should conquer emotions such as desire and aversion which lead one to downfall. Arjuna seems to be asking Him which emotion is the strongest and most difficult to conquer even when one has the right intentions.

Desire and Anger Cause One to Sin

Ir^JdmZdmM :

H\$m ‘ Ef H\$mY Ef aOmJUg‘ Ød...᳚

‘h᳚eZ᳚ ‘h᳚m᳚᳚ ‘m {dÕçZ{ ‘h d[aU ‘ ᳚&& 27 &&

The Lord said: Desire and anger push one to commit sinful activities. These are born out of the natural attribute of passion. One can never satiate them. They are the greatest enemies of a seeker. Among them, desire is the stronger enemy as it is the root cause of anger. (3.37)

Comments: In verses 2.62 and 2.63, the relationship and interconnection between the emotions of desire, anger, miserliness, obsession, arrogance, and jealousy were discussed. Desire or lust is the root cause for all these emotions which causes one’s downfall. Anger arises out of the attribute of passion, but desire is the root cause for anger. The Lord uses the term *mahashana* to describe desire, meaning that it can never be satiated. Everyone knows by experience that cravings of sense organs can

never be permanently satiated by indulging in them. Even when one consumes very tasty, sumptuous food and feels contented, that feeling evaporates by the next day and cravings will resurface. Trying to satiate desire by indulgence is like trying to douse a fire with ghee. The fire continues to rage. Desire or lust is the root cause of one's downfall and prevents one from achieving liberation. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that the emotion of desire is influenced by the demon Kalinemi.

Fire, Mirror, and Fetus

Y_Zm@d`V d{•`Wm@@Xem _bZ M ĩ&
`Wmë~Zm@dVm J^ñVWm VZX_mdV_ ĩ&& 38 &&

Just as smoke hides fire, just as dust covers a mirror and just as a womb covers a fetus, the emotion of desire (lust) envelopes everyone. (3.38)

Comments: While the previous verse 3.37 identified desire or lust as the root cause of evil, this verse explains the strength of this emotion through three different examples. Sri Rayaru in GV explains the reason for using these three different examples. These are related respectively to the three classes of beings, namely pious, passionate, and ignorant. Pious souls can also get enveloped by lust just as smoke covers a fire. However, just as one can see and feel the fire to some extent even when covered by smoke, pious beings can visualize the Lord even when influenced by desire. So they have the most to gain by controlling desire. Passionate souls are covered by desire just as dirt covers a mirror. With some effort, one can wipe the mirror clean and likewise passionate souls with effort can overcome the influence of desire. Ignorant souls are under the tight grip of desire just like a womb covers a fetus strongly. Such souls who are under the constant influence of lust can never overcome this emotion and fail to realize the Lord.

Sri Rayaru provides a second explanation for the three analogies. These analogies are related to the Lord, one's mind and individual soul, respectively. The Lord is self-effulgent but when one is covered by desire, the Lord cannot be seen just as fire cannot be seen when covered by smoke. When a mirror is covered with dust one cannot see the reflection of the original object. Similarly, when one's mind is covered by desire, one cannot visualize the Lord. Thirdly, when one is in the very tight grip of lust just as a fetus is covered by a strong womb, one cannot obtain true divine, spiritual knowledge.

Am̐dV k̐mZ_VZ k̐m{ZZm {ZĒ`d[aUm &
H\$m_ê\$ñU H\$mÝV` XînaUmZbZ M Ý&& 39 &&

O Son of Kunti! Desire is the greatest enemy of a seeker. It can never be satiated, and it is never satisfied. It can shroud the intellect of even learned ones. (3.39)

Comments: The Lord continues to answer Arjuna's question from verse 3.36. Does desire or lust impact even those who have acquired spiritual knowledge? This verse answers by stating that even learned ones are impacted by the force of lust. Previously it was stated that desire shrouds the three entities – knowledge about the Lord, knowledge about the individual and knowledge about the individual's mind. Even spiritual knowledge learnt through a teacher can get shrouded by lust and prevent a seeker from acquiring divine knowledge. Lust is never satiated. It is even stronger than fire. After all a fire gets extinguished once it consumes flammable material in its way. But lust remains unsatiated even after one indulges in it.

BpÝĐ`m{U\_Zm~{Õañ`m{YđmZ_À`V Ý&
EV{d_mh`Ē`f k̐mZ_mdĒ` X{hZ_Ý&& 40 &&

Desire finds a home in one's sense organs, mind, and intellect. It is through these elements that desire clouds one's judgement and leads one astray. (3.40)

Comments: Where does the quality of desire/lust reside in an individual? Lord Krishna previously stated that desire is the strongest enemy that comes in the way of one's spiritual journey. So, it is natural for one to look for the source of desire. After all, if one wants to conquer an enemy, one needs to know the location of the enemy. This verse answers by stating that lust finds home in one's sense organs, mind, and intellect.

Control Sense Organs to Overcome Desire

Vñ_mîd{pýÐ¶mÊ`mXm{Z`â`^aVf^î&
nmb_mZ àO{h øZ kñZ{dkñZZmeZ_î&& 41 &&

O Arjuna (Superior among the Bharatas)! Therefore, you should first control sense organs and destroy desire which can shroud both ordinary and special spiritual knowledge. (3.41)

Comments: The Lord continues to provide answers to Arjuna's question in a logical manner. If desire has its home in one's sense organs (including mind) and intellect, how does one control desire? The Lord answers by stating that one needs to control the sense organs to be able to control desire. Desire is a strong force that can shroud both ordinary and special knowledge (*jnana* and *vijnana*). Ordinary knowledge refers to knowledge that one acquires through study and through teachers. Special knowledge refers to the deep knowledge that one acquires by study, meditation, and contemplation of scriptural texts such as the **Vedas**, **Puranas** etc.

In the current context, Arjuna's knowledge is shrouded by his mental weakness due to the fear of losing his near and dear ones in the war. The

Lord exhorts him to conquer his mind and focus on performing his prescribed duty.

At this stage, it is useful to understand the concept of desire. Scriptures state that there are four aspects to one's activities – *dharma* (right conduct), *artha* (material riches), *kama* (desire) and *moksha* (liberation). There is a discussion in the **Mahabharata** regarding the relative importance of these four aspects. Vidura states that *moksha* is the most important one as that is everyone's goal. Bheema states that *kama* is the most important. Naturally, everyone is curious to find out more. Bheema states that desire can be either lofty (positive) or primal (negative). After all, one would work towards *moksha* only when one has the desire (*kama*) to achieve *moksha*. So, lofty desires are not prohibited. It is primal desire or lust that entangles living beings.

Know Thy Lord and Overcome Desires

BpYĐ`m{U namÊ`mh[apYĐ`ä`... na _Z... Y&
_ZgñV nam ~{Ö`m ~Ö... naVñV g... Y&& 42 &&

It is said that the sense organs are superior, and the mind is more superior to them. Intellect is superior to the mind and the ultimate consciousness (the Supreme Lord) is even more superior to the intellect. (3.42)

Comments: After describing the impact that desire/lust has on a seeker's spiritual journey and stating that desire is rooted in the sense organs, it was concluded that one must exert control over the sense organs in order to conquer desire. It was also indicated that desire is an immensely powerful emotion and even learned ones fall prey to it. A natural question that one would have at this stage is as follows – how can one control the sense organs (including the mind)? This verse answers by indicating that the weapon to conquer desire is knowledge. As the enemy resides in an individual's faculties, one must understand the relative importance of

various faculties. Only then can one conquer desire. To control desire, one must control one's sense organs. To control the sense organs, one must conquer obsession with objects of sensory perception and to do this one must control the mind. To control the mind, one must be able to control the intellect. But these are all inert entities. How can they help one control desire? Sri Rayaru [GV] explains the inner meaning of this verse by explaining that the faculties indicated here imply the respective controlling deities who activate the faculties. The relative gradation among the faculties and their controlling deities implied in this verse is as follows. Sense organs (and their controlling deities such as Indra) are superior to other organs in the body (and their controlling deities such as Prithvi). Objects of sensory perception (and their controlling deities such as Parvati) are superior to the sense organs (and their controlling deities). The Mind (and its controlling deity such as Rudra) is superior to objects of sensory perception (and their controlling deities). The Intellect (and controlling deity such as Saraswati) is superior to the mind (and its controlling deities). The principle of consciousness (and its controlling deities such as Brahma) is superior to intellect (and its controlling deities). The unmanifest principle (the inert nature and its controlling deity Mahalakshmi) is superior to the principle of consciousness. The supreme Lord Almighty is superior to the unmanifest principle (and to all controlling deities). The Lord has indicated many times that one must perform one's prescribed duties without expectations, as an offering to Him. This verse gives everyone an assurance that we are not alone in this universe and the various angelic forces that control all activities in this universe, and indeed in our bodies can help us in conquering desire if we approach our prescribed duties with sincerity and as an offering to the Lord.

Ed ~Ö... na ~XÜdm gñVä`m@E_mZ_mE_Zm V&
 O{h eì _hm~mh H\$m_e\$n XangX_ V&& 43 V&&

O Arjuna, one with strong arms! With proper knowledge of the Lord Almighty, the Supreme Principle, control your mind with your intellect and defeat the enemy called desire and focus your mind on your duty. (3.43)

Comments: The Lord concludes His teaching in this chapter by exhorting Arjuna to control his emotions and focus on performing his prescribed duty of fighting the just war by submitting to His will.

Summary of Chapter 3

This chapter is a continuation of chapter 2, where the Lord provides more details on the concept of duties without expectations. In the first 2 verses, Arjuna expresses confusion about the superiority between the paths of knowledge and action. In verses 3.3-3.9, the Lord teaches that both these paths lead to liberation and the choice of path depends on one's innate nature, talent, and background. The Lord also cautions Arjuna against avoiding all actions as no one can survive without performing some action. The Lord also provides clarification on the nature of duties that are prescribed to living beings. In verses 3.10-3.13, the Lord introduces the concept of *yagna* (ritual sacrifice) and the need for one to perform them to propitiate the deities who govern the various entities essential for the functioning of this universe. The Lord explains the Cyclic Order of the Universe in verses 3.14-3.16 where the interrelationships among the various constituents of the universe, namely – the individual souls, the deities, inert nature, and the supreme Lord are briefly presented. For the universe to function, everyone must play their designated role in the circle of life. In verses 3.17-3.21, the Lord teaches that those who have achieved the state of ultimate consciousness and have realized the Lord have no obligation to perform duties. Likewise, souls that are liberated have no obligation to perform any activities. However, they continue to perform activities to set an example to the masses. Such souls do enjoy deeper levels of bliss in *moksha*. In verses 3.22-3.24, the Lord clarifies that He has no obligation to perform any activity but does so out of pure compassion to set an example to others and to ensure order in society. Verses 3.25-3.29 describe the manner of activities performed by the ignorant ones and the learned ones. It also briefly describes the divisions and distinctions among the three constituents of the universe (the Lord Almighty, individual souls,

and inert nature) in terms of their attributes and actions. Learned ones understand these divisions and are aware that they do not act independently. In verse 3.30, the Lord summarizes the previous verses and instructs Arjuna to overcome ego and attachment and wage the war as an offering to Him. In verses 3.33 to 3.35, the Lord speaks about the strong influence of one's innate nature on one's activities. In verse 3.36, Arjuna asks Krishna why one indulges in sinful activities even when one is not inclined to do so. The Lord provides a detailed response to Arjuna in a logical, sequential manner in verses 3.37 to 3.43. To conquer desire, one must control one's sense organs, mind, and intellect. These are controlled by angelic forces with relative gradation which are working under the control of the supreme Lord. One must focus on performing one's prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord and, by His grace, conquer desire.

B{V VWr`m@Ü`m`...

End of Chapter 3

MVWm@Ü`m`... - kmZ`mJ...

Chapter 4 - Wisdom in Action

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 42 verses is known as *Jnana Yoga* (The Path of Knowledge). It is predominantly about the spiritual knowledge that a seeker needs to perform prescribed action (*karma*). Knowledge regarding the individual souls, various deities and the attributes of the Lord Almighty are explained to instill devotion in a seeker. The Lord explains that He incarnates in this world from time to time to establish virtue and to vanquish immorality. Knowledge about the various types of actions – right action, wrong action and inaction are also covered here. In the previous chapter, in verse 3.8, the Lord taught that one must perform one's prescribed duties without expectations (*nishkama karma*). In this chapter, till verse 4.15, some important attributes of the Lord Almighty are described. Verses 4.16 to 4.23 provide a comparison of *nishkama karma* to other types of activities with details of the types of *nishkama karma* such as worship and sacrifice. A central feature of this chapter is the classification and description of the different types of sacrifices (*yagna*) or austerities that *yogis* perform. These are described in verses 4.25 to 4.30.

Succession of Knowledge

I r^JdmZdmM ¥&

B_ {ddñdV `mJ àm°\$dmZh'ì` ` _ ¥&

{ddñdmZ _Zd àmh _Z[aúdmH\$d@~drV ¥&& 1 ¥&&

The Lord said: I declared this salvation conferring imperishable *yoga* to Vivaswan (Surya, the Sun deity), who in turn passed on the knowledge to his son Vaivaswata Manu. And Manu preached this to his son Ikshwaku. (4.1)

Comments: In verse 3.30, the Lord taught that one should perform one's prescribed duties without expectations as an offering to Him. In verses 3.31, 3.32 and others the Lord indicated the advantages and disadvantages of performing or not performing the duties as stated. The Lord backs up these arguments by providing examples of seekers in the past who have followed the path shown by the Lord and have achieved greatness. The Lord uses the term *avyaya* (imperishable) to indicate the permanent nature of such divine, spiritual knowledge. So, the reference to deities who over time had acted as advised previously is very pertinent.

Ed naānamāá_ B_ amOf`m {dX... ĩ&
g H\$m bZh _hVm `mJm Zi... naVn ĩ&& 2 ĩ&&

Emperors and *rishis* (sages) learnt and taught this knowledge successively from one generation to the next. O Parantapa (Arjuna, The tormentor of enemies)! Due to the passage of time this knowledge has disappeared. (4.2)

Comments: Sri Rayaru ascribes in GV 2 meanings to the word '*rajarshi*'. One meaning *raja* + *rishi* = emperors + sages. Second one meaning *rajasu rashayaha* = superior among emperors. This is important because Arjuna is also a king, and many emperors, sages, and superior emperors had followed the path taught by Krishna, implying that Arjuna should take note of these examples. While that knowledge had passed on from one generation to the next, it had faded due to the passage of time. Hence the need for Lord Krishna to reiterate them here.

g Edm` \_`m V@Ú `mJm àm°\$... namVZ... ĩ&
^°\$m@{g _g l m M{V ahñ` øVXI_m _ ĩ&& 3 ĩ&&

The same ancient supreme and secretive knowledge has been imparted to you by Me, for you are both a devotee and a friend to Me. (4.3)

Comments: The Lord states that Arjuna is receiving this precious and confidential teaching as Arjuna is His devotee and friend (Verse (2.7)). Sri Rayaru explains in GV that the use of the term *hi* implies two reasons for the Lord doing so-

- I am teaching this to you as you are my devotee and friend.
- This ancient knowledge is supreme and secretive.

The spiritual knowledge taught in the **Gita** is a summary of the scriptures such as **Pancha Ratra** that was taught by Lord Vishnu to deities such as Brahma, Vayu, Rudra, Indra, Surya, Yama, the Ashwini twins etc. In verse 3.20, the example of king Janaka was quoted to demonstrate the practice of *nishkama karma* among householders (who have family and societal responsibilities). The three verses 4.1 to 4.3 give examples of other great souls who have benefitted from this knowledge.

AOZ CdmM :

Ana ^dVm OY_ na OY_ {ddñdV... Y&
H\$W_VX {dOmZr`m Ed_mXm àm³Vdm{Z{V Y&& 4 Y&&

Arjuna said: Krishna! Your birth is in recent times. Surya (the Sun deity) was born a long time ago. How am I to understand that you taught this knowledge to Surya? (4.4)

Comments: In verse 3.30, the Lord stated that to achieve liberation one must perform one's prescribed duties without expectation, as an offering to Him. This implies that the Lord is supreme and worthy of worship. In other verses such as 2.12, the Lord clarified that He does not experience births and deaths like individual souls. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that Arjuna (a *jnani* himself who had already listened to Krishna's teachings in Chapter 2 and 3) was not asking about the Lord's birth (or manifestations), but about the evidence to prove the difference between the Lord Almighty and individual souls.

The Lord's Incarnations

Ir^JdmZdM Ĩ&
 ~h{Z _ ì`VrVm{Z OÝ_m{Z Vd MmOZ Ĩ&
 VmÝ`h dX gd_m{U Z Ēd dĒW naVn Ĩ&& 5 Ĩ&&

The Lord said: O Arjuna! Many manifestations of Mine and many births of yours have come and gone. O! Parantapa! I know them all clearly, but you do not. (4.5)

Comments: By stating that He always has many manifestations, the Lord answers Arjuna's question in 4.4 as to how He taught the knowledge to Surya who has been in existence for a long time. The Lord manifests (appears) at different times which are loosely termed as the Lord's births. This is quite different from individual souls such as Arjuna who experience many births and deaths. Further, the Lord clarifies that He is aware of all His incarnations and all births of others, but the individual souls are not aware of their many births. Hence this verse draws out the superiority and omniscient nature of the Lord as distinct from individual souls.

AOm@{n gpì``mĒ_m ^VmZm_rceam@{n gZ Ĩ&
 àH\$QV ñdm_{Yđm` gâ^dmâ`mĒ__m``m Ĩ&& 6 &&

I am not born like everyone; My body does not perish, and I am the controller of all beings. Through the entities of material nature created by Me, I manifest Myself in My transcendental form based on My own free will. (4.6)

Comments: The Lord seemed to indicate in verse 4.5 that He appears and disappears many times. But in verse 2.17, the Lord stated that He does not cease to exist. How can thus be reconciled? The next few verses detail the concept of manifestation as it relates to the Lord. The Lord does not experience physical births as experienced by individual souls. The term

birth (*janma*) when used in the context of Lord, relates to His manifestation which He does at His own free will using the entities of material nature that He Himself created. This is explained in the phrase *prakritim swam adhishtaya*. Sri Rayaru in GV interprets this phrase in three different ways:

- The Lord, in an incarnation such as Krishna manifests Himself through the bodies of Vasudeva and Devaki which He Himself had created.
- The Lord utilizes Goddess Durga (governor of *tamasic* nature) who is under His control, to cause ignorant souls to consider His manifestation as an ordinary birth.
- The Lord performs the above two actions of His own free will.

These 3 interpretations provide answers to the three questions that arise here.

Question 1: What does the statement that the Lord takes birth at a specific time and place when His body and soul are eternal mean? For example, the birth of Krishna to Vasudeva and Devaki.

Answer 1: Inert nature is under the control of the Lord Almighty. The Lord gives physical bodies comprised of material nature to Vasudeva and Devaki and enters their bodies in His transcendental form and manifests Himself.

Question 2: What makes some think of the Lord as having a birth like everyone else?

Answer 2: The Lord causes ignorance in some through Goddess Durga who acts under His control.

Question 3: What benefit does the Lord get by manifesting Himself through Vasudeva and Devaki (and indeed other manifestations)?

Answer 3: The Lord's actions are due to His free will which is His innate nature and not for any benefit.

`Xm `Xm {h Y_ñ` ½bm{Z^d{V^maV ĩ&
Aä`EWmZ\_Y\_ñ` VXm@E_mZ gOmā`h_ ĩ&& 7 &&

n[aİmUm` gmYZm {dZmem` M XiH\$Vm_ ĩ&
Y_gñWmnZmWm` gā^dm{ \_J`J ĩ&& 8 &&

O Bharata! Whenever there is a decline in *dharma* (virtue) and ascension of *adharma* (immoral values), I manifest Myself in this world. (4.7)

I manifest Myself from time to time to protect the virtuous, destroy the evil and to establish virtue in society. (4.8)

Comments: If the Lord has nothing to gain by incarnating, what is the purpose of His incarnations? These two verses answer by stating that the Lord incarnates purely out of His free will and out of pure compassion towards living beings. While the Lord has no obligation to incarnate at any specific time or place, generally He incarnates from time to time, to protect the virtuous whenever virtue in the society is obscured, and to destroy the evil whenever there is an ascension in immorality.

OÍ_ H\$_ M_ {Xi` \_Ed`m d{Îm VÎdV... ĩ&
E`ŠEdm Xh nZOÍ_ Z{V _m{V gm@OZ ĩ&& 9 &&

O Arjuna! One who realizes properly that My amazing manifestations and activities are divine, will not be reborn after leaving ones body and will reach My abode. (4.9)

Comments: In every manifestation of the Lord such as Lord Narasimha, Lord Rama, Lord Krishna etc., the Lord has demonstrated extraordinary powers and activities to advance the cause of righteousness and to punish the evil. Many times, His actions are meant to set an example for ideal living as in the case of Lord Rama. These incarnations are detailed

in epics such as the **Ramayana, the Mahabharata, the Bhagavata** etc. It must be noted that a seeker needs to have proper understanding of the Lord's activities. This is implied in using the term *tatvata*. It is quite easy to misunderstand some of the Lord's activities by looking at them peripherally. One must understand the real intent of His actions. Only then can one hope to achieve liberation. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that proper knowledge of the Lord's incarnations and activities is necessary for a seeker to achieve liberation but that is not sufficient. The seeker also needs to learn about Lord's other attributes such as omnipresence, omniscience etc.

drVamJ^`H\$mYm \_Y\_`m _m_nm{IVm... V&
~hdm kmZVngm nVm _Ømd_mJVm... V&& 10 &&

Those who have conquered desire, fear, anger and have surrendered to Me after having accepted Me as the Omnipresent and Supreme One, get purified through learning and meditation, and eventually will reach My abode. (4.10)

Comments: The previous verse stated that a seeker needs to have proper knowledge about the Lord's incarnations and actions. This verse describes such a seeker as one who has conquered emotions such as desire (in material objects), fear, and anger. Sri Rayaru [GV] provides an excellent explanation of this verse as having answered two important questions:

- Are there seekers who have achieved liberation by properly understanding the Lord's incarnations and activities? This verse describes the attributes of those seekers.
- How does the knowledge about the Lord's incarnations and activities lead one to liberation? This verse answers this question by stating that it is through surrender and devotion to the Lord, one can attain liberation.

Arjuna had expressed his surrender to the Lord (2.7) and hence he is a very eligible seeker.

Rewards are Based on Devoted Efforts

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
 ॥ दैवमिदं कुरुते नमो वासुदेवाय ॥ ११ ॥

O Partha! Whoever worships Me with devotion, in whatever way, I reward them accordingly. Everyone follows the example that I set. (4.11)

Comments: In the previous verses it was stated that one who worships the Lord will achieve liberation. Will all who worship the Lord achieve liberation equally? If yes, how can one account for the difference in efforts and approach? If no, isn't there partiality in result? This verse answers these questions stating that among those who worship the Lord, there are broadly two categories. The first one includes learned ones who perform activities without expectations and surrender completely to the Lord. These seekers are destined for liberation. The second category includes those who, while aware of the supremacy of the Lord, perform rituals worshipping other deities such as Brahma, Rudra, Indra etc., seeking temporary fruits such as progeny, wealth etc. Even though this category of people performs rituals to propitiate other deities, the fact that the Lord is the ultimate destination for their efforts results in them receiving temporary rewards.

In the second half of this verse, the Lord clarifies that even offerings made by the second category of people will eventually reach Him, but they will not be aware of this fact. The learned ones who act without any expectation are fully aware of this. Thus, the Lord rewards seekers based on their effort, conviction, and attitude, purely based on merit. So, there is no question of partiality.

H\$m→ÝV... H\$_Um {g{Õ `OÝV Bh XdVm... ý&
{j à {h _mZf bmH\$ {g{Õ^d{V H\$_Om ý&& 12 &&

In this world, people worship and perform sacrifices to propitiate other deities for temporary fruits. Success from these activities (although temporary) will fructify quickly. (4.12)

Comments: This verse provides the reasoning behind the explanation in the previous verse that all fruits are ultimately obtained from the Lord, regardless of the deities who are worshipped. It is seen in this world that one who propitiates other deities do receive fruits from one's efforts, but it is the Lord Almighty who ultimately grants wishes based on one's efforts and conviction.

Categories of Beings

MmVdÊ` \_`m gï JUH\$_{d^mJe... ý&
Vñ` H\$Vma\_{n \_m {dÕÇH\$Vma\_ì` _` ý&& 13 &&

I created the four categories (*varnas*) of beings based on their nature and activities. Though I created them, I do not have a creator. I also do not have any obligation to act, and I am eternal. (4.13)

Comments: It was stated previously that it is essential for one to surrender to the Lord to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge and attain liberation. This verse explains the reason why one should surrender to Lord. The Lord is like a father, and children are expected to worship their father. The Lord, who gave physical bodies to individual entities, provides details of the categories of people He creates.

This is probably the most controversial and least understood verse in the **Gita** as many people associate this verse with the caste system in society. The four categories here are based on the proportion of the three innate attributes (*sattv*, *rajas* and *tamas*) of beings. How can there be four

categories if there are three innate attributes? The four categories are based on the varying proportions of these three innate attributes. Sri Madhwacharya provides detailed explanations of the categories (*varnas*) and attributes (*gunas*) in GB and GTN. Individual souls are basically of three types – angels (deities), humans, and demons. Angels have the quality of pure *sattv* and are destined for liberation. Demons have pure *tamas* and are destined for hell. Humans have *rajas* mixed with varying proportions of *sattv*, *rajas* and *tamas* resulting in *satvik rajasas*, *rajasa rajasas* and *rajasa tamasas*. Those with a *satvik rajasa* quality are destined for liberation and among them are these four categories. As explained by Sri Jaya Teertha [ND] – these categories are characterized by the following - (i) *sattv* is much greater than *rajas* (*sattv* >> *rajas*), (ii) *sattv* is somewhat greater than *rajas* (*sattv* > *rajas*), (iii) *sattv* and *rajas* are in equal proportion but greater than *tamas* (*rajas* = *sattv* > *tamas*) and, (iv) *sattv* is greater than *tamas* which is greater than *rajas* (*sattv* > *tamas* > *rajas*). As stated by Sri Madhwacharya in GB, the qualities of *sattv*, *rajas* and *tamas* are based on the level of one's devotion to Lord Almighty Vishnu. One cannot conclude one's innate nature just by one's family of birth. The categorization of beings based on one's profession or vocation (*karma*) is covered in detail in Chapter 18.

The four categories of people indicated here are generally known as *brahmanas*, *kshatriyas*, *vaishyas*, and *shudras*, which also nominally indicates the profession that they undertake, namely, scholastic pursuits, administration, commerce, and service industry. All of them are eligible for liberation. Sri Jaya Teertha in his ND clarifies this concept by stating that Lord Vishnu's devotees (*vaishnavas*) are considered pious because of their higher levels of *sattvic* attributes, and not due to their brahminical profession. Sri Madhwacharya in GTN clarifies that the categorization based on one's innate nature (*swabhava*) manifests in one's natural aptitudes such as steadfast devotion to the Lord, self-control, valor, bravery, farming, commerce, service mindedness etc. This categorization should not be equated to the societal classification based on one's family of birth (*oupadika*).

While the deities have predominant *sattv* qualities, Sri Rayaru in his **Prameya Sangraha** [PS] provides more details on the categorization of deities. During the process of subtle creation, all individual souls obtain a subtle body called *Aniruddha deha*. During this time, the various deities get categorized - the four faced deity Brahma as *brahmin*, deities Vayudeva, Sessa, Garuda, rudra etc., as *kshatriyas*, many Suryas, some children of Aditi, many Maruts, Vasus etc., as *vyshyas*, and Ashwini twins, Prithvi, Kala, Mrutyu etc., as *shudras*. This clearly proves that there is nothing intrinsically superior or inferior about the categories. They are simply different from each other.

In the second half of this verse, the Lord clarifies that while He is the creator of these categories, He is not created by anyone. He also has no obligation to act.

Notes: Material nature comprises of three qualities, and these are present in all living beings in varying degrees. The three qualities are *sattv*, *rajas* and *tamas*. *Sattv* is generally translated as pure, virtuous, pious etc., *rajas* as passion and *tamas* as ignorance. Those identified with the quality of *sattv* are generally known to have purity in thought, words, and actions. Sri Madhwacharya identifies an additional attribute as part of *sattv*. This attribute is devotion to the Lord as stated by Sri Madhwacharya in his GTN based on **Naradeeya Purana**. Hence the translation of *sattv* as pious is more appropriate as piety also implies devotion. The quality of *rajas* leads one to be passionate about material possessions and sense pleasures. For brevity, from now on *rajas* will be translated as passion. The quality of *tamas* results in ignorance and delusion and is characterized by excessive lethargy, sleepiness, and indulgence in sense pleasures. Again, for brevity *tamas* will be translated as ignorance.

Actions Never Bind the Lord

Z _m H\$_m{U {bānpŶV Z _ H\$_ \ \$b ñnhm Ŷ&
B{V _m `m@{^OmZm{V H\$\_{^Z g ~Ü`V Ŷ&& 14 &&

Actions do not bind Me. I have no interest in any fruits from My actions. One who truly knows Me thus will not get entangled by actions. (4.14)

Comments: In the previous verse the Lord stated that He has no obligation to perform any activities. In the next few verses, He provides the nature of His activities and contrasts them with those of individual souls. Actions do not bind the Lord. The Lord has no interest in any outcome of His actions and acts on His own free will. The reason for individual souls getting entangled in actions is their expectations. The one who understands the nature of the Lord's actions will not be bound by actions. Sri Rayaru in GV provides a convincing explanation for the inherent difference between the Supreme Soul and the individual soul based on the choice of words in this verse. The Lord says '*yo maam iti abhijanati*', meaning the ones who know Me (*maam*, meaning Krishna) thus will not get entangled by actions. Here, the Lord's attributes are the subject matter which must be properly understood by others (*yo* = individual souls) to get released from bondage.

Ed kṁĒdṁ H\$V H\$_ nda{n __j {^... V&
H\$é H\$_d Vñ _mîd nd... ndVa H\$V _ V&& 15 &&

Learned ones, desirous of salvation, were aware of this truth and accordingly performed their prescribed duties. You should also follow the everlasting path traversed by these ancestors. (4.15)

Comments: Why do learned ones who are aware of the Lord's attributes about activities act at all? This verse answers by giving the examples set by earlier generations. In verse 3.30, the Lord had indicated that emperors such as Janaka achieved liberation by performing their prescribed duties without expectations. Such superior souls perform activities out of two reasons. One, to set an example for others in society and second, to experience exuberance in bliss (in *moksha*).

Types of Action

qH\$ H\$_ {H\$ H\$_ {V H\$d`m@B`Î _m{hVm... ĩ&
VÎm H\$_ àdú`m{ `ÁkEdm _mú`g@e^mV ĩ&& 16 ĩ&&

What is right action? What is inaction? Even learned ones get confused by these questions. I will explain this matter to you by knowing which, you will be rid of bondage. (4.16)

Comments: The previous verse taught that a seeker should perform prescribed duties. This verse provides details on the types of actions – right actions and inaction. Sri Rayaru in GV provides an interesting explanation for the use of the Sanskrit word ‘*tat*’ in this verse. *tat* is an interesting word in Sanskrit and its meaning depends on the context. At least 3 meanings of *tat* are – **therefore**, **that**, and **from**. The interpretations are –

- Even learned ones get confused about the concept of *karma*. **Therefore**, you must understand it properly
- In the previous verse 4.15, it was indicated that one must perform prescribed duties (*karma*). It is **that** karma which is discussed in this verse
- One will be rid of bondage **by** acquiring this knowledge

H\$_Um ø{n ~mÕi` ~mÕi` M {dH\$_U... ĩ&
AH\$_Uü ~mÕi` JhZm H\$_Um J{V... ĩ&& 17 &&

One should learn what constitutes right action, prohibited action and inaction, and learn about the distinction between them. All these actions are under My control. The subject of action (*karma*) is extremely complex by nature. (4.17)

Comments: In the previous verse, the words *karma* (action) and *akarma* (inaction) were used where *akarma* was also interpreted to include *vikarma* (prohibited action). In this verse, all three types of actions are

explicitly stated. Sri Rayaru in GV stresses that one must strive hard to understand the nature of action, especially since it is an extremely complex topic.

Sri Rayaru also provides an interesting, second interpretation of this verse following Sri Madhwacharya's GTN. The words *karmanaha*, *vikarmanaha*, and *akarmanaha* can be derived as – *karma* + *naha*, *vikarma* + *naha*, and *akarma* + *naha*. The word *naha* means 'from the Lord' (plural). With this derivation, this verse can also be interpreted as follows – all the three types of action (right action, prohibited action, and inaction) are implemented by the different forms of the Lord under His control. 'Different Forms' is implied by the plural (*naha*) indicated above.

$$H\$ \hat{E} \text{ ` } H\$ \_ \text{ ` } \dots n \acute{I} \text{ ` } XH\$ \_ \{ U \ M \ H\$ \_ \text{ ` } \dots \dot{V} \&$$

$$g \sim \{ \tilde{O} _ _ Z _ \hat{Z} \text{ ` } f \ g \ \text{ ` } ^{\circ} \$ \dots H \tilde{E} \tilde{n} ZH\$ _ H \$ V \ \dot{V} \&\& \ 18 \&\&$$

The wise realize that they do not perform activities independently and even when they are not active (during sleeping, dreaming), there is activity being performed (such as breathing) by the Lord Almighty. Such a person is performing duties fully and will derive full benefits thereon. (4.18)

Comments: Having introduced the types of action in previous verses, the Lord now describes these actions in the next few verses. Prescribed duties performed by one with the knowledge that the actual work is enabled by the Lord is doing the right action (*karma*). The one who performs duties without knowing that the Lord is enabling one to work engages in incorrect/futile action (*akarma*). Actions not approved by the scriptures constitute prohibited action (*vikarma*).

Sri Rayaru in GV provides another interesting, second interpretation of this verse based on Sri Madhwacharya's GTN. The word *karma* can also mean the individual soul based on the obligation to perform duties. The Lord is also termed *akarma* as He has no obligation to perform anything.

With this, the verse can be interpreted to mean as follows – the one who knows that the dependent individual soul has obligation to perform duties, and that the independent Lord Almighty has no obligation for duties, is indeed knowledgeable. Such a person is performing right actions fully.

This verse is identified by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in BGS as being the summary of this chapter. As this chapter is predominantly about the concept of action (*karma yoga*), this verse provides a succinct summary of the concepts presented.

Actions Do Not Taint the Contented and Equanimous

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ।
कर्मणो यो न मोहो भयं चाक्षयं ।

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ।
कर्मणो यो न मोहो भयं चाक्षयं ।

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ।
कर्मणो यो न मोहो भयं चाक्षयं ।

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ।
कर्मणो यो न मोहो भयं चाक्षयं ।

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ।
कर्मणो यो न मोहो भयं चाक्षयं ।

One who performs prescribed duties and sacrifices without expecting any rewards would have incinerated all activities in the fire of spiritual knowledge. Learned people consider such a person as truly knowledgeable. (4.19)

One with spiritual knowledge, who is detached from the outcomes of activities, who is ever contented, and who is focused on the Lord, even when involved in normal activities will be considered as not performing any activities. (4.20)

One who performs duties without any expectations, who has control over mind and intellect, and who has no attachment to the physical body will not be tainted by sin for actions performed solely for physical sustenance. (4.21)

One who is content with whatever is given by the Lord, who is beyond dualities (such as pain or pleasure), who harbors no jealousy and who treats success or failure with equanimity will not be entangled by actions. (4.22)

Actions will not taint one who acts without expectations, who is unattached to the physical body, who has the mind focused on the Lord and who performs duties as an offering (*yagna*) to the Lord. (4.23)

Comments: Verse 4.18 identified a wise person as one who performs prescribed duties fully and perfectly. These five verses describe the major characteristics of such a person.

1. Pandita: Verse 4.19 describes one who has conclusive knowledge as Pandita, as recognized by learned ones. Such a person would have incinerated all activities in the fire of spiritual knowledge.
2. Ever Contented: Verse 4.20 describes a wise person as being ever contented and not having any needs. Such a person has no attachment to either activities or any outcomes from activities and considers the self as a reflection of the independent Lord. Even when performing actions, such a person is considered as not performing any action at all, meaning such actions will not be binding.

3. Detached: Verse 4.21 describes a wise person as one who performs prescribed duties with no bodily attachments. Such a person when performing day to day activities for physical sustenance will not be tainted by any sins arising from such actions.
4. Equanimous: Verse 4.22 describes a wise person as one who is not perturbed by happiness or sadness, gain, or loss etc. Such a person will not harbor jealousy over someone's success and will be content with whatever is granted by the Lord.
5. Conviction in Divine Knowledge: Verse 4.23 summarizes the characteristics of the wise person described in the previous 4 verses and states that such a person is able to achieve these characteristics due to single minded focus on the Lord. Such a person will indeed perform all prescribed activities without expectations, without bodily attachment, with knowledge about the independent Lord, and as an offering (*yagna*) to please the Lord. Such activities will not entangle a wise person and will pave the way for liberation by the grace of the Lord.

Verse 4.22 seems to identify two characteristics of a wise person – one who is beyond dualities and one who is equipoised in success or failure. Do these both mean the same and hence there is a repetition here? No. Sri Jaya Teertha in [PD] clarifies that these two characteristics have a causal relationship. One who is tolerant of dualities is equipoised in success or failure.

Spiritual Sacrifices

~÷mnU ~÷ h{d~÷m3/4m ~÷Um hV_ Ÿ&
 ~÷d VZ JYVi` ~÷H\$_g_m{YZm Ÿ&& 24 &&

All articles and substances used in performing Vedic rituals (*yagna*) belong to the Lord. Various sacrifices, ghee and indeed fire itself and the

ritual activities are all under the control of the Lord as He pervades and owns everything. One who understands this truth will indeed reach the Lord's abode. (4.24)

Comments: In the previous verse, a wise person is described as someone who has conviction in divine knowledge. This verse explains and describes such conviction. All aspects involved in the performance of *yagna* (sacrifice) are under the control of the Lord. This is also consistent with verse 4.21, where a wise person was described as one who is detached. Sri Rayaru in GV explains the proper way of interpreting compound words such as *brahma havi* following the interpretation in Sri Madhwacharya's GTN. There are multiple ways of deriving such compound words in Sanskrit. There is a danger that one can interpret *brahma havi* to mean that the sacrifices offered in a sacrifice is identical with the Lord. Sri Madhwacharya [GTN] interprets *brahma havi* as *brahmani* + *havi*, meaning the sacrifices offered in a sacrifice belongs to the Lord. This applies to other aspects appearing in this verse. This interpretation is also consistent with the characteristics of a wise person described in verses 4.19 – 4.23.

Notes: The Sanskrit word *yagna* does not have a direct equivalent in English. In general, *yagna* means an intense act or endeavor that is performed for a specific purpose such as propitiating the Lord Almighty or some other deities. Many scholars loosely translate *yagna* as sacrifice, perhaps referring to offerings that are sacrificed during fire rituals. In keeping with the traditional translation, *yagna* will be translated as sacrifice in this book with the knowledge that *yagna* actually stands for an intense endeavor performed for a specific purpose.

Xd'dmna`k`m{JZ...n`nmgV`&
~÷m³/4mdna`k`kZdmnO^V`&& 25 &&

Some seekers (especially ascetics) consider worshipping the Lord as itself equivalent to performing a Vedic ritual (hence the Lord also goes by

the name of *yagna*). Others (especially householders) visualize the Lord in the sacrificial fire and perform the rituals. (4.25)

Comments: The next six verses 4-25 to 4-30 describe the different types of *yagna* (sacrifice) performed by different seekers to stress the point that *yagna* does not mean only performing ritual sacrifices with fire but it also has a metaphorical meaning.

In a later verse, (4.31) it is indicated that one who does not perform sacrificial rituals will not achieve anything of value either in this world or in other worlds. This verse clarifies that for some seekers such as ascetics, worshipping the Lord is itself a Vedic sacrificial ritual. In verse 4.23, it was indicated that wise people perform activities for the sake of *yagna* (*yagnaya acharate*). This verse, by specifically stating that ascetics worship *yagna* (the Lord), confirms that the word *yagna* also refers to the Lord Almighty.

I m̐mXrZrpYḌṭmÊ`Ý` g`_m{Jf O^{V ṽ&
eãXmXrZ {df`mZY` BpYḌ`m{¾f O^{V ṽ&& 26 &&

gdmUrpYḌ`H\$_m{U àmUH\$_m{U Mmna ṽ&
AmĒ_g`\_`mJm¾m O^{V kmZXr{nV ṽ&& 27 &&

Some offer sense organs of perception such as ears and eyes in the sacrificial fire of sense control. Some others offer sense objects such as sound (music) in the sacrificial fire called sense organs (such as ears). (4.26)

Some offer activities of sense organs of action (hands, legs etc.), and five types of life breath, in the sacrificial fire of self-control which glows with spiritual knowledge. (4.27)

Comments: *yagna* is a generic word that many associate with the physical act of performing Vedic rituals with fire etc. These verses describe

yagna metaphorically as defining different types of sacrifices performed by seekers.

Some seekers exercise control of sense organs of perception - eyes, ears, tongue, nose, and skin, by restraining excessive indulgence in sense objects and divert these sense organs towards the Lord. For example, restraining ears from listening to meaningless worldly stories and focusing them on the stories of the Lord Almighty. Even when consuming objects of senses such as food, seekers partake in them with the knowledge that they are offered to the in-dwelling Lord.

Ḍì` `kṁñVnṁ`kṁ `mJ`kṁñVWṁna ṽ&
ñdṁÜ` `kṁZ`kṁœ `V` ... g{eVdVṁ... ṽ&& 28 &&

Some perform sacrifices with earned wealth by donating to the deserving. Some perform sacrifices through penance. Some perform sacrifices through meditation. Some perform sacrifices by studying and analyzing scriptures such as the **Vedas**. Some perform sacrifices by teaching spiritual texts to others. All of them make great attempts to propitiate the Lord through their sacrifices. (4.28)

Comments: This verse clarifies that sacrifices are performed physically, vocally, and mentally with examples. Some physically donate part of their wealth generously to the deserving. Some undertake strict austerity such as maintaining silence for an extended period of time. This requires great mental concentration. Some undertake extensive studies and analysis of concepts in spiritual texts such as the **Vedas**. Some distribute their knowledge vocally through teaching and lectures. All these seekers utilize the tools and talent that the Lord gave them as a selfless sacrifice and submit them to the Lord Almighty.

AnṁZ O^{V àṁU àṁU@nṁZ VWṁ@na ṽ&
àṁUṁnṁZJVr éXÜdṁ àṁUṁ`m \_nam`Uṁ... ṽ&& 29 &&

Some perform sacrifices through breathing and breath control. They offer the exhaling breath to the inhaling breath and the inhaling breath to the exhaling breath and sacrifice the act of holding the breath. (4.29)

Comments: Some seekers take the path of *pranayama* or management of life breath to achieve self-discipline. These seekers offer the act of breath retention (*kumbhaka*) as a sacrifice to the Lord.

Ana {Z`Vmhman... àmUmZ àmUf O`{V î&
gd@ß`V `k{dXm `kj{nVH\$ë_fm... î&& 30 &&

Some limit the amount of food they consume and control the ability of sense organs to indulge in consumption of sense objects. All of them understand the meaning of sacrifice and get rid of sins through their chosen method of sacrifice. (4.30)

Comments: In verses 4.26 and 4.27, it was stated that some seekers perform the sacrifice of controlling their sense organs. In this verse, there is a specific example of seekers controlling the consumption of food to drive home the fact that of all indulgences, food is the most difficult to control. As was indicated in verse 2.59, when one practices fasting, the sense organs get weakened, but the craving for tasty food does not go away. When one ages, the sense organs start losing their effectiveness one by one, but the tongue and its craving for food never goes away. Some seekers perform the difficult task of controlling their food intake (just enough for physical existence) by will power and offer this sacrifice to the Lord.

Sri Rayaru in GV gives an additional interpretation for this verse. Sense organs are controlled by deities such as Indra, Surya etc. Deities such as Garuda, Rudra, and Sesha who control the functioning of the mind are superior to the deities controlling the sense organs. Some seekers understand this hierarchy, control their indulgence in food through will power and offer that as a sacrifice to the Lord.

`k{ei\_m\_V^O\_m `mpYV ~÷ gZ_mVZ_ |Ÿ&
Z_m | b_mH\$m@ñĒ `kñ` H\$V_m@Y` ... H\$égî_m_ Ÿ&& 31&&

O Kurusattama (Arjuna, Superior among the Kurus)! One who consumes the leftover nectar after performing these sacrifices will indeed reach the Lord (who has no beginning or end). One who does not perform these sacrifices will not achieve anything of value in this world, leave alone in the heavenly worlds. (4.31)

Comments: After describing the types of sacrifices performed by seekers in verses 4-25 to 4-30, this verse describes the difference in rewards attained by those who perform these types of sacrifices and those who do not. One who performs such selfless sacrifices will indeed reach the Lord and others who do not perform these would have wasted their lives. It is interesting to note that this verse specifically states that those who do not perform such sacrifices will not receive any rewards in this world. How can one prove that? One of the sacrifices identified was control of food consumption. It is seen by experience that those who indulge in excessive food consumption on a continuous basis end up with lifestyle diseases such as obesity, blood pressure etc. Hence, these austerities are also required to maintain a healthy lifestyle.

Ed ~h{dY_m `k_m {dVV_m ~÷U_m _ | Ÿ&
H\$_O_mZ {d{Ō V_mZ gdmZ Ed k_mĒd_m {d_mú`g Ÿ&& 32&&

All these different types of sacrifices are offered to the Lord Almighty. Understanding that all these sacrifices arise from mental, vocal, and physical actions, conduct your prescribed duties with proper knowledge and achieve release from bondage. (4.32)

Comments: This verse clarifies that different types of sacrifices are directed towards the Lord. This point is expanded later in verse 9.24, where the Lord declares that He is the owner and indeed the destination for all

sacrifices. After describing the various types of sacrifices performed by seekers, the Lord asks Arjuna to understand that these sacrifices are to be performed mentally, vocally, and physically, and that he should engage in his prescribed duty of participating in the war to protect his citizens. This advice is especially important as one can question the need to indulge in a destructive war when one can achieve liberation by following other sacrifices such as the acquisition and dissemination of knowledge. This verse clarifies that one must perform one's prescribed duty as a worship to the Lord, which is also a form of sacrifice.

Spiritual Knowledge Completes Action

l`mZ ði` ' `mX ¶kñÁkñZ`k... naVn ý&
gd H\$_m{ l b nmW kñZ n[ag_mß`V ý&& 33 &&

O Parantapa! Sacrifice in the form of acquiring and imparting spiritual knowledge is much better than sacrifice in the form of offering articles to those in need (and other types of sacrifices described before). O Partha! Even performing prescribed activities requires proper knowledge for fruitful completion. (4.33)

Comments: Verses 4.25 to 4.30 described different types of sacrifices performed by seekers in their quest for self-realization and liberation. Among the different types of sacrifices described, which is superior? This verse answers by stating that sacrifice in the form of acquisition and dissemination of divine, spiritual knowledge is most superior. The reason for its supremacy is its ability to bring to fruition the prescribed duties performed by a seeker. After all, one cannot perform any activity, if one does not have the knowledge of the need for such an action, or the method of performance of such action etc. One cannot conclude that only acquiring such knowledge is good enough. Such knowledge must be accompanied by proper performance of prescribed duties for one to succeed in one's spiritual journey.

V{Û{Õ à{UnmVZ n[aà I Z gd`m ĩ&
CnXú`pÝV V kmZ km{ZZñVĖDX{eZ... ĩ&& 34 &&

You can learn that knowledge by prostrating, by asking critical questions, and by serving the learned ones. Such scholars who have realized true divine, spiritual knowledge will educate you. (4.34)

Comments: Given that sacrifice related to knowledge is declared as superior, how does one obtain such knowledge? This verse answers by stating that one must first find a teacher who has truly realized divine, spiritual knowledge and approach that teacher with respect, humility, and an inquisitive mind to learn. In verse 2.7, Arjuna had surrendered to Lord Krishna as his teacher to help clear his doubts. One must follow this example to acquire true knowledge.

`ÁkmĖdm Z nZ\_mh\_ Ed`mñ`{g nmĖSd ĩ&
`Z ^VmÝ`efU Đú`ñ`mĖ_Ý`Wm\_{` ĩ&& 35 &&

O Pandava! You will be rid of ignorance once you understand My teaching. By acquiring this knowledge, you will realize that all beings exist in Me and that I am present in everyone. (4.35)

Comments: Arjuna was stricken with grief at the thought of losing his loved ones in the war. As discussed in Chapter 1, this resulted in clouding of his judgement and led to his questions and doubts about duty, knowledge etc. Lord Krishna states in this verse that Arjuna would overcome his ignorance by understanding Krishna's teaching which would convince him that everyone is controlled, protected, and pervaded by the Lord. By using the phrases *mayi* (within Me) and *sarva bhootani* (all beings - plural), the Lord is making it truly clear that He is supreme, and all beings act under His control. This is one of the core concepts of the philosophy of dualism of Sri Madhwacharya.

The Fire of Spiritual Knowledge Burns Ignorance and Sin

A{n MX{g nmnä` ... gdä` ... nmnH\$Îm_ ... ý&
gd kmZßbdZd d{OZ g'V[âî`{g ý&& 36 &&

`WYm{g g{ _Öm@{¾^ñ_gmV H\$éV@OZ ý&
kmZm{¾... gdH\$_m{U ^ñ_gmEH\$éV VWm ý&& 37 &&

Z {h kmZZ gÑe n{dì{ _h {dÚV ý&
VV ñd` | `mJg{gÕ... H\$m bZm@Ë_ {Z {dÝX{V ý&& 38 &&

Even if one has committed more sins than a very sinful person, one can navigate through worldly afflictions with the help of a boat known as divine, spiritual knowledge. (4.36)

Just as a blazing fire turns wood into ashes, the fire of knowledge burns off the ill effects of action. (4.37)

Nothing in this world is as pure as (spiritual) knowledge. One who is on the path of learning will, in due course of time, achieve self-realization. (4.38)

Comments: These three verses describe three major benefits from ‘sacrifice of knowledge’ - acquiring and acting on divine, spiritual knowledge (*jnana yagna*). In verse 4.36, knowledge is compared to a boat. Just as one needs a boat to cross a river, similarly one needs proper knowledge to traverse the river of worldly afflictions. A boat does not row itself. It needs a sailor. Similarly, mere knowledge is not good enough. One needs a proper teacher, and one must practice and act upon such knowledge. In verse 4.37, it is stated that the fire of knowledge burns off ill-effects of action just as a blazing fire turns wood into ashes. This implies that knowledge should be sharp, strong, and powerful, just like a blazing fire. Verse 4.38 categorically states that such knowledge is superior to

everything else in this world, and one must diligently pursue the path of learning to acquire this knowledge over time.

Sincerity, Sense Control, Spiritual Knowledge Lead to Liberation

I Õm d m Z b ^ V k m Z _ Ë n a . . . g ` V p Ý Ð ` . . . Ý &
k m Z b ä Ü d m n a m e m p Ý V _ A { M a U m { Y J À N { V Ý & & 39 & &

One who is sincerely pursuing the path of knowledge with sense organs completely under control and focusing on Me (the Lord) will attain spiritual knowledge and eventually attain eternal bliss. (4.39)

Comments: How does one obtain such knowledge? This verse answers by stating that the three prerequisites one must possess to achieve such superior knowledge are faith, self-control, and unswerving devotion to the Lord. One must note that all three of these prerequisites must be met.

A k ü m I Ô Y m Z ü g e ` m Ë \_ m { d Z í ` { V Ý &
Z m ` | b m H \$ m @ p ñ V Z n a m Z g I g e ` m Ë _ Z . . . Ý & & 40 & &

One who is ignorant, who is devoid of faith, and who is doubting will perish. One who doubts these teachings will not gain anything of value in this world or in other worlds and will never have peace of mind. (4.40)

Comments: This verse describes the opposite attributes to those in verse 4.39. It is known from experience that one who is insincere in efforts will not achieve anything of substance in this world even when it comes to worldly issues. One, who does not have conviction in spiritual principles, will not achieve anything of value in this world or afterlife.

` m J g Ý ` ñ V H \$ _ m U k m Z g { N p g e ` _ Ý &
A m Ë _ d Ý V Z H \$ _ m { U { Z ~ Ü Z p Ý V Y Z O ` Ý & & 41 & &

O Dhananjaya (Arjuna)! One who performs prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord and has vanquished any lingering doubts with the sword of knowledge will not be entangled by any action. (4.41)

Comments: A seeker must perform prescribed duties without any expectations on the outcome and submit any fruits obtained back to the Lord Almighty. In addition, such a seeker should also focus on acquiring divine, spiritual knowledge which will help destroy any doubts and develop deep conviction. Such a seeker will not be entangled by any activity and will achieve liberation. This verse categorically states that a seeker must perform *karma yoga* and *jnana yoga* along with *bhakti yoga* to achieve *moksha*.

Vñ_mXk_mZg^V öEñW k_mZ_m{gZ_m@@E_Z... ý&
{NîdZ ge` `mJ_ Am{Vð_m{îmđ / ^maV ý&& 42 &&

Therefore, O Bharata! Using the sword of knowledge, cut asunder the layer of doubts caused due to ignorance enveloping your mind. Lift yourself up and get going on performing your *yoga*, i.e., the duty of fighting this just war. (4.42)

Comments: Arjuna had developed deep doubts about the need to fight the war based on his fears of losing near and dear ones. Lord Krishna concludes the discussion in this chapter by encouraging Arjuna to get rid of the doubts in his mind through proper knowledge and focus on his prescribed duty of waging the rightful war with proper conviction.

Summary of Chapter 4

In chapter 3, the Lord taught that one must perform one's prescribed duties without expectations. In this chapter, the Lord teaches more about the nature of activities (*karma*) of both the Lord and individual beings. In verses 4.1-3, the Lord says that He had taught this spiritual knowledge previously to deities such as Surya etc. In response to Arjuna's question in

4.4 about the chronology of the Lord's current manifestation and those of other deities, the Lord provides details of His incarnations in 4.5-9 stating that He manifests at His own free will from time to time to protect righteousness and virtue in society and to destroy evil. In verse 4.13, the Lord discusses the creation of living beings based on one's innate nature, aptitude, and activities. In verse 4.14, the Lord states that He has no obligations and activities do not bind Him. He states that one who clearly understands the distinction between the supreme soul and individual souls will not be entangled by actions. Categories and nature of activities are described in verses 4.16-33 which provide comparison of *nishkama karma* to other types of activities (*karma*), and details of the types of *nishkama karma*. Verses 4.16 to 4.18, compare the different types of activities – *karma* (right action), *vikarma* (prohibited action), and *akarma* (inaction). Verse 4.18 describes the two attributes of one who is performing one's duty perfectly– (i) such a person realizes that even when performing prescribed duties, the actual work is being enabled by the Lord himself and (ii) when not actively performing duties, (ex: during sleep, dream) activity such as breathing is enabled by the Lord. Such a wise person will derive full benefits from duties performed. In that sense verse 4.18 is a summary of this entire chapter. Five verses (4.19- 23) describe the characteristics of such a wise person, which briefly are – pandit (highly knowledgeable), ever contented, detached, equanimous. That person would also have deep conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge. Verses 4.24-30 contain a discussion on different types of sacrifices performed by seekers in their quest for self-realization and liberation. These verses emphatically state that Vedic sacrifice (*yagna*) not only refers to the symbolic acts of propitiating deities with fire rituals etc., but also refers to other selfless acts such as donating to charity, devotional worship to the Lord Almighty, spiritual education, self-control, self-discipline etc. The discussion on sacrifices is concluded in verse 4.32 where the Lord exhorts Arjuna to fight the just war to protect his citizens as that is his prescribed duty. Performing

one's prescribed duty as an offering to the Lord is indeed a superior form of worshipping the Lord. In verse 4.33, the Lord teaches that action is complete only when it is accompanied by knowledge. In verses 4.36-38, the Lord describes the greatness of knowledge and in verse 4.39 outlines the attributes of a seeker searching for right knowledge. This chapter is concluded in verse 4.42, where Lord Krishna exhorts Arjuna to use knowledge (*jnana*) to get over any doubts he had about waging the war and to focus on fighting the just war with conviction.

B{V MVWm@Ü`m`...

End of Chapter 4

n#m_m@Ü¶m`... - H\$\_gÝÝ`mg`mJ...

Chapter 5 - The Path of Renunciation

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 29 verses is known as *Sanyasa Yoga* (The Path of Renunciation). Renunciation of worldly pleasures is termed *sanyasa* and performing prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord is termed *yoga* (action). In this chapter, the Lord answers Arjuna's questions on fundamental aspects of these two concepts – *sanyasa* and *yoga*. Arjuna's argument is that if renunciation were a better option than action, he could perhaps adopt the life of an ascetic and avoid waging the war. The Lord goes on to describe the characteristics of a renunciant and clarifies that one must incorporate both these paths to achieve self-realization. The Lord reiterates that Arjuna must focus on performing his prescribed duty of waging the war to protect his citizens from the evil Kauravas. This chapter also delves into the importance of detachment and the characteristics of seekers who have developed detachment from rewards through self-control.

Action or Renunciation? Which is Better?

AOZ CdmM ¶&

gÝÝ¶mg H\$_Um H\$îU nZ`mJ M eg{g ¶&
¶ÀN` EV`maH\$ VÝ_ ~{h g{Z[üV_ ¶&& 1 &&

Arjuna said: O Krishna! Sometimes you seem to praise the path of renunciation and other times you seem to praise the path of action. Please tell me clearly, which of the two is beneficial. (5.1)

Comments: In verse 2.48, the Lord clearly directs Arjuna to focus on his prescribed duties without expectations. This concept was expanded in Chapter 3 (*karma yoga*). In verse 4.22, from Chapter 4 (*jnana yoga*), the Lord stated that one must be equanimous in the face of happiness/sadness and be content with whatever is granted by Him. These two characteristics

are described by ‘*yoga*’ and ‘*sanyasa*’. If the latter is the better path, then Arjuna could conclude that he would be better off focusing on relinquishing all activities and developing equanimity and devotion to the Lord. He could then perhaps avoid participating in the destructive war.

Sri Rayaru in GV gives us a second interpretation, where the question is related to the comparison between ascetics and householders. Verse 4.41 can be interpreted as describing the attribute of a seeker who has relinquished all outcomes from actions and has taken on the role of an ascetic. Verse 4.42 directs that one must perform one’s prescribed duties and hence can be interpreted as referring to a householder. So, Arjuna could also be enquiring about the comparison between an ascetic and a householder, and if the former were the better of the two, he could perhaps embrace ascetism and avoid the battle.

Action and Renunciation - Both required for Liberation

Ir^JdZdM Y&
 gYŸŸm g... H\$_`mJü {Z... I`gH\$and^m Y&
 V`mñV H\$\_gYŸ`ngmV H\$_`mJm {d{eî`V Y&& 2 &&

The Lord said: Renunciation of worldly pleasures (*sanyasa*) and performing prescribed duties (*yoga*) are both necessary for one to achieve liberation. Performing prescribed action is better than merely renouncing worldly pleasures. (5.2)

Comments: The Lord categorically states that both—renunciation of worldly pleasures (*sanyasa*) and performing prescribed duties as an offering to Him (*karma yoga*) are necessary for one to achieve self-realization and liberation. One cannot conclude that only ascetics practice detachment and they do not have any obligations on action. Nor do householders only practice prescribed activities without practicing self-control. So, one cannot argue that *sanyasa* and *karma yoga* cannot co-exist in the same person. Lord Krishna recognizes Arjuna’s motivation

in this question and states that performing prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord (*karma yoga*) is superior to mere detachment, equanimity etc. (*sanyasa*), but both are required for achieving self-realization and ultimate liberation. Again, the Lord is impressing upon Arjuna that he must not avoid participating in his prescribed duty of fighting the just war.

k`... g {ZÈ`gÝ`ngr `m Z Ô{î Z H\$m→{V Ý&
{ZÕÔm {h _hm~mh g l | ~ÝYmV à_À`V Ý&& 3 Ý&&

One who neither hates the unpleasant nor craves for the pleasant is a real renunciant. O Arjuna, The One with Mighty Arms!! One who has conquered dualities (such as hatred and desires) will be freed from bondage. (5.3)

Comments: This verse clarifies that renunciation is not an attribute of only ascetics. Sri Rayaru [GV] states that in verse 4.22, the Lord described the attributes of one who has renounced, but without using the term *sanyasa*. Here He clarifies that such a person is a *sanyasi* (renunciant). This is important because Arjuna, in his question in 5.1 had used the term *sanyasa*.

gm>>`mJm nW½~mbm... àdXpÝV Z n{ÊSVm... Ý&
EH\$_ß`mpñWV... gâ`J C^`m{dÝXV \b_ Ý&& 4 &&

Ignorant people say that the path of knowledge and the path of action (performed as an offering to the Lord without expectation of outcome) are different and are not causally related. Learned ones do not say that. Whichever path is properly followed, it will lead to the results obtainable from both the paths. (5.4)

Comments: The Lord clarifies that the paths of knowledge and action are not exclusive but are in fact causally related (i.e. complement each other). Some scriptures such as the **Bhagavata Maha Purana** [BMP], in canto 11, chapter 21, state that those who focus only on ritualistic fire

sacrifices will only end up with irritation in the eyes due to smoke (in other words they do not achieve anything of value). Sri Rayaru in [GV] clarifies that the reference in BMP is related to someone who performs ritualistic activities with expectations on rewards and without offering the fruits to the Lord. Such activities are pointless. In summary, both the paths of renunciation and action are complementing each other and result in a seeker achieving divine, spiritual knowledge.

Ḑgṃ»`... àṃḐ`V ṛWṃZ VÚṃJaṃn Jâ`V ṽ&
EH\$ gṃ»`M `ṃJ M `... nÍ`{V g nÍ`{V ṽ&& 5 &&

Those following the path of action (performed as an offering to the Lord without expectations) and those following the path of knowledge (acquiring and disseminating spiritual knowledge) both reach the Lord's abode. The one who understands this is a true knower. (5.5)

Comments: The previous verse stated that both the paths of knowledge and action are important. How can one deduce that actions lead to knowledge? The Lord answers by stating that even those in the path of action do reach the His abode but through the path of divine, spiritual knowledge. These two paths are symbiotically related. Sri Rayaru in GV states a second interpretation of this verse as follows – The goal that is attained by a seeker who is an ascetic is also reachable by seekers who are householders (non-ascetics). Ascetics who have renounced everything will also perform activities, and householders act based on knowledge acquired.

Mere Renunciation without Action Leads to Misery

gYÝ`ṃgñV \_hṃ~ṃhṃ X... I \_ṃá\_`ṃJV... ṽ&
`ṃJ`°\$ṃ _{Z~÷ Z {MaUṃ{YJÀN{V ṽ&& 6 &&

O Arjuna, one with Mighty Arms! Mere renunciation of worldly pleasures while abdicating prescribed duties leads to grief. One who

performs prescribed action as an offering to the Lord while renouncing worldly pleasures will indeed reach the Lord. (5.6)

Comments: In this verse the Lord clarifies that mere renunciation of worldly pleasures while abdicating prescribed duties leads one to downfall. Developing detachment from rewards requires a lot of mental effort. Such efforts should not be wasted for temporary rewards. In addition to renouncing worldly pleasures, one must focus on performing one's prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord as this leads to liberation and lasting peace. On the other hand, a seeker who performs prescribed actions without attachment to the rewards, but as an offering to the Lord will indeed reach the Lord's abode. The goal of every action should be to please the Lord.

ॐ J ॐ {deÖmE_m {d{OVmE_m {OVpYD`... V&
gd^VmE_ ^VmE_m H\$dp{n Z {bß`V V&& 7 &&

One with a pure soul who is focused on the path of action with sincerity, with control over mind and sense organs, with firm conviction that the Lord of all beings is also ones Lord will not be tainted by the ill effects of any action. (5.7)

Comments: In verse 5.3, it was stated that a renunciant will not avoid unpleasant actions and will not crave for only pleasant activities. The first part of this verse states that the renunciant would have developed this conviction through the practice of self-control. The second part of this verse states that such a person will have achieved divine, spiritual knowledge as a secondary benefit which will then help in obtaining the primary benefit of *moksha*.

All Activities are Due to the Lord Alone

Zd {H\${#mV H\$am_r{V ॐ \$m _Y`V Vîd{dv V&
ní`Z ûmÊdZññeZ {OKZ ÁYz JÀNz ñdnZ ægZ V&& 8 &&

àbnZ {dgOZ J†Z CpÝ_fZ {Z_fZ A{n Ý&
BpÝÐ`mUr{ÝÐ`mWf dVÝV B{V Yma`Z Ý&& 9 &&

During activities such as seeing, listening, touching, smelling, eating, moving, sleeping, breathing, talking, excreting, holding, opening eyelids, closing eyelids, the sense organs are performing their activities propelled by the Lord. A seeker should understand that the Lord is independent, and no one can perform anything independently without the Lord's will. (5.8) (5.9)

Comments: Verses (5.3) – (5.7) described the attributes of a renunciant. These two verses describe the conviction behind those attributes. One who utterly understands that every action performed through one's physical body and mind takes place only because of the Lord's will can develop detachment from the rewards of any action. After all such a person knows that no one can perform any action independently, and in such a case no one can claim any rewards.

~÷Ê`mYm` H\$_m{U g“ Ê`ŠĚdm H\$am{V `... Ý&
{bß`V Z g nmnZ nÙnì{dmâ^gm Ý&& 10 &&

The one who performs prescribed duties without expectations, as an offering to the Lord Himself, knowing that the Lord is the cause of all activities, will not be entangled by actions just as water does not cling to a lotus leaf. (5.10)

Comments: In verse 5.6, it was stated that a seeker needs both renunciation and action to achieve self-realization. In verse 5.7, it was stated that such a seeker will not be tainted by actions. This verse combines the concepts in these verses and categorically states that such a seeker will not be impacted by any sins accruing from actions and will obtain *moksha*. This verse identifies the attributes of such a seeker who has incorporated both renunciation and action. Such a seeker –

- will not claim ownership on activities.
- has full conviction that the Lord causes all activities.
- performs activities as a worship to the Lord.
- is detached from any rewards from such actions.
- offers any accrued rewards to the Lord.
- is aware that the Lord has caused these activities for the benefit of the seeker.

Such a seeker is not impacted by any effects of such action, just as water does not cling to a lotus leaf. The comparison with the lotus is very apt. The lotus is hydrophobic as even when it is immersed in water, it does not hold water. Similarly, the seeker described here, even when immersed in worldly activities will not be tainted by any effects of such actions.

This verse has been appropriately identified by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha as a summary of chapter 5 in BGS as it truly summarizes the characteristics of a seeker whose spiritual journey incorporates both *karma* and *sanyasa*.

H\$m`Z\_Zgm~Öçm H\$db[apÝÐ`a{n V&
`m{JZ... H\$\_ H\$dpÝV g“ Ē`ŠĒdm@@Ē_eŌ` V&& 11&&

Virtuous seekers perform their prescribed duties with purity in their physical body, sense organs, mind, and intellect, without attachment and without expectations, to cleanse their minds. (5.11)

Comments: In previous verses 5-6 to 5-10 it was stated that a seeker needs to incorporate both renunciation and action to succeed in the path of self-realization. This verse clarifies that actions must be accompanied by purity in body, mind, intellect, and sense organs all of which are essential for any activity. Such a seeker can cleanse his mind. A pure mind can absorb divine, spiritual concepts easily, which then allows the seeker to perform prescribed activities without getting entangled by them.

`°\$... H\$\_ \b E`ŠEdm empYV_mBZm{V Z{ðH\$s _ |Ÿ&
A`°\$... H\$m\_H\$maU \b g°\$m {Z~Ü`V Ÿ&& 12 &&

A true *Yogi* (seeker) who performs prescribed duties without expectations on outcome, as an offering to the Lord and with a sense of duty, will achieve steady peace. One who merely longs for the fruits of actions stays imprisoned in worldly affairs. (5.12)

Comments: The previous verses 5-6 to 5-10 discussed the need to practice both renunciation and prescribed duties (action) to achieve eternal bliss (*moksha*). Are there other ways for one to achieve *moksha*? This verse clarifies that there are no other ways. These two paths are both necessary to achieve *moksha*. One who fails to practice either will develop obsession with temporary, worldly rewards and will never be able to escape from the cycle of *samsara*.

gdH\$_m{U_Zgm gYŸ`ñ`m@ñVg I der Ÿ&
ZdÜma na Xhr Zd H\$dp H\$ma`Z Ÿ&& 13 &&

True happiness is experienced by those who completely surrender to the Lord and are convinced that no one performs any activity or gets any activity performed by others independently. Such seekers will experience inner bliss within their own selves - a city with nine doors. (5.13)

Comments: In verses 5-8 to 5-9, it was stated that a true seeker is aware that none of the actions performed by that seeker are independently performed. They are in fact performed by the Lord, using the seeker as an instrument. This verse clarifies that such a seeker also needs to be aware that the seeker also cannot cause those actions to be performed independently. The Lord is responsible for all activities which are performed by Him of His own free will. Such a seeker even when residing in a physical body having nine orifices (like nine doors to a city) will experience peace and will not be tainted by any activities.

Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha gives an example of an episode in the **Mahabharata**, where the city of Dwaravati which had nine doors was compared to a human body which has nine orifices. When some indulge in prohibited activities such as gambling, the in-dwelling Lord chooses not to protect them, just like Lord Krishna did not protect the Pandavas who lost their kingdom to the Kauravas in the game of dice.

Doership – Individual Souls and Lord Almighty

Z H\$VĖd Z H\$_m{U b mH\$ñ` gO{V à^... ĩ&
Z H\$_\b\$g`mJ ñd^m dñV àdV V ĩ&& 14 &&

ZmXÎm H\$ñ`{MV nm n Z Md gH\$V {d^... ĩ&
Ak mZZm@dV kmZ VZ _÷pYV OYVd... ĩ&& 15 &&

A living being cannot perform activities independently or get activities performed by others nor achieve fruits from such actions nor get fruits for others independently. The ever-independent Lord is responsible for all these actions. (5.14)

Living beings cannot independently diminish sins nor claim credit for good deeds. Their knowledge is veiled by ignorance, and hence they are deluded. Being deluded, they cannot realize the Lord. (5.15)

Comments: Verses 5.8&5.9 state that living beings, when they interact with the external world (through actions such as seeing, talking) are not actually doing so on their own. These two verses provide more insight into the nature of actions as they relate to living beings. Sri Rayaru in GV provides two interpretations for these verses depending on the attribution for the words ‘*prabhu*’ in 5.14 and ‘*vibhu*’ in 5.15, both of which mean the Lord. These two words can be either attributed to *jiva*, the individual soul (as it is superior to inert objects) as also to the Lord Almighty (who is the Lord of all).

- **Individual Souls:** The first half of the verse 5.14 states that individual souls cannot act on their own or can they cause action by someone else. How about the reward for actions performed, regardless of how they are performed? The second half of the verse (5.14) answers by stating that individuals also do not have independence on the issue of rewards. The first half of 5.15 states that individual souls do not accrue negative or positive effects of action on their own. If the Lord is responsible for all actions, why is it that no one can physically see the Lord? The second half of 5.15 states that individuals cannot see the Lord as they are covered by ignorance.
- **Lord Almighty:** The Lord has not granted individuals, ability to act on their own. Likewise, the Lord has also not granted individuals, the liberty to claim rewards for their actions on their own. If the Lord is responsible for all actions of the individuals, will the Lord not be tainted by such actions? The first half of 5.15 states that the Lord is not tainted by actions of the individuals. The Lord provides individuals apparatus and facilities to act based on the individuals' innate nature to help them in their spiritual journey.

There are several questions that arise at this stage regarding the nature of actions related to an individual soul, inert objects, and the Lord. These questions are summarized as follows:

- If an individual soul does not have independence in performing actions, how can that soul be held responsible for the consequences of such actions?
- If the Lord Almighty is the one who is independent and is responsible for all actions performed by individual souls, how can the Lord be immune from the effects of such actions?

Sri Madhwacharya in his commentary on the **Brahma Sutras** [BSB] and in other works such as GTN, adequately answers these questions.

Firstly, one must understand the nature of attributes, doership (doer is an entity that performs some action) and independence as they relate to the three entities in the universe namely, individual souls, inert objects, and the Lord Almighty.

Attribute\Entity	Inert Objects	Individual Souls	Lord Almighty
<i>Doership</i>	No	Yes	Yes
<i>Independence</i>	No	No	Yes

The Lord is independent in all aspects and has unlimited ability to perform activities independently. Hence, He has both doership and independence. Inert objects neither have ability to perform anything nor do they have independence. Individual souls do have doership but not independence, hence they have dependent doership. The relationship between the Lord, inert objects and living beings is illustrated with the example of a dairy farmer milking a cow through its udders in Sri Madhwacharya's GTN 3-33. All three entities are required in the task of extracting milk from a cow. The udder is akin to an inert object. It cannot act, nor does it have any awareness or intent. The cow is a living being. It has awareness, it produces milk, it has an intention to give milk, but it cannot independently extract milk from itself. The dairy farmer is like the Lord who uses the udder and extracts milk from the cow.

Armed with the above information, the two questions raised can be answered as follows:

- Individual souls also have the quality of doership, but they are not independent. The Lord grants individuals the ability to perform activities based on their innate intent (*iccha*), attempt (*prayatna*) and knowledge (*jnana*). After all everyone has an intent to achieve liberation. The Lord recognizes this intent and grants the souls facilities such as a physical body, mind, intellect and sense organs to attain knowledge and perform prescribed duties. Even though individual souls do not have independence in action, they do have responsibility for their actions and hence are subject to dos and

don'ts (*vidhi, nishedha*). The key here is the intent that is present in individual souls. This concept is clarified in **Brahma Sutra** (2.3.47).

- The Lord is not tainted by actions performed by individual souls as the Lord merely grants them the ability to perform such actions. The Lord has nothing to gain by providing individual souls with the facilities they need. He does so out of pure compassion.

With the above information one can also resolve apparent conflicts in spiritual texts where in some texts individual souls are described as not having the attribute of doership, while in other texts the individual souls are described as having the attribute of doership. The former is indicating that the doership is not independent and the latter is indicating that the doership is dependent.

knZZ V VXknZ `fm Zm{eV_mĚ_Z... V&
Vfm_m{XĚ`dÁknZ àH\$me`{V VĚna_ V&& 16 &&

For those whose ignorance is destroyed by proper knowledge about the Lord, that very knowledge will reveal the Supreme Lord to them like a brilliant sun. (5.16)

Comments: The previous verse 5.15 indicated that the limitations of individual beings are due to their knowledge enveloped by ignorance. This verse clarifies how such ignorance can be overcome. If one's innate knowledge is covered by ignorance, how can that person be convinced to perform prescribed duties (*yoga*) with detachment (*sanyasa*)? Sri Rayaru in GV explains that knowledge that is enveloped by ignorance is the innate knowledge (*swaroopa jnana*) that is specific to a soul. The ignorance can be removed by the seeker obtaining proper knowledge through scriptural studies and teachings from a Guru. This knowledge is termed '*paroksha*' (indirect). Thus, a seeker by obtaining *paroksha* knowledge can get rid of ignorance, perform prescribed duties with detachment and attain divine, spiritual (*aparoksha* or direct) knowledge and reach the Lord.

VxÕ`ñVXmĚ\_mZñV{pđmñVĚnam`Um... ĩ&
 JÀNÝĚ`nZandqîm kmZ{ZYVH\$Ě_fm... ĩ&& 17 &&

One whose mind is firmly established in the Lord, one who accepts the Lord as one's owner, and has unflinching faith in the Lord, and who has taken shelter in the Lord, will be rid of sins due to divine knowledge and will reach the abode of the Lord, never to return. (5.17)

Comments: Verse 5.16 states that a seeker must acquire indirect knowledge through scriptural studies, to destroy ignorance which leads to acquiring divine, spiritual knowledge that eventually leads to *moksha*. This verse clarifies that one cannot expect to acquire direct knowledge (*aparoksha*) immediately after acquiring indirect knowledge. One must repeatedly study scriptures with the mind fully immersed in the Lord and ensure that the knowledge acquired is without any doubts and develop full conviction in such knowledge. This will allow a seeker to be prepared to absorb direct, divine, spiritual knowledge which leads the seeker to *moksha*.

The Learned See the Lord in All

{dÚm{dZ`gânP ~m÷U J{d hpñV{Z ĩ&
 e{Z Md ænmH\$ M npÊSVm... g_X{eZ... ĩ&& 18 &&

Learned ones will see the Lord in all beings - in educated, pious people, in exalted scholars, in cows, in elephants, in dogs, in cruel people who kill animals, and indeed in all. Such persons will see the same blemishless Lord of infinite auspicious attributes present in everyone. (5.18)

Comments: Previous verses 5.16 and 5.17 stated that a seeker must first acquire indirect knowledge through scriptural studies. When is a seeker considered to have obtained that knowledge? This verse states that a seeker who has successfully acquired indirect knowledge will know that the

same Lord Almighty is present everywhere and in everyone. They will know the same blemishless Lord of infinite auspicious attributes as present in different species of animals.

BBd V{OV... gJm `fm gma` pñWV _Z... ý&
{ZXmf {h g_ ~÷ Vñ_mX ~÷{U V pñWV... ý&& 19&&

One whose mind perceives the same Lord in everyone and everything will conquer worldly miseries in this current life itself. One who realises the blemishless Lord as the same everywhere will indeed reach the Lord. (5.19)

Comments: The previous verse 5.18 referred to the Lord as *Sama* without explicit mention. In this verse, it is clarified that the attribution *Sama* is to the Lord only, as evidenced by the adjective in the second line, *nirdosham* (one who is devoid of any blemishes). Sri Rayaru explains this in GV.

Equanimous Seekers Focus on the Lord

Z àôî`V {à` àms` Zm{ÛOV àms` Mm{à` _ ý&
pñWa~{Õag_Tm ~÷{dX ~÷{U pñWV... ý&& 20 &&

A renunciant who is aware that the Lord is independent should neither excessively rejoice during pleasurable times nor get depressed during periods of distress but always maintain equanimity. Such a person, realising that living beings are not independently responsible for their conditions, will always be focused on the Lord. (5.20)

Comments: This verse describes additional attributes of seekers who have successfully acquired spiritual knowledge. Such seekers will exhibit equanimity in the presence of pleasure or pain. They are no longer enveloped by ignorance and are aware of the independent nature of the Lord Almighty.

~m÷ñneîdg°\$mĒ_m {d'YXĒ`mĒ\_{Z`Ēg I _|Ÿ&
g ~÷`mJ`°\$mĒ_m g I _j`_íZV Ÿ&& 21 &&

One who has withdrawn from attachment to sense pleasures through external objects will experience inner bliss, although temporarily. Permanent bliss is experienced only through meditation, by focusing the mind steadfastly on the Lord. (5.21)

Comments: Verse 5.6 states that mere renunciation of worldly pleasures while abdicating actions is pointless. However, one can argue that by practising detachment from sense pleasures, one can overcome desires and experience peace. In this case, why perform any specific activities? This verse states that any peace that is attained by withdrawal from attachment to sense pleasures is temporary. To experience unlimited bliss, one must also focus on performing activities such as meditation with the mind steadfastly focused on the Lord. This verse uses the term *akshaya* meaning 'unlimited' in the second line. The procedure for meditation is described later in the verses 5.27 and 5.28. Sri Rayaru has a second interpretation for this verse as follows: A renunciant will experience some amount of bliss just by remembering the Lord. It goes without saying that when renunciation is coupled with deep meditation on the Lord, the seeker will be on the path to achieve *moksha* (unending bliss).

Yogis withdraw from Indulgence

`{h gñneOm ^mJm X... I `mZ` Ed V Ÿ&
AmÚÝVdÝV... H\$mÝV` Z Vf a_V ~Y... Ÿ&& 22 Ÿ&&

O Arjuna, Son of Kunti! Know that temporary pleasures experienced through contact with sense organs are the reasons for misery. The wise do not seek to rejoice in them. (5.22)

Comments: Why do learned ones avoid indulging in pleasurable sense activities? This verse answers by stating that the learned ones are aware that such activities, while they appear to bring pleasure in the short term, always end up in misery (for example, the long term health effects of indulging in excessive sweet dishes). The reason for such misery is due to the transitory nature of the pleasure experienced.

eŠZmVrhd `... gṁṁṁ àṁH\$ eara{d_ṁjUmV ṁ&
H\$m_H\$mYmØd dJ g `°\$... g g l r Za... ṁ&& 23 ṁ&&

One who can withstand the pressures of desire and anger in this lifetime, before leaving their body, is the real *yogi*. Such a person is indeed blissful. (5.23)

Comments: This verse urges a seeker to develop detachment from emotions such as desire, anger, etc., in the current lifetime itself. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV the importance for a seeker to develop such detachment in the current lifetime while the seeker has a human form. There is no guarantee that one will be reborn in human form. It is not easy for other living forms, such as animals, to develop such detachment. Hence, one should not waste the opportunity that the Lord has provided by granting one a human form. Sri Padmanabha Teertha, in his commentary **Gita Bhashya Bhava Pradeepika** [GBBP] clarifies that the use of the word *nara* (human) in this verse does not imply that only humans are eligible for bliss. Those who have attained *Brahma Loka* (the abode of Brahma) are also eligible for bliss as they do not have emotions of desire, anger, etc. Sri Madhwacharya in his GB, clarifies that one reaches *Brahma Loka* only after overcoming such emotions.

`ṁ@ÝV...g l ṁ@ÝVamam\_ñVWm@ÝVÁ`ṁ{Vad `... ṁ&
g `ṁJr ~÷{ZdṁU ~÷^Vṁ@{YJÀN{V ṁ&& 24 &&

A *yogi* who has realised the futility of seeking pleasures from the external world will experience inner bliss and will realise Lord Almighty. Such a person who is truly knowledgeable about the true nature of the Lord will indeed reach the Lord's abode. (5.24)

Comments: The next few verses describe the nature of the learned. They experience bliss on two counts. Firstly, by overcoming passions such as desire and aversion, they feel liberated. Second, by focusing on the Lord in their minds, they experience inner bliss. They are focused only on the Lord and nothing else, as indicated by the use of the word *eva* (only) in the first line. The Lord here is described as *anatarjyoti* meaning the one who is self-effulgent.

b^YV ~÷{ZdU_ F\$f`... j rUH\$ë_f... Y&
{NpÛYm`Vmë_mZ... gd^V{hV aVm... Y&& 25 &&

The learned ones who have dispelled all doubts and ignorance and who wish good things for all beings will be rid of sins and indeed reach the Lord. (5.25)

Comments: The previous verse stated that one who focuses on the Lord will achieve inner bliss. This verse further stated that such a seeker who is rid of sins will rise above duality (such as joy/misery), exercise self-control, and have strong convictions in spiritual knowledge. Such a conviction occurs once a seeker is devoid of any doubts or ignorance about spiritual issues.

H\$m_H\$mY{d`°\$mZm`VrZm`VMVgm_Y&
A{^Vm ~÷{ZdU dW {d{XVmë_Zm_Y&& 26 &&

For one who has achieved self-realisation and through sincere efforts is able to control the mind and win over passions such as desire and anger, the Lord will be visible everywhere. (5.26)

Comments: This verse states that one who has achieved self-realisation through self-control will not only experience inner bliss but will also be able to visualise the Lord as his protector, always and everywhere.

Contours of Meditation

ñnenZ H\$Edm ~{h~møü j üdmÝVa ^dm... Ý&
àUmnZm g_m H\$Edm Zmgä`ÝVaMm[aUm Ý&& 27&&

`VpÝÐ¶\_Zm~{Ö\_{Z\_m j nam`U... &
{dJVÀNm^`H\$mYm `... gXm _°\$ Ed g... Ý&& 28 &&

One who has control over sense organs and has a steady mind, who focuses eyes in the area between the eyebrows or the edge of the nose, who controls the exhaling and inhaling breaths, who is not impacted by desire, fear, and anger and who is focused steadfastly on achieving liberation, is indeed liberated in this very life. (5.27) (5.28)

Comments: Verse 5.21 indicated the need for meditation. These two verses describe the procedure for meditation on the Lord. Meditation involves three main steps. The first step is to withdraw sense organs from indulging in pursuing sensory pleasures. The second step is to control breathing by holding the breath steady after inhalation and exhalation. The third step is to focus the eyes on the region between the eyebrows or the edge of the nose. These steps help a seeker maintain physical and mental steadiness, which allows the mind to concentrate on the Lord. Such a seeker is deemed to have achieved liberation in this very life. In other words, such a seeker will indeed achieve liberation hereafter.

^m°\$ma `kVngm gdbmH\$_hœa_ Ý&
göX gd^VmZm kmEdm _m empÝV_ÀN{V Ý&& 29 &&

One who meditates on Me and knows Me as the ultimate consumer of all sacrifices and rituals, as the Supreme Lord of the universe and as the well-wisher for all beings, will indeed reach Me and will be liberated. (5.29)

Comments: The previous two verses described the process of concentrated meditation on the Lord. The above verse describes the subject of such meditation, namely Lord Almighty.

Summary of Chapter 5

In chapter 3, the Lord taught that one must perform ones prescribed duties without expectations. (*nishkama karma*). In chapter 4, the Lord imparts knowledge (*jnana*) about the nature of activities (*karma*) of both the Lord and individual beings. In chapter 5, the Lord answers some fundamental questions from Arjuna (5.1) regarding the concepts of renunciation (*sanyasa*) and action (*karma*). It is apparent from Arjuna's question that if renunciation were a better option than action, he could perhaps adopt the life of an ascetic and avoid waging the war. The Lord answers (5.2) by stating that while both the paths of renunciation and action lead one to liberation, the path of action is superior. The Lord goes on to describe the characteristics of a renunciant (5.2) and clarifies that one must incorporate both these paths to achieve self-realization (5.6). An oft quoted example is that of a person who is sick in the stomach due to an unhealthy diet. For such a person to heal, it is important to both consume the medication prescribed by the doctor and at the same time avoid indulging in an unhealthy diet. By stating that the path of action is superior, the Lord is clarifying to Arjuna that he must participate in his prescribed duty of waging this war to protect his citizens, while detaching himself from any outcomes of his actions. The Lord also clarifies that both ascetics and householders are equally eligible to attain salvation, based on their efforts. An ascetic who may have acquired divine, spiritual knowledge will still be involved in performing activities and likewise a householder who is preoccupied with performing prescribed activities will also be involved in acquiring spiritual knowledge. Some scriptures downplay the role of

actions such as ritual fire sacrifices which may only result in eye irritation, due to smoke. It is clarified that any such description of action is related to actions that are performed with specific expectations. They do not apply to actions performed as an offering to the Lord without expectations (5.4). It is also clarified that one cannot achieve much by merely relinquishing the outcomes of actions, without offering them to the Lord. Any activity can be deemed as complete and useful only when such activities are performed with a pure mind and as an offering to the Lord with no material expectations (5.6). An ideal seeker is one who performs prescribed duties with detachment towards the rewards, performs activities while exercising control over sense organs and the mind, knows that the Lord is the one who is causing the action, and is aware that the Lord Almighty is the Lord of everyone in the universe. He performs activities with devotion and as a worship to the Lord. Such a seeker will not be tainted by any effects of actions just as water does not stick to a lotus leaf (5.10). One should realize that it is the Lord who makes it possible for one to perform any activity. The Lord activates all activities in the universe. However, the individual souls are responsible for the outcomes of their activities, even though they are enabled to act by the Lord. The individual soul has dependent doership and the Lord is the only independent doer. The Lord activates the intent and attempt of the individual souls, hence the individual souls are held responsible for the actions. The Lord is never tainted by any such actions, as He has nothing to gain by any action and performs them out of pure compassion for the individual souls (5-14, 5-15). The nature of knowledge in learned ones is described in verses 5.15 to 5.17. Knowledge is of two types, indirect and direct. The inherent knowledge in individual souls is masked by ignorance, and seekers get rid of this ignorance through spiritual studies, analysis, and listening to lectures from teachers (indirect knowledge) etc. This paves the way for seekers to achieve self-realization (direct knowledge). Learned ones perceive the same blemishless Lord full of infinite auspicious attributes present in all living beings (5.18). Learned ones who have developed detachment from sense pleasure, experience peace due to a sense of liberation, but everlasting bliss is only possible through meditation with the mind focused exclusively on the Lord (5.12).

Learned ones avoid indulging in sense pleasures which are temporary and lead only to misery (5.22). The Lord exhorts one to develop control over sense organs and emotions such as desire, anger in one's current lifetime itself while one has a human form, as this will not be possible with other life forms (5.23). The procedure for performing concentrated meditation which was stated as a necessity in verse 5.21 is described in verses 5.27 and 5.28. The chapter is concluded in 5.29 which describes the characteristics of the Lord who is the goal of such meditation. A seeker who meditates on the Lord, knowing the Lord as the consumer of all sacrifices and rituals, as the Lord of all, and as one who is the well-wisher for everyone, will indeed achieve liberation.

&& h{V n#m _m@Ü¶m` ... &&

End of Chapter 5

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय - आत्मयोगः

Chapter 6 - The Path of Self Restraint

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 47 verses is termed *Atma Samyama Yoga* (The Path of Self Restraint) or *Dhyana Yoga* (The Path of Meditation). The previous chapters described the broad contours of the path of action (*karma yoga*) and the path of knowledge (*jnana yoga*). Further, the characteristics of a seeker who is on a journey to self-realization were broadly identified as one having detachment from outcomes of action (*sanyasa*) and performing prescribed duties (*yoga*) as an offering to the Lord. This was briefly described in verse 2.39. *Yoga* as described here prepares a seeker to learn more about the greatness of the Lord which is covered in detail in chapters 7 to 12. This chapter delves more into the details of *yoga* (action) and its components. *Yoga* has two components – external and internal. The external component of *yoga* refers to the prescribed activities that one must perform that are visible to others. For example, Arjuna waging the war to protect his citizens from the Kauravas' misrule. This aspect of *yoga* was briefly described in verse 2.45 and was expanded in chapters 3 to 5. The internal component of *yoga* is termed *dhyana yoga* (path of meditation), This is also an essential aspect of *yoga* and was briefly described in verse 5.27. This chapter delves into details of *dhyana yoga*. Characteristics of a true *yogi* are described. The physical aspects of meditation such as place, physical pose, breath control etc., are also described. Requirements for moderation in consumption are also discussed. To a question from Arjuna regarding the condition of those who make a sincere attempt but are not able to successfully implement *karma* and *dhyana*, the Lord teaches that no sincere effort is a waste, and such seekers will get additional opportunities to complete their spiritual journey.

The Ascetic and the Yogi

Ir^JdZdM Y&
 AZm{IV... H\$_\b H\$m` H\$\_ H\$am{V `... &
 g gY`mgr M `mJr M Z {Za{3/4Z Mm{H\$`... Y&& 1 &&

The Lord said: One who performs prescribed duties without expectations is both a real ascetic and a real *yogi*; not the one who has simply relinquished performing ritual fire sacrifices. (6.1).

Comments: As indicated before, this chapter delves into details of *dhyana yoga*, or the internal component of *yoga* (path of action). When is a seeker eligible to follow the path of *dhyana* (meditation) which prepares one to learn about the qualities of the Lord? This verse states that a true seeker who has both detachment towards outcomes of actions and commitment to performing prescribed duties is ready and eligible for *dhyana yoga*.

Some schools such as *sankhya*, hold the view that ascetics who have relinquished ritual fire sacrifices are the only ones eligible for *dhyana yoga*. This verse clarifies that even ascetics have obligations to perform sacrifices such as worship of the Lord, learning and preaching scriptures etc., as was stated in verse 4.25. Hence all seekers (including ascetics, and householders) are eligible for *dhyana yoga* if they perform their prescribed duties without expectations.

` gY`mg_{V àmh`mJ V {d{Õ nmÊSd Y&
 Z øgY`ñVgH\$ën`mJr ^d{V H\$üz Y&& 2 Y&&

O Pandava (Arjuna)! Understand that relinquishing passions such as desire and anger (detachment) is an integral part of *karma yoga*. One who is performing activities without getting rid of desire is not a real *yogi*. (6.2)

Comments: Previous verses stated that a real seeker has both the characteristics of detachment from outcomes and commitment to performing prescribed activities, which are broadly termed *sanyasa* and *yoga*. To emphasize the fact that these are not separate paths, this verse explicitly states that *sanyasa* as described here is an essential component of *yoga*.

Amée j m_Z`mJ H\$ H\$maU\_À`V ĩ&
`mJmê\$Tñ` Vñ`d e\_... H\$maU\_À`V ĩ&& 3 ĩ&&

For the one who has indirect knowledge (through scriptures) of the Lord, the path of achieving direct, divine knowledge is through the path of action. One who has achieved direct knowledge of the Lord, through steadfast prayer and meditation, will experience exuberance in bliss upon liberation. (6.3)

Comments: Knowledge is of two types. Indirect knowledge (*paroksha jnana*) is the knowledge that a seeker acquires through study of scriptures, from listening to teachers etc. This knowledge helps the seeker to get rid of ignorance that covers innate knowledge (verse 5.16). A seeker armed with such indirect knowledge, by practicing *sanyasa* and *yoga*, will be eligible for self-realization through direct, divine knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*). Will an *aparoksha jnani* indulge in activities and if so, what is to be gained? This verse builds upon the description in verse 3.20 and clarifies that an *aparoksha jnani* continues to perform activities to set an example to the society. Such actions are not wasted efforts but will result in increased exuberance in bliss upon liberation. There is another difference in duties performed by *paroksha* and *aparoksha jnanis*. The former needs to also engage in service to society to help those in need (just as one needs to pay taxes). The latter does not have such a broad mandate but needs to serve superior souls.

`Xm {h ZpÝÐ`mWf Z H\$_ñdZf ,mV Ý&
gdgH\$ëngÝÝ`mgr `mJmê\$TñVXmÀ`V Ý&& 4 Ý&&

One who is naturally disinterested in sense pleasures, has no attachment to actions, and performs actions only as an offering to the Lord is said to have achieved direct knowledge of the Lord. (6.4)

Comments: This verse describes the characteristics of a realized soul (*aparoksha jnani*) who has attained direct, divine knowledge. Such a person is said to be naturally disinterested in sense pleasures and in rewards from actions. This is different from other seekers who are yet to reach this stage. These other seekers may also have developed aversion to sense pleasures, but such aversion does not come to them naturally. They must actively practice control of sense organs.

The Mind is a Friend and an Enemy

CÕaXmĚ_Zm@@Ě_mZ Zm@Ě_mZ_dgmX`V Ý&
AmĚ_d ømĚ_Zm ~ÝYamĚ_d [anamĚ_Z... Ý&& 5 &&

One should elevate oneself through the mind and should never fall into misery because of a weak mind. The mind is one's friend and is also one's enemy. (6.5)

Comments: The next few verses describe the role of the mind in a seeker's evolution. The specialty of this verse is that it has 7 repetitions of the word '*atma*'. This is a remarkably interesting word in Sanskrit that has different meanings such as – self, Lord Almighty, mind, intellect, devotion etc. One can decipher the actual meaning only by looking at the context in which this word is used. The above translation interprets the 7 occurrences of *atma* as one, oneself, mind, mind, mind, one and mind.

Sri Rayaru [GV] provides an alternate meaning of this verse by interpreting *atma* as the Lord Almighty in some places. The Lord is ones

friend and the Lord is also one's enemy. Hence, one must strive to earn the Lord's grace and one must avoid earning His wrath.

~ÝYamĚ_m@@Ě_ZñVñ` `ZmĚ_dmĚ_Zm {OV... Ý&
AZmĚ_ZñV eìĚd dVWm@Ě_d eìdV Ý&& 6 &&

For one who wins over the mind with the intellect, the mind is indeed a friend. For one who cannot win over the mind, it becomes an enemy (the Lord becomes a friend to the devoted, and an enemy to those not devoted). (6.6)

Comments: This verse provides the reason for the mind to be someone's friend or enemy. For one who has developed control over the mind using the intellect, the mind is a friend. For such a seeker, the mind is a fertile ground for performing concentrated meditation on the Lord. For one who has no control over the mind, the mind itself becomes an enemy. So, the mind is like a key, which can be used to both lock and open a door.

A second interpretation as per Sri Rayaru in GV is as follows: For a seeker who has won over the Lord through devotion, the Lord becomes a friend. Those who are not devoted to the Lord will have the Lord as their enemy. In the above two interpretations the word '*atma*' has been translated as intellect and devotion, respectively.

{OVmĚ_Z... àemÝVñ` na_mĚ_m g_m{hV... Ý&
erVmîUg I X... I f VWm_mZmn_mZ`m... Ý&& 7 &&

kñZ{dkñZVámĚ_m H\$QñWm {d{OVpÝĎŦ... Ý&
`°\$ BĚ`À`V `mJr g_bmîmí_H\$m#mZ... Ý&& 8 &&

The Lord manifests in the heart of a seeker who has won over the Lord with devotion and has control over the sense organs and the mind. Such a seeker will have attained both ordinary, indirect knowledge (though

study of scriptures etc.) and special, direct, divine knowledge. This seeker is exemplified by contentment, detachment from sense pleasures, is equipoised when facing extreme conditions such as cold/heat, praise/insult, happiness/sadness etc. The seeker also treats mud, stone, and gold equally and is indeed the real *yogi* (6.7) (6.8)

Comments: Previous verses indicated that the mind and the Lord Almighty can be both friends and enemies. For a learned one who has won over both the mind (through intellect) and the Lord (through devotion), the Lord is a friend. These two verses describe the effect felt by such a seeker. With the Lord manifesting in the heart of such a seeker (in other words through the grace of the Lord), the seeker will develop great patience and equanimity in the face of extreme cold/heat, praise/insult etc. By acquiring knowledge through spiritual studies (indirect knowledge), a seeker develops control over sense organs/mind and devotion to the Lord, which in turn allows the seeker to win over the mind as well as the Lord. This allows the seeker to realize the Lord (direct knowledge), which in turn equips the seeker with equanimity in the face of extreme situations.

Equal Treatment

göpy`îm`XmgrZ_Ü`ñWûr`~ýYf î&
gmYîd{n M nmnf g_~{Õ{d{eî`V î&& 9 &&

Such a person treats everyone – well-wishers, friends, enemies, casual acquaintances, middlemen, the hateful, family along with virtuous people, and sinners equally. Equality is in the sense that the same blemishless Lord full of infinite auspicious attributes is indwelling in everyone. (6.9)

Comments: This verse continues to describe important attributes of a seeker who has achieved self-realization (with direct, divine knowledge). The population that one deals with daily is categorized into seven types -

- Well-wishers: Those who help others unconditionally
- Friends: Those who go out of their way to save others from danger
- Enemies: Those who always harm others
- Casual acquaintances: Those who neither help nor hurt.
- Middlemen: Those who help sometimes and harm sometimes
- Hateful: Those who hate others
- Family: Those who only help.

Everyone comes across these types of people daily and a real *yogi* treats them fairly and equally according to the guidelines in the scriptures. Equality is recognizing that the Lord indwelling in everyone is equally supreme with infinite auspicious attributes without blemish.

Procedure for Dhyana (Concentrated Meditation)

ॐJr ॐOrV gVW_ AmĒ_mZ ah{g pñWV... ĩ&
EH\$mH\$s ॐV{MÎmĒ_m {Zamēran[aJh... ĩ&& 10 &&

Such a seeker controlling his sense organs and mind, detached from desires and consumption, prefers to be alone, with the mind fully focused on the Lord. (6.10)

Comments: In verse 5.27, the procedure for performing meditation was briefly discussed. The next few verses provide more details on meditation. To properly perform meditation, one must focus on three aspects, mental, physical, and respiratory. The most difficult aspect to control among these three is of course, the mental aspect. Hence, there has been more emphasis on the importance of controlling one's mind. A *yogi* engaged in meditation first finds a suitable, calm place to minimize distractions from the external world.

eMm Xe à{Vðmß` pñWa_mgZ_mĒ_Z... ĩ&
ZmĒ` pÀNV Zm{VZrM Mb{OZH\$emÎma_ ĩ&& 11 &&

VÌH\$mJ _Z... H\$Ēdṁ `V{MÎṁpÝĐ`{H\$`... Ý&
Cn{dí`ṁgZ `Á`ṁX ¶ṁJ\_ṁĒ\_{deÕ` Ý&& 12 &&

For meditation, a seeker should choose a clean place and make a firm seat which is neither too high nor too low. The seat should be made of three layers starting with *kusa* grass, soft animal skin and a clean, soft cloth on top. (6.11)

On this seat, the seeker should sit comfortably but firmly (with one of the *yoga* poses such as the lotus, the diamond etc.), with due control over body and mind, and start meditation on the Lord for self-purification. (6.12)

Comments: For concentrated meditation, it is necessary to observe personal cleanliness and cleanliness of the environment. For one to ensure a clear mind and focus on the Lord Almighty, it is important to ensure physical cleanliness.

g_ H\$m`{eamJrd Yma`ṁMb pñWa... Ý&
gââú` Zn{gH\$mJ ñd {XeüṁZdbmH\$`Z Ý&& 13&&

àemÝVmĒ_ṁ {dJV^r~÷Mṁ[adV pñWV... Ý&
_Z... g`â` _{f Îṁṁ `°\$ AṁgrV _Ēna... Ý&& 14 &&

The seeker should keep body, head, and neck in a straight line, sit firmly without the eyes wandering and focus the eyes on the tip of the nose and meditate on the Lord. (6.13)

With a clear, uncluttered mind, devoid of any fears from external elements, focusing the mind on the Lord, keeping the sense organs from straying, a seeker should meditate on Me (Lord Krishna) with firm conviction in My supremacy. (6.14)

Comments: After preparing the physical apparatus (space, seat etc.), the seeker is now ready to start meditation, observing physical discipline by keeping body, head, and neck straight. It is also important to be free from fears from external elements such as wild animals when performing meditation. The Lord also says that the seeker should observe *brahmacharya* which some interpret as celibacy. However, meditation applies to all, not just the unmarried. So, the real interpretation of the *brahmachari* is *brahma* + *achara*, the one whose mind is active only on topics related to the Lord (*brahma*).

`Opd gXm@@E\_mZ `mJr {Z`V_mZg... ĩ&
empÝV {ZdmUna_m _EgñWm_{YJÀN{V ĩ&& 15 &&

A seeker who meditates thus, with firm control on the mind, and complete focus on the Lord, will achieve eternal bliss after leaving the present body. (6.15)

Comments: This verse describes the benefit experienced by a seeker who performs concentrated meditation on the Lord, based on the procedures described previously. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that such a seeker will not just achieve the state of *jeevan mukti* (inner bliss experienced while alive) but will also achieve everlasting bliss in the company of the Lord in *moksha*.

Moderation in Consumption

ZmE`ýVñV `mJm@pñV Z MH\$mÝV_ZýV... ĩ&
Z Mm{VñdßZerbñ` OmJVm Zd MmOZ ĩ&& 16 &&

`°\$hma{dhmañ` `°\$M'iñ` H\$_g ĩ&
`°\$ñdßZmd~mYñ` `mJm ^d{V X... I hm ĩ&& 17 &&

O Arjuna! One cannot achieve benefits of such meditation if one over eats or does not eat at all. Similarly, one who oversleeps or does not sleep at all, will also lose all benefits from meditation. (6.16)

One who wishes to benefit from such meditation should practice moderation in eating, relaxing, sleeping, and other daily activities. (6.17)

Comments: These two verses describe the requirements for physical wellbeing for a seeker to successfully perform concentrated meditation. It is important for a seeker to ensure physical wellbeing by observing moderation in habits such as eating, sleeping etc. It is evident from practice that overeating leads to bodily discomfort. Similarly, oversleeping leads to laziness and lethargy. Neither of these conditions are conducive for meditation. Likewise, one should not unnecessarily indulge in difficult, strict fasting (as some do to reduce weight) as this can also have health consequences. Basically, one needs to observe moderation in eating and sleeping. However, those who are in good physical condition, should not avoid fasting on special days such as *Ekadashi*.

`Xm {d{Z`V {MÎm _ AmĚ _Ý` dmd{VăV ĩ&
{Z...ñnh... gdH\$m _ă`m `°\$ BĚ`À`V Vxm ĩ&& 18&&

`Wm Xrm {ZdmVñWm Z“V gmn _m ñ _Vm ĩ&
`m{JZm `V{MÎmñ` `OVm `mJ _mĚ _Z... ĩ&& 19 &&

When one can control sense organs and focus the mind on the Lord, one would achieve victory over desire and such a person is indeed the real *yogi*. (6.18)

The condition of a person, who can meditate on the Lord with complete control over the sense organs and the mind, is similar to that of a lamp glowing steadily in a windless place. (6.19)

Comments: One who can observe moderation in habits (6.16), (6.17), and implement the techniques of meditation described in previous verses 6.11 – 6.14, will be able to control the sense organs, and mind, and successfully meditate with the mind focused on the Lord. The state of a focused mind is compared to that of a lamp in a windless place where the lamp continues to glow steadily.

Characteristics of a Dhyana Yogi

`İmna\_V {MÎm {ZéÕ `mJgd`m İ&
 `İ Mdñ\_Zm@@\_mZ ní`bmË_{Z Vî`{V İ&& 20 &&

g I _mË`pYVH\$ `ÎmX ~{ÕJmø_VrpYÐ¶_&
 d{Îm` `İ Z Mdñ` pñWVübb{V VîdV... İ&& 21 &&

` bāüdm Mmna bm^ \_Y`V Zm{YH\$ VW... İ&
 `pñ\_Z pñWVm Z X... I Z JéUm@{n {dMmë`V İ&& 22&&

V {dÜmX X... I g`mJ{d`mJ `mJg{kV_ İ&
 g {Zü`Z `m°\$ì`m `mJm@{Z{dÊUMVgm İ&& 23&&

Practicing such meditation, one who has gained complete control over the mind, is able to see the Lord within oneself and experience bliss. (6.20)

One who has reached such a state will experience happiness beyond the reach of the sense organs that can only be comprehended by the intellect and will not lead the mind away from the Lord. (6.21)

One who experiences such happiness will not find anything more valuable and will not panic even in the most challenging situations. (6.22)

This path that frees one completely from misery is the real *yoga*. A seeker should practice such *yoga* with mental conviction detached from worldly pleasures. (6.23)

Comments: These 4 verses describe the experience of a *yogi* who is immersed in *dhyana*, meditation. They are characterized as follows:

- the mind, which is under control, will not seek any outside material.
- the *yogi* experiences inner bliss by visualizing the Lord within.
- the *yogi* experiences a level of happiness that cannot be comprehended by sense organs.
- the mind is focused steadfastly on the Lord and does not stray.
- the *yogi* does not consider anything else as more valuable.
- the *yogi* is not impacted by worldly distress.

Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that this state of meditation not only helps a seeker conquer any existing unhappiness but ensures that the seeker will not experience unhappiness in future also.

gH\$ënà^d_mZ H\$m_mñĒ`³Ēd_m gd_mZ AefV... Ĩ&
_ZgdpÝĒ`J\_m\_ {d{Z`â` g_ÝVV... Ĩ&& 24 &&

eZ... eZéna_V ~Ōç_m Y{VJhrV`_m Ĩ&
AmĒ_gñW _Z... H\$Ēd_m Z {H\$ç#mX{n {MÝV`V Ĩ&&25&&

A seeker should resolve to completely renounce activities of sense pleasure and use the mind to control the sense organs completely. (6.24)

A seeker should strive to bring the mind gradually under the firm control of the intellect. Having controlled the mind, one should focus attention on the Lord to the exclusion of all external thoughts, refrain from chasing sense pleasures, and tightly control the sense organs. (6.25)

Comments: The first action that a seeker must undertake is to make a resolution to completely renounce indulging in sense pleasures. A seeker who is serious about traversing the path to liberation should take this first step. After all, it is common even in worldly life for someone desirous of achieving somethings to start by making a mental resolution to reach that goal. The Lord recognizes that it is almost impossible for one to withdraw the mind away from sense pleasure instantly. Hence, the advice to implement the process gradually, in steps.

Mental Tranquility

`Vṁ `Vṁ {Züa{V _Zü#ṁb_pñWa_ ṽ&
VVñVVṁ {Z`â`VXmĒ_Ý`d de Z`V ṽ&& 26 &&

The mind, by nature, is always wandering. As and when the mind starts straying into worldly matters, the seeker should forcibly bring the mind back to focus on the Lord. (6.26)

Comments: This verse continues the discussion on mind control. The mind is ever wandering. The mind also cannot be empty. One way to ensure that the mind is not filled with worldly matters is to forcibly focus and fill the mind with issues related to the Lord. This ensures that the mind will gradually focus on the Lord and move away from worldly matters.

àeṁÝV_Zg øZ `ṁ{JZ g l _Îṁ__ ṽ&
Cn{V eṁÝVaOg ~÷^V_H\$Ē_f_ ṽ&& 27 &&

High level of happiness will accrue to a *yogi* who has a tranquil mind devoid of passionate qualities (such as obsession and aversion), and who is focused on the Lord. This is a well-known fact. (6.27)

Comments: This verse states that the advantage of *dhyana* meditation is achievement of superior happiness. A tranquil mind focused on the Lord can protect itself from the impacts of passionate qualities in

nature that lead to hatred, desire etc. This verse uses the word *hi* which means well-known. The implication is that this concept is supported by scriptural texts such as the **Vedas**.

`OZ Ed gXm@@ë\_mZ `mJr {dJVH\$ë_f... V&
g I Z ~÷gñne_ë`ÝV g I _íZV V&& 28 &&

In this manner, a seeker who is constantly focused on the Lord, and is free from vices (such as hatred and desire) will experience the company of Lord and will effortlessly experience bliss. (6.28)

Comments: The previous verse explained that a yogi focused on *dhyana* meditation will experience extreme happiness. This verse describes that happiness as the highest bliss that one experiences in the company of the Lord.

gd^VñW_më_mZ gd^Vm{Z Mmë_{Z V&
BjV `mJ`°\$më_m gdÌ g_XeZ... V&& 29 &&

Such a seeker can visualize the Lord in all beings and see all beings under the control of the Lord Almighty. Such a seeker has the realization that the all-pervading Lord present in all beings is equal in infinite, auspicious attributes. (6.29)

Comments: This verse describes the aspects of Lord Almighty as visualized by a *yogi* practicing *dhyana* meditation. Verse 5.29 and 6.14 described some aspects of Lord Almighty and this verse describes additional attributes in the context of a *dhyana yogi*.

Rewards from Dhyana

`m\_m ní`{V gdÌ gd M_{` ní`{V V&
Vñ`mh Z àUí`m{ g M _Z àUí`{V V&& 30 &&

One who sees Me (Lord Krishna) everywhere and who sees everything in Me will never lose Me and I will never be lost to that person. (6.30)

Comments: This verse states the special benefit accruing to a seeker who performs *dhyana* meditation using the procedures described previously. Such a seeker will see the Lord residing in everyone and everything and will also know the Lord as the controller of everything in the universe. The Lord will take care of such a seeker who will always be devoted to Him.

gd^VpñWV `m \_m ^OE`H\$Ed_m pñWV... ĩ&
gdWm dV_mZm@{n g `mJr \_{` dV ĩ&& 31 &&

Seekers who see only My presence in all beings and worship Me as such will ultimately reach My abode regardless of their conditions or state of being during their lifetime. (6.31)

Comments: This verse discusses additional benefits from *dhyana* meditation. A seeker performing such meditation with conviction about the Lord's presence in everyone will achieve *moksha* regardless of whether the seeker has taken a just or an unjust path. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV that in the latter case, the quantity of bliss experienced in *moksha* will be reduced. Why do some realized souls take an unjust path? Many times, as in the case of Bharata and Ajamila, realized souls indulged in undesirable activities (a result of past action) due to the will of the Lord. But they were eventually shown the proper path by the Lord and ultimately achieved *moksha*. They would however experience a reduction in bliss in *moksha*.

Sri Padmanabha Teertha in his Gita commentary [GBBP], makes a reference to verse 3.17 where a realized soul destined for *moksha* has no obligations to perform any activities. Such a seeker will also eventually reach the Lord even if that seeker had not performed any activities.

AmĒ_mnā`Z gdĪ g\_ní`{V`m@OZ ĩ&
g l d_m`{X d\_m X... l g`mJr na_m _V... ĩ&& 32&&

O Arjuna! One who wishes for others, the same that is wished for oneself (presence of happiness and absence of sadness) and sees the same Lord in everyone is indeed a superior *yogi*. (6.32)

Comments: In this verse the Lord describes the characteristics of a *yogi* who is superior to others. Such a seeker will wish for others what the seeker would have wished for himself/herself and would see the same Lord in everyone. Does it mean that the *yogi* will treat or consider everyone as equal? No. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies. The word *sama* or equal refers to the same Lord that is present in everyone as indicated by the phrase ‘*ekatvam asthita*’ in the previous verse. The same Lord is present in everyone with infinite auspicious attributes while being devoid of any blemishes.

How to Tame a Wavering Mind?

AOZ Cd_mM ĩ&
`m@` `mJñĒd`m àm³V... g_mā`Z _YgXZ ĩ&
EVñ`mh Z ní`m{ M#mbĒd_mV pñW{V pñWam_ ĩ&& 33 &&

M#mb {h _Z... H\$îU à_m{W ~bdX ÑT> ĩ&
Vñ`mh {ZJh \_Y` d_m`m[ad gXîH\$a_ ĩ&& 34 &&

Arjuna said: O Madhusoodana! I cannot see how the mind, which by nature is fickle, can be focused steadfastly on meditation. (6.33)

O Krishna! The mind is always wavering, it is turbulent, it is strong and obstinate. It can corrupt one’s body and sense organs. It is my view that trying to control the mind is extremely difficult, just like catching the wind. (6.34)

Comments: Arjuna, after listening to Krishna's teachings on *dhyana* meditation expresses doubts about the ability of the mind to meditate with full focus. The mind, by nature is fickle and is always wavering. The mind is extraordinarily strong, and many times forces one's body and sense organs astray. How can one control such a mind? It would be like trying to capture the wind. These are natural questions that would arise in a seeker.

Ir^JdZdM M Y&
 Age` _hm~nhm _Zm X{ZJh Mb_ Y&
 Aä`mgZ V H\$M'V` dam½`U M J÷V Y&& 35 &&

Ag`VmE\_Zm `mJm Xîàmñ B{V _ _{V... Y&
 dí`nE\_Zm V `Wm eŠ`m@dñá\_nm`V... Y&& 36 &&

The Lord said: O Arjuna, One with Strong Arms! No doubt it is exceedingly difficult to control the wavering mind. O Son of Kunti! It can be controlled by practice (of *dhyana* meditation) and detachment (from sense pleasures). (6.35)

One who cannot achieve control over the mind can never benefit from meditation. One should strive to achieve mind-control through continuous practice, focus and concentrated meditation. (6.36)

Comments: In these two verses, the Lord prescribes two ways for one to achieve control over the mind. One would be to keep practicing *dhyana* meditation and the other would be to develop detachment from sense pleasures. Both these are not easy to achieve but one must strive to continuously practice and over time one will be able to control one's mind. It is evident from one's experience that one interested in learning any skill in life such as sports or music, must continuously practice and never give up. We see many examples of high achievers who have excelled in their chosen profession by sheer grit, determination, and constant practice. The

same qualities when applied to meditation and detachment will help one develop control over one's mind.

One can question as to why one would need to develop detachment by avoiding indulgence in sensual pleasures as one can wait for such time till all desires are exhausted. Sri Jaya Teertha in PD uses the example of a wayward, drunk elephant which naturally becomes tame with exhaustion. But this is not true of sense organs. It is impossible to satiate sense organs by mere consumption. For example, one who craves good food and consumes it in excess may temporarily feel satisfied and in fact may refuse more food due to exhaustion. However, this feeling does not last, and the craving comes back the next day. So, one must continuously practice detachment to achieve control over one's mind.

Fate of Sincere but Unsuccessful Seekers

AOZ CdmM ĩ&

A`{V... I Œ`mnVm `nJm f {bV_mZg... ĩ&

Aàmß` `mJg{g{Œ H\$m JqV H\$ŕU JÀN{Vĭ&& 37&&

H\${ f b_m^`{d^i`pÍNbm^_d ZÍ`{V ĩ&

Aà{Võm _hm~mh {d_Tm ~÷U... n{W ĩ&& 38 &&

EVÝ_ ge` H\$ŕU NÎm\_hñ`efV... ĩ&

ĒdXÝ`... ge`ñ`mñ` NÎmm Z ønnÚV ĩ&& 39 &&

Arjuna said: O Krishna! What happens to someone who attempts to traverse the spiritual path with sincerity but is unable to succeed due to failure in controlling the wandering mind? (6.37)

O Krishna, One with Mighty Arms! Will the efforts of that person be dissipated like a cloud scattered by high winds, and will that person be banished and turned away from heavens and superior worlds? (6.38)

O Krishna! You should completely dispel my doubts. There is no one else who can answer these questions. (6.39)

Comments: Arjuna continues his questions to Krishna on the aspect of mind control. He realizes that many who are very sincere in their efforts to traverse the spiritual path cannot achieve detachment even after trying. What would happen to them, and are their efforts wasted? It appears, that they would be denied the heavens and *moksha* because of their failure to complete their prescribed duties or *dhyana* meditation. Or they will achieve nothing of value in this life or after life. Will they wither away like clouds scattered by a strong wind, or will they be relegated to hell? Arjuna, who had previously requested Krishna to help dispel his doubts in verses 2.7 and 3.2 again begs Him for guidance.

Ir^JdZdM Y&
nmW Zdh Zm_I {dZneñVñ` {dUV Y&
Z {h H\$ë`mUH\$V H\$[üÔJ{V VmV JÀN{V Y&& 40 &&

The Lord said: O Partha! Such a sincere person will not experience any ill effects in this world or the next. One who indulges in even limited virtuous activities will never experience downfall. (6.40)

Comments: The Lord answers Arjuna's questions in the next four and half verses. Arjuna's questions were based on the following arguments. Some seekers may avoid performing activities that would result in rewards such as heavens, based on their belief that those rewards are temporary. Given the difficulty in performing concentrated meditation on the Lord, they would also fail in *dhyana* meditation and would not be able to achieve liberation. So, they would lose out on both. Lord Krishna answers in verse 6.40 stating that a seeker who has tried to perform prescribed activities, meditation etc., will not experience any ill effects either in this world or hereafter. They will not be denied birth in human species. And they will indeed not be relegated to hell. Even limited but sincere efforts will save such seekers from downfall.

à¸¸` nÊ`H\$V¸Z b¸H\$¸Z C{fËd¸ e¸œVr... g_¸... Ý&
eMrZ¸ I r_¸V¸ Jh `¸J^i¸@{^O¸`V Ý&& 41 &&

AWd¸ `¸JZ¸_d H\$b ^d{V Yr_¸V¸_ Ý&
EV{Õ Xb^Va b¸H\$ OÝ_ `¸XrÑe_ Ý&& 42 &&

Such a person who was engaged in many virtuous acts in his/her lifetime, although imperfectly, will reach the heavenly world hereafter and will be reborn, in due course, in a pious and prosperous family. (6.41)

Or such a person could be reborn in a family of learned *yogis* (seekers on the path of self-realization). Although, it is extremely difficult and rare to get such births. (6.42)

Comments: Such seekers who have made sincere attempts at performing their prescribed duties and have not succeeded in perfectly completing *dhyana* meditation will receive additional opportunities for fulfillment in future births. They could be reborn in advantageous circumstances such as in pious, prosperous families or families of learned *yogis*. It is rare for someone to get such opportunities. Those who are blessed to be born in such circumstances will have the right environment for scriptural learnings and will also be in the company of pious, learned teachers which will surely help them in their spiritual journey.

Vì V ~{Õg`¸J b^V nmdX{hH\$_ Ý&
`VV M VV¸ ^` ... g{gÕ¸ H\$éZÝXZ Ý&& 43 &&

nd¸ä`¸gZ VZd {õ`V ødem@{n g... Ý&
{Ok¸ga{n `¸Jñ` eãX~÷¸{VdVW Ý&& 44 &&

O Kuru Nandana (Arjuna, Scion of the Kuru dynasty)! In this new birth, the seeker can continue the spiritual journey started in previous births with more perfection and finally achieve self-realization. (6.43)

Based on practice gained in previous births, the seeker who focuses the mind effortlessly on meditation, will be rid of sins, and will ultimately achieve liberation. (6.44)

Comments: The Lord explains the activities of a *yogi* who is reborn. Such a seeker who was not able to complete a spiritual journey in a previous birth, being born in advantageous circumstances is able to continue the spiritual journey and perform *dhyana* with more precision, finally leading to liberation. Even those seekers who are not inclined to perform focused *dhyana* meditation will find themselves on that path, out of habit from previous births.

à`VmX ¶V\_mZñV `mJr geÕ{H\$pe~f... ¶&
AZH\$OÝ_g{gÕñVVm `m{V nam J{V_ ¶&& 45 &&

A seeker who, over many births, makes a sincere attempt to traverse the spiritual path will be rid of sins and will reach the Lord's abode. (6.45)

Comments: In this verse, the Lord clarifies that a seeker who is desirous of achieving *moksha* will continue to make sincere attempts on the spiritual path and will eventually be rid of sins and reach His abode. It must be noted that mere intention to perform prescribed activities and *dhyana* meditation are not enough. That intention must be followed by sincere attempts at execution.

Vnpñdä`m@{YH\$m `mJr km{Zä`m@{n _Vn@{YH\$...¶&
H\$_ä`ü{YH\$m `mJr Vñ_mX ¶mJr ^dmOZ ¶&& 46&&

One who is on the path of intense meditation on the Lord is superior to the one who practices strict penance. Such a seeker is also superior to one who has attained (indirect) spiritual knowledge and superior also to one focused on performing only ritualistic activities. O Arjuna! Immerse yourself in such intense meditation on the Lord. (6.46)

Comments: In this verse, the Lord extols the virtues of *dhyana* yoga. Performing concentrated meditation on the Lord, being fully aware of the Lord's infinite auspicious attributes devoid of blemishes and performing prescribed activities only as an offering to the Lord without expectations is the most superior path for a seeker to attain the Lord.

The Superior Yogi

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
 इति श्रीभगवद्गीतायां अष्टादशोऽध्यायः ॥ ४७ ॥

A seeker who performs such *dhyana* yoga with devotion to the Lord is superior. The one who performs such *yoga* by serving the Lord is more superior and the one who performs such *yoga* with devotion, service and without any expectations is the most superior among all such seekers. (6.47)

Comments: The Lord concludes the teaching on *dhyana* yoga meditation by describing the relative gradations among seekers who perform such *yoga*. Some perform their prescribed activities and exercise concentrated meditation on the Lord. When such meditation is combined with devotion to the Lord (and is not done just mechanically), such efforts are considered superior by the Lord. Seekers who go a step further and offer their service to the Lord are even more superior. Finally, seekers who perform prescribed duties with devotion, with their minds fully immersed in the Lord and serve the Lord without any expectation are considered by Lord Krishna to be the most superior among all seekers.

Given that the purpose of this chapter is to teach path of *dhyana* (meditation), this last verse fully summarizes the core concepts in this chapter. Hence, it is considered the summary verse by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS.

Summary of Chapter 6

The previous chapters described the paths of action and knowledge (*karma yoga*, *jnana yoga*). *Yoga* has two components – external (prescribed activities that one performs which are visible to others) and internal. The internal component of yoga is termed *dhyana yoga* (path of meditation). This chapter delves into details of *dhyana yoga* or *atma samyama yoga* (the Path of Self-Restraint). The Lord starts by stating that a real *yogi* is one who relinquishes expectations from actions and not one who merely gives up ritual fire sacrifices (6.1). Such a seeker also has societal obligations to help the underprivileged (6.3). A seeker must exercise control over the sense organs and the mind. The importance of the mind which can be both a friend and a foe to a seeker is explained in verses 6.5–6.8. A *yogi* sees the Lord equally in everyone. The process of meditation in terms of location, physical pose etc., are described in verses 6.10–6.14. Successful meditation also requires moderation in activities such as eating, sleeping etc. Verses 6.20-6.23 describe the nature of inner bliss experienced by a *yogi* during *dhyana* meditation. The requirement for controlling the sense organs and the mind for successful meditation are described in verses 6.24-6.32. Arjuna expresses the difficulty one would face in controlling the mind in verses 6.33-6.34, and Lord Krishna describes the solution for the fate of those seekers who may sincerely approach the spiritual path but are not able to execute it for various reasons. In verses 6.40-6.45, the Lord assures that no sincere efforts are wasted, and the seeker will get additional opportunities for self-realization in future births. In verse 6.47, the Lord concludes the teachings in this chapter by stating that among all seekers who practise *dhyana* meditation, superior are those who perform their prescribed activities with devotion to the Lord, without expectations.

॥ ह{V fđm@Üŧŧm`... ॥

End of Chapter 6

gá_@Ü`m`... - kmZ{dkmZ`mJ...

Chapter 7 - The Path of Knowledge and Wisdom

Chapter Introduction: In this chapter of 30 verses, the Lord teaches the concepts of *jnana* (knowledge) and *vijnana* (special knowledge or wisdom). In verse 2.39, the Lord stated that He would teach about the *yoga* (way or path) to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge, knowing which one would be able to properly perform prescribed duties, get rid of accrued sins, and achieve liberation. Such procedures were described from chapters 2 to 6. The path described had two components, external and internal. The external component dealt with the procedures to be performed, and this was covered till chapter 5. Chapter 6 dealt with the internal procedure of *dhyana* meditation that a seeker needs to perform. Thus, the first 6 chapters were broadly concerned with descriptions of the methods and procedures (both external and internal) a seeker would need to perform to be able to acquire divine, spiritual knowledge. The next 6 chapters describe in more detail such divine, spiritual knowledge about the Lord Almighty, which forms the principal message of the **Gita**. In the earlier chapters 2 – 6, there were some discussions on the Lord's attributes which were included contextually, but the next 6 chapters provide more, exclusive details about the Lord's attributes. The term *jnana* in general means ordinary knowledge, which is acquired through the study of scriptures, learning from teachers etc. This is also known as *paroksha jnana* (indirect knowledge), as one acquires this before attaining self-realization. *Vijnana* is specialised knowledge or wisdom acquired after self-realization. This is also known as *aparoksha jnana* (direct knowledge). This chapter provides a detailed discussion of these two types of knowledge. The two types of knowledge are specifically about the Lord Almighty.

Discourse on Divinity

I r^J d m Z d m M &
 _æ`mg°\$ \_Z m... n m W `m J `O Z \_X m I `... ý&
 Age` g \_J \_m `W m k m ñ` {g V À N U ý&& 1 ý&&

The Lord said: O Partha! With your mind fully absorbed in Me, seeking refuge in Me, meditate on Me. Listen to Me to understand the way (*yoga*) you can extensively know Me, dispelling all the doubts. (7.1)

Comments: The Lord starts His sermon to Arjuna about His attributes. To understand these, seekers would require their minds to be completely focused on the Lord with firm conviction that the Lord is the protector and shelter for all. The Lord uses the adjectives *asamshayam* (without doubt) and *samagram* (complete) in this verse. Sri Madhwacharya in his GB clarifies that these words cannot be interpreted to conclude that one can completely understand the Lord. Rather they refer to the knowledge that a seeker can acquire, meaning that by listening to the Lord's teachings attentively, a seeker can understand the Lord's attributes to the maximum extent (based on the seeker's abilities). Even deities such as Rudra, Brahma etc., cannot completely comprehend the Lord's attributes which are infinite.

k m Z V @ h g { d k m Z { _X d ú `m á `e f V... ý&
 `Á k m Ē d m Zh ^ `m @ Y `Á k m V ì ` _d {e î `V ý&& 2 ý&&

I will impart to you in full the spiritual knowledge (indirect knowledge – *paroksha jnana*) and wisdom (direct knowledge – *aparoksha jnana*) about Me knowing which there will be nothing else to know. (7.2)

Comments: The Lord states the two types of knowledge that He would be imparting. *Jnana* refers to ordinary or indirect knowledge (*paroksha jnana*) which one normally acquires through studies of scriptures, learning from teachers etc. *Vijnana* = *vishesha jnana* refers to

of the universe which are all under the control of the Lord. This verse explicitly states that inert nature which is made up of the basic elements (earth, fire, water, wind, space) and the principles of mind, individuation, and intellect are all under the control of the Lord. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV, quoting from GB that the principle of individuation (*ahankara*) also includes the superior principle of cosmic intelligence (*mahat*).

Ana`{ VñEdY`m àH\$V {d{Ö _ nam _ V&
Ord^Vm _hm~mh` ``X Ym`V OJV V&& 5 &&

O Arjuna, One with Mighty Arms! These eight divisions of inert nature are in the lower aspect of nature. Different from, and superior to inert nature and all living beings is Mother Nature (Goddess Mahalakshmi) who provides shelter to all and supports the entire universe. The Lord is superior to Goddess Mahalakshmi and all liberated souls who have achieved *moksha*. (7.5)

Comments: In the previous verse 7.4, the Lord described the components of inert nature and indicated that they all act under His control. In this verse, He identifies other, sentient components of the universe such as individual souls, liberated souls, and the ever-liberated Goddess Mahalakshmi, and clarifies that they too are under His control.

EVÚmZr{Z ^Vm{Z gdmUrE`nYma` V&
Ah H\$EñZñ` OJV... à^d... àb`ñVWm V&& 6 &&

All living beings are born from inert nature and sentient nature. Through these two aspects of nature, I am responsible for the creation and dissolution of the universe. (7.6)

Comments: The universe is made up of inert matter and sentient nature. Lord Krishna further clarifies that not only are the components of the universe under His control, but He is also responsible for the creation and dissolution of the universe. The Lord states '*aham prabhavaha*

pralayaha’, which literally means, ‘I am creation and dissolution’. Sri Rayaru in GV quoting Sri Madhwacharya’s GB clarifies that the actual meaning of this phrase is ‘I am responsible for creation and dissolution’ stating that the phrase is used in a figurative sense. For example, it is common for many to refer to a kingdom by the name of its king. This is done in the context of a king who has full control over his kingdom.

The Lord is Supreme

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
 ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय

O Dhananjaya! There is no entity in this universe that is superior to Me (Lord Krishna). Everything in the universe is supported by Me, just like a garland of pearls is supported by a string. (7.7)

Comments: This verse is one of the most quoted verses in the **Gita** as it emphatically captures the Lord’s declaration that He is the Supreme One, and everything and everyone in the universe are under His control – in other words, the principle of Vishnu’s Supremacy (*Vishnu Sarvottamatva*). When the Lord indicates that everything in the universe acts under His control and He is responsible for the universe’s creation and dissolution, He clarifies that there is no one superior to Him and He is also responsible for the sustenance of the universe. Any confusion that some may have that perhaps *Maya* (or illusion) covers even the Lord, is categorically dispelled here.

It is interesting to note the simile of a bunch of pearls supported by a string is used here to describe the Lord supporting the universe. While one can see pearls worn by someone, the string is not visible. But if the string were to snap, the pearls will not hold together. Similarly, while the Lord supports the universe, one cannot see Him. He indeed works in mysterious ways.

Author's Note: This is also an interesting verse from the perspective of numerology. Number 7 is considered very auspicious, and **Gita** has 700 verses. The fact that the Lord's supremacy is demonstrated in the 7th verse of the 7th chapter is worth noting.

agm@h_ßg H\$mÝV` à^m@pñ\_e{eg`_`m... Ý&
àUd... gddXf eãX... I nméf Zf Ý&& 8 &&

O Son of Kunti! I am the sweetness in water. I am the radiance in the Sun and the Moon. I am the primordial syllable *Om* in the **Vedas**. I am the sound in space. I am virility in humans. (7.8)

Comments: In verse 7.2, the Lord resolved to teach Arjuna both indirect (ordinary) knowledge (*jnana*) and direct (special, divine) knowledge (*vijnana*). Some aspects of indirect knowledge were covered in verses 7.4 – 7.7. In the next few verses, the Lord provides more specialized details about His attributes and glories which form specialized knowledge (*vijnana*). In verses 7.4 – 7.7, the Lord states that everything and everyone in the universe act under His ownership and control. In the next few verses, He provides more details about the meaning of ownership. The basic elements of nature such as water, fire etc., are under His control, and in addition, the Lord owns and powers the essence in these elements. The Lord provides the character of sweetness to water; hence He is known as sweetness. Likewise, He powers the radiance in the Sun and the Moon. He is also known as *Om*, the primordial syllable which is the root for all Vedic literature. The syllable *Om* is made up of 3 letters; *a*, *u*, and *ma*, and these gave rise to the triumvirate in the holy hymn, **Gayatri** which in turn gave rise to the 3 parts of the **Purusha Sookta** hymns from the **Vedas**, from which arose Vedic literature. The Lord also empowers virility in humans.

nÊ`m JÝY... n{Wì`m M VOümpñ_{d^mdgm Ý&
OrdZ gd^Vf Vnümpñ_Vnpñdf Ý&& 9 &&

I am the fragrance on earth. I am the brilliance in fire. I am the life in living beings. I am the austerity in ascetics. (7.9)

Comments: The Lord causes and consumes the pleasant fragrance in earthly material. The reason for the use of the adjective pleasant is to clarify that earthly materials emanate different smells, and the Lord consumes only pleasant fragrance. Fire has both radiance and energy. In the previous verse, it was stated that the Lord is responsible for the radiance in luminous objects such as the Sun, the Moon and Fire. Here He is confirming that even the energy in these objects are due to Him alone. The Lord has special affection for ascetics who are constantly meditating on Him. He states that He powers the austerity in ascetics.

~rO _m gd^VmZm {d{Õ nmW gZmVZ _| ¤&
~{Õ~{Õ _Vm _pñ _ VOñVOpñdZm _h _| ¤&& 10 ¤&&

Know that I am the eternal seed and the root cause for the existence of all beings. Intelligence in the intelligent is due to Me. Strength in the powerful is due to Me (The Lord is the root cause not only of all beings but also of their strength and qualities). (7.10)

Comments: The Lord has stated previously that all objects in the universe such as the five basic elements of nature, the Sun, the Moon etc., are all under His control. In addition, He has separately clarified in verses 7.8 onwards, that not only are all objects under His control, their innate attributes (such as sweetness in water, radiance/energy in fire) are also due to Him alone. A tailor designs a dress using basic materials such as cloth, thread etc., and the finished dress has all characteristics of its ingredients such as softness, strength etc. The tailor gets the credit for creating the dress, but he has no role in the presence of the innate qualities of the ingredients. The Lord is not like the tailor in this example. He not only is responsible for the creation of objects but is also responsible for the innate qualities in those objects. These aspects form part of *vijnana*, which is specialized knowledge about the Lord's greatness. A seeker needs to

understand this, and only then will he be able to develop trust and faith in worshipping the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV also interprets this verse to indicate that even deities who govern the intrinsic attributes of objects are under the Lord's control.

~b ~bdV_m Mm_h H\$_m _amJ{dd{OV_ }&
Y_ {déŌ_m ^Vf H\$_m _m@pñ_ ^aVf^ }&& 11 }&&

I am the strength in the powerful people who are devoid of passions such as lust, anger, and attachment. I am the desire in beings not contradicting *dharma* or virtue. (7.11)

Comments: The Lord who is devoid of any defects or weaknesses represents the positive attributes in individuals such as strength in powerful people who do not use such strength for negative purposes. One should visualize and worship the Lord, as represented by the positive aspects and attributes of objects.

` Md gmpîdH\$<sub>m</sub> ^md<sub>m</sub> amOgmñV<sub>m</sub> \_gmü ` }&
_Î_m Ed{V VmZ {d{Ō Z Ēdh Vf V _{ ` }&& 12 }&&

All entities defined by pious (*sattv*), or passionate (*rajas*) or ignorant (*tamas*) qualities are powered and controlled by Me. I am not dependent on them, but they all depend on Me. (7.12)

Comments: In verses 7.8 – 7.11, the Lord states that He is the essence of all objects, and identifies them by way of examples: sweetness in water, radiance in fire, the primordial symbol Om in the scriptures, intelligence in the wise, strength in the powerful, etc. On the surface, these verses seem to indicate the Lord's identity with these attributes. While these attributes were created by and act under the control of the Lord, they are not identical to the Lord. This verse clarifies this relationship by clearly stating that all objects in the universe comprised of the triumvirate of attributes (*sattv*, *rajas*, *tamas*) are under His control. The Lord further states

that He is not dependent on them and rather, they all depend on Him, thus making it abundantly clear that these objects and attributes are not identical to Him but in fact owe their existence to Him.

Ignorance – Causes, Effect, and Solution

{Î{^JU_`^mda{^...gd{X OJV ĩ&
_m{hV Zm{^OmZm{V _m_ä`...na_î``_ ĩ&& 13 ĩ&&

Deluded by the influence of the three qualities of nature, the world fails to recognize Me as the supreme (*param*) and immutable (*avyayam*) being. (7.13)

Comments: How can the world made up of the three qualities come under delusion and not realize the Lord as being beyond the three qualities? Sri Rayaru in GV explains that people look at other people in the world whose physical bodies are made up of the three qualities. They conclude that similarly, the Lord's body could also be made up of these three qualities. However, learned ones understand that the Lord's body is transcendental in nature and is not subject to birth or decay or destruction. The Lord who has limitless auspicious attributes is beyond the three qualities of nature. This concept is also part of *vijnana* (specialized knowledge about the Lord).

While the Lord, during His incarnation in this world as Rama or Krishna, looks and acts like any other human being, from time to time He also demonstrates extraordinary powers (far and beyond any human's capacity) which are described in epics such as the **Mahabharata**. Hence, a seeker will be able to understand the Lord's superiority by hearing about His glories.

Xdr øfm JU_`r \_\_\_m`m XaE``m ĩ&
__d``ànÚÝV _m`mVm VapÝV V ĩ&& 14 ĩ&&

Maya (the divine illusion), the governing deity of these three qualities is under My control. No one can overcome this illusion. Only those who take shelter in Me can cross this illusion. (7.14)

Comments: What causes delusion in people? This verse answers by stating that delusion is due to the influence of the three qualities of *sattv*, *rajas* and *tamas* and they are caused by Nature presided over by Goddess Durga (as per Sri Rayaru [GV]). How can one overcome such delusion? As Maya operates under the control of the Lord, one must surrender to the Lord to be freed from delusion.

Z _m XîH\$VZm _Tm... ànÚÝV ZamY _m... Ý&
_m` `m@nöVknZm Anga ^md _m{ I Vm... Ý&& 15 Ý&&

Ignorant, sinful individuals deprived of proper knowledge caused by delusion represent the worst of humanity. They are demoniac in nature and hence do not surrender to Me. (7.15)

Comments: In the previous verse, the Lord states that one can overcome delusion by taking shelter in Him. If so, why isn't everyone following this advice? The Lord responds by stating that individuals who by nature are ignorant and sinful are not able to overcome delusion, which prevents them from acquiring proper knowledge of Him. They have a demoniac nature and hence do not surrender to Him and are not able to overcome delusion.

Types of the Lord's Devotees

MV{dYm ^OÝV _m OZm... gH\$VZm@OZ Ý&
AmVm {OkmgaWmWu kmZr M ^aVf^ Ý&& 16 Ý&&

O Arjuna, Superior among Bharatas! Four types of virtuous people worship Me (Krishna). Those in distress (afflicted by diseases), those

seeking spiritual knowledge, those seeking riches and the learned ones (who have already acquired spiritual knowledge). (7.16)

Comments: The previous verse describes sinful people who do not surrender to the Lord. This verse describes the categories of people who are devoted to the Lord. These largely consist of those who have some physical ailment, those who are seeking material wealth, those who are desirous of spiritual knowledge and those who have acquired divine, spiritual knowledge. The Lord's devotees who pray to the Lord in times of distress do so as they would like to continue performing their prescribed duty as an offering to Him and this would require them to be freed from distress. Devotees who pray for wealth do so to help them acquire the means to perform activities pleasing to the Lord, such as charity. Learned ones pray for self-realization.

Vfñ kmZr {ZË` `°\$ EH\$^°\$d{eî`V ÿ&
{à`ñ {h km{ZZñ@Ë`W_ Ah g M __ {à` ... ÿ&& 17"ÿ&&

Among these four types, learned ones who know Me as the Supreme One and are exclusively devoted to Me, are the most superior. They are very fond of Me, and I am very fond of them. (7.17)

Comments: Among these four types of devotees, is there a gradation? The Lord states that among these types, learned ones who have acquired divine, spiritual knowledge are the most superior. They have two main characteristics – (a) their minds are exclusively focused on the Lord, and (b) they are exclusively devoted to the Lord. The Lord declares that such devotees are fond of Him, and He is fond of them.

CXñññ... gd EdV kmZr ËdñË_d __ _V __ ÿ&
Añññññ... g {h `°\$ñË_ñ _ñ _ñdñË_ñ J{V__ ÿ&& 18 ÿ&&

All these four types of people are certainly worthy. But learned ones are like My own form. They surrender to Me completely and constantly meditate on Me and eventually reach the highest state of bliss. (7.18)

Comments: If learned ones are superior among the four and the Lord is fond of them, how about the other types? The Lord states that all four types are superior devotees, but among them learned ones are the most superior.

This verse uses the phrase ‘*atma eva*’ when describing learned ones. Some philosophers interpret ‘*atma eva*’ to mean ‘My own form’ quoting the text ‘*nama roopevihaya*’ from the **Atharva Upanishat (6.8)** in reference to rivers merging in an ocean and apparently losing their identity. Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha quotes Sri Madhwacharya’s interpretation of this Upanishat and points out that the proper word derivation of the above text is ‘*nama roopeSavihaya*’ = *nama roope avihaya*, which indicates that rivers maintain their identity even when they merge with the ocean. The proper interpretation of the phrase ‘*atma eva*’ is that learned ones are extremely dear to the Lord.

~hZm OY_Zm_YV kmZdmZ_m ànÚV í&
dmgXd...gd_{V g_hmĚ_m gXb^...Y&& 19 &&

Such learned ones, based on their efforts over many births, acquire the true knowledge that Lord Vasudeva (Krishna), the Supreme One, is complete in all respects and is the true owner of the universe. They ultimately reach My abode. It is extremely rare to find such a person in this world. (7.19)

Comments: Why will everyone not reach *moksha*? This verse answers by stating that only those who attain true understanding of the Lord Almighty will reach His abode. Not everyone is convinced of the Lord’s attributes. Learned ones, over many births perform their prescribed duties without expectations of rewards, with devotion to the Lord. Through

studies, learning etc., they attain true knowledge about the Lord's attributes such as the Lord's ownership of the universe and His completeness. They eventually reach His abode. Such learned people are rare.

Worshippers of Lesser Deities

H\$m_ñVñVöVkmZm... ànÚV@Ý`XdVm... Ý&
V V {Z`\_\_mñWm` àH\$E`m {Z`Vm... ñd`m Ý&& 20Ý&&

Many in this world, devoid of true divine knowledge due to their obsession with worldly riches, perform stipulated rituals as per their innate nature and propitiate other, lesser deities. (7.20)

Comments: In the previous verse, it was stated that learned people with true, divine knowledge are rare in this world. However, one does see many religious people in the world. So, how can the learned be considered rare? This verse answers by stating that not everyone worships the Lord without expectations on rewards. Many people in the world, who are drawn to material riches perform religious rituals as stipulated in the scriptures to propitiate and please lesser deities. They do this based on their innate nature and are unable to attain proper, divine knowledge.

`m `m `m `m VZ ^°\$... I Õ`m@{MV{`ÀN{V Ý&
Vñ` Vñ`mMb I Õm Vm_d {dXYmā`h_ Ý&& 21&&

g V`m I Õ`m `°\$ñVñ`mamYZ_rhV Ý&
b^V M VV... H\$m_mZ`_d {d{hVmZ {h VmZ Ý&& 22&&

Whoever sincerely wishes to worship other deities with devotion, I grant them the required unflinching faith. (7.21)

Such a devotee will propitiate the chosen deity with unflinching faith and will receive the fruits of the worship which are granted by Me (intrinsically residing in that specific deity). (7.22)

Comments: There are broadly two types of devotees which are not mutually exclusive. *Shuddha Bhagavathas* (Pure Devotees of Lord Almighty) and *Mishrayajees* (devotees of other deities). Verse 7.19 describes the characteristics of learned ones and they belong to the class of *Shuddha Bhagavathas*. Among *Mishrayajees* (*Mishra* = mixed; *yajee* = worshipper), there are two types. The first category is the so called *Trividyas* (those who perform rituals based on the peripheral meanings of the three **Vedas**). They believe that the purpose of the **Vedas** is to help one acquire material riches and they accordingly perform Vedic rituals to propitiate lesser deities to get their desires fulfilled. Even in this case, the actual rewards are granted by the Lord using lesser deities as the medium. The second category of *Mishrayajees* are really *Shuddha Bhagavathas* who are pure devotees of the Lord, but for various reasons also propitiate other deities. They will over the time receive proper guidance from a teacher and will focus on worship of the Lord without expectation and will ultimately achieve *moksha*.

A'VdÎm \ \$b Vfm VØdË`ën_Ygm_ ÿ&
XdmZ Xd`Om `mp'V _Ø°\$m `mp'V _m_{n ÿ&& 23 &&

Those who propitiate other deities due to their limited understanding, will receive only minimum, temporary fruits. On the other hand, those who are primarily devoted to Me will ultimately reach Me and experience eternal bliss. (7.23)

Comments: If propitiating other deities results in rewards, why should one focus on propitiating the Lord Almighty alone? This verse answers by stating that one who propitiates only other, lesser deities will receive only temporary fruits. Even if they reach the worlds of other deities after their time on earth, their stay in those worlds will be temporary. On the other hand, devotees who primarily worship the Lord Almighty will eventually attain the Lord's abode permanently. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV that it is not prohibited for one to worship other deities; one should worship

other deities as members of the Lord Almighty's entourage (*parivara*) and not separately.

The Ignorant Have False Knowledge

Ai`°\$ i`{°\$ _mnp _Y`YV _m _~Ö¶... Ý&
na ^md _OmZÍVm __mì`` _ZÎm __ Ý&& 24 &&

Unwise people, who are not aware of My eternal, infinite, auspicious, superior attributes, wrongly think of Me, the Unmanifest, as having a perishable existence. (7.24)

Comments: What separates the Lord Almighty from other deities? Why do those who propitiate other deities receive temporary rewards, while those who worship the Lord Almighty receive permanent bliss? This verse answers these questions. Ignorant ones (termed *abuddhayas*) do not realize that the Lord Almighty is supreme, has no births, and does not have a perishable body. They perceive the Lord as having perishable existence.

Sri Rayaru in GV provides a second interpretation for this verse as follows – Ignorant ones who are not able to comprehend the Lord's supremacy or His infinite, auspicious attributes, regard Him as identical to individual souls.

In summary, verses 7.20 to 7.24 describe the characteristics of the three types of beings: *Shuddha Bhagavathas* (*sattvic*), *Trividyas* (*rajasic*), and *Abuddhayas* (*tamasic*). This concept is covered in detail in Chapter 17.

Zmh àH\$ne... gdñ` `mJ _m`mg _mdV... Ý&
_Tm@` Zm{^OmZm{V bmH\$m _m_O_i`` _ Ý&& 25&&

Shrouded by My infinite strength and the curtain of Maya (Goddess Durga) as willed by Me, I am not comprehensible to everyone. Fools in this world do not know Me as the one without beginning or end. (7.25)

Comments: Why are some not able to acquire proper understanding of the Lord's attributes? This verse states that one can only imbibe knowledge based on one's innate nature. It is due to the will of the Lord Almighty and Goddess Durga's form of MahaLakshmi (who operates under the control of Lord as per verse 7.14) that the ignorant are not able to acquire proper understanding of the Lord's attributes. Does it cause concern to the Lord that some ascribe wrong qualities on Him? No. It is the Lord Himself who causes such ignorance to the undeserving.

The word *yogamaya* is interpreted as '*yoga sahita maya*', where *yoga* refers to the Lord's infinite strength and *maya* refers to Goddess Durga. As per Sri Madhwacharya [GB], Sri Jaya Teertha [PD], and Sri Rayaru [GV], *yoga* can be interpreted to mean either *upaya* (means or instrument) or strength (*shakti*). However, in this verse, the interpretation of *yoga* as strength is correct as *maya* already represents the instrument (*upaya*) of strength. This interpretation is also supported by **Padma Purana**.

Shrouded Divine Knowledge

दध्मि ग_व्रवन्तं दध्मन्तं ममोऽहं
 अहं ममवन्तं ममवन्तं ममवन्तं 26

O Arjuna! I am completely aware of all prior, current, and future conditions of all beings. But no one knows Me (completely). (7.26)

Comments: If the curtain of Maya results in some not being able to understand the Lord's attributes, does the same curtain prevent the Lord from knowing about them? This verse emphatically states that the Lord knows everything (past, present and even future) about everyone. This in fact is one of His major attributes. However, no one knows the Lord completely. Other enormously powerful deities such as Goddess Mahalakshmi, Brahma, Vayudeva etc., know the Lord Almighty extremely well, but not fully, and their knowledge is also due to His grace.

BÀNmÛfg_ĒWZ ŪÝŪ_mhZ ^maV Ĩ&
gd^Vm{Z g_mh gJ `mpÝV naÝVn Ĩ&& 27 &&

O Bharata! O Parantapa! All beings are ignorant about the Lord from the very beginning of creation due their delusion in dualities such as happiness/sadness, caused due to corruption by the qualities of desire/hatred. (7.27)

Comments: In verses 7.14 and 7.25, it was stated that the prime cause for one's ignorance is the will of the Lord Almighty and Goddess Durga. This verse states that, in addition, there are two secondary causes for one's ignorance: desire and aversion. These two passions cloud one's judgement about dualities such as happiness/sadness, success/failure etc. An alternate interpretation by Sri Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB and GTN is as follows: the primary reason for one's delusion in non-duality of the Lord and the individual soul is due to the influence of the Lord and Goddess Durga.

Overcome False Knowledge and Worship with Conviction

`f\_m ĒdÝVJV nmn OZmZm nÊ`H\$_Um Ĩ&
V ŪÝŪ_mh{Z_°\$m ^OÝV_m ÑTdVm... Ĩ&& 28 &&

Those virtuous people who have washed off their sins and have overcome the delusion of dualities such as pleasure/pain worship Me with steadfast conviction. (7.28)

Comments: Verse 7.27 seems to indicate that all living beings suffer from delusion right from the time of creation. This verse clarifies that people who perform virtuous acts will be rid of their sins and will get over the delusion of dualities. They worship the Lord with steadfast conviction.

This verse is a summary of this chapter as per Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha's BGS, as it indicates the primary qualities of virtuous beings who focus on worship of the Lord with steadfast conviction.

Oam_aU_mj_m`\_m\_m{I\_È`_`VpYV`_`Y&
V~÷V{ÛX...H\$ÈñZ_AÜ`m\_È\_H\$Mm{Ib\_`Y&& 29 &&

Those seeking liberation from mortal afflictions such as old age and death, take refuge in Me, and acquire the right knowledge of *Brahman* (the Lord Almighty), *Adhyatma* (the individual self) and *karma* (all actions). (7.29)

Comments: This verse states that the reward for one worshipping the Lord as per 7.28, is attainment of spiritual knowledge about: *Brahman* (The Supreme Lord), *adhyatma* (prime self) and *karma* (fruitive action). For one to escape worldly entanglements, it is important to learn about the Lord's nature in addition to worshipping the Lord with steadfast conviction, as proper knowledge strengthens conviction.

The Last Moments

gm{Y^V{YXd_mgm{Y`kM`{dX...Y&
à`mUH\$b@{nM\_mV{dX`°\$MVg...Y&& 30 &&

One who has proper knowledge about *Adhiyajna* (Lord of Sacrifice) along with that of *Adhibhoota* (prime materials) and *Adhidaiva* (prime deities), and who think of Me (Lord Krishna) during their last moments have their minds fully transfixed on Me and will indeed know Me. (7.30)

Comments: This verse concludes the teaching in this chapter, which is about the concepts of knowledge and wisdom. The Lord summarizes the teaching by stating that the learned ones who are focused on Him with steadfast conviction are knowledgeable about specialized topics (*vijnana*)

such as *Brahma*, *Karma*, *Adhyatma*, *Adhibhoota*, *Adhidaiva* and *Adhiyajna*. Remembering this knowledge especially during the time a seeker leaves the body will ensure that the seeker will attain the Lord. These concepts are described in more detail in the next chapter.

Summary of Chapter 7

The first 6 chapters were broadly concerned with descriptions of the methods and procedures (both external and internal) that a seeker would need to perform to be able to acquire divine, spiritual knowledge. The next 6 chapters describe in more detail such divine, spiritual knowledge about the Lord, which forms the principal message of the **Gita**. In earlier chapters 2 – 6, there were some discussions on the Lord's attributes which were included contextually, and the next 6 chapters provide more exclusive details about the Lord's attributes. Chapter 7 provides a detailed discussion of the two types of learning – knowledge and wisdom. Ordinary knowledge (*jnana*) is that knowledge that is gained from scriptural studies and through teachers. Wisdom or direct knowledge (*vijnana*) is specialized knowledge about the Lord Almighty that one can attain after self-realization. In verses 7.4 - 7.6, the components of the eight-fold nature in the universe are identified. In verses 7.7 - 7.11, the Lord describes His ownership of everything in the universe and stresses that He is responsible for even the intrinsic attributes of objects. The cause of ignorance, the influence of delusion on living beings, and procedure to overcome delusion are also discussed in verses 7.13 – 7.14. The various types of seekers who are devoted to the Lord are identified in verses 7.16 – 7.19 as those in sickness, those seeking spiritual knowledge, those seeking riches, and those who have already acquired divine, spiritual knowledge. Among these four types of devotees, the Lord is fond of the last type who worship Him without any expectations. Verses 7.20 – 7.23 deal with worshippers of other deities in comparison with those who are exclusively devoted to the Lord Almighty. Those who only worship other deities may receive temporary fruits and

those who exclusively worship the Lord Almighty ultimately attain everlasting bliss. In verses 7.24 - 7.26, the issue of false knowledge is described. In verse 7.28, the Lord exhorts the virtuous to overcome false knowledge and worship Him with conviction. The chapter ends with a message from the Lord in verses 7.29 – 7.30 about the thoughts that a seeker should focus on at the time of leaving this world. These last two verses act as a bridge to the next chapter where the concepts introduced here are dealt with in detail.

॥ Bṛ gá_ṁ@Ü`ṁ` ॥

End of Chapter 7

Aī_m@Úm`... - Aja~÷`mJ...

Chapter 8 - The Imperishable Lord

Chapter Introduction: This chapter, titled *Akshara Brahma Yoga*, the path of the imperishable Lord, comprising 28 verses, shows the sure path to reach the Lord through concentrated meditation and single pointed devotion. The previous chapter covered the issues of indirect knowledge and direct knowledge as they relate to the Lord. Towards the end of the chapter, in verses 7.29 and 7.30, the Lord introduced some special topics such as *Adhibhoota*, *Adhidaiva*, *Adhiyajna*, etc. This terminology was used for the first time, and Arjuna naturally has questions about its context and meaning. The Lord answers Arjuna's questions, and much of the chapter is devoted to the act of remembering the Lord during one's final moments and one's journey hereafter.

Arjuna's Eight Questions

AOZ CdmM ĩ&

qH\$ VX ~÷ {H\$ _Ü`mĒ_ qH\$ H\$_ néf mĭm_ ĩ&

A{Y^V M qH\$ àm°\$_{YXd {H\$_ À`V ĩ&& 1 ĩ&&

A{Y`k... H\$W H\$m@Ì Xh@pñ_Z _YgXZ ĩ&

à`mUH\$m\_b M H\$W k`m@{g {Z`VmĒ_{^... ĩ&& 2 ĩ&&

Arjuna said, “O Purushottama (The Supreme One)!” Who is *Brahma* (Lord Almighty)? What is ‘*Adhyatma*’ (Prime Self)? What is *Karma* (Fruitive Action)? What does one call *Adhibhoota* (Prime Nature)? Who are ‘*Adhidaiva*’ (Prime Deities)? 8.1

O Madhusoodana! Who is known as *Adhiyajna* (Lord of Sacrifice) in this body? And why? How are you to be known at the time of departure by *yogis* (seekers) with self-control? (8.2)

Comments: In verse 7.30, the Lord stated the need for one to have proper knowledge about Him, especially during one's last moments. Arjuna has eight questions regarding the concepts in verses 7.29 and 7.30. Lord Krishna answers these questions in the next few verses.

Brahma, Karma, Adhibhoota, Adhidaiva, Adhyatma, Adhiyajna

Ir^JdmZdmM ĩ&
 A j a ~÷ na_ ñd^ndm@Ü`mĒ\_\_À`V ĩ&
 ^V^ndmØdH\$am {dgJ... H\$_g{kV... ĩ&& 3 ĩ&&

The Lord said: *Brahma* refers to the imperishable Lord who pervades everything and everyone. *Adhyatma* refers to the material equipment that allows a soul to act (body, sense organs, conscience). *Karma* refers to the Lord's act of creation, which is responsible for the birth and existence of all living beings. 8.3

Comments: The Lord responds to each of Arjuna's eight questions.

- *Brahma* refers to the imperishable Lord Almighty. The adjective *param* (meaning supreme) is used here to denote the Lord Almighty, as there are other imperishable (*akshara*) entities also in the universe such as inert nature, the letters, the **Vedas**, etc. (verse 2.17) which are dependent on the Lord
- *Adhyatma* (prime self) refers to material equipment that helps a soul function in this world: the physical body, sense organs, and conscience (which the Lord grants according to a soul's *svabhāva* or innate nature).
- *Karma* (Fruitive Action) refers to *visarga*, the special activity of creating the universe performed by the Lord Almighty.

A{Y^V j am ^nd... néfüm{YXdV_ ĩ&
 A{Y`km@h_dmĪ Xh Xh^Vm da ĩ&& 4 ĩ&&

O Arjuna! The five basic elements of material nature (earth, fire, water, space, and wind) form *Adhibhoota*. Superior deities who reside inside and govern the physical bodies of living beings (namely Sesha, the serpent deity, and the four faced deity Brahma) form *Adhidaiva*. Powering all living beings and the consumer of offerings in all sacrifices is I, going by the name of *Adhiyajna* (Lord of Sacrifice). (8.4)

Comments: The Lord continues to answer Arjuna's remaining questions:

- *Adhibhoota* (Prime Nature) refers to the five basic elements of nature, (fire, water, earth, space, and wind) that comprise one's physical body.
- *Adhidaiva* (prime deities) refers to superior deities such as Sesha and four-faced Brahma that reside in the bodies of living beings.
- *Adhiyajna* (Lord of Sacrifice) refers to Me (Lord Krishna).
- The Lord is termed *Adhiyajna* as He activates and powers one to perform sacrifices, and He is also the consumer of the essence of such sacrifices, as was stated previously (verse 5.29).

Sri Rayaru in GV provides additional interpretations for some of these entities based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB as follows: *Adhyatma* also refers to the Lord's form (as He has the prime or supreme form), *Adhidaiva* also refers to Goddess Mahalakshmi (as she is the foremost among all deities), and *Adhibhoota* refers to all living beings (as living beings are superior to inert objects).

The Final Moments

A'VH\$mb M _m_d ñ_aZ _3Edm H\$bda _'Y&
`... à`m{V g _Ømd `m{V ZmñE`ì ge`... Y&& 5 Y&&
`|`| dm{n ñ_aZ ^md E`OË`YV H\$bda _'Y&
V V_d{V H\$mYV` gXm VØmd^m{dV... Y&& 6 &&

One who thinks of Me (Krishna) at the time of leaving one's body will attain Me. There is no doubt about this. (8.5)

O son of Kunti! Whatever entity one thinks of at the time of leaving one's body, one will attain the same entity (due to the force of habit). (8.6)

Comments: The Lord answers Arjuna's eighth question by stating that learned seekers remember the Lord at the time of leaving the body which results in their attaining the Lord, which is a state of permanent, exalted happiness devoid of any misery. How does one who is focused on the Lord at the time of departing this world reach the Lord? Whatever entity one is thinking of during the last moments, the person will attain that entity in the succeeding births. The story of King Bharata in the **Bhagavata Purana** illustrates this. Bharata once rescued a deer struggling in flood waters and nursed it back to health. He developed a strong attachment to it and was thinking of it even at the last moments of his life. This resulted in him being born as a deer.

It should be noted that the verse says, *anta kala*, meaning the final moments. It does not say the final instant. This is because everyone, at the exact final instant of the soul leaving the body, feels relief. However, it is only the learned devotees of the Lord who remember Him in the moments leading up to death.

Sri Madhwacharya in his **Bhagavata Tatparya Nirnaya** [BTN] commentary on the epic **Bhagavata Maha Purana** [BMP] (10.1.42) quotes the **Naradeeya Purana** and states that one's innate eligibility and the Lord's will are the deciding factors in determining one's next birth (in addition to one's final thoughts). Thus, one who is thinking of angels during the last moments may not be born as an angel but may be born in the vicinity of angels.

Vñ_mV gdf H\$m bf _m_Zñ_a`Ü` M`&
_æ`{nV\_Zm~{Ö\_m\_dî`ñ`ge`... && 7 &&

Hence keep thinking about Me (Krishna) always. Perform your duty of fighting this just war with your mind and intellect focused on Me and you will certainly attain Me. There is no doubt about this. (8.7)

Comments: After emphasizing the need to remember Him during one's last moments, the Lord gets back to Arjuna's dilemma. He exhorts him to keep his mind and intellect focused on Him and get on with fighting the just war. This would ensure that Arjuna would not be tainted by any adverse effects of the war.

Aä`mg`mJ`°\$Z MVgm@ZY`Jm{Zm &
na_néf {Xì` `m{V nmWmZ{MÝV`Z ý&& 8 &&

O Partha! One who, through rigorous practice of mind control, withdraws the mind from worldly matters and focuses the mind and the intellect on the divine, supreme, omnipresent Lord Almighty, will reach the Lord's abode. (8.8)

Comments: How can one ensure that one's mind will be focused on the Lord during the final moments, especially as one would normally be in great pain due to physical ailments? The Lord answers by stating that through rigorous practice of mind control, one can develop the habit of focusing the mind on Him and approach all activities with the attitude that He is the one who is performing the activities. This will help a seeker keep the Lord in mind, which becomes useful during the last moments of life.

The Lord's Form for Recollection

H\$qd namU_Zem{gVma`
AUmaUr`mg_Zñ_aÚ... ý&
gdñ` YmVma\_{MÝË`ê\$n`
A{XË`dU V_g... nañVmV ý&& 9 &&

One should meditate on the Lord Almighty as one who is omniscient, who is ancient, who governs the entire universe, who is smaller than the smallest object, who supports and protects everyone and everything in the universe, who is incomprehensible, who has the radiance of the sun, and who transcends material nature. One should think of the Lord, especially during one's last moments. (8.9)

Comments: The previous verses stated that one must remember the Lord during one's final moments. In what way should one remember the Lord? This verse provides a compact yet powerful description of the Lord's form and attributes as eight qualities that one must memorise and make efforts to remember always. This would make it easy for a seeker to remember the Lord during the final moments. The comparison of the Lord's radiance with that of the sun is only to give an example so that one can comprehend it to some extent. The Lord's qualities, such as radiance and splendor, are infinite. Just to ensure that there is no misinterpretation due to the comparison with the sun, this verse also uses the phrase *tamasa para* meaning the Lord transcends material nature.

The Final Journey

à`mUH\$m\_b\_Zgm@MbZ ^ŠĚ`m `°\$m `mJ~bZ Md ĩ&
^dm_Ü` àmU\_mdí` gâ`H\$ g V na néf\_n{V {Xì`_ ĩ&& 10 &&

One who, at the time of leaving one's body, meditates on the divine form of the Lord with utmost devotion, with a focused mind, and holds one's life breath in the forehead between the eyebrows, will surely reach the Lord's abode. (8.10)

Comments: This verse describes the breath control that one must attempt at the last moments of life while one is meditating on the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that this requirement applies primarily to those who are practitioners of *pranayama* and have attained proficiency in breath control and are termed *vayujayis* (ones who have conquered breath). One

must practise other techniques indicated earlier, such as detachment, devotion, learning etc., to achieve *moksha*. Sri Jaya Teertha in PD states that two types of seekers are recognised here. One who is proficient in the path of devotion (*Bhakti Yoga*), and the other who is proficient in breath control (*pranayama*).

`X j a dX{dXm dXpYV
{depYV `X ¶V`m drVamJm... Y&
`{XAN'YVm ~÷M` MapYV
VÎm nX gJhU àdú` Y&& 11 &&

Those who learned the **Vedas** know the Lord as eternal, with no end. Those who have relinquished passions such as lust and anger will strive to attain the Lord. Seekers control their sense organs and focus their minds on Brahma (Lord Almighty). I will explain to you briefly about that Supreme Principal (Lord Almighty). (8.11)

Comments: The previous verse described the procedure for breath control for those proficient in *pranayama* (which should also be attempted by everyone else). This verse describes further requirements for those who have conquered the breath (*vayujayi*).

gdÜman{U g`å` _Zm ö{X {ZÊ\$Ü` M Y&
ÜY¶mYm`mÊ\_Z... àmU\_ AmpñWVm `mJYmaUm Y&& 12&&

Am{ _E`H\$m j a ~÷ ì`mhaZ _m_Zñ_aZ Y&
`... à`m{V Ê`OZ Xh g `m{V na_m J{V_ Y&& 13 &&

At the time of leaving the physical body, a seeker should control all channel outlets in the body (except the *Sushumna* channel), with the mind focused on the Lord, and immerse in continuous meditation on the Lord, with the life breath centred on the forehead. (8.12)

Such a person who, with great devotion to the Lord, chants the primordial syllable *Om* will leave the body to traverse to the Lord's abode. (8.13)

Comments: As there are many channels in the body, one must attempt to leave the body out of the head through the *Sushumna* channel to reach the Lord's abode. One who leaves the body through other channels will reach other worlds. For example, one leaving out of one's eye will reach Surya Loka, the world of the Sun deity. This verse also states that the seeker should focus the mind on *hrudi*, which Sri Rayaru GV clarifies in a reference to Lord Narayana. The word *hrudi* expands as *harati* + *jagat*, meaning 'One who dissolves the universe'.

The primordial syllable *Om* succinctly represents the Lord. *Om* made up of three letters *a*, *u*, and *ma*, expands into the three parts of the holy Gayatri hymn, which itself expands into the three sections of the Vedic hymn, the **Purusha Sookta**, from which all Vedic literature emerged. Later in chapter 10.25, the Lord Himself states that among all letters, He dwells in the letter *Om* giving it supremacy. Verse 17.23 also has additional details on the primordial syllable *Om*.

AZÍ`MV... gVV `m 'm ñ_a{V {ZÉ`e... &
Vñ`mh gb^... nmW {ZÉ` `°\$ñ` `m{JZ... && 14 &&

O Partha! I am easily attainable to those who are continuously meditating on Me, with their wandering minds withdrawn from stray thoughts. (8.14)

Comments: In the previous verses, the Lord instructed that one should strive to remember Him during one's final moments. In this verse, it is clarified that only those who are constantly thinking about, meditating on the Lord (*nitya yukta*) and forcibly withdrawing the wandering mind from worldly issues, will be able to remember Him when it counts the most, that is, at the final moment.

This verse is a succinct summary of this chapter as stated by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in [BGS].

No Rebirths for Those Attaining the Lord

म नै नञोयं खलु । म बभूवै नमः ॥
 नमोऽस्तु ते नमः । गच्छेत्तु नमः ॥ 15 ॥

अमृतं दत्तं नमः । नमोऽस्तु ते नमः ॥
 म नै नञोयं खलु । गच्छेत्तु नमः ॥ 16 ॥

Learned ones, who through their efforts have reached My abode, will not return to this world of misery and will not take on transitory physical bodies again. (8.15)

O Arjuna! Those who hereafter attain all other heavenly worlds below the abode of Brahma will ultimately return to the cycle of births and deaths. O son of Kunti! Those who attain My abode will be in eternal bliss and will never be born again. (8.16)

Comments: In verse 8.13, it is stated that the learned ones who remember the Lord during their final moments will reach the Lord's abode. These two verses clarify that one who reaches the Lord's abode will not return to the earth, which is the dwelling place for living beings with transitory physical bodies.

The six upper worlds above earth are *Bhuvārloka*, *Suvarloka*, *Mahārloka*, *Janoloka*, *Tapoloka* and *Satyaloka*. Those who reach the worlds of *Janoloka*, *Tapoloka*, and *Satyaloka* will not return to earth. This is because of the Lord's special presence in them. This is clarified by Sri Rayaru in [GV].

Creation and Dissolution of the Universe

ghò`Jn`ÝV_ Ah`x÷Um {dX... Ý&
amqì `JghòmÝVn V@hmanì {dXm OZm... Ý&& 17 &&

Those who know that the Lord's day spans over multitudes of *yugas* and His night also spans multitudes of *yugas* are knowers of Day and Night. (8.17)

Comments: In this verse, the Lord introduces the concept of day and night in relation to His acts of creation and dissolution of the universe. Sri Rayaru in GV states that the word *sahasra* used in this verse should not be construed to literally mean thousands, but to uncountable multitudes (as no one can count the Lord's time). The duration of creation and dissolution of the universe are symbolically indicated as daytime and night-time for the Lord Almighty, as His time cannot be measured.

Sri Satyadhyana Teertha in his GPC states that the *yuga* referred here indicates one hundred years of deity Brahma, whose one year is made up of 360 days, with each day equating to 864 crore (8.64 billion) human years.

Aì`°\$mX ì¶°\$`... gdm... à^dÝË`hamJ_ Ý&
amí`mJ\_ àbr`ÝV Vìdmì`°\$gkH\$ Ý&& 18 &&

During the Lord Almighty's daytime (after the conclusion of the great dissolution of the universe), the unmanifest Lord undertakes the creation of the universe. During the night time of the Lord, the universe is dissolved into Him. (8.18)

Comments: The dawn of the day for the Lord (*avyakta*) is when the dissolution of the universe is complete and the process of creation starts. The time of dissolution of the universe is described as the "nighttime of the Lord". No one can measure the Lord's time. Sri Madhwacharya in GTN states that the word *nimesha* (time to bat an eyelid) is used to informally

indicate the split second of time taken for creation or dissolution of the universe.

^VJm_g Edm` ^Edm ^Edm àbr`V`&
amÍ`mJ\_de... nmW à^dĚ`hamJ_`&& 19 &&

O Partha! The multitudes of living beings and inert nature are repeatedly created, and they undergo dissolution into the Lord and will again be created. This is the cycle of creation, sustenance, and dissolution. (8.19)

Comments: This verse states that the process of creation and dissolution of the universe are continuous and endless.

The Lord Almighty's Supremacy (Hari Sarvottamattva)

nañVñ_mÎm ^mdm@Y`m@ì`°\$m ì`°\$mV gZmVZ...`&
`... g gdf ^Vf ZÍ`Ěg Z {dZÍ`{V`&& 20 &&

Aì`°\$m@j a BĚ`°\$ñV_mh... na_m J{V_`&
`àmb` Z {ZdVŸV VŌm_na_`&& 21 &&

The unmanifest entity, which is vastly different and superior to the visible universe made up of individual souls and inert nature, is the invisible supreme Lord Almighty, who will never perish even when everything in the universe perishes. (8.20)

This unmanifest principle is the Lord Almighty, to reach whom, is the goal of everyone. One who reaches Him will never return to this world. Such is My supreme form. (8.21)

Comments: Since the previous verses described the concepts of day and night for the Lord to represent the times of creation and dissolution of the universe, one may question if the Lord is also subject to birth and

decay. Verse 8.20 clarifies that the Lord, who is responsible for creation and dissolution, is eternal, has no beginning or end, and is imperishable. Verse 8.21 clarifies that He goes by the name of *Akshara* (one without decay), because of His imperishable nature. This verse also states that one who reaches the Lord's abode will never return to the earth.

Verse 8.20 uses the terms *para* and *anya* meaning supreme and different, respectively, indicating that the Lord Almighty is superior to and different from all other entities in the universe, such as individual souls and inert objects. This concept is further emphasised later in Chapter 15 (verses 16-20) and validates the philosophy of dualism propagated by Sri Madhwacharya.

Devotion is the Superior Path

néf... g na... nW ^3Ē`m bā`ñĒdZÝ`m Ĩ&
`ñ`mÝV...ñWm{Z ^Vm{Z `Z gd{X VV_ Ĩ&& 22 &&

O Partha! The Supreme One is reachable only through pure, exclusive devotion. Such a Lord is resident in all beings and pervades the entire universe. (8.22)

Comments: In verse 8.10, it is stated that devotion, meditation, and detachment are all required for one to reach the Lord. As per Sri Rayaru [GV], this verse clarifies that devotion to the Lord is the preeminent path.

Returning and Non-returning Paths

`İ H\$m b ĒdZmd{Îm\_ AndqÎm Md `m{JZ... Ĩ&
à`mVm `mpÝV V H\$m b dú`m{ ^aVf^ Ĩ&& 23 &&
A{¾Á`m{Vah... eŠb... fÊ\_mgm CÎmam`U_ Ĩ&
Vİ à`mVm JÀNpÝV ~÷ ~÷{dXm OZm... Ĩ&& 24 &&

Y_m am{îñVWm H\$ñU... fÊ_mgm X{j Um`Z_!&
 VÌ MmÝĐ_g Á`m{V`mJr àmß` {ZdVW !&& 25 &&

eŠbH\$ñU JVr øV OJV... eṁæV _V !&
 EH\$`m `mĒ`Zmd{Îm _AÝ``m@@dVW nZ... !&& 26 &&

O Arjuna, superior among the Bharatas! I will now teach you about the paths taken by seekers, from which they will either return to this world or not return to this world. The paths are identified by their respective governing deities. (8.23)

Eligible seekers, leaving this world through the paths of deities governing fire, light, daytime, the fortnight of the waxing moon, and the first half of a lunar year, will reach the abode of the Lord and not return to this world. (8.24)

Other seekers leaving this world through the path of deities governing smoke, nighttime, the fortnight of the waning moon, and the second half of a lunar year will reach the land of the Moon deity and will return to this world again. (8.25)

These two paths are permanent and are termed the *Shukla* path and the *Krishna* path. Those leaving through the first path will not return, and those leaving through the second path will return to this world. (8.26)

Comments: These three verses describe the paths taken by a soul after leaving the physical body. The soul progressively traverses the worlds governed by various deities. Some seekers leave this world and traverse the worlds governed by the following deities: *Agni/Archi* (fire), *Aha* (daytime), *Shukla Paksha* (fortnight of waxing moon), and *uttarayana* (first half of a lunar new year). These seekers, who predominantly take the path of knowledge (*jnana yogis*), will ultimately reach the abode of the Lord Almighty and never return to the earth. Other seekers leave this world and traverse the worlds governed by the following deities: *dhooma* (smoke),

ratri (nighttime), *krishna paksha* (fortnight of the waning moon) and *dakshinayana* (second half of a lunar new year). These seekers, who are focused on the path of action (*karma yogis*) with the expectation of rewards will return to this earth.

Some commentators adopt the literal translation of the times and periods indicated in these verses and wrongly conclude that the destination of a soul depends on the time, day, fortnight, and month of leaving this world. Sri Rayaru in GV, based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB, clarifies that the reference to the time periods indicated in these verses should be interpreted to mean the respective governing deities. After all, time is inert. How can time determine the destination of a soul? Also, not all entities identified in these verses are related to time (*kala*). For example, *agni/archi*, and *dhooma* are not related to time. Hence, the entities described in these verses can only be interpreted to mean their respective governing deities. Further, as per Sri Madhwacharya's GB, in the **Padma Purana** it is clarified that an *aparoksha jnani* (a seeker with direct, divine knowledge of the Lord) will achieve liberation regardless of the time, day, fortnight, month of leaving this world.

In the **Mahabharata**, it is stated that Bheeshma waited until the onset of *uttarayana* (the first half of the lunar year) to leave this world. Does this not imply the superiority of one period over the other? It is clarified by Sri Jaya Teertha in [ND] that among those who attain liberation, the ones who leave their body during the period of *uttarayana* experience higher bliss. One must remember that Bheeshma was an *iccha marani* and had the power to decide the time of his exit from the world. His situation cannot be generalized.

In summary, a soul's destination after leaving the physical body is based on its efforts and performance during its soul's lifetime in this world and the acquisition of divine, spiritual knowledge, including knowledge about the paths taken hereafter. The destination is not determined by the

time of the soul leaving the body. Sri Rayaru also clarifies this in GV, quoting the **Brahma Sutra** (4.2.22).

Rewards for Properly Knowing the Paths of the Final Journey

ZV gVr nṁW OmZZ `ṁJr _ø{V H\$üz Ÿ&
Vñ _V gdf H\$ṁbf `ṁJ`°\$ṁ ^dṁOZŸ&& 27 &&

dXf `kf Vnṁg Md XṁZf `V nÊ` \b à{Xï_ Ÿ&
AÊ`{V VĖgd{ X {d{XĖdṁ `ṁJr na ñWṁZ_n{V MṁÚ_ Ÿ&& 28 &&

O Partha! A seeker who properly understands these two paths and acts accordingly will never be deluded. O Arjuna, hence, always practise the prescribed activities to reach the Lord. (8.27)

One who understands these principles will accrue more benefits compared to accruals from studying the **Vedas**, performing sacrifices, and donating to others. Moreover, such a seeker will indeed reach the Lord's abode. (8.28)

Comments: These two verses conclude the teachings in this chapter. Lord Krishna instructs Arjuna to understand thoroughly the process of a soul leaving the physical body and the paths taken in reaching the ultimate destination. The Lord reiterates that Arjuna must perform his prescribed duty of waging the just war with proper conviction in the concepts described in this chapter. Further, such knowledge about the paths taken by a soul results in one earning much more benefit than that available from other spiritual activities such as learning the **Vedas**, donating to charity, etc. The intent here is to demonstrate the importance of such knowledge.

Summary of Chapter 8

Chapter 7 covered the issues of knowledge and wisdom as they relate to the Lord. Towards the end of that chapter, in verses 7.29 and 7.30, the

Lord introduced some special topics such as *Adhibhoota*, *Adhidaiva*, *Adhiyajna*, etc. This terminology was used for the first time, and Arjuna naturally had questions about their context and meaning. The Lord answers Arjuna's questions, and much of the chapter is devoted to the act of remembering the Lord during one's final moments and one's journey hereafter. Arjuna asks eight questions in verses 8.1 and 8.2 and the Lord answers them in verses 8.3 - 8.5. *Brahma* refers to the imperishable Lord. *Adhyatma* refers to material equipment that allows a soul to act (body, sense organs, conscience). *Karma* refers to the Lord's act of creation, which is responsible for the birth and existence of all living beings. Basic elements of material nature such as earth and fire form '*Adhibhoota*'. Superior deities who reside inside and govern the physical bodies of living beings (namely Sesha, the serpent deity, and the four-faced deity Brahma) form *Adhidaiva*. Powering all living beings and the consumer of offerings in all sacrifices is the Lord, going by the name of *Adhiyajna* (Lord of Sacrifice). The Lord answers Arjuna's eighth question by stating that learned seekers remember the Lord at the time of leaving their bodies, which results in their attaining Him. In verses 8.6 - 8.14, the Lord teaches the need for one to remember Him during the final moments and the procedure to do the same. Verses 8.15 - 8.16 state that those who remember the Lord properly during their final moments will not return to earth. The concept of the Lord Almighty's day and night and their relationship to His acts of creation and dissolution of the universe are addressed in verses 8.17-8.20. The Lord declares in verse 8.22 that the path of devotion is supreme among all paths available to reach the Lord. The paths taken by a soul after leaving the physical body are described in verses 8.23 - 8.26. The chapter is concluded in verses 8.27 and 8.28 with the Lord instructing Arjuna to focus on his prescribed duty of waging the just war while being fully aware of the key concepts covered in this chapter. These include the knowledge of paths traversed by a soul after leaving the physical body, with the ultimate destination being the Lord's abode.

॥ Bṛ V Aī m@Úm` ... ॥

End of Chapter 8

Zd_m@Ü`m`... - amO{dÚmamOJø`mJ...

Chapter 9 – Path of Supreme Knowledge and Secrets

Chapter Introduction: This chapter, titled the ‘Path of Supreme Knowledge and Secrets’ comprises 34 verses. The central message here is an assurance to all seekers that they will have their desires fulfilled through devoted worship and meditation on the Lord. The wise seek the Lord through such devotion and worship, while the ignorant seek limited material and mundane gains, and never lead a fulfilled life. This chapter is a continuation of the concepts in Chapter 7 where some important attributes of the Lord were revealed. Towards the end of Chapter 7, the Lord introduces some new concepts such as *Adhyatma*, *Adhibhoota*, *Adhidaiva*, *Adhiyajna* etc. Arjuna’s questions about these concepts were answered in Chapter 8. Now, the Lord continues the discussion from Chapter 7. In that sense, Chapters 7, 8 and 9 are in proper sequence. While the Lord has infinite auspicious forms, attributes, activities etc., there are eight activities of the Lord Almighty that directly impact living beings. They are – creation (*Srishti*), sustenance (*Stithi*), dissolution (*laya*), regulation (*niyamana*), knowledge (*jnana*), ignorance (*ajnana*), bondage (*bandha*) and liberation (*moksha*). Together they are called *Janmadi ashtaka* and they are also covered in this chapter. This chapter is called the Path of Supreme Knowledge (*‘Raja Vidya Yoga’*) as it teaches these particularly important concepts about the Lord. It is also called the Path of supreme secrets (*‘Raja Guhya Yoga’*) meant only for the faithful.

The Lord’s Greatness

Ir^JdmZdmM Ý&

BX V V JøV_ àdú`má`Zg`d Ý&

kñZ {dkñZg{hV `ÁkñĒdm \_mú`g@e^mV Ý&& 1 &&

amO{dÚm amOJø n{dì{X_îm_ |&
àĚ` jmdJ\_Yâ` gg I H\$V_î``_ |&& 2 |&&

AlÔYmZm... néf m Y_ñ`mñ` naVn |&
Aàß` \_m {ZdV'V \_Ě`ggmadĚ_{Z |&& 3 |&&

The Lord said: I will now impart most confidential principles to you, as you are devoid of faults such as envy and are eligible to receive this teaching. Gaining this sacred and special knowledge along with knowledge from the scriptures will free you from evil. (9.1)

It is the crown of knowledge. It is the pinnacle of secrets. It is purifying. It is superior. It is the means to learn about the Lord Almighty who powers everyone's sense organs. It is easy to follow, and it is the path for eternal bliss. (9.2)

O Parantapa! Those who do not have faith in the knowledge that teaches about the Lord Almighty will not reach the Lord and will keep returning to this mortal worldly life. (9.3)

Comments: The Lord starts His sermon by stating that He will be teaching particularly, important and very confidential concepts here. This is to draw the attention of seekers and to generate curiosity in them. Only those who are pure and are devoid of negative attributes such as envy are eligible and able to understand these teachings. The Lord resolves to teach Arjuna both general knowledge that would be available from scriptures (*jnana*) and special, divine knowledge (*vijnana*) which is not easily available. Only those who are sincere in their devotion to the Lord can imbibe such special knowledge, hence it is most secretive.

The Lord imparts this knowledge over the next 16 verses. In 12 verses from 9.4 – 9.15, general knowledge (*jnana*) that would be available from scriptures is taught. The next 4 verses 9.16 – 9.19, contain discussion on special, divine knowledge (*vijnana*).

The Omnipresent, Indwelling Lord

`m W{X gd OJXì`°\${VZm Ý&
 _ĒñWm{Z gd^Vm{Z Z Mmh VîddpñWV... Ý&& 4 Ý&&

Z M _ĒñWm{Z ^Vm{Z ní` \_`mJ_œa_ Ý&
 ^V^p M ^VñWm __mĒ_m ^V^mdZ... Ý&& 5 Ý&&

`Wm@@H\$mepñWV{ZĒ`dm`... gdÌJm_hmZ Ý&
 VWm gd{U ^Vm{Z _ĒñWmZrĒ`nYma` Ý&& 6 &&

Everything in this universe is pervaded by My unmanifest form which cannot be seen. All inert objects and sentient beings are supported by Me. But I am not dependent on anyone for support. (9.4)

Everything in the universe, including sentient beings and inert objects, even though anchored in Me (Krishna), cannot perceive Me through sense organs. Look at My infinite, divine powers. Even though they are anchored in Me, I do not depend on them. (9.5)

The majestic wind blowing in space is not impacted by the attributes of entities that it encounters. Similarly, even though every living being is anchored in Me, there is no mutual superimposition of attributes. (9.6)

Comments: These three verses provide details on the concept of the Lord's manifestation in every object in the universe; inert and sentient. The Lord is omnipresent and is the supporter for everything in the universe but Himself needs no support of anyone or anything. If the Lord is pervading everywhere, why is He not seen? Verse 9.4 defines the Lord's attribute of *avyakta* (the unmanifest), because of which He is not seen.

Anyone standing on the ground experiences the condition of the ground. For example, if the ground is cool or hot due to the weather, one

standing on it will feel the cold or the heat. This is due to the impact of contact between the object that is supported and the object that is providing the support. So, if the Lord is supporting everything in the universe, why is that support not felt physically by the beings in the universe? This is answered in verse 9.5, where it is stated that those who are supported by the Lord cannot perceive Him through their sense organs. This is fundamentally because (unlike the example of the ground), the Lord does not have a physical form made up of material nature but has a transcendental form.

It must be noted in verse 9.5, the Lord uses the term '*mama atma*' (my soul) as the entity that pervades and supports everything in the universe. However, in verse 9.4, the Lord uses the term '*avyakta moorthy*' (unmanifest form) as the entity that pervades and supports everything in the universe. How can these be reconciled? Sri Jaya Teertha in PD explains that the reason for using different terminology is to confirm that, in the case of the Lord, His form and soul are the same. This is quite different from the case of living beings where the physical form and the soul are different.

The concept in verse 9.5 is illustrated through the example of a gentle breeze in verse 9.6. A gentle, majestic wind blowing in space encounters many objects in its path but does not assume the attributes of those objects. Likewise, even though the Lord pervades everything in the universe and supports everyone in the universe, His attributes do not get contaminated by entities He encounters. They too cannot imbibe His attributes onto themselves. Some can question the appropriateness of using the wind as an example. When a gently blowing wind is in the vicinity of a fragrant object (say a flower), one who is nearby can smell the fragrance of the flower carried by the wind. How can one say that the wind is not contaminated by the fragrance? Sri Rayaru in GV answers by stating that fragrance does not itself become a quality of the wind. The wind stays independent of the fragrance. The particles that constitute fragrance are carried by the wind but do not become an attribute of the wind. Once the wind travels a sufficient distance, the fragrance is no longer present as

those particles are dissipated. This proves that the wind itself does not take on the attribute of the fragrance. Hence, the example of the wind is appropriate.

These verses describe the attribute of *Stithi* (sustenance) among the eight major attributes of the Lord referred to in the introduction to this chapter.

Role of the Lord Almighty During Creation and Dissolution

gd^Vm{Z H\$m'V` àH\$V `mp'V _m{ H\$m_ ' &
H\$ën j ` nZñVm{Z H\$ënXm {dgOmā`h_ ' && 7 &&

O Son of Kunti! During the grand dissolution of the universe, all sentient and non-sentient entities will merge with the triumvirate of nature (*sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas* attributes) which are under My control. At the start of the next cycle, I will recreate the entities (give them physical forms). (9.7)

Comments: After discussing His attributes of omnipresence and pervasiveness in verses 9.4 – 9.6, the Lord describes His role in the process of creation (*Srishti*) and dissolution (*laya*) of the universe in the next few verses .

The Lord uses the term '*visrujami*' to describe His act of creation of the universe, instead of the usual term '*srujami*'. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV that '*visrujami*' refers to special creation while *srujami* refers to normal creation. This is to indicate the fact that the souls of living beings are eternal and are not subject to creation, and during the time of creation, the Lord gives physical bodies to different souls in different species, based on the nature of those souls.

àH\$V ñd_m_d'ä` {dgOm{ nZ... nZ... ' &
^VJm_{_ H\$EñZ_ Ade àH\$VdemV ' && 8 &&

The triumvirate of nature is always under My control. Using them as the material cause, I keep creating multitudes of entities (sentient and inert) again and again. (9.8)

Comments: The previous verse stated the Lord's activities of creation and dissolution of the universe. In this verse, the Lord states the procedure that He uses for creation. The Lord utilizes the inert nature which is under His control as the material cause for creation. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that the Lord does not need any entity or utility to perform activities, but He uses inert nature for creation out of His free will.

Z M _m Vm{Z H\$_m{U {Z~ÜZpÝV YZO` ÿ&
CXmgrZdXmgrZ_ Ag°\$ Vf H\$_g ÿ&& 9 &&

O Dhananjaya! These activities such as creation of the universe can never bind Me. Even though I perform these activities, it is as if I never performed them because of My detachment. (9.9)

Comments: Anyone performing any activity naturally must face consequences for such activity. Is the Lord also bound by His activities such as creation which results in multitudes of entities being born? This verse answers by stating that the Lord is not bound by His actions. There are two reasons for this. One, the Lord does not perform these actions for any gain but rather to help the individual souls on their spiritual journey. Secondly, the Lord Himself controls all activities (*karma*). Therefore, *karma* can never bind the Lord.

Sri Madhwacharya in GB explains the context for the use of the word *udaaseena* (meaning indifference) when it comes to the Lord's attitude in performing actions such as creation. It is known that one needs the Lord's grace to receive any benefits from Him. Given this, the Lord must have some interest in such activities. How can He then be indifferent? We can understand this when we see that the word 'indifferent' refers to

the Lord's effortless, unattached approach to His activities as He has nothing to gain from them.

—`m@Ü` j U àH\$V... g`V gMamMa_ |&
hVZm@ZZ H\$mÝV` OJ{Ûn[adVW |&& 10 |&&

O Son of Kunti! Under My supervision, Mother Nature creates the universe made up of sentient and inert objects. Through the mother nature, the universe undergoes the cycle of repeated creation. (9.10)

Comments: If the Lord indeed shows indifference in the process of creation of the Universe, as stated in the previous verse, does it mean that the Lord has no interest in or oversight over this activity? This verse counters this question by stating that the process of creation and indeed all His activities occur under His supervision, which is implied by the use of the word *adhyaksha*. Sri Rayaru explains in GV that *adhyaksha* means one who is overseeing or supervising the activity, as *aksha* means seeing. The process of creation is performed by sentient Mother Nature (Sri Lakshmi) using inert nature, under the supervision and control of the Lord. In summary, while the Lord performs creation using sentient and insentient nature without effort or attachment, He supervises and oversees the process. This verse describes the attribute of *Niyamana* (regulation) among the eight major attributes of the Lord referred to in the introduction to this chapter, as the Lord is seen to be supervising and overseeing the process of creation.

The Ignorant and the Arrogant Underestimate the Lord

AdOmZpÝV _m _Tm _mZft VZ_m{ I V _ |&
na ^md _OmZÝVm __ ^V_hœa _ |&& 11 &&

_mKmem _mKH\$_mUm _mKkmZm {dMVg... |&
am j gr_mgat Md àH\$qV _m{hZt { I Vm... |&& 12 |&&

Ignorant fools are unaware that I (Krishna) am the Supreme being, eternal and full of infinite, auspicious attributes. They insult Me by considering Me as having a human like body (subject to decay and death). (9.11)

Those with demoniac natures have their intellect clouded with ignorance. Their desires for heaven will not be realized. Their rituals and sacrifices are a wasted effort. They will not attain true spiritual knowledge and they are senseless. (9.12)

Comments: while the Lord, who has infinite powers is responsible for the creation, sustenance, and dissolution of the universe and for granting physical bodies to all souls, why is it that some consider Him the same as other human beings? And why are there no consequences for those who are insulting the ever-compassionate Lord? These two verses provide the answers. Ignorant ones look at the Lord's incarnations such as Rama, Vamana, Krishna etc., and assume that the Lord too has a human like body. They are not able to comprehend the Lord's infinite attributes and strength. The reason for their ignorance is their innate nature, which the Lord describes using the word '*prakrutim*' (by nature). Some even have hatred towards the Lord. Such demoniac people will not achieve any lasting rewards or spiritual knowledge, and hence will not be able to perform any activity that would lead to liberation.

In the epic [BMP] **Bhagavata Maha Purana** (7th canto, 7-1-32), there is a discussion on Shishupala (the king of Chedi and a known adversary of Krishna) who hurled many abuses at the Lord and was killed by Him. As per BMP, ultimately Shishupala achieves *moksha*. Some interpret this to mean that even those who constantly hate the Lord are thinking about Him incessantly and hence are eligible for *moksha*. It is clarified in Sri Madhwacharya's [MBTN] verse 21-259, and BTN verse 7-1-32, that Shishupala had two separate souls resident in his body. One was the pious soul of Jaya (one of the doorkeepers of the Lord's abode) and the other was that of a demon. Due to a curse, Jaya had to endure being in

Shishupala's body. When Shishupala was killed by Lord Krishna, Jaya attained the Lord, while the demoniac soul was relegated to the eternal hell.

Nature of Lord's Devotees

hñV mZñV m nmW Xdt àH\$V m{ IVm... V&
^OÝË`ZÝ`_Zgm kmËdm ^Vm{X_ì``_ V&& 13 V&&

O Partha! Pious people know Me as the root cause of everything in the universe and one who has a never-ending existence. They worship Me single mindedly. (9.13)

Comments: If some view the Lord as human-like (as stated in verse 9.11), could that be due to the Lord having human like attributes? This verse answers that question by stating that if that were so, even those with divine nature should consider the Lord as human like. But that is not the case. Those with divine nature know the Lord as being responsible for the existence of all entities in the universe and that He Himself is not subject to decay. They worship the Lord single mindedly. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that the Lord is not subject to fourfold decay – (i) in the physical body (as He has a transcendental body), (ii) in the soul (as no soul is subject to decay), (iii) in attributes (as the Lord is full of infinite auspicious attributes) and (iv) in happiness (as He is always devoid of misery). The concept of fourfold decay was explained in verse 2.18. This verse describes true knowledge (*jnana*) that is characteristic of pious souls.

gV H\$V`ÝVm m `VÝVü ÑTdv... V&
Z_ñ`ÝVü m ^ŠË`m {ZË``°\$m CnmgV V&& 14 V&&

kmZ`kZ Mmß`Ý` `OÝVm m nmgV V&
EH\$ËdZ nWŠËdZ ~hYm {dæVm _I _ V&& 15 &&

Such pious souls worship Me (Krishna) in various ways – through constant singing of My glories, through involvement in strict rituals such as fasting, through constant meditation and through constant salutations to Me. They strive hard to achieve spiritual knowledge and worship Me with great devotion. (9.14)

Some seekers worship Me through the sacrifice of knowledge (listening, analyzing, and contemplating on spiritual knowledge). Some worship My primary form (Narayana), or My various forms (Vasudeva, etc.) knowing that all these forms are identical and that I am omnipresent, with infinite forms. (9.15)

Comments: In verse 9.13, it was stated that pious souls worship the Lord with the knowledge that He has a never-ending existence. In these two verses, the path of worship is described. Some worship the primary form of the Lord as Narayana, others worship the various forms that originated from Narayana such as the four forms of Aniruddha, Pradyumna, Sankarshana, Vasudeva and the twenty-four forms that start from Keshava (multifaceted worship). The Lord is same in all His forms. Further, the Lord is different from other entities such as individual souls and inert objects as indicated using the word *prithak* meaning different. Sri Rayaru in GV indicates another interpretation of the multifaceted worship of the Lord, and the different types of sacrifices performed by seekers, which was stated previously in chapter 4 (4.25).

Ah H\$Vah `k... ñdYm@h\_h\_mfY\_`&
_YÌm@h_h_dmÁ`\_ Ah\_{3/4ah hV\_`&& 16 &&

{nVm@h`ñ` OJVm_mVm YmVm {nVm_h...`&
dÚ n{dÌ_mH\$ma F\$³gm_`Oad M`&& 17 &&

I am the action of sacrifice. I am the ritual of sacrifice. I am the offering to departed elders. I am the healing herb. I am the hymn. I am ghee offered in sacrifice. I am the ritual fire. I am the offering. (9.16)

I am the father, mother, supporter, worshipful grandfather of this universe. I am the subject of all knowledge and everything that is holy. I am postulated by the primordial holy syllable ‘Om’ and the infinite **Vedas** - Rik, Sama and Yajur (9.17)

Comments: In verse 9.1, the Lord resolves to impart to Arjuna both general knowledge – *jnana* (obtainable through scriptures) and very, special knowledge (*vijnana*) about the Lord Almighty. The Lord described such general knowledge in 12 verses from 9.4 to 9.15. In the next four verses 9.16 to 9.19, the Lord teaches special, divine knowledge (*vijnana*) which identifies the Lord’s presence in all entities, all activities, all sounds and indeed in everything.

In verse 9.16, the Lord states His presence in all activities and entities that pertain to a seeker performing a fire ritual to please Him. By stating that He was the ritual of sacrifice, the Lord is indicating that He controls and stimulates the act of a seeker performing a fire ritual.

Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that one should not attach peripheral meaning to the activities and entities indicated here, but rather focus on their hidden, inner, spiritual meaning. With this approach the activities and entities where the Lord indicates His presence and ownership are as follows: father = responsible for one’s birth; mother = responsible for one’s birth; supporter = supports and sustains the universe; grandfather = worthy of worship; knowable = worthy of being known; holy = cause of holiness in holy objects; symbol *Om* = full of infinite, auspicious attributes; *rik* = worthy of respect; *sama* = Equal presence in His various forms; *yajur* = worshipped by everyone.

J{V^Vṁ à^... gṁ j r {Zdṁg... eaU göV ṽ&
à^d... àb`... ñWṁZ {ZYṁZ ~rO_ì``_ ṽ&& 18&&

I am the destination (for those seeking liberation). I provide for everyone. I am the owner of everything. I am the witness for everything. I am the refuge for everyone. I am the protector for everyone. I am the true friend for everyone. Creation is from Me. Dissolution is from Me. I am the cause for the existence of everyone and everything. I am the imperishable, primordial seed. (9.18)

Comments: In this verse the Lord continues to identify some major activities, entities, and attributes that He is responsible for. In many instances those who achieve liberation are referred to as having reached the Lord. In this verse, the Lord states that He is indeed the destination for those seeking liberation. The Lord is also known as *nidhana*, meaning ‘one into whom the universe dissolves’. In verse 9.7, it is stated that the universe dissolves into nature. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV, that as nature itself is supported by the Lord, it is appropriate for the Lord to be identified with the act of dissolution. The Lord also uses the qualifier *avyayam* when referring to the primordial seed, to distinguish the Lord’s nature as being imperishable, in comparison with the seed in the material world that is subject to change and destruction. Sri Raghuttama Teertha in his PDBB clarifies that the word ‘*nivāsaḥ*’ (refuge) here applies to those who are already liberated and those who are seeking liberation.

Vnṁā`h\_h df {ZJ†ṁā`ĒgOṁ{ _ M ṽ&
A_V Md _Ē`ü gXg f ṁh_OZ ṽ&& 19 &&

O Arjuna! Residing in the Sun, I am the cause of heat and light. I cause clouds to rain, and I also cause the rain to cease. I prevent someone from dying (by supporting the sense organs and the body) and I am also the cause of death. I am the cause and effect of all activities. (9.19)

Comments: The Lord identifies His role in granting powers to entities, such as heat and light, to the Sun. The Lord is also known as *sat* and *asat*. Sri Rayaru explains two different sets of interpretations for these words. *Sat* and *asat* mean ‘group of activities’ and ‘the reason for the group of activities’, respectively. *Sat* also means one who is supreme. The Lord is also known as *asat*, as this refers to one for whom there is no superior entity. This interpretation is supported by *Shabda Nirnaya* as indicated by Sri Madhwacharya in GTN.

Ritual Practitioners v/s Unconditional Devotees

Ì{dÚm _m gm_nm... nVnmnm
 `k[âîQm ñdJqV àmW`ÝV Ý&
 V nÊ`_mgmÚ gaÝÐbmH\$_
 ÁýpÝV {Xî`mZ {X{d Xd^mJmZ Ý&& 20 &&

V V ^ŠĚdm ñdJbmH\$_ {demb
 jrU nÊ`\_Ě`bmH\$_ {depÝV Ý&
 Ed Ì`rY__Zànbm
 JVmJV H\$m_H\$m_m b^ÝV Ý&& 21 &&

Those with superficial (and literal) knowledge of the three **Vedas**, propitiate Me with Vedic rituals and crave for heavenly riches. Based on their good deeds, they attain the heaven presided by deity Indra and enjoy the luxuries therein. (9.20)

They indulge in enjoying luxuries in expansive heavenly worlds, and after exhausting their credits from good deeds (*punya*), are reborn in this world. Focused only on the superficial aspects of the **Vedas**, they perform rituals seeking heavenly pleasure and are stuck in this cycle. (9.21)

Comments: In the next few verses, the Lord explains the difference in rewards experienced by ritualists (those who perform Vedic rituals with the expectation of specific outcomes), and His unconditional devotees. Later, verse 9.24 indicates that the Lord consumes the fruits of all rituals whether they are performed by ritualists or unconditional devotees. If that is so, why is there a difference in the final reward? The difference is due to the approach and attitude in performing such rituals. Ritualists perform Vedic rituals to propitiate other deities with the expectation of rewards such as worldly riches while on earth, heavenly worlds hereafter etc. They do submit all rituals to the Lord Himself, but their activities are not without expectation. On the other hand, unconditional devotees of the Lord perform all activities as an offering to the Lord with utmost devotion and without any expectations. The difference in final rewards is due to the difference in their approach. Previously in verse 7.23, it was indicated that ritualists only experience temporary fruits. These two verses clarify the meaning of temporary fruits by stating that ritualists do reach the heavenly worlds hereafter, enjoy the privileges there and after exhaustion of credits eventually return to earth (in another birth).

AZÍ`m[ü'V`ÝVm _m ` OZm... n`nmgV Í&
Vfm {ZË`m{^`°\$mZm `mj \_ dhmâ`h _ Í&& 22 &&

Some exclusively worship Me with devotion, leaving aside all other thoughts and serve Me wholeheartedly with their body and mind. I take responsibility to grant their wishes and safeguard blessings they have already earned. (9.22)

Comments: This verse explains the rewards experienced by unconditional devotees of the Lord. They worship the Lord single mindedly without any expectations. The Lord grants them permanent bliss. This is indicated using the phrase 'yoga kshema' where *yoga* refers to attaining something that one does not yet possess, and *kshema* refers to the state of retaining what is attained. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that *yoga* here refers

to attaining liberation (state of bliss) and *kshema* refers to retaining that state permanently (eternal bliss).

This verse is identified as the single verse that represents this entire chapter by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS, as unconditional devotion to the Lord is the ultimate form of prayer that a seeker needs to perform to achieve liberation.

`@B`Ý`XdV<sub>m</sub> ^°\$<sub>m</sub> `OÝV I Õ`_m@pÝdV_m... Ý&
V@{n _m_d H\$mÝV` `OÝË`{d{YndH\$ _ Ý&& 23 &&

Ah {h gd`k_mZ_m ^°\$_m M à^ad M Ý&
Z V _m_{^OmZpÝV VîdZ_mVíÀ¶dpÝV V Ý&& 24 &&

`mpÝV XddV<sub>m</sub> Xd<sub>m</sub>Z {nVZ `mpÝV {nVdV_m... Ý&
^V_m{Z `mpÝV ^VÁ`_m `mpÝV _Ú{OZ_m@{n _m' Ý&& 25 &&

O Son of Kunti! Those who worship other deities with sincerity are in fact worshipping Me alone, but in an indirect, unauthorized manner. (9.23)

I am indeed the consumer as well as the Lord of all worships and sacrifices. Those who are ignorant of this principle, propitiate other deities and keep going back and forth between this mundane world and the heavenly world. (9.24)

Those who propitiate heavenly deities reach the respective deities. Those who worship the ancestral deities reach them as well. However, those who worship Me exclusively reach My abode, never to return. (9.25)

Comments: These verses clarify that even for those who only worship other deities, the fruits of their worship are granted by the Lord Himself, as He is the ultimate object and controller of all worships and

sacrifices. Given that the Lord is indeed the object of all worship, why is there a difference in the rewards for ritualists and unconditional devotees? The difference is due to the approach of these two types of worshippers. What is the reason for the difference in their approach? Verse 9.24 states that ritualists are not fully aware that the Lord is indeed the object of all worship, which causes them to approach other deities for quick results. Further, verse 9.25 clarifies that ritualists reach the heavenly abodes of the respective deities of their propitiation.

The Lord is Easy to Please

nì nîn \ \$b Vm` `m _ ^ŠĚ`m à`ÀN{V Ĩ&
VXh ^ŠĚ`növ\_ýmĳ\_ à`VmĚ_Z... Ĩ&& 26 &&

Whatever a devotee offers Me with sincere devotion, whether it is a leaf, a flower, some fruit, or water, I accept such devout offerings of the striving souls. (9.26)

Comments: As the Lord is supreme and is the eventual object of all worship and sacrifices, is it possible that ritualists view the worship of the Lord Almighty as exceedingly difficult and hence propitiate other, lesser deities? This verse clarifies that there is no difficulty involved in worshipping the Lord who does not expect any grand worship. He expects sincerity and unconditional devotion. Anything offered by such devotees even if it is a leaf or a flower or a fruit or even water is gladly accepted by the Lord. This again proves that the attitude of ritualists in resorting to indirect worship of the Lord is due to their lack of understanding of His true attributes.

In great epics such as the **Mahabharata**, the **Ramayana**, and the **Bhagavata**, the Lord is seen accepting with pleasure even ordinary substances such as a leftover leaf (as in the case of Draupadi) or a flower (as in the case of Gajendra) or a fruit (as in the case of Shabari). Sri Vidyamanya Teertha in his GPM offers an interesting interpretation of this

verse. *Leaf* here refers to the **Vedas** (as per Gita (15.1) where the **Vedas** are compared to the leaf of a Banyan tree which represents the universe) and hence worship with a leaf means worshipping the Lord through proper understanding of the **Vedas**. *Flower* refers to non-violence among the eight flowers that are dear to the Lord as per the scriptural saying *ahimsa prathamam pushpam*. The other seven flowers are - self-control, compassion to all beings, forgiveness, knowledge, penance, truth, and *dhyana* meditation. Offering some *fruit* refers to the act of performing duties without any expectations of rewards. Offering water refers to the teary eyes that one experiences because of intense, unconditional prayer to the Lord.

Submit Everything to the Lord

`EH\$am{f `Xým{g ` ,mhm{f XXm{g `V ý&
`Îmnñ`{g H\$mÝV` VV H\$éîd _XnU_ ý&& 27 &&

e^me^\\\$bad _mú`g H\$_~ÝYZ... ý&
gÝÝ`mg`mJ`°\$mĒ\_m {d\_°\$m \_m\_nî`{g ý&& 28 ý&&

O Son of Kunti! Whatever you do, whatever you consume, whatever sacrifice or ritual you perform and whatever penance you undertake, offer them all to Me. (9.27)

By doing this you will not be bound by the effects of activities, which otherwise have either positive or negative outcomes. By performing prescribed duties, without expectations, you will be released from worldly bondage and reach My abode. (9.28)

Comments: In verse 9.26, it was stated that the Lord is easy to please and will accept even ordinary substances offered with sincerity and devotion. Verse 9.27 states that in addition to whatever material substances one offers to the Lord, it is also important to submit any worshipful

activities that are performed such as ritual sacrifice, charity, austerity etc., also as an offering to the Lord. Doing so will release a devotee from any side effects from activities performed and will pave the way for liberation.

Verse 9.28 describes the attributes of bondage (*bandha*) and liberation (*moksha*) which are part of the eight attributes indicated earlier.

g_m@h gd^Vf Z _ Ūî`m@pñV Z {à`... ĩ&
 ` ^OpÝV V \_m ^ŠĚ`m _{` V Vf Mmš`h _ ĩ&&29&&

I treat all beings equally. I have no friends or enemies. Those who worship Me with devotion are supported by Me and I will protect them. (9.29)

Comments: The Lord treats everyone impartially with equality. Equality here implies reciprocity. The Lord's grace is proportional to one's devotion and likewise, His wrath is also proportional to one's misdeeds. The Lord never hates sincere devotees and likewise, He never protects enemies who knowingly hate Him.

A{n MV gXamMmam ^OV _m_ZÝ`^mH\$ ĩ&
 g_mYad g _ÝVî`... gâ`J î`d{gVm {h g_m ĩ&& 30&&

{j à ^d{V Y _mĚ _m eœÀNmpÝV {ZJÀN{V ĩ&
 H\$mÝV` à{VOmZr{h Z \_ ^o\$... àUí`{V ĩ&& 31 ĩ&&

One who worships Me with utmost devotion is to be considered a pious person even if that person has previously committed sinful activities. Such a person has resolved properly. (9.30)

Such a person will immediately focus his/her mind back on righteous activities and will be in the path of eternal bliss. O Son of Kunti! My devotees will never be harmed. (9.31)

Comments: The supremacy of devotion is exemplified in these verses. A similar concept was discussed previously in verse 4.36 where it was indicated that right knowledge will absolve even those who are indulging in misdeeds. Here the Lord is clarifying that such people who have conviction in the Lord Almighty's supremacy over all other deities and indeed over everything in the universe, will soon get back on the right track and achieve His grace. The discussion here applies to pious souls who due to various reasons such as a curse have strayed onto the wrong path.

Souls eligible for liberation who have indulged in sinful activities will have to pay for their misdeeds (such as misery in hell) but due to their innate nature will eventually get back to the right path, develop devotion to the Lord and achieve liberation. Sri Rayaru [GV] clarifies that deities and sages who by nature are pious (*sattvic*) may also indulge in misdeeds. This could happen when they have accumulated positive credits (*punya*) beyond their eligibility. They would then experience a reduction in such credits by indulging in misdeeds out of compulsion such as a curse. They would however not have to experience hell as their misdeeds were beyond their control.

— {h nmW ì`nm{ I È` `@{n ñ`... nm n`mZ`... ¶&
 {ó`m dí`mñVWm eĐmñV@{n `mpÝV nam J{V_ ¶&& 32 ¶&&
 qH\$ nZ~mØUm... nÊ`m ^°\$m amOf`ñVWm ¶&
 A{ZÈ` 'g l b mH\$ \_ B \_ àmß` ^Oñd _m _ && 33 ¶&&

O Partha! Even those who, due to sins committed in previous births or due to a curse, are born in less hospitable, disadvantageous environments, will achieve eternal bliss through their faith in Me. (9.32)

It is obvious that those who are born in virtuous families and holy environments will reach Me through their faith. As you are in this transitory, distressful world, worship Me without delay to reach your spiritual goal. (9.33)

Comments: Every soul has natural attributes based on which it would take birth to play a specific role in society. Sometimes due to sins committed in prior births or due to a curse, it is possible for someone to be born in less hospitable, disadvantageous circumstances where they might not have easy access to education, spiritual learning etc. Even those souls can achieve liberation through faith and unflinching devotion to the Lord. It goes without saying that others who are fortunate to have been born in advantageous circumstances (such as birth in pious families, kingly families etc.) are able to access spiritual education, develop faith in the Lord and achieve liberation. Krishna advises Arjuna to make use of the opportunity of his human birth in this transitory and distressful world and perform his prescribed duties with devotion to Him without delay. This is a message that applies to the entire human race.

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
 नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ३४

Focus your mind exclusively on Me (Krishna). Be devoted only to Me. Worship only Me. Surrender to Me through prostration. Thus, by depending exclusively on Me, you will reach My abode. (9.34)

Comments: The Lord concludes the discussion in this unique chapter by exhorting Arjuna to focus his mind, and worship, propitiate and honour Him exclusively. The reward for such exclusive devotion to the Lord is liberation (*mukti*). As this chapter was focused on the discussion of the Lord's special attributes, in the concluding verse the Lord encourages Arjuna to develop devotion to Him after getting convinced about His greatness.

Summary of Chapter 9

While the Lord has infinite auspicious forms, attributes, activities etc., there are eight activities of the Lord that directly impact living beings. These are – creation (*srishti*), sustenance (*sthiti*), dissolution (*laya*), regulation (*niyamana*), knowledge (*jnana*), ignorance (*ajnana*), bondage (*bandha*), and liberation (*moksha*). Together they are called *Janmadi ashtaka* and they are covered in this chapter. This chapter is called ‘*Raja Vidya Yoga*’ as it teaches these important concepts about the Lord. The Lord provides the context for the teachings in this chapter in verses 9.1, 9.2, and 9.3 where He resolves to impart both general knowledge (acquired through scriptures - *jnana*) and special, divine knowledge about Himself (*vijnana*). The attribute of *sthiti* (sustenance) among the eight major attributes of the Lord as they relate to living beings is covered in verses 9.4 – 9.6. In verses 9.7 and 9.8, the Lord’s attributes of creation (*srishti*) and dissolution (*laya*) are covered and in 9.10, His attribute of regulation (*niyamana*) of the universe is discussed. Verse 9.13 describes the attribute of knowledge (*jnana*) as it pertains to pious souls, and verses 9.11, 9.12 pertain to the attribute of false knowledge (*ajnana*) of demoniac souls. In verse 9.1, the Lord resolved to impart Arjuna both *jnana* the general knowledge obtainable through scriptures and very special knowledge about Himself (*vijnana*). The Lord describes such general knowledge in 12 verses from 9.4 to 9.15 and in four verses 9.16 to 9.19, the Lord instructs special, divine knowledge (*vijnana*) which identifies His presence in all entities, all activities, all sounds and indeed in everything. In verses 9.20 to 9.25, the Lord explains the difference in rewards experienced by ritualists (those who perform Vedic rituals with expectations on outcome), and His

unconditional devotees. The supremacy of the path of devotion is described in verses 9.26 – 9.29. Verse 9.28 alludes to the attributes of bondage (*bandha*) and liberation (*moksha*). Verses 9.30 – 9.31 state that even if pious souls indulge in misdeeds (due to some compulsion such as a curse) they will eventually get back to the right path and move towards liberation. In 9.34 the Lord concludes this chapter by instructing Arjuna to focus his mind exclusively on Him, since performing prescribed duties with unconditional devotion will lead one to liberation.

» && B{V Zd_m@Ü`m`... &&
End of Chapter 9

Xe_m@Ü`m`... - {d^V`mJ...

Chapter 10 - Divine Manifestations

Chapter Introduction: Number ten signifies fullness. It is very fitting that the Lord details His greatness in this tenth chapter of 42 verses. In the 6th chapter, the Lord provided details of *dhyana* meditation, and in the last verse of Chapter 9 the Lord taught that one should concentrate and focus the mind exclusively on Him to achieve everlasting bliss (*moksha*). For one to develop such firm conviction in meditation, one needs to be fully aware of the Lord's greatness and attributes. It is also necessary for one to develop a mental picture of the Lord to focus the mind during meditation. The Lord details many of His glorious forms from verse 10.21 to 10.38, to aid in meditation. Some of the Lord's attributes and special presence in activities and entities were briefly described in 5.29, 7.8, 9.16 etc. More details on these concepts are provided in this grand chapter.

The Lord's Great Qualities

Ir^JdmZdmM V&

^` Ed _hm~mhm eU _ na _ dM... V&

`Îm@h àr` _nUm` dú`n{ {hVH\$mâ` `m V&& 1 V&&

The Lord said: O Arjuna, Mighty Armed One! Listen to some more of My paramount qualities. I will speak unto you for your welfare as you will delight in them. (10.1)

Comments: The Lord clarifies that Arjuna, being of a pious nature, values knowing about His greatness and will listen to His sermon attentively. Hence, the Lord chose Arjuna to teach about His paramount attributes.

Z_{dX... gaJU... à^d Z_hf`... &
 Ah_{X{h XdmZm_hfuUm M gde... && 2 &&&

Even groups of deities and great sages do not have complete knowledge of My paramount qualities or about the creation of this universe. I am the reason for the existence of all deities, all sages and indeed every being, and I am beginningless. (10.2)

Comments: The Lord states that even deities and great sages do not know about His greatness and powers completely, which implies that no one in the universe knows the Lord fully. While He is the cause for the creation of the universe and indeed for everyone's existence, the Lord Himself has no creator. He existed always and will continue to exist forever. Sri Rayaru in GV cautions that one should not conclude that the reason for not knowing about His beginning is due to the difficulty in obtaining such knowledge. The fact is that He is birthless and He always existed. This is different from the incomplete knowledge that one has about His act of creation which occurred, but one cannot completely comprehend. Sri Rayaru provides three interpretations based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB for the phrase '*na me vidhuhu*' (no one knows Me) as follows - (i) deities and great sages do not understand My greatness fully; (ii) deities and great sages do not understand My act of the creation of the universe completely; (iii) deities and great sages do not fully understand that I have no beginning. Sri Rayaru also quotes a **Brahma Sutra** (2.3.9) which states that the Lord is birthless and hence has no beginning.

`m _m_O_ZmqX M d{Îm bmH\$_hcea_ &
 Ag_T... g_Ë`f gdmn... à\_À`V && 3 &&&

One who knows Me as eternal, is not subject to birth. The controller and activator of everything and everyone, the root cause for the existence of the universe, and the Supreme Leader is never deluded. Such a person will be freed from all sins. (10.3)

Comments: The word *anadi* has an interesting interpretation by Sri Rayaru in GV. A superficial meaning of *anadi* is one without beginning. However, the Lord precedes this word by *ajam* (one without birth), which also means one without beginning. Dividing the word *anadi* as *ana* and *adi* leads to two interpretations. *Ana* means activity, *adi* is beginning, so *anadi* means the one who is the cause of activity in everyone. Also, *ana* means the deity *mukhya prana* (*vayudeva*) and hence *anadi* can also be interpreted as the one who existed even before the deity *mukhya prana*. This interpretation is also consistent with the Vedic quote in the **Purusha Sookta** which states – *pranaad vayur ajayatha* (during the process of creation, the deity Vayudeva arose out of the Lord's breath).

~{ÖkñZ_g_mh... j_m gE` X... e... Ý&
g l X... I ^dm@^mdm ^` Mm^`_d M Ý&& 4 Ý&&

Aqhgñ g_Vñ V{ïññVññ XñZ `em@`e... Ý&
^dpÝV ^mdñ ^VmZñ _Îñ Ed nWp½dYñ... Ý&& 5 &&

I alone provide all the qualities to living beings such as intelligence, right knowledge, non-illusion, forgiveness, truthfulness, control over the sense organs and the mind, deep devotion to the Lord, happiness, sadness, birth, death, fear, fearlessness, non-violence, equanimity under pleasure or pain, contentment, austerity, charity, fame, infamy and so on. (10.4) (10.5)

Comments: After having declared Himself as the subject of knowledge that leads one to liberation, the Lord describes the various attributes and emotions that He equips all living beings with, to help them in their livelihood and spiritual journey. The Lord not only provides living beings with physical bodies and sense organs to conduct their lives, He also enables them with various faculties and emotions to complete their personalities.

hf`... gá nd MEdmam ZdñVWm ĩ&
 Ømdm mZgm OmVm `fm bñH\$ B_m... àOm... ĩ&& 6 &&

During the period of the previous Manu, I created the seven great sages, the deities who emanated from the mind of Brahma, and the four Manu deities. Their progeny in turn populated the universe. (10.6)

Comments: The Lord stated previously that He is the cause for the creation of all living beings. Here He is describing the details of such a creation. The Lord initially created the seven great sages (Mareechi, Atri, Angeerasa, Pulastya, Pulaha, Kratu, Vasishta). Sri Rayaru in GV explains that Manu also means one endowed with knowledge and hence Manu deities also are all deities starting from four faced Brahma. The Lord initially created Brahma and through him all other deities were created. The progeny of the seven sages and the deities then populated the universe. The reference to four types of Manu deities indicates the categorization of deities into four categories like human beings described previously in chapter 4 (4.13). *Brahmanas*, *kshatriyas*, *vyshyas* and *shudras* are the four classes of deities. Brahma belongs to the category of Brahmana. Deities such as Vayudeva, Seshadeva, Rudradeva, Garuda, Indra are Kshatriyas etc. It was clarified in 4.13 that the four categories in society are based on the innate nature and talent of souls and, no category is superior to another. In fact 4.13 uses the word *varna* which means colour. Thus, the four categories are different like colours are different and one should not confuse them with the caste system prevalent in society. The fact that these types of categories exist even among deities is proof that one should not grade people based on their classification.

EVm {d^qV `mJ M \_\_\_\_ `m d{Îm Vîdv... ĩ&
 gm@{dH\$ânZ `mJZ `Á`V ZmÎ ge`... ĩ&& 7 &&

One who is properly aware of My majesty and supremacy will be accomplished in steadfast meditation. There should be no doubt about this. (10.7)

Comments: The Lord described some of His attributes and greatness in verses 10.2 to 10.6 and in this verse He declares that one who properly understands His majesty and supremacy will develop the ability for concentrated meditation on Him, which eventually leads to liberation.

Ah gdñ` à^dm _Îm... gd àdVW ÿ&
 B{V _Ëdm ^OÝV _m ~Ym ^mdg_pÝdVm... ÿ&& 8 &&
 _{f Îm _ÒVàmUm ~mY`ÝV... nañna_ ÿ&
 H\$W`ÝVü \_m {ZË` Vî`pÝV M a_pÝV M ÿ&& 9 &&

Learned ones understand Me as responsible for all creation and as regulator of all activities. They worship Me with deep devotion. (10.8)

Learned ones focus their minds on Me, absorb their body and sense organs in My service, teach their students about Me, discuss My prowess with others, dance and rejoice in My glory while feeling fully contented. (10.9)

Comments: In these verses, the Lord describes the way learned ones identified in verse 10.7 worship and serve Him. Learned ones not only rejoice in their divine knowledge, but they also impart such knowledge to others and engage in spiritual discussions to help others develop conviction in the Lord's activities, greatness, and prowess.

Vfm gWV` °\$mZm ^OVm àr{VndH\$ _ ÿ&
 XXm{ _~{Õ`mJV`Z _m_n`mpÝV V ÿ&& 10 ÿ&&

For those who immerse their minds in Me and worship Me with affection, I grant wisdom with which they can attain My abode. (10.10)

Comments: In this verse the Lord states that He rewards His devotees with the knowledge and wisdom they need to achieve liberation. His devotees who worship Him with single minded focus (described in verses 10.7 – 10.9), having understood His greatness (summarized in verses 10.2 – 10.6), are accordingly rewarded.

This verse is identified as the summary of this entire chapter by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS as it summarizes the reward for a seeker who truly understands the Lord's prowess. This is also explained in more detail in later verses.

Author's Note: There is a curious mathematical aspect to this verse. This 10th verse in this 10th chapter has 10 words! It was stated in the introduction that the number 10 stands for fullness. Also, $10 \times 10 \times 10 = 1000$ symbolizes the 1000 names of the Lord as in the **Vishnu Sahasra Nama**. It is very apt that this verse is the summary of this chapter.

Vfñ_dñZH\$ññW_ Ah_kñZO V_... &
Zñe`mã`ñĒ_^ñdññWñ kñZXrñZ ^ññdVñ 'ñ&& 11 &&

In turn, out of compassion I come to dwell and destroy the darkness in their minds caused by ignorance with the shining light of knowledge. (10.11)

Comments: In addition to rewarding His ardent devotees with knowledge to achieve liberation, the Lord states that He frees their minds and shatters any ill-feelings and misery. After all, for one to develop a deep conviction in divine knowledge, one's mind must be freed from misery, prejudice, and other negative emotions.

AOZ CdmM ṽ&
na ~÷ na Ym_ n{dÌ na_ ^dmZ ṽ&
néf emœV {Xì` _ Am{XXd_O {d^_ ṽ&& 12 ṽ&&

AmhñĒdm_f` ... gd Xd{fZmaXñVWm ṽ&
A{gVm Xdbm ì`mg... ñd` Md ~dr{f _ ṽ&& 13ṽ&&

gd_VñV_Ÿ`_Ÿ_m dX{g H\$ed ṽ&
Z {h V ^JdZ ì`q°\$ {dXXdm Z XmZdm... ṽ&& 14 &&

ñd`_dmĒ_Zm@@Ē_mZ dĒW Ēd néfñÎm_ ṽ&
^V^mdZ^Ve XdXd OJĒnV ṽ&& 15 &&

d³V_hñ`efU {Xì`m ømĒ_{d^V` ... ṽ&
`m{^d^V{^bmH\$mZ B\_mñĒd ì`mß` {Vð{g ṽ&& 16 &&

H\$W {dÚm_h `mqJñĒdm gXm n[a{MÝV`Z ṽ&
H\$f H\$f M ^ndf {MÝĒ`m@{g ^JdZ \_`m ṽ&& 17 &&

{dñVaUm@Ē_Zm `mJ {d^qV M OZmXZ ṽ&
^` ... H\$W` V{á{h ûmĒdVm ZmpñV _@_V_ ṽ&& 18 &&

Arjuna said: O Krishna! Great sages, deities and heavenly singers praise you as the supreme entity, the ultimate abode for everyone, supremely sacred, full of auspicious attributes, eternal, and omnipresent. You have also taught me the same. (10.12) (10.13)

O Keshava! I trust everything you have said to me. O Lord! Neither great deities nor demons, nor indeed any others know you fully. O Purushottama! Controller of the universe, and Lord of everyone and everything. Only you know yourself fully. (10.14) (10.15)

Please educate me about your divine majestic forms with which you pervade this universe. O Lord of Infinite Abilities! How should I be thinking about you? O Supreme Lord! How do I visualize you and your presence in different entities in this universe? O Janardana! Tell me more details about your supreme abilities and majestic forms. I will never be satisfied with any amount of your sweet nectarine words. (10.16) (10.17) (10.18)

Comments: After hearing about the Lord's greatness and attributes in brief, Arjuna is now curious and interested in learning more. He states that great sages and deities have praised the Lord's attributes and the Lord Himself has reiterated them. Further, Arjuna knows that even great deities are not capable of fully knowing the Lord who is the creator of even Brahma and Rudra (indicated by the use of the Lord's name Keshava in 10.14, where *ka* refers to Brahma and *Isha* refers to Rudra, and Keshava is in fact the one who created both Brahma and Rudra). Only the Lord knows His forms fully. Arjuna further states that for one to meditate on the Lord, it is important for one to visualize His forms. Hence, Arjuna would like to learn about the Lord's majestic forms. In 10.16, Arjuna requests the Lord to teach him fully about His forms. Arjuna is never satisfied with any amount of the sweet nectarine words of the Lord. In 10.16, Arjuna uses the term *vibhuti* while referring to the Lord's form. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that *vibhuti* has two different meanings. Firstly, *vibhuti* = *vividhatayaa bhootayaha* meaning different forms of the Lord such as Rama, Krishna etc., and secondly *vibhuti* = *vishishtaha bhootayaha*, meaning the form of the Lord that bestows superiority to a specific entity or quality among its peers. These will be detailed in later verses.

The Lord's Divine Manifestations – Direct and Hidden

Ir^JdZdM Ĩ&

hYV V H\$W{`î`m{ {Xi`m ømĚ\_{d^V` ... Ĩ&

àYmY`V... H\$éI ð ZmñĚ`Ym {dñVañ` _ Ĩ&& 19 &&

Ah_mĒ_m JSmH\$e gd^Vme`pñWV... ĩ&
 Ah_m{Xü _Ü` M ^VmZm_ÝV Ed M ĩ&& 20 &&

The Lord said: O Arjuna, Superior among Kurus! I will tell you about some of My main majestic forms. There is no end to My forms. (10.19)

O Gudakesha (Arjuna, one who has conquered sleep)! I am omnipresent, I exist in the hearts of all living beings, and I power their existence. I am responsible for the creation, sustenance, and dissolution of all beings. (10.20)

Comments: The Lord is pleased with Arjuna's sincerity and curiosity and resolves to teach him about His majestic forms. The Lord confirms that He has infinite forms. This seems to be in response to Arjuna's request in 10.16, where he wanted to learn about the Lord's forms fully (without leaving anything out). After all, not even great deities know fully about the Lord's forms or attributes. In 10.20, the Lord states that while He has special presence in many entities, He is present in everyone's hearts, and He is the cause for the creation, the sustenance, and the dissolution of the universe.

In the next 18 verses from 10.21 to 10.38, the Lord explains in detail His specific, majestic forms. This group of verses is one of the most important parts of the **Gita**.

Sri Rayaru in GV explains that *vibhuti roopa* (divine manifestations) are of two types – direct forms and hidden forms. The Lord describes both types of manifestations. Direct form refers to His forms of Rama, Krishna, Vyasa, Kapila etc., while the hidden forms refer to the Lord's form resident in specific objects that gives them supremacy. The hidden forms are of three types: (i) supreme among similar objects, (ii) supreme among dissimilar objects which share a common condition, and (iii) supreme among objects except for an obvious leader. These categories are identified

in Sri Madhwacharya's GTN referring to an ancient work, the **Vibhuti Tattva**. These categories will be identified in later verses. Also, Sri Rayaru uses *shabda nishpatti* (word derivation) to indicate the specific attribute of the Lord signified by the name of the chosen superior entity in each class.

Am{XÈ`mZm\_h {dîUÁ`m{Vfm a{dae_mZ ÿ&
_ar{M_éVm_pñ_Zj ÌmUm_h eer ÿ&& 21 ÿ&&

Among the twelve Adityas, I am Vishnu. Among all radiant objects, I am Ravi (Sun). I am Marichi among the Marut deities. I am The Moon among the constellations of the stars in the night sky (Resident in the Sun, Marichi, and the Moon, I grant them superiority among their peers). (10.21)

Comments: Among the twelve children of Aditi, the Lord is Vishnu (*Vishnu* = *vyaptatvaat sarveshu pratishtatvaat* = the one who pervades the universe and is resident in all). Among all luminous objects, He is Ravi (*rashmi yukto* = one who is full of infinite glow). Among the 49 Marut deities He is Marichi (*marinam charayati* = the one who moves clouds). Among stars, He is Shashi/Moon (*shashaha asya aasteeti* = one who is full of happiness).

In this verse, one can see examples of the different categories of the Lord's manifestations. Vishnu is one of His direct manifestations. The other three entities identified – Ravi, Marichi, Shashi are indirect manifestations. Also, Ravi (Sun) is chosen as supreme among similar radiant entities, while Shashi (the Moon) is indicated as supreme among the stars. The Moon is not a star. However, it is the brightest object in the night sky. This is an example of a superior object among dissimilar objects (Moon and Stars) that share a common condition (the night sky). The Lord's special presence in the chosen superior object is signified by the Lord's attribute as explained by Sri Rayaru in GV through word derivation. For example, Ravi is the worldly name one uses for the Sun, but primarily Ravi means the one who is full of infinite glow, a reference to the Lord Almighty. This discussion applies to all other superior forms as well.

dXmZm gm_dXm@pñ_ XdmZm_pñ_ dmgd... ĩ&
BpÝÐ`mUm_Zümpñ_ ^VmZm_pñ_ MVZm ĩ&& 22&&

Among the **Vedas**, I am Sama Veda. Among deities, I am Vasava (Indra). Among the sense organs, I am the mind. Among the faculties of living beings, I am memory. (10.22)

Comments: The Lord is known as Sama (one who treats everyone equally), Vasava (exists everywhere), Manas (embodies knowledge) and Chetana (has infinite memory).

éÐmUm eH\$aümpñ_{dîem`jajgm_ ĩ&
dgZm nmdH\$ümpñ_ _é... {eI[aUm_h_ ĩ&& 23 &&

Among the eleven Rudra deities, I am Shankara. I am Vittesha (Kubera) among the Yaksha deities. I am Pavaka among Vasus, and Meru among mountain peaks. (10.23)

Comments: The Lord's forms are derived as follows. Shankara (one who is the cause of happiness), Vittesha (owner of all wealth), Pavaka (purifier of everything) and Meru (one who is not activated by some other entity). As indicated before, Shankara is the name for the supreme among the Rudra deities and he derives his superiority and name from the Lord whose attribute is identified by the derivation of the word Shankara.

namYgm M_»`_m {d{Õ nmW ~hñn{V_ ĩ&
gZmZrZm_h ñH\$ÝX... gagm_pñ_ gmJa... ĩ&& 24 ĩ&&

O Partha! Among priests, I am Brihaspati. I am Skanda among warrior commanders. I am the ocean among water bodies. (10.24)

Comments: Among the priests, the Lord has special presence in Brihaspati and resides in him in the same name which stands for the one who is the Lord of all deities. He is known as Skanda (the one who ejects the universe out of Himself during creation) and Sagara (as He is the consumer of the essence in all substances and activities).

_hfU^Jah {Jam_ñā`H\$_ja_&
`kZm On`kmpñ_ñWmdamU {h_mb`... 25 &&

I am Bhrighu among the sages. I am the letter (*akshara*) Om among all letters. I give special powers to chanting hymns (Japa) among all rituals and sacrifices. I am Himalaya among all immovables. (10.25)

Comments: He is known as Bhrighu (the one who eviscerates enemies). He is called Akshara (the one not subject to four-fold decay as described in 2.18). He is Japa (the one who protects anyone born) and Himalaya (the one who is the shelter for the two forms of Lakshmi – *hree* and *shree*). In 10.23, Meru was recognized as the supreme among mountain peaks but in this verse, Himalaya is identified as supreme among all immovables.

AæEW... gddj mU XdfuU M ZmaX... 26 &&
JYdU {MlaW... {gÖZm H\${nbm _{Z... 26 &&

I am Ashwattha (Banyan), among all trees. I am Narada among all divine sages. I am Chitraratha among Gandharvas, the heavenly musicians. I am the sage Kapila among all Siddha sages. (10.26)

Comments: The Lord is known as Ashwattha (the one with a horse like face in the form of Hayagreeva, as *Ashwa* means horse). He is Narada (the one who fulfills the wishes of humans as *nara* means human). He is known as Chitraratha (the one with the spectacular chariot as *ratha* means chariot). Among sages He is Kapila who is a direct form of the Lord Almighty where *kapila* means one who is the embodiment of happiness,

protects the universe and dissolves it within Himself during the great dissolution (*ka* means happiness, *pi* which leads to *palana* means one who protects and *la* which leads to *laya* means one who absorbs the universe during dissolution).

HH Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha offers another unique derivation for the word Kapila as *kapi* + *la* where, *kapi* indicates monkey like unsteadiness and *la* stands for *layati* (destruction). Thus, Kapila can also be interpreted as the attribute of the Lord Almighty who destroys the monkey like unsteadiness in His devotees minds.

C f ... I dg _œmZm {d{Ö _m__VmØd _\&
EamdV JOÝÐmUm ZamUm M Zam{Yn _\&& 27 &&

Among horses, I am Uccaishravas, born from the ocean of nectar during the churning. I am Airavata among the elephants. I am King among humans. (10.27)

Comments: The Lord is known as Uccaishravas (the one who has the highest fame) and Airavata (the one who protects *ira*, Goddess Lakshmi). He is also known as Naradhiva (the one who rules over everyone on earth).

Am`YmZm_h dO YZZm_pñ_ H\$m_YH\$ \&
àOZümpñ_ H\$ÝXn... gnmUm_pñ_ dmg{H\$... \&& 28 &&

I am the thunderbolt (diamond) among all weapons. I am Kamadhuk (wish fulfilling cow) among cows. I am Manmatha/Kandarpa (Cupid) responsible for progeny. I am Vasuki among all single hooded serpents. (10.28)

Comments: The Lord is called Vajra (the one who is without blemish), Kamadhuk (the one who grants His devotees wishes), Kandarpa

(one who enjoys different types of happiness) and Vasuki (one who grants the comfort of shelter to devotees).

AZŸVümpñ_ ZmJmZm déUm `mXgm_h_Ÿ&
{nVUm_`\_m Mmpñ\_`_... g`_Vm_h_Ÿ&& 29 &&

Among multi hooded Naga serpents, I am Ananta. I am Varuna among all aquatics. I am Aryama among the ancestor deities. I am Yama among the deities authorized to regulate the worlds. (10.29)

Comments: The Lord is known by the name Ananta which means unending (the one who spans unending or infinite space, time, and attributes). He is Varuna (the one who grants the ultimate abode of bliss - *moksha*) and Aryama (omniscient). He is Yama (the one who grants the power of regulation).

It must be noted that the deity Varuna in whom the Lord resides by the same name is not an aquatic entity, but he is the governing deity of water.

à†mXümpñ_ XË`mZm H\$m b... H\$b`Vm_h_Ÿ&
_JmUm M_JŸĐm@h dZV`ü n{jUm_Ÿ&& 30 &&

I am Prahlada among the daityas. I am Kala among the entities that bind. I am Mrugendra (lion) among the animals. I am Vainateya (Garuda) among the birds. (10.30)

Comments: He resides in Prahlada by the same name (the one with supreme happiness). He is Kala (the one who knows everything), Mrugendra or lion (the one who is the Lord of devotees who are searching for Him), and Vainateya (the one who shelters devotees who offer special salutations to Him).

ndZ... ndVn_pñ_ am_... eó^Vn_h_ |&
PfmUm_H\$aümpñ_ òmVgm_pñ_ Om•dr |&& 31|&&

Among the entities that purify, I am Pavana. I am Rama among the warriors who carry weapons. Among the fish, I am Makara (crocodile). I am Jahnavi (Ganges) among the rivers. (10.31)

Comments: The Lord is called Pavana (the one who is worshipped by emperors). His direct form Rama (the one who creates happiness in this world) is supreme among warriors who carry weapons. He is known as Makara (the one who reveals very little about Himself; *maakara* = *maa* + *karoti* indicates someone who reveals Himself, but here instead of *maa* the letter is shortened to *ma* hence Makara stands for someone who reveals very little about Himself). He is Jahnavi (the one who protects those detached from worldly life).

gJmUm_m{Xa'Vü_Ü`| Mdnh_OZ |&
AÜ`mĒ_{dÚm {dÚmZm dmX... àdXVm_h_ |&& 32 &&

Arjuna! I am responsible for the birth, life, and death of all beings. Among types of knowledge, I am Adhyatma, spiritual knowledge. I am Vada (debate) among discussions. (10.32)

Comments: The Lord is known as Adhyatma (Lord of all living beings). There are three types of philosophical discussions, *vada* (debate among scholars to establish the truth about a particular issue), *jalpa* (debate with the specific purpose of winning over and converting the opposing party), and *vithanda* (debate to refute an opponent's point of view). The Lord resides in *vada* giving it a superior status among the types of discussions and goes by the name Vada (the one who is known by all sounds).

Aj amUm_H\$nam@pñ_ ŪYŪ... gm_m{gH\$ñ` M |&
Ah_dmj`... H\$mbm YmVm@h {dæVm_ | I... |&& 33|&&

I am the letter A (*akara*) among all letters. I am Dvandva among all compound words (in Sanskrit grammar). I am Kala (time) which has no end. I support and sustain everything and hence go by the name of Dhata. I am omnipresent. (10.33)

Comments: The Lord is also known by the letter ‘A’ as it denotes the Vishwa form of the Lord that resides in everyone’s eyes (as stated in **Katha Upanishat**, the primordial syllable *Om* is derived as *a + u + ma*, where the three letters denote three different forms of the Lord, namely, Vishwa, Taijasa, and Prajna). The Lord is known as Dvandva (the one who resides both inside and outside of all entities), Kala (the one who eviscerates worldly miseries). The Lord resides in four-faced Brahma also known as *vishwato mukha* (one with many faces) with the same name as He spans the entire universe. He is also known as Dhata (one who supports and sustains everything in the universe).

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय 34

I am Mrutyu and cause death to everyone. I am the giver of birth to everyone. I represent and regulate the feminine qualities of fame, wealth, speech, memory, intellect, firmness, and tolerance. (10.34)

Comments: The Lord is known as Mrutyu (the one who destroys everything), Udhbava (the one who is the cause of everyone’s birth), Keerthi (one who is to be praised), Shree (the one who shelters everyone), Vak (the one who stimulates everyone’s speech), Smriti (the one who has to be remembered by devotees), Medha (the one who regulates intellect), Dhruti (the one who regulates one’s firmness), and Kshama (the one who regulates one’s quality of tolerance).

This verse is an example where the Lord is indicating His presence in attributes and qualities as opposed to entities, such as deities, places, mountains, rivers etc.

~hĒgm_ VWm gmāZm Jm` Ìr NýXgm_h_ ĩ&
_mgmZm _mJerfm@h F\$VZm H\$g_mH\$a.. ĩ&& 35 ĩ&&

I am the Brihat hymn among all the hymns of the Sama Veda. I am Gayatri among the poetic meters. I am Margasheersha (harvest month) among the twelve months. I am Kusumakara/Vasanthā (spring) among the seasons. (10.35)

Comments: He is Brihatsama (*brihats* = the one who is superior to deity four faced Brahma and *ama* = the one who cannot be fully known), Gayatri = *gayat* + *trati* (the one who protects those who sing His praises), Margasheersha = *margaanam* + *sheersha* (the one who is at the pinnacle of the paths such as the path of Archi that one takes after leaving one's body), and Kusumakara = *kumaam* + *sumaam* (the one who causes ignorance in evil and wisdom in the pious).

Note that in the **Sama Veda**, where the verses from the Rig Veda are set to musical score, there are different types of singing such as *rarthantara*, *vairoopa*, *brihat* etc. Among them, the Lord resides in the *brihat* type of *sama* singing with the same name, Brihatsama.

ÚV N\ b`Vm_pñ_ VOñVOpñdZm_h_ ĩ&
O`m@pñ\_ ì`dgm`m@pñ_ gîd gîddVm_h' ĩ&& 36 &&

I am gambling among the deceitful vices. I am the splendour in the splendid. I am victory in the victorious. I am conviction in the steadfast. I am purity in the pious. (10.36)

Comments: The Lord is known as Dyoota (the one who indulges in sports such as gambling), Tejas (the one who glows). He is responsible for the qualities of Jaya (the one who is ever victorious), Vyavasaya (the one who is resident in the quality of enterprise), and Sattvam (the one who gives purity to the pious).

It must be noted that the Lord is not responsible for one indulging in gambling which is recognized as one of the vices that is to be avoided. It is just that even among the sinners, the Lord enables their activity which is as per their innate nature.

đĩŮrZm dñgXdñ@pñ_ nñÊSdñZm YZO`... ĩ&
_ZrZm_ß`h ì`ñg... H\$drZm_eZm H\${d... ĩ&& 37 &&

Among the descendants of Vrushni, I am Vasudeva. Among Pandavas, I am Dhananjaya (Arjuna). I am Vyasa among the sages. I am Shukracharya among the seers. (10.37)

Comments: The Lord is called Vasudeva (the one who provides shelter to everyone and who spans everywhere). He is Dhananjaya (*dhanam* + *jayati* = the one who has won treasure). He is Vyasa (*vi* + *asa* = the one who has a special existence). This is a direct form of the Lord. He is also known as Ushana Kavi (the one who has an interest in the act of creation). This is also the name of Shukracharya, a great scholar.

XÊSm X_`Vm_pñ_ Zr{Vapñ_{OJrfVm_ ĩ&
mZ Mdñpñ JøñZm kñZ kñZdVm_h_ ĩ&& 38 &&

I am Danda (the punishing rod) in chastisers. I am the strategy in those aspiring for victory. I am silence in secrets. I am wisdom in the wise. (10.38)

Comments: The Lord is Danda (as He regulates the act of punishing). He is strategy/Neeti (the one who promotes moral values). He

is known as silence/Mouna (the one who is worshipped by Manu deities). He is known as Jnana (the one who regulates knowledge).

Thus in 18 verses from 10.21 to 10.38, the Lord describes His presence in various entities and objects giving them superiority among their peers. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that the Lord has identified some entities as having His special presence though they were not the obvious leaders in those categories. These are -

- Samaveda in 10.22, where Rig Veda is known as the superior among the **Vedas**.
- Vasava (deity Indra) in 10.22, where Lakshmi, Brahma etc., are known to be superior to Indra.
- *japa* (meditation) among ways of worship in 10.25, where *jnana* (worship through knowledge) is known to be superior among ways of worship.
- *vajra* (diamond) among weapons in 10.28, where *chakra* (disc) is known to be superior among weapons.
- *ushana* (Shukracharya) among scholars in 10.37, where deity Brahma is known to be superior among scholars.
- Dhananjaya (Arjuna) among the Pandavas in 10.37, where Bheema is known to be superior among the Pandavas.

As per Sri Madhwacharya's GTN, the above entities are identified as having the special presence of the Lord as cases to illustrate their superiority among other subcategories within a main category. This was explained in the comment section of verses 10.19 and 10.20, where it was stated that the supremacy of the Lord among His hidden forms is of three types: (i) supreme among similar objects, (ii) supreme among dissimilar objects who share a common condition, and (iii) supreme among objects except for an obvious leader. For example, among deities, after the Lord, the order of gradation is Sri Lakshmi, Brahma, Vayu, Saraswathi, Bharati, Sessa, Garuda, Rudra, Varuni, Sowparni, Parvati and then Indra. However, Indra is superior among the deities in Swarga Loka (heaven).

`f {n gd^VnZm ~rO VXh_OZ ĩ&
Z VXpñV {dZm `Ēñ`mV _`m ^V MamMa_ ĩ&& 39&&

I am the primordial seed responsible for the attributes and qualities in all beings. There are no moveable (sentient) or stationary (inert) objects without My presence in them. (10.39)

Comments: The Lord clarifies that He is resident in every object in the universe, sentient or inert. While He has special presence in some objects giving them superiority in their respective categories, such as the Sun (Ravi) among glowing objects, one should not assume that the Lord is not resident in other glowing objects.

Uncountable Divine Manifestations

ZmÝVm@pñV __ {Xì`mZm {d^VrZm naVn ĩ&
Ef VÔeV... àm°\$m {d^V{dñVam _`m ĩ&& 40 &&

O Parantapa! There is no end to My infinite divine majestic forms. I have only indicated a sample of My infinite expansive forms. (10.40)

Comments: In verse 10.16, Arjuna had requested the Lord to teach him about His majestic forms and manifestations, and after describing His divine manifestations in verses 10.21 to 10.38, the Lord declares here that His forms are infinite, implying that no one can completely comprehend Him.

`ÚX {d^V_V gîd I r_X{OV_d dm ĩ&
VîXdmdJÀN Ēd __ VOm@egâ^d _ ĩ&& 41 &&

Whoever or whatever is supreme in their respective categories and exhibit strength and richness, their premiership arises from an infinitesimal fraction of My glory. (10.41)

Comments: The Lord further clarifies that the supremacy in any attribute or quality visible in any entity is due only to an infinitesimal fraction of the Lord's special presence in them. Hence, the Sun (Ravi) who is supreme among all glowing objects exhibits such supremacy due to the presence of a minute fraction of the Lord's glory. This is different from the Lord's direct forms identified in these verses such as Vishnu, Rama, Kapila, Vyasa, and Krishna.

AWdṁ ~hZVZ qH\$ kṁVZ VdṁOZ ṽ&
{dīā`mh{X H\$ĒñZ EH\$meZ pñWVṁ OJV ṽ&& 42&&

O Arjuna! What use is it for you to know about My majestic forms? I pervade and support the entire universe with a minute fraction of My glory. (10.42)

Comments: The intent of the Lord's question is to caution Arjuna (and everyone else) that one should not conclude that His forms are limited to those identified in this chapter as they represent a miniscule fraction of His infinite forms. There will be more description about the Lord's pervasiveness in future chapters. This chapter is a prelude to the glorious universal form of the Lord which will be covered in the next chapter.

Summary of Chapter 10

In this chapter, the Lord details His forms and presence in many entities, attributes in response to Arjuna's questions which appeared in verses 10.12 to 10.18. Arjuna was keen to learn about the Lord's divine glories and countless manifestations as one needs to form a mental image of the Lord to visualize Him during concentrated meditation. The Lord identifies His divine manifestations and special presence in entities which gives them superiority. These are described in 18 verses from 10.21 to 10.38. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that *vibhuti roopa* (divine manifestation) is of two types – direct forms and hidden forms. Direct form refers to His forms of Vishnu, Rama, Krishna, Vyasa, Kapila etc., while hidden forms

refer to the Lord's presence in specific entities that gives them supremacy. The superiority among the hidden forms are of three types: (i) supreme among similar objects, (ii) supreme among dissimilar objects which share a common condition, and (iii) supreme among objects except for an obvious leader. Also, Sri Rayaru uses *shabda nishpatti* (word derivation) to indicate the specific attribute of the Lord signified by the name of the chosen superior entity in each class. In verse 10.21, He identifies Ravi (sun) as the entity that is superior among similar objects, namely luminaries. In the same verse, the Lord also identifies Shashi (Moon) as superior among stars. The Moon is not a star. However, the Moon and the stars share the common attribute of being visible in the night sky. In that sense, the Moon is superior to the stars. This is an example of an entity that is superior among dissimilar objects. In verse 10.22, He identifies *sama veda* as superior among the **Vedas**. However, it is well known that *Rig veda* is the superior. So, the interpretation here is that the Lord is identifying *Sama veda* among the **Vedas** except for the obvious leader (namely *Rig Veda*). This is also seen in verse 10.25, where the Lord identified *japa* (meditation) as superior among the forms of worship where one knows that *jnana* (knowledge) is the supreme form. In addition to such entities (both sentient and inert such as mountains, rivers etc.), the Lord also signifies His presence in qualities and attributes such as fame, memory, intellect, tolerance etc., as seen in verse 10.34, and also in activities such as gambling in 10.36. In verse 10.16, Arjuna had requested the Lord to teach him completely about His majestic forms and manifestations, and after describing His divine manifestations in verses 10.21 to 10.38, the Lord declares in verse 10.40, that His forms are infinite, implying that no one can completely comprehend Him. The Lord concludes His sermon on His majestic forms by cautioning Arjuna that he should not assume that the Lord's various forms are limited to those described in this chapter because they are infinite and expansive. This is a prelude to the description of the Lord's universal form (next chapter).

»» B{V Xe_m@Ü`m`... »»

End of Chapter 10

EH\$mXe@Ü¶¶... - {dæê\$ñXeZ_

Chapter 11 - The Lord's Universal Form

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 55 verses is termed *Vishwa Roopa Darshanam* (The Lord's Universal Form). In the concluding verse of the previous chapter, the Lord declares that He has presence in everything in the universe and just a minute fraction of His energy causes superiority in many objects. The Lord also indicates that previous teachings provide only a glimpse of His powers. This chapter conveys more details about His forms. After listening to the Lord's teachings on His divine manifestations, His amazing activities in terms of creation of the universe etc., Arjuna is naturally curious to behold the Lord's omnipotent form. The Lord grants Arjuna's wish by giving him Divine Vision before exhibiting His grand, Universal form which is the quintessential feature of this chapter. The description of the Lord's Universal Form mirrors the description in the **Purusha Sookta** (the Nature of Cosmic Being), from the **Rig Veda** which is considered the primordial group of hymns that gave rise to the entire span of Vedic literature. In that sense this chapter is like a commentary on the **Purusha Sookta**. This chapter also has a soulful prayer by Arjuna on seeing the Lord's universal form. While the Lord had previously taught Arjuna about His greatness and attributes, the act of physically seeing the Lord's universal form completely solidifies Arjuna's conviction in Sri Krishna's teachings.

Arjuna's Desire to View the Lord's Universal Form

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_XZJhm` na\_ Jø\_Ü`mĔ_g{kV_ ¶&

`îd`m°\$ dMñVZ_ mhm@` {dJVm __ ¶&& 1 ¶&&

^dmß``m {h ^VmZm IVm {dñVaem _`m ¶&

Ĕdîm... H\$_bnîmj_ mhmĔâ`_{n Mmî`` _ ¶&& 2 ¶&&

Ed_VÚWm@EW Ēd_ AĒ_mZ na_œa Ĩ&
 Đĩ{_ÀNm{ V ê\$ñ_ Eœa néfġm_ Ĩ&& 3 Ĩ&&

Ý`g `{X VÀNŠ`\_`m Đĩ{{V à^m Ĩ&
 `mJœa Vm\_ Ēd Xe`m@Ē_mZ_ì``_ Ĩ&& 4 &&

Arjuna said: O Krishna! Out of compassion, You blessed me with the most secret divine knowledge. My ignorance is dispelled by Your words. (11.1)

O Krishna, One with Lotus Eyes! I understood about the cycle of births and deaths of living beings. I also learnt about Your infinite greatness. (11.2)

O Supreme Lord! It is true that You taught me a lot about Your attributes and forms. O Supreme among All Beings! I crave to have a vision of Your great, unimaginable majestic form. (11.3)

O Lord of *Yogas*! If you feel that I can see Your form physically, please show me Your Universal form that has no end. (11.4)

Comments: Arjuna, after hearing about the Lord's divine manifestations and His amazing activities, is now craving to have a vision of the Lord's form. After all, no amount of studying or listening about the Lord can be compared to the experience of directly seeing the Lord. Also, a direct vision of the Lord is extremely helpful for one during meditation. Hence, Arjuna requests the Lord to grant him a vision of His magnificent form. Arjuna also knows that the Lord is beyond the perception of sense organs which he indicates by addressing the Lord as Prabhu in verse 11.4. However, Arjuna also addresses the Lord as Yogeshwara (one who is the master of all *yogas* - ways and means), implying that the Lord would guide him on the sure path to a direct vision of His Supreme form. Arjuna humbly requests the Lord in 11.4 that if He felt that he is eligible and

capable of seeing His imperishable form, then the Lord should grant him that vision.

The Lord grants Arjuna's Wish

I r^J d m Z d m M Ĩ &
 n í ` _ n m W ê \$ n m { U e V e m @ W g h ò e ... Ĩ &
 Z m Z m { d Y m { Z { X ï ` m { Z Z m Z m d U m H \$ V r { Z M Ĩ && 5 &&

 n í ` m { X È ` m Z d g Z é Ð m Z A { æ Z m _ é V ñ V W m Ĩ &
 ~ h ý ` Ñ ï n d m { U n í ` m @ ü ` m { U ^ m a V Ĩ && 6 &&

 B h H \$ ñ W O J È H \$ È ñ Z n í ` m Ú g M a m M a _ Ĩ &
 _ _ X h J S m H \$ e ` f m ý ` Z Ð ï { _ À N { g Ĩ && 7 &&

 Z V _ m e Š ` g Ð ï _ Z Z d ñ d M j f m Ĩ &
 { X ï ` X X m { \_ V M j ... n í ` _ ` m J _ æ a _ Ĩ && 8 &&

The Lord said: O Partha! My forms are infinite, transcendental, colourful and of varying shapes. See My hundreds of thousands (infinite) of forms. (11.5)

O Bharata! See all deities - Adityas, Vasus, Rudras, Ashwini twins, Maruts - in Me. Also see many amazing, astonishing things you have never seen before. (11.6)

O Gudakesha! In My Universal form, you can see the entire universe with all animate and inanimate objects in one place. You can see everything you wish to see here. (11.7)

But you will not be able to see My Universal form with your normal eyes. I grant you Divine Vision with which you will be able to view My supreme splendor. (11.8)

Comments: The Lord having been humbly prayed to by Arjuna, resolves to grant Arjuna the vision of His magnificent Universal Form. The reference to *hundreds and thousands* in 11.5 indicates innumerable or infinite forms. The Lord displays all deities in His form as well as many astonishing, indescribable entities that Arjuna has never seen before. He also tells Arjuna to see in Him all entities in the universe and anything else that he can imagine. In 11.8, the Lord confirms that Arjuna would not be able to see His Universal Form with his normal eyes and that He would grant Arjuna a pair of divine eyes to behold His Universal Form.

Sanjaya Describes the Amazing Spectacle

gO` CdM V&
Ed` ŠEdm VVm amOZ \_hm`mJœam h[a... &
Xe`m\_g nmWm` na_ êšn_œea_ V&& 9 &&

Sanjaya said:

O King Dhrutarashtra! Lord Sri Hari, the Lord of all activities, having said thus, displayed His magnificent Universal form with multitudinous attributes to Arjuna. (11.9)

Comments: At this stage, Sanjaya informs King Dhrutarashtra that Lord Hari accedes to Arjuna's request and displays His magnificent Universal Form. (Hari, as the Lord is referred to here has at least two meanings – the one who consumes the offerings from devotees' sacrifices and one who is coloured green). Those who had gathered in the battle ground were able to view the Lord's Universal form to the extent of their capabilities and eligibilities.

AZH\$d³İZ`Z_ AZH\$mØVXeZ_ V&
AZH\${Xì`m^aU {Xì`mZH\$mÚVm`Y_ V&& 10 &&

{Xì`\_më`mâ~aYa {Xì`JÝmZbnZ\_`V&
gdü`\_`Xd_ AZÝV {dæVm_`I\_`V&& 11 &&

{X{d g`ghòñ`^dÚJnXpëWVm V&
`{X^m... gÑer gm ñ`mX^mgñVñ`_hmË_Z... V&& 12 &&

The Lord's Universal form has infinite faces, infinite eyes, infinite amazing aspects, multitudes of divine ornaments, multitudes of divine weapons. (11.10)

The Lord's Universal form is sporting divine garlands, divine clothes, divine sandal wood paste, is full of infinite amazing, wondrous attributes (such as knowledge, bliss) with faces on all sides. (11.11)

That exalted Universal form has the brightness of thousands and thousands (countless) of Suns rising altogether at the same time. (11.12)

Comments: Sanjaya describes the Lord's form as seen by him. It must be remembered that he is relaying the proceedings of the war to King Dhrutarashtra, as Lord Vedavyasa had granted Sanjaya the ability to visualize the war from a distance. Lord Vedavyasa is another form of Lord Krishna, as per 10.37. So it is not a surprise that Sanjaya was also able to visualize the Lord's Universal form which otherwise was not visible to normal human eyes. The description in 11.10 about the Lord's attributes is consistent with the one in the **Purusha Sookta**.

The fact that Arjuna was able to view the Lord's Universal Form with the entire universe in it, in the background of the battlefield, also proves that the universe is indeed a real entity and not an illusion. Of course, Arjuna required the Divine Vision granted to him by the Lord to view the universe pervaded by Him.

VÌH\$ñW OJÈH\$ÈñZ à{d^°\$ _ZH\$Ym Ý&
Aní`ÔdXdñ` eara nmÊSdñVXm Ý&& 13 &&

VV... g {dñ`\_m{dñ`m öi`am \_m YZO`... Ý&
àUâ` {eagm Xd H\$VmO{ba^mfV Ý&& 14 &&

Arjuna, at that time, saw the entire universe with its manifold divisions, whirling inside the Universal form of Lord Krishna, the Lord of all deities. (11.13)

Arjuna, trembling with tears in his eyes and immersed in indescribable feelings, prostrated before the Lord, bowing his head, and started praying. (11.14)

Comments: Arjuna, after viewing the Lord's Universal Form in all its glory, is overcome with emotion. He describes the Lord's Universal Form in the following 17 verses with tears of joy in his eyes.

Arjuna's Tearful Prayer

AOZ CdmM Ý&
nÍ`m{ _XdññVd Xd Xh gdmñVWm ^V{defgKñZ Ý&
~÷mU_re H\$_bmgZñW F\$ftü gdmZ CaJmü {Xì`mZ Ý&& 15 Ý&&

Arjuna said: O Lord! In Your divine form I can see all deities, and different types of creatures. I can also see the four faced deity Lord Brahma, and Lord Rudra sitting on his lap. I can see all the great sages and divine serpents. (11.15)

Comments: The four faced deity Brahma shelters in the Lord Almighty, Rudra similarly shelters in Brahma (symbolically indicated by him sitting on deity Brahma's lap). As per the epic **Padma Purana**, all other deities are sheltered in various organs of Lord Rudra.

AZH\$~mhXad³ÌZÌ ní`m{ Ēdm gdVm@ZÝVê\$ñ_ |&
 ZmÝV Z _Ü¶ Z nZñVdm@qX ní`m{ {dæœea {dæê\$ñ |&& 16 &&

{H\$ar{QZ J{XZ M{H\$U M VOmanqe gdVm Xr{á_ÝV_ |&
 ní`m{ Ēdm X{Zarú` g_ÝVmÔrámbH\$Ú{V_à_`_ |&& 17 &&

I see Your infinite forms with infinite shoulders, infinite stomachs, infinite faces, infinite eyes everywhere. O Lord of the Universe! I cannot see the beginning, end, or middle of Your forms. (11.16)

I see Your unending divine forms wearing crowns, holding maces and discs, with resplendent glow of light like blazing Suns. Your incredible forms are everywhere, and they seem to pierce my eyes. (11.17)

Comments: In verse 11.16, the use of the word *sarvataha* (everywhere) indicates the Lord spanning all spaces. Space is infinite and so is the Lord. The reference to the Lord's infinite organs mirrors the description in the **Purusha Sookta**.

Ēd_ja na_d{XVî` Ēd\_ñ` {dæñ` na {ZYmZ_ |&
 Ēd_ì``... eœœVY_Jmám gZmVZñĒd néfñ 'Vm_ |&& 18 &&

You have no end. You are the Supreme One. You are the one to be known. You are the primary shelter to this world. Your strength never diminishes. You are the protector of timeless righteous values. You have no beginning. You are eternal, and You are described in scriptures such as the **Puranas**. (11.18)

Comments: This verse indicates the eternal existence of the Lord as the one who has no beginning, middle or end. While verse 11.16 referred to the Lord spanning infinite space, this verse indicates the Lord spanning infinite time.

AZm{X_Ü`mYV\_ZYVdr`‘ AZYV~mh e{eg`ZÌ_Ÿ&
nÍ`m{Ēdm XráhVmed³İ ĨñdVOgm {dæ{X VnYV_Ÿ&& 19 &&

You have infinite powers with no beginning, middle or end. You have infinite shoulders, and Your infinite eyes power the Sun and the Moon. I can see Your form brightening and burning the entire Universe with blazing fire in Your mouth. (11.19)

Comments: While verses 11.16 and 11.18 made references to the Lord spanning infinite spaces and times, this verse states that the Lord's attributes are also infinite. The reference to the Sun and the Moon mirrors the description in the **Purusha Sookta**.

Úmdmn{Wì`m[aX\_YVa {h ì`má Ēd`H\$Z {Xeü gdm... Ÿ&
ÑîQm@ØV êšn_J VdX bmH\$ì` àì`{WV_hmĒ_Z Ÿ&& 20 &&

Your single form spreads from heaven to earth; it fills the interspace and pervades in all directions. O Greatest of all souls! Your form is both amazing and threatening. All Your devotees in all three worlds seem to be petrified. (11.20)

Comments: The Lord's form appears threatening as He prepares to lift the burden Mother Earth is carrying. Evil doers are a burden on earth and from time to time the Lord devises ways to lessen this load. The war of the **Mahabharata** is one such instance. The Lord does appear cruel and threatening to evil doers because they are guilty of wicked acts. Realised souls such as Brahma, Rudra who are used to the vision of the Lord are not threatened by this form. In **Bhagavata** [BMP], Canto 7, Prahlada was praying to Lord Narasimha who had taken a frightening form while killing the evil demon, Hiranyakashipu. Prahlada states that superior deities who had gathered there (such as Brahma, Rudra) were not frightened by the Lord's form as they were realized souls and were used to viewing such forms of the Lord.

A_r {h Ēdṁ gag”ṁ {depÝV H\$MØrVṁ... àṁOb`ṁ JUpÝV Ý&
ñdñVrĒ`ŠĒdṁ _h{f{gÕg”ṁ... ñVdpÝV Ēdṁ ñV{V{^... nîH\$bṁ{^... Ý&& 21 &&

Liberated deities are seen entering Your form. Some are seen praying with folded hands out of fear. Many sages and other heavenly beings are praying to You for the welfare of everyone. (11.21)

Comments: Verse 11.15 described deities sheltered in the Lord and in this verse, deities are described as entering and leaving the Lord’s form at will. The reference in verse 11.15 is to deities who are not yet liberated, and the reference in this verse is to deities who are liberated. This is clarified by Sri Rayaru in GV following Sri Madhwacharya’s GTN supported by the epic **Brahmanda Purana**.

éĐṁ{XĒ`ṁ dgdṁ ` M gmÜ`ṁ {dæ@{æZṁ \_éVüṁî`nmü Ý&
JÝYd` jṁga{gÕg”ṁ dr jÝV Ēdṁ {dpñ`Vṁüd gd Ý&& 22 &&

Rudras, Adityas, Vasus, Sadhyas, Vishwes, Ashwinis, Maruts, Pitrs, Gandharvas, Yakshas, Asuras, and Siddhas are looking at you with amazement. (11.22)

Comments: The term *ooshmapa* is used to describe the Pitr or ancestral deities. This is because these deities consume the vapours from boiling water, hot cooked rice etc., offered by devotees.

êšn _hîṁ ~hd³îZî _hṁ~ṁhṁ ~h~ṁhénṁX_ Ý&
~hXa ~hXîṁH\$bṁb ÑîŪṁ bṁH\$bṁ... àî`{WVṁñVWṁ@h_ Ý&& 23 &&

Z^...ñne Xrá_ZH\$dU ì`ṁîṁZZ Xrá{deṁbZì_ Ý&
ÑîŪṁ {h Ēdṁ àî`{WVṁÝVamĒ_ṁ YqV Z {dÝXṁ{ _e_ M {dîUṁ Ý&& 24 &&

XiṁH\$amb{Z M V _ I m{Z ÑîQd H\$mbZbg{P^m{Z ṽ&
{Xem Z OmZ Z b^ M e_ àgrX Xde OJ{pdmg ṽ&& 25 ṽ&&

O Krishna, Mighty Armed One! Your form is magnificent and huge. It has infinite faces, eyes, shoulders, thighs, feet, abdomens and sharp tusk and teeth. All three worlds are terrified and so am I. (11.23)

O Vishnu! Your form touches the sky, dazzling in many colours with large glowing eyes and mouth wide open. Looking at this, my mind is full of fear. I am trembling, unable to stay steady. (11.24)

O Lord of All Deities! Looking at Your infinite faces glowing like the fire of universal destruction with extended, sharp, strong, piercing teeth, I am losing my bearings. O Supporter of the Universe! Please have mercy on me. (11.25)

Comments: Verse 11.23 refers to the Lord's face, shoulders, thighs, and feet. This is like the description in the **Purusha Sookta** where it was stated that during the creation of the universe, four categories of population with four different nature and qualities were born out of the Lord's face, shoulders, thighs, and feet. Verse 11.24 describes the Lord's mouth as being open since the Lord is preparing to destroy millions during the war and consume them.

A_r M Ēdm YVamîñ` nîm... gd ghdm{Znmbg”... ṽ&
^rî_m ĐmU... gVnîñVWm@gm ghññ_Xr`a{n `mY_»`... ṽ&& 26 ṽ&&

d³îm{U V Ēda_mUm {depÝV XiṁH\$amb{Z ^`mZH\$m{Z ṽ&
H\$M{Ūb¾m XeZmÝVaf gÑí`ÝV M{UVéîm_m“... ṽ&& 27 ṽ&&

Bheeshma, Drona, Karna, the son of Soota, and all the sons of Dhrutarashtra, along with many Kings and many brave warriors from our side are all seen running towards Your terrifying mouth which has

dreadful, sharp teeth and many are seen with their heads smashed and stuck between Your teeth. (11.26) (11.27)

Comments: The reference to the Kauravas and other warriors seen entering the Lord's open mouth, which has sharp, dreadful teeth is a symbolic way of indicating their impending death in the war. A question that arises currently is as follows. If the **Gita** was taught by Lord Krishna to Arjuna before the start of the war, how could Arjuna see the vision of many warriors dying in the war as indicated here. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that Arjuna was granted Divine Vision by the Lord so that he could see the His Universal Form. The same Divine Vision also gave Arjuna the ability to see things that would happen in the future.

Sri Rayaru in GV explains that deities who have Divine Vision can view things with infinite precision. In the epic **Vishnu Dharma**, there is an episode related to King Puroorava and the Ashwini deities who visit him. The King requests them to wait a short while as he wants to see them after taking a shower and dressing himself in his royal clothes and ornaments. The deities see him later and laugh at him. The King asks the deities the reason for their reaction. They say that even though the King took just some time to get himself dressed; he had grown a little older during that time. The implication here is that though everyone grows old every minute of the day, no one can see or feel the minute changes in their bodies. But the Ashwini deities because of their divine eyesight were able to see even the minutest change in the King's body during the time that he took to dress himself.

`Wm ZXrZm ~hdm@a~dJm... g_Đ_dmf^_ I m ĐdpÝV ý&
VWm Vdm_r ZabmH\$dram {depÝV d³İmÊ`{^dÁdbpÝV ý&& 28 &&

`Wm àXrá ÁdbZ nV“m {depÝV Zmem` g_ŌdJm... ý&
VWd Zmem` {depÝV bmH\$mñVdm{n d³İm{U g_ŌdJm... ý&& 29 &&

Just as currents of water from all rivers flood into the ocean, brave warriors from this world are seen hurtling into Your burning mouth from all directions. (11.28)

Just as moths crash into a blazing fire with great speed and perish, many of these warriors are running into your mouth with great speed only to get destroyed. (11.29)

Comments: These two verses identify the warriors who are shown to be entering the Lord's mouth as a symbolic way of describing their imminent death. Verse 11.28 which refers to *veera* (brave) warriors seems to be referring to *sattvic* warriors who are fighting for a just cause, and are hurtling into the Lord's mouth, just like rivers merging into a majestic ocean, which is a natural event. Verse 11.29 describes warriors rushing into their deaths just like moths rush towards a blazing fire. This seems to be referring to evil warriors who by nature are drawn to sinful activities even when they know the perils associated with such actions.

b{bøg Jg_mZ... g_ÝVnV b_mH\$mZ g_JmZ dXZÁdb{Ø... Ý&
VOm{^amn` OJĒg_J ^mgñVdmJm... àVnpÝV {dîUm Ý&& 30 Ý&&

A_m>>`m{h _ H\$m ^dmZJê\$m Z_m@ñV V Xdda àgrX Ý&
{dkmV{ÀNm{ ^dÝV_mÚ Z {h àOmZm{ Vd àd{îm_ Ý&& 31 Ý&&

O Vishnu! You are devouring and swallowing all these warriors with Your fiery mouth. Your fiery energy is spreading and burning the entire universe. (11.30)

Why are You showing me this terrifying form? O Lord of Lords! Please tell me. Please be merciful. I bow my head to you. I would like to understand You better as You are the reason for the existence of this Universe. I cannot understand Your ways. (11.31)

Comments: Verse 11.30 describes the Lord's form which is terrifying and threatening. Arjuna who had heard about the Lord's compassionate qualities is perplexed. In verse 11.31, He states that while the Lord has described His attributes and qualities earlier, he is unable to understand why He is now displaying such a terrifying form.

Arjuna is a mere Instrument in the War

Ir^JdZdM &

H\$m bm@pñ_ bmH\$ j `H\$ÈàdÕm bmH\$mZ g_mhV{ _h àdîm... ý&

F\$V@{n Èdm Z ^{dî` pÝV gd `@dpñWVm... àÈ`ZrH\$f `mYm... ý&& 32 ý&&

The Lord said: I am the controller of Time and Space, mighty enough to destroy all the worlds, and I have resolved to destroy all these warriors here. Excepting you and a few others, all these soldiers will perish. (11.32)

Comments: Lord Krishna responds to Arjuna's question about His form and states that one of His activities is destruction of evil doers. The Lord had declared previously in 4.7 and 4.8 that He would incarnate Himself from time to time to protect virtuous lives and to destroy evil doers. Such a time had come now where evil forces were controlling much of Bharat and the Lord's incarnation as Sri Krishna was designed to destroy the evil and reestablish Dharma. The Lord assures Arjuna that most soldiers would perish in the war with the exception of Arjuna himself and a few others. The Lord uses the term '*api*' meaning 'also' to indicate 'others' who will survive the war. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that 'others' refers to Arjuna's four brothers and three warriors from the other side, Ashwatthama, Krutavarma and Krupacharya. This is as per the **Souptika Parva** chapter of the **Mahabharata**.

Vñ_îd_{îñð`em b^ñd {OÈdm eìZ ^Lúd amÁ` g_Õ_ ý&

_`dV {ZhVm... nd\_d {Z{îm\_î ^d gî`gm{MZ ý&& 33 ý&&

ॐU M ^rî_ M O`ĐW M H\$U VWm@Y`mZ{n `mYdramZ Ĩ&
 _`m hVmñĒd O{h \_m ì`{Wǎm `Ü`ñd OVm{g aU gnĒZmZ Ĩ&& 34 Ĩ&&

O Savyasachi (Arjuna, the one who is ambidextrous)! Therefore, lift yourself up and wage this just war. Defeat your enemies and achieve fame. Enjoy the plentiful kingdom. All these warriors have already been killed by Me. You are a mere instrument in this act of war. (11.33)

All brave warriors such as Bheeshma, Drona, Jayadratha, Karna have already been killed by Me. You do not need to grieve. Wage the war and go through the formality of killing them. You will be victorious in this war. (11.34)

Comments: In verse 2.6, Arjuna had expressed doubts as to whether he would win the war. The Lord had instructed him that he should wage the war as it was his duty to do so. Lord Krishna had also stated in verse 2.37, that Arjuna stood to gain regardless of victory or defeat in the war. If he won, he would enjoy ruling the prosperous kingdom, and if he lost his life he would attain heaven for diligently performing his prescribed duty. In these verses, the Lord goes a step further and tells Arjuna that victory was a certainty as He had already planned death for the Kauravas, and Arjuna had only to go through the formality of fighting the war to preserve his fame. In verse 11.34, the Lord explicitly names Kaurava warriors Bheeshma, Drona, Jayadratha, and Karna as the ones whose deaths were preordained. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV that these warriors were protected with specific boons that would have rendered them impossible to conquer, so Arjuna's apprehension about their invincibility was understandable. The Lord puts Arjuna's mind at ease by stating that even these warriors would perish in the war (Later in the war, these warriors would encounter unique situations where they would perish without contradicting the powers, they possessed due to prior boons).

gO` CdM M V&
 EVÀÑĒdm dMZ H\$edñ` H\$VmO{bdn_mZ... {H\$arQr V&
 Z_ñH\$Ēdm ^` Edmh H\$ŭ gJÒX ^rV^rV... àUâ` V&& 35 V&&

Sanjaya said: Hearing these words from Lord Keshava, Arjuna prayed again to Krishna, shaking with fear, with folded hands, bowed head in a trembling voice. (11.35)

Comments: In response to King Dhrutarashtra's curiosity about further developments in the war, Sanjaya states that Arjuna who was terrified at the Lord's magnificent but frightening form starts addressing the Lord in a trembling voice. As will be seen later, Arjuna is also concerned that he might have treated Krishna as just a normal friend without being fully aware of His greatness, and this concern could also have led to Arjuna's fear.

Arjuna's Remorseful Prayer

AOZ CdM M V&
 ñWmZ öfrH\$e Vd àH\$sĒ`m OJV àöî`Ē`ZaÁ`V M V&
 a j m{g ^rVm{Z {Xe m ĐdpÝV gd Z_ñ`pÝV M {gÕg”m... V&& 36 V&&
 H\$ñ_m f V Z Z_aZ _hmĒ_Z Jar`g ~÷Um@B`m{XH\$Ī V&
 AZÝV Xde OJ{pdmg Ēd_j a gXgĪmĒna V`V V&& 37 V&&

Arjuna said: O Hrishikesha! The entire universe is dancing and celebrating Your greatness. This is understandable. All evil demons are running helter-skelter, and all deities such as groups of Siddhas are bowing their heads to You. (11.36)

O Supreme Soul! How can one not bow before You as You are the most supreme being who created even four faced Brahma? You are the One

without end, Lord of all Lords, supporter of the Universe, and You are imperishable. You are superior to every entity, manifest and unmanifest, in the universe. (11.37)

Comments: Arjuna prays to the Lord with utmost humility. He recounts the Lord's greatness as the most superior being in the entire universe and the one who created even four faced Brahma. All deities in the universe bow before the Lord Almighty as they owe their existence to Him. In verse 11.37, Arjuna uses the word *Mahatma* to address the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV refers to the scriptures and explains *Mahatma* as *mahat* + *atma* where *mahat* indicates completeness and *atma* has four meanings – the one who spans the entire universe, the one who accepts whatever is offered by devotees, the one who consumes the essence of acceptable offerings, and the one who is eternal.

Ēd_m{XXd... néf... namUñĒd_ñ` {dœñ` na {ZYmZ_ ĩ&
dÎm@g dÚ M na M Ym_ Ēd`m VV {dœ_Z'Vêšn ĩ&& 38 ĩ&&

dm`\_`_m@{¼déU... eemH\$... àOm{n{VñĒd à{nVm_hü ĩ&
Z_m Z_ñV@ñV ghòH\$Ēd... nZü ^`m@{n Z_m Z_ñV ĩ&& 39 ĩ&&

You are the primordial Lord. You are the One described in the scriptures. You are the shelter for the entire Universe. You know everything. You teach everything. You are the one to be known. You are full of infinite lustre. O One with Infinite Forms! The Universe is filled by You. (11.38)

You are - Vayu, Yama, Agni, Varuna, Chandra, Prajapati, and grandfather to all. I offer my obeisance to You thousands of times, again and again. (11.39)

Comments: In verse 11.38, Arjuna continues his prayer to the Lord. The Lord is everywhere, always full of infinite, auspicious attributes. In

verse 11.39, Arjuna describes the Lord as Vayu (form of strength and wisdom), Yama (blemishless), Agni (activator of the inert Universe), Varuna (accepts any offering from devotees), Chandra (full of bliss), Prajapati (ruler of subjects) and Pitamaha (grandfather-father of Brahma who himself is the father to all). He is indwelling in all these deities and He powers their activities. The deities are in fact named after the Lord indwelling in them as indicated by the meanings above.

Z_... nañVñXW nđVñV Z_m@ñV V gdV Ed gd ĩ&
AZÝVdr`m{ V{dH\$_ñĒd gd g_mBZm{f VVm@{g gd... ĩ&& 40 ĩ&&

I bow in front of You, from behind You and from all directions. You are complete in all respects, with infinite strength. There is no end to Your bravery. You pervade everywhere. Hence You are known as *sarva* (everything). (11.40)

Comments: In verse 11.39, Arjuna describes the Lord's form as intrinsically powering superior deities by the same name. Here Arjuna extends that description to state that the Lord is everywhere and in everything. He specifically addresses the Lord as 'Sarva' (one who is everywhere). Sri Rayaru in GV explains that the definition of 'Sarva' stated by Arjuna unambiguously clarifies that the reference to 'Sarva' in scriptures such as the **Chandogya Upanishat** (3-14-1), the **Taittireeya** (3-12) should be interpreted as referring to the Lord's attribute of pervading and spanning everywhere in the universe and should not be construed to mean that the Lord Himself is the universe.

g I {V_Ēdm àg^`X°\$ h H\$îU h `mXd h g I {V ĩ&
AOmZVm_{h_mZ VdX_`m à\_mXmV àU`Z dm@{n ĩ&& 41 ĩ&&

`f mnhmgmW\_gĒH\$Vm@{g {dhmaeæ`mgZ^mOZf ĩ&
EH\$m@Wdm@B`À`V VĒg_j VĒj_m`Ēdm\_h\_à`_ ĩ&& 42 ĩ&&

{nVm@{g bṁH\$ñ` MamMañ` Ēd_ñ` nÁ`ü JéJar`mZ`Ÿ&
Z ĒdĒg_m@ñĒ`ä`{YH\$... H\$Vm@Ý`m bṁH\$I`@B`à{V\_à^md`Ÿ&& 43`Ÿ&&

Vñ_mĒàUâ` à{UYm` H\$m` àgmX` Ēdm_h_re_rSç`Ÿ&
{nVd nìñ` g l d g»`... {à`... {à`m`nh{g Xd gmX`Ÿ&& 44`Ÿ&&

Without knowing Your greatness, thinking of You merely as my friend, I have taken liberties and called You thus - Hey Krishna! Hey Yadava! Hey, My Friend! - sometimes by mistake and sometimes in affection. (11.41)

When relaxing, sleeping, sitting, and eating I have shown disrespect by making fun of You. O Supreme One! You are full of infinite, auspicious attributes. I beg You to forgive me. (11.42)

O Supreme Soul with Unending Abilities! You are the father of this universe for both animate and inanimate objects. You are worthy of worship by all. You are the greatest teacher. There is no one equal to You in all three worlds. How can there be any one more superior? (11.43)

O Lord of Lords! As You are worthy of my worship, just like a father is to a son, a friend to another friend, and a lover to a loved one, please forgive all my mistakes. I beg You with all sincerity. (11.44)

Comments: In these verses, Arjuna expresses his remorse for taking liberties when interacting with Krishna, being unaware of His greatness. Normally when one is relaxing or sleeping, it is common for one to be in a lighter mood. Arjuna is indicating to Krishna that during such light moments he has treated Him as any other friend and might not have shown Him proper respect. Arjuna is saying that his behaviour is partly due to his ignorance about Krishna's greatness and partly due to his friendship. Normally, when one addresses elders, teachers etc., one would not directly call them by their names, but would address them using respectful terms.

Arjuna has addressed the Lord as Friend, Yadava etc., and hence is now feeling remorseful. Arjuna begs Krishna to forgive him just as a father would forgive a child, a friend would forgive a friend etc.

AÑïnd ö{fV@pñ_ ÑîQm ^`Z M ài`{WV_Zm_!&
VXd_ Xe` Xd ê\$ñ àgrX Xde OJ{pdmg!&& 45!&&

{H\$ar{QZ J{XZ MH\$hñV‘ BÀNm{ _Edm Đĩ`_h VWd!&
VZd ê\$ñU MV^OZ ghò~mhm ^d {dæ_V!&& 46!&&

Seeing Your form which I have never seen before, I am overjoyed. But I am also frightened, and my mind is shaken. O Lord, Abode of Everyone! Please show me Your form that I am used to seeing so far. (11.45)

O One with Infinite Shoulders! I would like to see Your normal form with four shoulders wearing a crown and holding a mace and a disc. (11.46)

Comments: Arjuna states that he is overjoyed to have had the unique opportunity to view the Lord’s Universal Form. But at the same time, he is frightened looking at the Lord’s threatening form even though the purpose of that was the destruction of evil forces. Arjuna is also remorseful about his playful behaviour with Krishna during their times together. Arjuna now requests Krishna to appear again in His prior form where He was four shouldered, wearing a crown and holding a mace and a disc in His hands.

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_`m àgpZ VdmOZX ê\$ñ na X{eV\_mĚ`_mJmV!&
VOm_` {dæ\_ZYV\_mÚ`_Y_ĚdXÝ`Z Z Ñïnd_!&& 47!&&

Z dX`kÜ` ``ZZ XnZZ M {H\$`m{^Z Vnm{^éJ... ý&
Edê\$ñ... eŠ` Ah ZbmH\$ Đĩ) ĒdXÝ`Z H\$éàdra ý&& 48 ý&&

_m V ì`Wm _m M {d_T^mdm ÑîQm ê\$ñ Kma_rÑL) ‘ _X_ ý&
ì`nV^r... àrV\_Zm... nZñĒd VXd \_ ê\$ñ{ \_X àní` ý&& 49 ý&&

The Lord said: O Arjuna! As I Am pleased with you, I showed you My amazing Universal form which is full of infinite energy and has no beginning or end. No one else has seen this form before. (11.47)

O Arjuna, Bravest Among the Kurus! The Universal form that you were able to see has not been visible to anyone in this world. One cannot see this even if one has carried out elaborate sacrifices or practiced intense austerities or made significant charitable donations or undertaken deep study of the scriptures. (11.48)

Do not be frightened and bewildered by seeing My terrifying Universal form. Set aside your fears and put your mind at ease as I will now appear in the form which you have seen before. (11.49)

Comments: The Lord states that Arjuna was able to view His Universal form because of his devotion and spiritual evolution. Sri Rayaru in GV cautions that one should not literally interpret verses 11.47 and 11.48 to conclude that no one other than Arjuna has seen the Lord’s Universal Form. After all, in verses 11.20 and 11.23, it was clearly stated that everyone in the universe was terrified by looking at the Lord’s Universal Form. Hence, the proper interpretation of 11.47 and 11.48 is that no one would have seen the Lord in the same way as Arjuna was able to see Him. This means that those who are less capable and hence have lesser eligibility would have experienced the vision of Lord with much lesser precision and clarity. Also, Sri Madhwacharya in GTN with reference to the **Brahmanda Purana** clarifies that superior deities such as Brahma and Rudra would have viewed the Lord’s Universal Form with much higher precision and

clarity. Additionally, later in verse 11, 52, the Lord confirms that other deities also would be viewing the Lord's Universal Form just like Arjuna.

gO` CdM

BĒ`OZ dngXdñVWmŠĒdm ñdH\$ ê\$ñ Xe`m_mg ^`... ĩ&

Aœmg`m\_mg M ^rV\_Z ^Ēdm nZ... gmå`dn_hmĒ_m ĩ&& 50 &&

Sanjaya said: Lord Vasudeva having said thus, appeared before Arjuna in His earlier form. Lord Almighty Krishna having appeared thus pacified Arjuna. (11.50)

Comments: Sanjaya relays the next development as an answer to King Dhrutarashtra's curiosity. The Lord responding to Arjuna's request in verse 11.46, puts him at ease by reappearing in His own human like form that Arjuna was used to seeing before.

AOZ CdM ĩ&

ÑîQX _mZf ê\$ñ Vd gmå` OZmXZ ĩ& BXmZr_pñ _gdîm... gMVm... àH\$QV JV... ĩ&& 51 &&

Arjuna said: O Janardana! I am relieved after seeing Your calm human like form. I am back to my natural state. (11.51)

Comments: The Lord always exists in all His forms. To put Arjuna's mind at ease, the Lord reappears in His calm human like form. Arjuna is now relieved to see Krishna in the form that he was used to seeing.

The Glory of Devotion

I r^JdmZdmM ĩ&

gXXe{ _X ê\$ñ ÑîdmZ{g `Ý__ & ĩ

Xdm Aß`ñ` ê\$ññ` {ZĒ` XeZH\$m{-U... ĩ&& 52 &&

Zmh dXZ Vngm Z XnZZ Z MĀ` `m&
eŠ` Ed{dYm Đĩ) ÑĩdmZ{g \_m `Wm ĩ&& 53 &&

The Lord Said: Even deities aspire to see My Universal Form that you were fortunate to see. Looking at My form, some experience happiness and others feel both happiness and fear. (11.52)

Neither by study of the **Vedas**, nor by difficult penance nor by charity and not even by sacrificial rituals can I be seen the way you were able to see Me. (11.53)

Comments: In 11.52, the Lord states that it is exceedingly difficult for one to get an opportunity to physically see Him. Even superior deities are constantly striving to experience a vision of the Lord's Universal Form. Among those who can view the Lord, some deities such as Brahma, Rudra etc., are able to see Him and experience joy. Others feel both joy and fear by looking at the Lord. Arjuna himself states in 11.45 that he was both happy and petrified looking at the Lord's form. In 11.53, the Lord explains the difficulty in getting an opportunity to view His Universal form, saying that even study of the **Vedas**, performing difficult penance, donating to charity, or performing extensive ritual sacrifices cannot guarantee such an opportunity.

^ŠĚ` m ĔdZÝ` `m eŠ` Ah_d{dYm@OZ &
kñV Đĩ) M VîdZ àdĩ) M naVn ĩ&& 54 &&

O Parantapa! Only by single minded devotion can one understand Me, see Me, and attain My abode. (11.54)

Comments: If one is not guaranteed a vision of the Lord even after undertaking difficult tasks to please Him as indicated in 11.53, how can one obtain this vision of the Lord? This verse answers by stating that one needs to surrender to Him with sincere, unconditional, unparalleled devotion to

experience a direct vision of the Lord. The Lord uses the adjective ‘*ananya*’ meaning unparalleled or incomparable to describe the path of devotion. This implies that one should consider the path of devotion to be superior to all other paths such as the path of knowledge, the path of action, donating to charity etc. This also means that these other paths are also required for one to realize the Lord but are not sufficient in themselves. They must be accompanied by single pointed devotion.

This verse has been recognized by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in BGS as summarizing this entire chapter. Reference to the word ‘*drashtum*’ (to see) signifies the vision of the Lord’s Universal Form. This verse also identifies unparalleled devotion as the way to experience divine vision. Hence, this verse is indeed a summary of this entire chapter.

—EH\$—H\$Y—Ēna—m—Ø°\$... g“d{OV... &
{Zda... gd^Vf `... g—m—{V nmÊSd ¡&& 55 &&

O Pandava! One who performs all duties only for My sake, who knows Me as the Supreme One, who is My ardent devotee, who has relinquished worldly pleasures and who has no enmity towards anyone will indeed reach My abode. (11.55)

Comments: The Lord concludes the sermon in this glorious chapter by reiterating the qualities of a seeker who will succeed in reaching the Lord’s abode.

Summary of Chapter 11

After listening to the Lord’s teachings on His divine manifestations, His amazing activities in terms of creation of the universe etc., in the previous chapter, Arjuna is naturally curious to physically see the Lord’s form. The Lord now exhibits His grand, Universal form which is the core of this chapter termed *Vishwa Roopa Darshana* (Vision of The Lord’s

Universal Form). The Lord empowers Arjuna with divine vision as one cannot view Him with ordinary eyes (11.8). Arjuna views the Lord's amazing, incredible, Universal Form spanning the entire universe with countless heads, limbs etc. The descriptions of the Lord's Universal Form mirrors that in the **Rig Vedic** hymn, the **Purusha Sookta**. Arjuna describes the grand sight and compares the Lord's energy to that of thousands of rising suns (11.12). He can see the entire universe sheltering inside the Lord including all the deities starting from four faced Brahma (11.15). He also sees many deities entering the Lord and praying to the Lord with utmost humility (11.21). Everyone is frightened on seeing the Lord's terrifying form. The Lord indicates in 11.32 that He (taking the name of Kala) is about to perform the act of destroying the evil forces who had caused the rise of immorality in the world. This was the reason for His frightening form. The Lord further tells Arjuna that He had already killed all the leaders of the Kaurava army excepting a few, thereby clearing Arjuna's doubts about winning the war. Waging the war is now a formality for Arjuna (11.33). Arjuna, after seeing the Lord's form states that while he feels blessed, he continues to be terrified and threatened by the Lord's frightening form. He is also remorseful that he has not treated Krishna with proper respect as he was not fully aware of His greatness (11.41) and asks for forgiveness (11.44). Arjuna also requests Krishna to appear again in His earlier form that he was used to seeing (11.46). The Lord states that it is exceedingly difficult for anyone to experience a direct vision of His Universal Form. Even great deities strive extremely hard to experience such a vision (11.52). Undertaking even difficult tasks such as diligent study of the **Vedas**, performing difficult rituals, donating to charity etc., will not help one to experience such a direct vision, unless they are accompanied by unparalleled, pure, unconditional devotion to the Lord (11.54). The last few verses in this chapter act as a bridge to the next chapter which focusses on the path of devotion.

&& B{V EH\$mXem@Úm` ... &&

End of Chapter 11

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय - अथोपासनाध्यायः

Chapter 12 - The Path of Devotion

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 20 verses is known as *Bhakti Yoga* (The Path of Devotion). In chapter 10, the Lord described His special presence in beings and objects which gave them superiority among peers, and in chapter 11 the Lord revealed His Universal Form to Arjuna to convince him of His strength and powers. The Lord also states that it is exceedingly difficult for one to behold a vision of His Universal Form and Arjuna was indeed fortunate to have been granted that Divine Vision. In the concluding verses of chapter 11, the Lord declares that sincere devotion towards Him is the best way for a seeker to reach Him. This chapter expands on the concept of devotion and is hence termed the Path of Devotion. In verse 7.23, it was stated that those who propitiate other deities will achieve only temporary fruits and not everlasting bliss. However, in the scriptures it is stated that the Lord's consort Goddess Mahalakshmi who is ever liberated is worshipped by all deities from Brahma onwards and that she grants liberation to the eligible. A natural question that would arise is about the effects of propitiating Goddess Lakshmi who is also known to grant *moksha* to devotees. Arjuna (on behalf of other seekers) seeks clarification on the benefits of propitiating Goddess Lakshmi who is the governing deity for the principle of the unmanifest (*avyakta*). The Lord responds to Arjuna's question in verses 12.2 to 12.7 of this chapter and concludes that worshipping Lord Narayana is an easier way to attain *moksha* than pleasing Mahalakshmi. Further, Lakshmi operates under the Lord Almighty's control. One should propitiate Sri Lakshmi and other deities as part of the Lord's entourage for maximum effect. *Bhakti* or devotion is focusing one's mind on the Lord. The Lord teaches us methods of worshipping Him through action (*karma yoga*), through knowledge (*jnana yoga*), through meditation (*dhyana yoga*) and through devotion (*bhakti yoga*). The last eight verses in this chapter describe the characteristics of an ideal devotee who is dear to the Lord.

Worshipping Goddess Mahalakshmi and Lord Almighty

AOZ CdmM &

Ed gVW`°\$m`^°\$mñEdm n`nmgV Ĩ&

`Mmß`ja_ì`°\$ Vfñ H\$`mJ{dîñ_m... Ĩ&& 1 Ĩ&&

Arjuna said: Some seekers propitiate the Lord Almighty with extreme devotion and some others focus on worshipping Goddess Mahalakshmi (also known as *akshara*, *avyakta*), the imperishable, unmanifest principle of divinity. Among these, which group has a better understanding of the path to liberation? (12.1)

Comments: In chapter 7, verse 7.23, the Lord clearly stated that propitiating other deities will only yield temporary fruits and not the permanent bliss experienced in *moksha*. In verse 11.55, the Lord indicated that one should consider Him the supreme entity and surrender to Him with unconditional devotion to achieve liberation. However, in many instances in the **Vedas**, it is clearly stated that Goddess Lakshmi also grants liberation. Further, she is superior to all other deities such as Brahma and Rudra and is responsible for the creation of the universe. In verse 7.5, it was stated that Goddess Lakshmi controls all inert nature. She is superior to all other deities as she is ever liberated and has an imperishable existence (indicated by the adjective *akshara* in this verse). Given these facts, while some seekers focus exclusively on the Lord Almighty, others focus on worshipping Goddess Lakshmi. A natural question one would have is about the best path for the seeker, given that both the Lord (directly) and Goddess Lakshmi (indirectly) are known to lead one to salvation.

The Easier Path to Liberation

I r^JdmZdmM Ĩ&

_æ`mđí`_Zm`\_m {ZĒ`°\$m CnmgV Ĩ&

I Ũ`m na¶mñVñV`_`°\$V_m _Vm... Ĩ&& 2 Ĩ&&

The Lord said: In My opinion, those seekers who worship Me with supreme faith, and conduct their prescribed duties and meditation with the mind immersed in Me, are superior. (12.2)

Comments: The Lord responds to Arjuna's question in the following six verses, 12.2 – 12.7. In this verse, He categorically states that those who propitiate Him with supreme devotion have a better understanding of the path to liberation compared to those who focus only on propitiating Goddess Lakshmi, the imperishable, unmanifest principle. The Lord provides detailed reasoning for this in the following verses.

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gdĪJ_{MÝĒ` M H\$QñW_Mb Yd_ ĩ&& 3 ĩ&&

g{p`â`pÝĐ`Jm\_ gdĪ g\_~Õ`... ĩ&
V àmßZdpÝV _m_d gd^V{hV aVm... ĩ&& 4 ĩ&&

The immutable, unmanifest principle does not perish; is beyond description and pervades everywhere; it is beyond comprehension, has no limited form like the sky, and is eternal. Those who worship this principle with control over the senses, with mental equanimity and desiring the welfare of everyone will also attain Me. (12.3) (12.4)

Comments: Verse 12.3 lists eight superior attributes of Goddess Lakshmi – imperishable, indefinable, unmanifest, omnipresent, incomprehensible, immutable, constant, and eternal. As per the scriptures, propitiating Goddess Lakshmi will also lead one to liberation. These verses clarify that those who propitiate Goddess Lakshmi who has these superior attributes will also attain the Lord, but indirectly. Those who propitiate Goddess Lakshmi must have strict sense control, mental equanimity, and desire welfare for all.

Šbem@{YH\$VañVfm_ Aì`°\$m g°\$MVgm_ ĩ&
Aì`°\$m {h J{VX... I Xhd{Øadmß`V ĩ&& 5 ĩ&&

` V gd{U H\$\_m{U \_{\` gY`ñ` _Enam... V&
AZY`Zd `mJZ _m Ü`m`YV CnmgV V&& 6 &&

Vfm_h g_ÖVm _E`ggmagmJamV V&
^dm{ _Z {MamV nmW _æ`md{eVMVgm _ V&& 7 &&

It takes great effort to propitiate the unmanifest principle properly. Attaining the final goal of eternal bliss is exceedingly difficult for one following the path of propitiating only this principle. (12.5)

O Partha! One who surrenders all activities to Me, considering Me as the Supreme One, worshipping Me with single minded devotion and focusing the mind on Me will be able to cross the ocean of death bound samsara, through My grace. (12.6) (12.7)

Comments: The Lord clarifies that achieving liberation by only propitiating the unmanifest principle is exceedingly difficult. Sri Madhwacharya in his GB states many reasons for this which are explained by Sri Rayaru in GV.

- Goddess Lakshmi operates under the control of the Lord as stated in 7.5, 15.17 and hence propitiating only her is an indirect path to liberation.
- One must observe extremely strict measures in terms of controlling one's mind and senses, maintaining mental equanimity etc., as any dilution in these stipulations will hinder a seeker in obtaining Goddess Lakshmi's grace for achieving liberation. These stipulations are detailed in verses 6.7, 6.8 etc.
- Propitiating the Lord is easier as He pardons devotees who are unable to adhere strictly to stipulations in worship. The Lord will

ensure that such devotees will, in due course of time, overcome their shortcomings (6.40).

- One who propitiates the Lord Almighty with the same effort that would be spent in propitiating Goddess Lakshmi will achieve liberation sooner.

Sri Madhwacharya in GB quotes passages from the **Sama Veda** (*Madhuchhandasa* and *Ayasya* branches) to support these interpretations. Sri Vidyamanya Teertha in his GPM states that those who only propitiate Goddess Lakshmi may get distracted by the wealth that they may receive from her which makes it very hard for such seekers to exert control over their mind and senses.

In conclusion, worshipping the Lord directly is an easier way to attain liberation compared to the indirect way of pleasing the Lord through Goddess Lakshmi. It must be noted that one must worship Goddess Lakshmi and other deities such as Vayudeva, Rudra etc. also, but with a conviction that all these deities are part of the Lord's entourage. It should also be noted that in the benediction of **Gita Vivruti** [GV], Sri Rayaru explicitly states – '*Lakshmi Narayanam Natva*' which translates to – I offer my obeisance to Goddess Lakshmi and Lord Narayana.

Ways to Reach the Lord

~æ`d \_Z AmYĒñd \_{` ~qÕ {Zde` ĩ&
{Zd{gî`{g \_æ`d AV D\$Ūd Z ge` ... ĩ&& 8 &&

AW {MÎm g_mYmV Z eŠZm{f _{` pñWa_ ĩ&
Aä`mg`mJZ VVm _m{ ÀNmá YZO` ĩ&& 9 &&

Aä`mg@ß`g_Wm@{g _EH\$_na_m ^d ĩ&
XW{n H\$_m{U H\$dZ {g{Ō_dmsñ`{g ĩ&& 10 ĩ&&

AWXB`e°\$m@{g H\$V _ÚmJ_m{IV...V&
gdH\$_\bë`mJ WV... H\$é `VmĒ_dmZ V&& 11 V&&

Focus your mind exclusively on Me. If this is not possible, direct your intellect towards Me (to acquire knowledge about Me). You will be able to attain My abode in due course. Let there be no doubt about this. (12.8)

O Dhananjaya! If you are unable to focus your mind on Me singularly, with an intent on reaching Me as the ultimate goal, perform repeated practice (*abhyāsayogena*) to focus your mind on Me. (12.9)

If repeated practice to focus your mind on Me is not possible, then engage in activities that please Me (such as austerity, worship, service, charity etc.), for My sake, considering Me as supreme. Thereby you will eventually attain Me. (12.10)

If it is not possible for one to perform activities such as intense austerity, worship etc., then one should offer all their actions to Me with no expectations. (12.11)

Comments: After having established that the best path for a devotee to attain liberation is by directly propitiating the Lord, a natural question that would arise is about the best way to do that. In these four verses, the Lord describes a progressive method for a devotee to worship Him with singular mental focus. In verse 12.8, the Lord states the superiority of meditation with mental concentration (*dhyana yoga*) as previously described in Chapter 6. If one is not able to achieve this, then one should try learning about the Lord through scriptural studies (*jnana yoga - paroksha*). If these are not possible, a devotee should practice repeatedly to achieve these (12.9). If for some reason, one is not able to perform such practice, then the Lord states in 12.10, that the devotee should at least engage in physical activities that would please Him (such as worshipping

Him with flowers, service, charity etc.) as these activities are not taxing on the mind and intellect. For those who do not have deep conviction in the Lord, but would rather focus on propitiating other deities, the Lord states in 12.11 that such a devotee should at least perform this propitiation without expectations and submit the fruits of such action to Him. In verse 7.22, the Lord states that even those who propitiate other deities will receive their rewards only through the Lord Himself.

Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS identifies 12.8 as the core verse in this chapter. Here the Lord has indicated that the best path for a devotee to attain liberation is through direct propitiation of Him with singular mental focus (meditation) on Him. Thus, this verse contains the core principles of this chapter.

l`m {h kñZ\_ä`ngmV kñZmÕçmZ {d{eî`V ÿ&
Ü`mZmEH\$\_\sbE`mJñE`mJmÀNmpÝVaZÝVa_ ÿ&& 12 ÿ&&

Acquiring proper knowledge is better than repetitions of actions without proper knowledge. Meditation with firm conviction on the Lord is better than acquisition of knowledge. Performing prescribed duties while relinquishing fruits of action is better than mere meditation. Such selfless duties combined with deep meditation on the Lord are the ways to attain the Lord's abode. (12.12)

Comments: The Lord concludes His discussion on the methods for a devotee to achieve liberation in this verse by summarizing the various steps involved in attaining *moksha*, and the relative importance among such steps. The final destination for every living being is to attain liberation from bondage, a state where one would experience eternal bliss. The way to attain *moksha* is by realizing direct vision and direct knowledge of the Lord (*aparoksha jnana*). Such direct knowledge is achievable for one who is immersed in meditation of the Lord with singular mental focus (*dhyana*). Such meditation is possible for someone who has learnt about the Lord (indirectly through study of scriptures, teachings from a Guru etc. – *paroksha jnana*). One must repeatedly practice meditation and scriptural

studies to obtain an understanding of the Lord. One will be able to focus one's minds on meditation and scriptural studies, if one involves oneself in activities that please Him (such as worshipping the Lord, service to society, charity etc.).

Characteristics of an Ideal Devotee

AÜïm gd^VnZm _Ì... H\$éU Ed M V&
{Z _m {ZahH\$na... g_X... l g l ... j _r V&& 13 V&&

g'Vi'... gVV `mJr `VnE_m ÑT{Zü`... V&
_æ`{nV\_Zm~{Õ`m _Ø°\$... g _ {n`... V&& 14 V&&

One who has no enmity towards any other being, who is friendly to everyone, who feels others' pain, who is devoid of selfishness and ego, who has equanimity with regard to victory and defeat in worldly matters, who forgives others' mistakes, who is always contented, who is involved in performing prescribed duties sincerely, who is in meditative contemplation, who has control over the mind, who has deep conviction in spiritual principles and who has surrendered mind and intellect to Me is indeed very dear to Me. (12.13) (12.14)

Comments: In the following verses, the Lord identifies the characteristics of an ideal devotee who is dear to Him. Many of these characteristics appeared in previous chapters such as 2.55 – 2.61, 4.22, 5.18 to 5.21, 6.7 to 6.9. The Lord had also stated the nature of a devotee dear to Him in 7.17. All these characteristics are now consolidated in one place in the following eight verses 12.13 to 12.20.

In verse 12.13, the Lord describes the characteristics of a compassionate devotee as one who

- Has no enmity towards anyone
- Anticipates distress and protects friends from it

- Is ever compassionate
- Does not claim ownership of any object
- Is not under delusion on attributes not present
- Treats happiness and sadness with equal disdain
- Has patience

In verse 12.14, the Lord continues to describe the characteristics of a devotee who has a firm mind and conviction as one who

- Is ever contented
- Performs prescribed duties and intense meditation with spiritual knowledge
- Has control over the mind
- Has conviction in supremacy of the Lord
- Has mind and intellect focused on the Lord
- Is deeply devoted to the Lord

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥
हृदयं ध्यात्वा न विचिन्तयति ॥ १५ ॥

One who is not perturbed by the goings on in this world, who does not perturb this world, and who is not impacted by pleasure, anger, fear, or anxiety is indeed dear to Me. (12.15)

Comments: This verse expands on the characteristics of a *stita prajna* (a person with mental equanimity) that was described earlier in verses 2.54 onwards.

अज्ञानं च मोक्षं च विदुः ॥
गदमाँनं न विदुः ॥ १६ ॥

One who does not crave for worldly pleasures, who is pure internally and externally, who is carefree while performing duties, whose mind is not

perturbed and who avoids unnecessary activities, is indeed dear to Me. (12.16)

Comments: The Lord uses the term *sarvarambha parityaagi* to describe a devotee who avoids unnecessary activities. Sri Rayaru [GV] describes the four actions to be avoided by such a devotee. They are – (i) activities not dear to the Lord, (ii) performing activities with ego, (iii) performing activities with expectation on the rewards, and (iv) not submitting all activities to the Lord. Such a devotee is indeed very dear to the Lord.

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय

One who never gets elated (by worldly riches), who never hates others, who never complains (on not achieving expected results), who never desires the prohibited, who always avoids all activities – auspicious or inauspicious, is indeed dear to Me. (12.17)

Comments: Verse 12.15 identified some characteristics of an ideal devotee. This verse clarifies that such characteristics should always be present in a devotee. Sri Rayaru in GV explains the context for the Lord declaring that His devotees should avoid both auspicious (*shubha*) and inauspicious (*ashubha*) activities. The implication is that one should avoid even auspicious activities (such as performing rituals for temporary rewards) if they end up in entangling a devotee. One should only aspire for divine knowledge, detachment (towards worldly matters) and devotion to the Lord.

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय

Vè`{ZÝXmñV{V\_mZr gÝVi`m`Z H\$Z{MV Ý&
A{ZH\$V... pñWa_{V^{°\$_mZ_}{à`m Za... Ý&& 19&&

One who treats with equanimity both friends and foes, insults and praise, heat and cold, pleasure and pain, who is thoughtful and content with whatever is given, who is equipoised and who is unconditionally devoted to Me is indeed very dear to Me. (12.18) (12.19)

Comments: These characteristics were highlighted previously in 6.7, 6.8, 6.9 etc., when describing an ideal *dhyana yogi* (one who is immersed in concentrated meditation of the Lord). The qualities of friendship in a friend or enmity in a foe are not inherent in friends and foes but are due to the Lord who endows one with these qualities based on one's innate nature.

` V Yâ`m_V{X`Wm°\$n`nmgV Ý&
IÔYmZm_Ëna_m^°\$mñV@Vrd_}{à`m... Ý&& 20Ý&&

The methods indicated here are the ways to worship the Lord Almighty and achieve liberation. The Lord states that one who observes these methods sincerely, with deep faith and devotion in Him, is indeed very dear to Him. (12.20)

Comments: Any devotee who has any of these characteristics described in verses 12.13 to 12.19 is dear to the Lord. Hence, a devotee who has all these identified characteristics is indeed extremely dear to the Lord and will easily reach Him.

Summary of Chapter 12

In chapter 10, the Lord described His divine presence in beings and objects which give them superiority among their peers, and in chapter 11, the Lord revealed His Universal Form to Arjuna to convince him of His strength and powers. The Lord also stated that it is exceedingly difficult for one to achieve the vision of His Universal Form and that Arjuna was

indeed fortunate to have been granted that Divine Vision. In the concluding verses of chapter 11, the Lord declares that sincere devotion towards Him is the best way for a seeker to reach Him. This chapter expands on the concept of devotion and is hence termed the Path of Devotion.

In verse 7.23, it was stated that those who propitiate other deities will achieve only temporary fruits and not everlasting bliss. However, in the scriptures it is stated that the Lord's consort, Goddess Mahalakshmi who is ever liberated is worshipped by all deities from Brahma onwards and she grants liberation to the eligible. A natural question that would arise is about the effects of propitiating Goddess Lakshmi who is also known to grant *moksha* to devotees. Arjuna (on behalf of other seekers) seeks clarification on the benefits of propitiating Goddess Lakshmi who is the governing deity for the principle of the unmanifest (*avyakta*). The Lord responds to Arjuna's question in verses 12.2 to 12.7 of this chapter and concludes that worshipping Lord Almighty Narayana is an easier way to attain *moksha* and pleasing Mahalakshmi is difficult. Further, Lakshmi operates under the Lord's control. One should propitiate Goddess Lakshmi and other deities as part of the Lord's entourage for maximum benefit.

Bhakti or devotion is focusing one's mind on the Lord. In verses 12.8 – 12.12, The Lord teaches Arjuna the methods of expressing devotion using facilities such as intellect, studying, performing prescribed duties etc. The last eight verses in this chapter describe the characteristics of an ideal devotee who is dear to the Lord. Many of these characteristics were stated in previous chapters and are consolidated here in a unified manner for easy reference.

&& B{V ŪmXe@Ū`m`... &&

End of Chapter 12

Ì`Xe@Ü`m`... - j`j`k`mJ...

Chapter 13 - The Field and The Knower of the Field

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 35 verses is termed *Kshetra Kshetrajna Yoga* (The Field and the Knower of the Field). As indicated in the introductory chapter, Sri Rayaru in GV has provided an excellent categorization of the 18 chapters in Gita by dividing them into 3 groups of 6 chapters each. Chapters 7-12 dealt primarily with the topic of the Lord's attributes and greatness as seen in Chapter 10 (The Lord's Divine Manifestations), Chapter 11 (The Lord's Universal Form) etc. After all, the goal of every living being is to realize the Lord to achieve liberation. Chapters 1-6 discussed the various means for one to realize the Lord, such as the path of knowledge, the path of action, the path of devotion etc. These last six chapters (Chapter 13 to 18) expand on some of the important concepts covered in the previous chapters. In chapter 2, verses 2-12 onwards, the attributes of individual souls were described. In chapters 10, 11, 12 etc., the Lord's forms, attributes and greatness were discussed. In verse 7.4, the attributes of eightfold inert nature were discussed. Arjuna now wants to understand more about the interrelationships between the three entities – the Lord Almighty, individual souls, and inert nature. The Lord responds to Arjuna's questions on the entities in verses 13.2 to 13.24. The interrelationships between these three entities form the philosophical basis for the principle of fivefold differences (*pancha bheda*).

The Field and The Knower of the Field

AOZ CdM V&

àH\$V néf Md j`j`k`d M V&

EVÛ{XV{`ÀNm{` kmZ k` M H\$ed V&& 1 V&&

Arjuna said: O Keshava! I would like to know more about – inert nature, the individual, the field of activity, the knower of the field of activity, knowledge, and the object of knowledge. (13.1)

Comments: Arjuna requests details on the following six topics – *prakruti* (inert nature) and *purusha* (individual soul), *kshetra* (field of activity) and *kshetrajna* (one who fully knows about *kshetra*), *jnana* (knowledge and prerequisites to obtain knowledge) and *jneya* (the one who is to be known). In verses 13.2 to 13.7, the Lord provides details on *kshetra* and *kshetrajna* and verses 13.8 to 13.19 cover the topics of *jnana* and *jneya*. Verses 13.20 to 13.24 are related to *prakruti* and *purusha*. The remaining verses describe the interaction and interrelationships among these entities.

The word *purusha* can refer to both the individual soul (*jeevatma*) and the Lord Almighty (*paramatma*) based on the context of its use, as seen from verses 13.22 where it refers to the individual soul and 13.23, where it refers to the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that the word *purusha* in this verse refers to the individual soul. Also, the word *jnana* which ordinarily refers to knowledge should be taken to mean the method to obtain knowledge. This will be evident from the Lord's response in verses 13.8 to 13.12, where the Lord identifies 20 different characteristics needed to obtain knowledge.

Ir^JdmZdmM ĩ&
 BX eara H\$mYV` j ĩ{Ē`{^Yr`V ĩ&
 EVÚm d{Îm V àmh... j ĩk B{V V{ŪX... ĩ&& 2 ĩ&&

The Lord said: O Son of Kunti! This body made of inert nature is the field of activity. One who has a good understanding of the constituents of this field of activity is the knower. (13.2)

Comments: The Lord uses the word *shareera* (physical body) to identify the entity that forms *kshetra* (the field of activity), based on word derivation. Here, *shareera* = *shar* (the entity subject to feelings) + *eera* (the entity owing its existence to the Lord). The knower of the field of activity is termed *kshetrajna*, the one who knows *kshetra* which is derived from *ksheeyate* (the entity with indwelling Lord Almighty).

The Lord is The Knower

j ìk Mm{n _m {d{Õ gd j ìf ^maV ÿ&
j ì j ìk`mkZ `îmÁkZ _V __ ÿ&& 3 ÿ&&

O Bharata! In all fields of activity, I am the knower. Preeminent knowledge is knowing both *kshetra* (field of activity) and *kshetrajna* (knower of this field of activity). (13.3)

Comments: Since the physical body (*kshetra*) belongs to a living being, can that living being be called *kshetrajna* (knower of the field of activity)? No. The Lord clarifies by emphatically stating that He is the knower of the field of activity. Further, **Vishnu Sahasra Nama**, verse 2 identifies *kshetrajna* as one of the names of the Lord. Also, by using the qualifier *sarva* (all) before the term *kshetra*, it is clarified that the universe of inert nature also comes under the definition of field of activity.

The Field and Its Transformations

VË j ì ` f `mÑ³M `{ÔH\$m[a `Vü `V ÿ&
g M `m `Èà^mdü VËg_mgZ _eU ÿ&& 4 ÿ&&

What is this field of activity? How is it described? What are its transformations? Who governs them (referring to *kshetrajna*)? How is He described? What are His influences? Let Me answer these in brief. (13.4)

Comments: The Lord now resolves to provide details of the field of activity in terms of its composition, transformation, governing entities, influencing entities etc. The fact that the field of activity is under the control of other entities, confirms its dependent nature.

F\${f{^~hYm JrV NÿXm{^d{dY... nWH\$ ÿ&
~÷g ÌnXü d hv_{Ø{d{Z{üV... ÿ&& 5 ÿ&&

Great sages have sung praises about the nature of the field of activity. The **Vedas** also describe them separately. The **Brahma Sutras** have given definitive rulings on this topic. (13.5)

Comments: The Lord states that the concepts described in His teachings have been well known, based on proclamations from various sages and descriptions in scriptures such as the **Vedas**, **Brahma Sutras** etc. In that sense, these are authentic and recorded teachings.

_hm^VnY`hH\$nam ~{Öaì`°\$_d M Y&
BpYĐ`m{U XeH\$ M n#m MpYĐ`JmMam... Y&& 6 &&

BÀNm Ûf... g I X... I g”mVüVZm Y{V... Y&
EVËj ì g_mgZ g{dH\$na_Xmöv_ Y&& 7 &&

The field of activity is comprised of the following - the five basic elements of nature (earth, water, fire, space, air), principles of individuation, consciousness, intellect and the three qualities of nature which comprise the unmanifest. Along with these, there are eleven sense organs (five organs of perception, five organs of action and mind), five objects of the sense organs (form, smell, sound, taste, touch), emotions of desire, disdain, pleasure, pain, the physical body, mental propensity, and determination (all these entities have governing deities). (13.6) (13.7)

Comments: The Lord describes the composition of the field of activity. It contains both physically observable elements such as the five basic elements of nature, inner faculties, and qualities/attributes. All these make up a personality. The unmanifest entity is comprised of the three qualities of nature, namely, *sattv* (pious), *rajas* (passion), and *tamas* (ignorance). The principle of intellect is one of the four inner faculties, which are mind (*manas*), intellect (*buddhi*), individuation (*ahankara*), and memory (*chitta*). The mind causes confusion, and the intellect helps in discrimination.

In verse 13.34, the Lord had also indicated that He would describe the entities that govern the components of the field of activity. They are governed by deities who cause the entities to act. The deities who control the components of the field of activity are described by Sri Rayaru in GV as follows -

- (i) The five basic elements of nature: space (Ganapathy), air (Mareechi), fire (Vahni), water (Varuna), and earth (Dhara Devi)
- (ii) The four cosmic principles: *avyakta* - unmanifest (Lakshmi), *mahat* – cosmic intelligence (Brahma), *ahankara* - individuation (Rudra), *buddhi* - intellect (Parvati)
- (iii) The mind (Skanda, Indra, Aniruddha – son of Kama)
- (iv) 5 sense organs of perception): ear (Moon), skin (Marut), eyes (Sun), tongue (Varuna), nose (Ashwini twins)
- (v) 5 sense organs of action: voice (Agni), hands (Maruts), Feet (Yagna, Shambhu), excretory organs (Yama), organs of reproduction (Shiva, Manu)
- (vi) 5 objects of sense organs: sound, touch, form, taste, smell (five children of Shiva)

The above 25 principles result in the effects of emotions indicated in 13.7. The governing entities for these effects are: Desire (Sreedevi and Bharatidevi), disdain (Kali), sadness (Dwapara), happiness (Mukhya Vayu), determination and boldness (Saraswati, Bharati), mental propensity (Sreedevi), physical Body (other deities)

The relative gradations of these governing deities were alluded to in verse 3.42. All these deities operate under the control of the Lord as indicated previously in verse 3.43.

A note on the principles of *mahat* and *buddhi*: Many times, the term *buddhi* is used to refer to both *mahat* and *buddhi*. However, *mahat* and *buddhi* are different principles with *mahat* referring to cosmic intelligence

and *buddhi* referring to normal intelligence. In that sense, *mahat*, whose governing deity is Brahma, is responsible for special, divine knowledge (*vijnana* - *aparoksha*), and *buddhi* whose governing deity is Parvati is responsible for acquired knowledge (*jnana* - *paroksha*). The concepts of *jnana* and *vijnana* were covered in Chapter 7. Also, many principles have multiple governing deities, with one primary governing deity and one or more secondary deities. In all cases, the Lord is the controlling deity.

Prerequisites for Knowledge

A_m{ZEd_ AXpâ^Ed_ Aqhg m j mpYVamOd_ Y&
AmMm`mrngZ emM ñW¶_mĒ_{d{ZJh... Y&& 8 &&

BpYĐ`mWf dam½`_ AZhH\$ma Ed M Y&
OY__Ē`Oamì`m{YX... I XmfZXeZ_ Y&& 9 Y&&

Ag{°\$aZ{^îd“... nÌXmaJhm{Xf Y&
{ZĒ` M g_{MÎĒEd_ Bîm{Zîmn{Îmf Y&& 10 &&

__{` MmZÝ``mJZ ^{°\$aî`{^Mm[aUr Y&
{d{d°\$Xeg{dĒd_ Aa{VOZgg{X Y&& 11 &&

AÜ`mĒ\_kmZ{ZĒ`Ēd VîdkmZmVXeZ_ Y&
EVÁkmZ_{V àm°\$_ AkmZ`XVm@Y`Wm Y&& 12 &&

The prerequisite attributes for one to achieve true knowledge are as follows - humility, modesty, non-violence, tolerance, sincerity, servitude towards teachers, internal and external cleanliness, steadfastness, detachment from sense pleasures, absence of ego, awareness of birth, death, old age and diseases, non-attachment to possessions, equipoise during gain and pain, deep single-minded devotion in Me (Krishna), keeping aloof, staying away from crowds, always thinking about the Lord. All these

attributes comprise knowledge and are the means to achieve knowledge. Anything contrary to these constitutes ignorance. (13.8) (13.9) (13.10) (13.11) (13.12)

Comments: From verse 13.3 onwards, the Lord provides details about the entity (the Lord) that stimulates and powers the components of the field of activity. To understand the attributes and nature of that entity, it is important for a seeker to have requisite mental and physical discipline. These are represented by the 20 attributes of an enlightened person identified in these 5 verses and they form the path or procedure or ways (*sadhana*) for one to understand the Lord. An ideal seeker is one who:

1. is humble
2. is unpretentious
3. practices non-violence
4. is tolerant
5. is sincere in action (physical, vocal, mental)
6. respects and serves teachers and scholars
7. has internal and external cleanliness
8. has conviction in righteousness
9. has self-control
10. renounces sensual desires
11. is devoid of ego
12. is always aware of the distressful conditions of birth, death, old age, and disease
13. is detached from worldly possessions
14. is not excessively attached to family and possessions
15. is equanimous in the face of pleasure and pain
16. is exclusively devoted to the Lord
17. prefers to be in solitude
18. stays away from crowds indulging in useless activities (not dear to the Lord)
19. is constantly involved in learning about the Lord
20. is immersed in contemplation of scriptures for realizing the Lord

The Object of Knowledge

k` `ÎmV àdú`m{ `ÁkEdm@_V_íZV Ý&
AZm{X_Éna ~÷ Z gÎmBmgXÀ`V Ý&& 13 Ý&&

Now I will describe that principle which is to be known (the object of knowledge), knowing which one will attain the nectar of immortality. That object is the Supreme Lord who has no beginning and is eternal. This principle is distinct from entities that have form (*sat*) and those that are formless (*asat*). (13.13)

Comments: Lord Krishna clarifies that He is the object of knowledge and hence is termed *jneya* (the one to be known). The Lord identifies Himself as *jneya* but uses the qualifier *anadi matparam* (the one who has no beginning and who is Supreme) as in verse 8.3. Of course, in verse 7.7 etc., He already declared that there is no one superior to Him, and hence there is no need to repeat that attribute. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that the Lord is distinct from entities that have form and those that are formless. The entities that have form are the three basic elements of nature (earth, water, fire) and those that are formless are the two remaining basic elements of nature (air, space). This is a way of indicating that the Lord is above and beyond the influence of nature.

gdV... nm{UnmX VW gdVm@{j{eam_ I _ Ý&
gdV... I{V_„mH\$ gd_mdÈ` {Vð{V Ý&& 14 &&

The object of knowledge (Lord Almighty) pervades everywhere and has legs, hands, eyes, ears, mouths, and heads everywhere. It spans the universe. (13.14)

Comments: If the Lord is different both from entities with form and those without form, how is He to be visualized? This verse answers by stating that the Lord indeed spans everywhere with all organs, however,

these organs are transcendental (*aprakruta*) and not *prakruta* (composed of material nature). The Lord had made His Universal form visible to Arjuna and other eligible souls as was described in Chapter 11.

gdpyĐ`JU^mg gdpyĐ`{dd{OV_ | ĩ&
Ag°\$ gd(^ f d)^H\$Md {ZJU JU^ñŠV ĩM && 15 &&

It (the object of knowledge) activates all sense organs and objects of sense perception. It does not have any sense organs. It is not impacted by anything and consumes everything. It is devoid of attributes and is full of attributes (13.15)

Comments: The Lord continues His description of the object of knowledge. While 13.14 dealt with the Lord's form, this verse is about the Lord's attributes and seems to imply antithetical qualities. Sri Rayaru in GV provides rationalization for these seemingly contradictory descriptions. The Lord not having sense organs is referring to Him not having sense organs made of material nature as His organs are transcendental in nature. Similarly, while He consumes the positive essence of all activities, He is not bound by actions. And He is devoid of attributes as He is beyond the three attributes of nature (*sat, rajas, tamas*). He is full of infinite, auspicious attributes.

~{ha'Vü ^VmZm_Ma Ma_d M ĩ&
gú_ĒdmV VX{dk` XañW Mmp'VH\$ M VV ĩ&& 16 &&

It exists both inside and outside of all beings. It is mobile and stationary at the same time. It is extremely minute hence cannot be perceived by sense organs. It is very far and at the same time, very near. (13.16)

Comments: The Lord is present in all living beings and exists outside of them, pervading the entire universe. He is termed stationary in the sense that He does not experience transformation in His attributes.

A{d^o\$ M ^vf {d^o\$_d M pñWV_ ĩ&
 ^V^V M VÁk` J{gîU à^{dîU M ĩ& 17 &&

It resides in different beings in an undivided form but appears to have different forms. It holds and supports all beings. It pervades everywhere and fills everything. It is known at all times. It consumes everything (at the time of dissolution of the universe) and creates everything (at the time of creation of the universe). (13.17)

Comments: The Lord is present in all beings in an undivided form (*avibhaktam*) but appears to have different (*vibhaktam*) forms. The use of the term ‘eva’ in this verse refers to the Lord appearing to have different forms. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that learned ones know the Lord as having undivided form, with multiple incarnations of the same form with no difference. Ignorant ones consider these as different.

Á`{Vf{\_{n V, `{VñV_g... na‘Á`V ĩ&
 kZ k` kZJâ` ö{X gdñ` {d{ðV_ ĩ&& 18 &&

It is the light of even bright objects (such as the Sun), beyond darkness (such as ignorance, death), omniscient, self-illuminating, is reachable through knowledge and it especially resides in everyone’s heart. (13.18)

Comments: The object of knowledge (The Lord Almighty) is a self-illuminating divine light that powers all luminous objects in the universe such as the Sun, and as stated in the **Vedas**, it is beyond ignorance, death, and material nature. It is the embodiment of all knowledge and knows Itself fully. How can one reach such an entity? This verse answers by stating *jnanagamya*m (the Lord is reachable through spiritual, divine knowledge). In verse 13.16, it was stated that the Lord exists both inside and outside of living beings. In this verse, it is clarified that the Lord resides inside every living being within the heart (*hrudi*). Sri Rayaru in GV quotes the **Brahma**

Sutras (1.2.7) to explain the Lord's existence in a minute form as well as an immeasurable one spanning the entire universe with a comparison to the sky which occupies all spaces.

B{V j Ì VWm kmZ k` Mm°\$ g_mgV... Ý&
_Ø°\$ EV{Úkm` \_Ømdm`mnÚV Ý&& 19 &&

I have thus described in brief, the field of activity, knowledge, and the object of knowledge. My devotees who properly understand these principles will reach My abode. (13.19)

Comments: The Lord concludes His sermon on the topics that Arjuna had identified in verse 13.1, namely, *kshetra* (field of activity) and *kshetrajna* (one who fully knows about *kshetra*), but does not explicitly indicate *kshetrajna* here, as it is included in *jneya*. Verses 13.2 to 13.7, covered the details of *kshetra* and *kshetrajna* and verses 13.8 to 13.19 covered the topics of *jnana* and *jneya*. The word *jnana* is used to mean both knowledge and the prerequisites for knowledge and these were covered in verses 13-8 to 13-11, and verse 13.12 respectively. The Lord also states that His devotees who properly understand and live by these principles will reach Him. It must be noted that mere scholarship on these topics is not enough for one to reach the Lord. They must be incorporated in a seeker's life. Such a person is indeed a true devotee of the Lord.

Nature and Being

àH\$qV néf Md {dÕÇZmXr C^md{n Ý&
{dH\$mamü JUüü {d{Õ àH\$Vgâ^dmZ Ý&& 20 &&

Know that nature and being are both eternal. Their transformations and the three qualities (*guna*) are all due to nature. (13.20)

Comments: In the next five verses 13.20 – 13.24, the Lord answers Arjuna's question from verse 13.1 regarding *prakruti* (nature) and *purusha*

(being). *Prakruti* can mean both insentient nature and sentient nature. Likewise, *purusha* can mean both the individual soul and the Supreme Soul (Lord Almighty). The appropriate interpretation depends on the context in which these words are used. Verse 13.6 describes *prakruti* (nature), and verse 13.7 describes its transformations. These constitute the physical body and personality of *purusha* (the living being – individual soul). Both nature and individual souls have no beginning and have always existed.

H\$m`H\$maUH\$VĖd hV... àH\$VéÀ`V ĩ&
néf... g l X... I mZm ^mŠVĖd hVéÀ`V ĩ&& 21 &&

Creation of an individual's physical body and sense organs is performed by sentient nature (Goddess Mahalakshmi), and the experience of emotions by an individual is due to the Lord. (13.21)

Comments: This verse describes the interaction between the individual soul, nature (inert and sentient) and the Lord. Again, as stated in the comments on the previous verse, *prakruti* can mean both inert nature and sentient nature and, *purusha* can mean both individual soul and the supreme soul (Lord Almighty). Accordingly, Sri Rayaru in GV provides two interesting interpretations.

While the Lord Almighty is primarily responsible for the creation of living beings and for the experience of their emotions, Goddess Lakshmi also has a role to play. She has a higher role in creation as compared to consumption or experiencing happiness or sadness by living beings. Hence, she is indicated as the cause for the creation of living beings.

Alternately, this verse can also be interpreted to mean as follows. Inert nature is the material cause in the physical creation of living beings, and living beings consume or experience emotions such as happiness and sadness.

néf... àH\$VñWm {h ^L°\$\$ àH\$VomZ JUmZ Ý&
H\$maU JUg“m@ñ` gXgÚm{ZOÝ_g Ý&& 22 &&

It is well known that the individual soul residing in the body, comprised of the elements of nature, experiences emotions through contact with the three attributes of nature. It is then reborn in pious or unholy families depending on the level of attachment with such emotions. (13.22)

Comments: The use of the letter ‘hi’ in the first line indicates that the impacts of the elements of nature on the emotions experienced by a living being are known through experience. An individual experiences emotion such as happiness or sadness due to the impact of the attributes of nature such as *sattv*, *rajas* and *tamas*. Excessive attachment to such emotions will entangle an individual. For example, individuals who experience happiness may focus exclusively on accumulating worldly riches to ensure everlasting happiness, which prevents them from performing activities that please the Lord. Their actions impact the circumstances of their succeeding births.

CnĐi@m@Z_ÝVm M ^Vm ^m°\$m _hœa... Ý&
na_mĚ_{V Mmß`°\$m Xh@pñ_Ýnéf... na... Ý&& 23 Ý&&

The Lord resides in all individuals and is a witness to their activities. He activates and propels every action based on a soul’s innate abilities. He consumes the fruits of all activities, and He is omnipotent. (13.23)

Comments: Verse 13.4 raises many questions on the field of activity, the knower etc. One of the questions was about the entity who governs the field of activity. The Lord answers this question by stating that He is the entity that governs all activities in all beings, and He is also the consumer of all these activities. The previous verse 13.22 indicated that interactions with the effects of the qualities of nature determine the future birth of an individual. This verse clarifies that the qualities of nature are material causes and the instrumental cause is the Lord. As stated in

comments to verse 13.20, the word *purusha* can refer to either a living being, or the Lord Almighty and the appropriate interpretation depends on the context. In this verse, *purusha* refers to the Lord due to the use of the adjective *para* (supreme).

Ed d{Îm\$ néf àHsqV M JU... gh ý&
gdWm dV_mZm@{n Z g ^`m@{^Om`V ý&& 24 &&

One who understands that the individual souls and the Supreme One are different, who understands nature (sentient and insentient) and acts accordingly, will not be reborn regardless of one's state and condition during one's lifetime. (13.24)

Comments: Verses 13.20 to 13.23 described the interaction between *purusha* (living being) and *prakriti* (sentient and insentient nature). Together with previous verses which described the interaction of these entities with the Lord, one can understand the relationship among these three entities. The Lord states that one who has a proper understanding of these concepts will achieve liberation even if one has strayed onto wrong paths in one's lifetime. Many times, even the learned ones due to force of circumstances (such as a curse) might stray away from the right path. Such beings will in due course of time, through the Lord's grace, get back to the right path and move towards liberation.

Ü`mZZmĚ\_Z nÍ`pÝV H\$MXmĚ_mZ_mĚ_Zm ý&
AÝ` gm>>`Z `mJZ H\$\_`mJZ Mmna ý&& 25 &&

AÝ` Ědd\_OmZÝV... I Ědm@Ý`ä` CnmgV ý&
V@{n Mm{VVaÝĚ`d \_Ě` I{Vnam`Um... ý&& 26 &&

Some visualize the Lord residing in their bodies through their intellect and through meditation. Some visualize the Lord through the path of knowledge. Some visualize the Lord in their duties (Work is Worship). (13.25)

Those who cannot visualize the Lord through the above means, worship the Lord by learning about Him from scholars. Even those, who rely only on acquiring knowledge about the Lord through listening to scriptures, will cross this ocean of worldly affliction. (13.26)

Comments: Since one needs to experience a direct vision of the Lord to attain divine, spiritual knowledge, this verse identifies the different paths taken by seekers in their spiritual journey. Some visualize the Lord through concentrated meditation (*dhyana*). Some visualize the Lord through intense study, contemplation, and analysis of scriptures (*jnana*). Some visualize the Lord through performance of prescribed duties without expectations (*karma*).

Sri Rayaru in GV quotes Sri Madhwacharya's GTN for a second interpretation of this verse. Some sages visualize the Lord in their hearts through meditation and through their innate talent (*pratibha*) of novel interpretations of scriptures. Deities, through their innate talent of discovering newer interpretations of scriptures, can visualize the Lord without a need for vocal instruction from their superiors. Some who are superior among rulers perform their prescribed duties such as protecting their citizens during attack from enemies and performance of sacrifices (such as *Ashwamedha*). They visualize the Lord who appears before them to consume their offerings during such sacrifices.

Verse 13.26 addresses the situation of those who are not as talented as the deities indicated in 13.25. Such seekers also benefit greatly from learning about the Lord through vocal instructions from their teachers and can ultimately cross the ocean of worldly miseries. This indicates the power of *shravana* or vocal instruction. Deities starting from Brahma have gradations in not only their physical form but also in their innate talent. For example, Lord Brahma and Lord Vayudeva are endowed with 32 superior qualities in their physical form. Other deities have lesser superior qualities in their physical forms. Likewise, Lord Brahma and Vayu have the highest

innate talent (*pratibha*) among all living beings and can visualize and meditate on the Lord without any explicit vocal instruction. But it is observed that even these great deities are often listening to Vedic teachings from the Lord. They do this as a respect to the Lord to earn His grace and to develop even deeper conviction in their understanding of Him.

Sentient Nature and the Lord Almighty

`m dV gÄOm`V {H\$ {#mV gÎd ñWm daO“ ____ Ý&
j Ì j Ì kg`m JmV V{Û{Õ ^aVf^ Ý&& 27 &&

O Superior among the Bharatas! Know that all entities in the universe, movable and immovable, are created out of the union of sentient nature and the Lord Almighty. (13.27)

Comments: The Lord continues to answer the question posed in 13.27 regarding the field of activity, its origins, its transformations etc. This verse describes the process of creation of living beings. The union of *kshetrajna* (the Lord Almighty) and *kshetra* (the sentient nature embodied by Goddess Lakshmi) results in the creation of all entities in the universe. The word *kshetra* which was previously interpreted to mean the physical body of living beings can also be interpreted to mean Goddess Lakshmi. It should be noted that in a later verse 14.3, the Lord explicitly indicates that He and His consort are responsible for the creation of all living beings.

The Individual Soul and the Supreme Being

g_ gdf ^Vf {VðÝV na_œa_ Ý&
{dZÍ`Èñd{dZÍ`ÝV `... nÍ`{V g nÍ`{V Ý&& 28 &&

g_ nÍ`Z {h gdÌ g_dpñWV_rœa_ Ý&
Z {hZñÈ`mÈ\_Zm@QÈ\_mZ VVm `m{V nam J{V_ Ý&& 29 &&

The same Lord Almighty resides in all beings. Even when these living beings perish, the Lord continues existence as He is imperishable. The one who knows this is indeed knowledgeable. (13.28)

One who knows the Lord as being defectless, full of infinite auspicious attributes, and residing in equal measure in all, will never lose knowledge and will never experience downfall. Such a person will be on the right path (13.29)

Comments: In verse 13.3, the Lord indicates that He resides in all beings as *kshetrajna*. However, living beings experience different emotions such as happiness and sadness in varying proportions. These verses explain that regardless of the differing experiences in different living beings, the Lord exists uniformly in everyone. Sri Rayaru in GV quotes the **Brahma Sutra** (3.2.11) which states that the Lord who exists in different places and in different beings has no difference among His forms.

àH\$È`d M H\$_m{U {H\$_ _mU{Z gde... V&
`... nî`{V VWm@@È_mZ_ AH\$Vma g nî`{V V&& 30 &&

All activities of living beings are performed by the Lord Almighty Himself using the elements of nature, based on their innate abilities. One who is aware of this dependency on the Lord is truly knowledgeable. (13.30)

Comments: This verse clarifies that the difference in birth situations experienced by living beings is primarily due to their differing innate natures (and resulting activities) and not due to any partiality on the part of the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV quotes the **Brahma Sutra** (2.1.35) to support the argument that the Lord does not exhibit partiality towards anyone.

This verse also describes the doership of activities performed by living beings. Rayaru in GV provides two interpretations for this verse based on the phrase '*atmanam akartaram*'. It was stated previously in

comments on verse 6.5, that the word ‘*atma*’ has many meanings and the two meanings applicable here are – individual soul and Supreme Soul (Lord Almighty). With these two meanings, the phrase ‘*atmanam akartaram*’ can be interpreted as follows - Ones who are considered truly knowledgeable are aware that -

(i) the Lord who activates the individual beings to perform their activities is Himself not activated by anyone else (*akartaram*)

(ii) living beings cannot perform any activities independently (*akartaram*)

This important verse is identified by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS as comprising the core concepts in this chapter.

ॐ X᳚ ^VnW½^᳚d ᳚ EH\$ñW ᳚ Zní`{V ᳚ &
VV Ed M {dñV᳚ma ~÷ gānÚV VX᳚ ᳚ && 31 &&

One who realizes that multitudes of different living beings exist inside, and are created by, the same Lord, is deemed to be on the right path to reach the Lord’s abode. (13.31)

Comments: The Lord not only activates all living beings, He is also the supporter of multitudes of living beings and in that sense, they are said to exist inside Him. Sri Rayaru explains in GV that the use of the qualifier ‘*pritak*’ (different) when describing various living organisms (*bhootanam*), refers to the varying nature of individual souls (*jiva-jiva bheda*) which is one of the essential features of the *pancha bheda* (the fivefold differences) principle. This will be explained at the end of this chapter.

AZ᳚{XĒd᳚{pJUĒd᳚V na ᳚mĒ ᳚m@`_ī``... ᳚ &
earañW᳚m@{᳚n H\$᳚YV` Z H\$᳚am{V Z {b᳚᳚`V ᳚ && 32 &&

He is imperishable. Hence the Lord, even though existing inside an individual will not be impacted by the defects of that individual. The activities of individuals do not taint the Lord. (13.32)

Summary: The previous verse alluded to the differences amongst individual souls and between individual souls and the Lord. This verse purports to answer many questions that may arise from superficial interpretations in scriptures that seem to indicate identity among individual souls and the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV quotes Sri Madhwacharya's GTN and advances five arguments to illustrate the difference between individual souls and the Lord.

1. This verse uses the word '*shareerastha*' to refer to individual souls who have physical bodies comprised of the elements of nature and are subject to birth. The Lord is referred to as '*anadi*' (birthless). This concept was described in 10.3.
2. Individual souls are influenced by the three qualities of nature (*guna*) as indicated in verses 13.20 to 13.22. The Lord is referred to as '*nirguna*' (the one beyond the three qualities of nature). This concept is discussed in 7.13 and 14.19.
3. This verse uses the word '*shareerastha*' to refer to individual souls who have physical bodies comprised of the elements of nature and hence are subject to decay and death. The Lord is referred to as '*avyaya*' (imperishable). This concept was discussed previously in 2.17.
4. The Lord independently causes the activities of individual souls who by themselves cannot perform any activity. The Lord's activities are not with any expectations as indicated by the phrase '*na karoti*'. The Lord has no obligation to perform any activities. This concept was indicated in 3.22.
5. Even though the Lord is the cause of activities in everyone, He Himself is not tainted by the actions of individual souls as indicated

by the phrase ‘*na lipyate*’. This was also indicated in verses 4.14, 9.9 and 13.30.

`Wm gdJV gmúâ`mX AmH\$me Zmn{bß`V ĩ&
gdİmdpřWVm Xh VWm@@Ě_m Zmn{bß`V && 33 &&

Just as space that pervades everywhere and touches everything is not tainted by anything, the Lord likewise is pervading everywhere and in everyone, but is never tainted. (13.33)

Comments: This verse provides an example to illustrate the concept of the Lord not getting tainted by anyone’s activities which was addressed in the previous verse. Space exists everywhere, in the minutest of objects and outside in the entire universe. However, it does not take on the attributes of those objects. Likewise, the Lord who resides in every being is not impacted by the attributes and activities of these beings. A similar example was employed previously in verse 9.6.

`Wm àH\$me`Ě`H\$... H\$ĚñZ bmH\$[_ a{d... ĩ&
j ĩ j ĩr VWm H\$ĚñZ àH\$me`{V ^maV ĩ&& 34 &&

O Bharata! Just as a single Sun illuminates this entire world, the Lord who is omniscient illuminates the entire universe. (13.34)

Comments: This verse uses the example of the Sun to demonstrate the Lord’s infinite energy and radiance. There is only one Sun that illuminates our entire world, and likewise there is only one Lord Almighty who illuminates, powers, and activates the entire universe and its inhabitants.

The Fivefold Difference

j ĩ j ĩk`mad_ AÝVa kmZM j fm ĩ&
^VàH\$[V_m j M` {dX`mpÝV V na_ ĩ&& 35 ĩ&&

One who can, through the eyes of knowledge, clearly understand the difference between the field of activity, the knower of the field of activity and the method to achieve liberation from nature's bondage, will surely attain the Lord's abode. (13.35)

Comments: The Lord concludes His teachings in this chapter by summarizing that one, who by following the methods in 13.8 to 13.12 can attain proper knowledge about the field of activity and the knower of activity, and the differences between them will indeed attain the Lord whose special attributes and differences from individual souls and inert objects were identified in various verses such as 13.32 to 13.34. This verse uses the term *antaram* (difference) to indicate the difference between *kshetra* (living beings and nature) and the *kshetrajna* (the Lord Almighty).

The relationship between the three entities in the universe, namely individual souls, inert nature, and the Lord Almighty described in this chapter can be viewed as an explanation for the concept of fivefold differences (*pancha bheda*), which is one of the foundational principles of the philosophy of Sri Madhwacharya. The fivefold differences among – (i) inert objects, (ii) among individual souls, (iii) between individual souls and inert objects, (iv) between the Lord and individual souls, and (v) between the Lord and inert objects. Verses 13.6 and 13.7 enumerated the different components of nature that impact an individual's personality. These indicated the differences among the inert components of nature. Verse 13.22 indicates that individual souls experience different types of births based on their interaction with the qualities of nature, and verse 13.31 refers to different living beings and hence they describe the difference that exists between individual souls. Verses 13.20 and 13.21 describe the impact of inert nature on living beings, highlighting the difference between individual souls and inert objects. Verse 13.19 indicates the difference between inert nature and the Lord Almighty and verse 13.34 clarifies the difference between the individual soul and the Lord Almighty.

Summary of Chapter 13

As indicated in the introductory chapter, Sri Rayaru in GV has provided an excellent categorization of the 18 chapters of Gita by dividing them into 3 groups of 6 chapters each. The last six chapters (13 – 18) provide details on some of the important concepts covered in the previous chapters. In chapter 2, verses 2-12 onwards, the attributes of individual souls were described. In chapters 10, 11, 12 etc., the Lord's forms, attributes and greatness were discussed. In verse 7.4, the attributes of eightfold inert nature were discussed. Arjuna now wants to understand more about the interrelationships among the three entities – the Lord, individual souls, and inert nature. This chapter provides clarification on this topic and forms the philosophical basis for the principle of fivefold differences. In verse 13.1, Arjuna requests details on the following six topics – *prakruti* (inert nature) and *purusha* (individual soul), *kshetra* (field of activity) and *kshetrajna* (one who fully knows about *kshetra*), *jnana* (procedure to obtain knowledge) and *jneya* (the one who is to be known). In verses 13.2 to 13.7, the Lord provides details on *kshetra* and *kshetrajna* and verses 13.8 to 13.19 cover the topics of *jnana* and *jneya*. Verses 13.20 to 13.24 are related to *prakruti* and *purusha*. The remaining verses describe the interaction and interrelationships between these entities. The relationship among the three entities in the universe, namely the individual souls, inert nature that the Lord described in this chapter can be viewed as an explanation for the concept of fivefold differences (*pancha bheda*) which is one of the foundational principles of the philosophy of Sri Madhwacharya.

&& B{V İ`mXe@Ü`m`... &&

End of Chapter 13

MVXe@Ü`m`... - JUÌ`{d^mJ`mJ...

Chapter 14 - Division of Qualities

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 27 verses is termed *Gunatraya Vibhaga Yoga* (Division of Qualities). This chapter has details on the three qualities of nature (*sattv* – pious, *rajas* – passion, *tamas* – ignorance) which define one's personality. These concepts were introduced in chapter 3 (3.5) and are expanded here. The creation of the universe through sentient Mother Nature is described. The ways in which the three qualities bind a person are also explained. The method to escape from the clutches of the three qualities are described. The previous chapter had a discussion on the interactions between inert nature, the individual soul, and the Lord. Verse 13.22 indicates the impact of the three qualities of nature on living beings. Activities of living beings are influenced by the three qualities of nature and such activities entangle them. This chapter provides details on the three qualities of nature in terms of their origin, influence, impact and more importantly, the method to overcome them.

Ir^JdZdM Y&

na ^`... àdú`m{ kmZmZm kmZ_îm__ Y&

`ÁkmEdm\_Z`... gd nam {g{Ö{Vm JVm... Y&& 1 Y&&

BX kmZ_nm{ IË`\_\_ gYâ`_mJVm... Y&

gJ@{n ZmnOm`YV àb`Z ì`WpYV M Y&& 2 Y&&

The Lord said: O Arjuna! There is one more important principle which I will teach you now. Great sages have attained liberation by understanding this concept. (14.1)

One who realizes this knowledge will attain My abode and will not be reborn during the next cycle of creation. Also, they will not suffer during the next cycle of dissolution. (14.2)

Comments: For one to get freed from bondage and achieve liberation, it is important to understand the ways that one gets influenced by the three qualities of nature. The Lord had resolved to impart such knowledge to Arjuna in verse 2.39 and expanded on the concepts introduced in verse 3.5. In verse 14.1, the Lord states that seekers who understood this concept previously had attained liberation, and hence it is a proven path. In verse 14.2, the Lord states the rewards for those who attain this knowledge during their spiritual journey. Such seekers will attain *moksha*, which is identified as the state where one does not suffer from worldly miseries that impact living beings who are subject to repeated births and deaths. In that sense, the state of *moksha* is identified as ‘*sadharmya*’ (in an extremely limited sense, somewhat like the state of the Lord who is never subject to any miseries).

Origin of the Three Qualities

___`m{Z\_hx÷ Vpñ\_Z J^ XYmā`h_`!&
gā^d...gd^VnZm VVn ^d{V ^maV !&& 3 &&

gd`m{Zf H\$mYV`_V`... gā^dpYV`m... !&
Vmgm ~÷ _hÚm{Zah ~rOàX... {nVm !&& 4 !&&

O Bharata! Mother Nature (Goddess Mahalakshmi) is My consort, in whose womb I place the embryo, from which the process of creation of all beings starts. (14.3)

O Son of Kunti! For all living beings born in various species, Mother Nature is the mother, and I am the father planting the seeds. (14.4)

Comments: In these two verses, the Lord describes the process of creation of living beings which is due to the interaction of the Lord with His consort, Goddess Mahalakshmi who is the governing deity of nature. This aspect was briefly described previously in verse 13.27. Inert nature and its components were previously identified in verse 7.4. Sri Rayaru in

[GV] clarifies that the interaction described in this verse applies to every cycle of creation of the universe. Further, this applies to all categories of living beings such as deities (angels), humans, and demons.

Entanglement by the Three Qualities

gîd aOñV_ B{V JU... àH\$Vgâ^dm... Ý&
{Z~ÜZpV _hm~mhm Xh X{hZ_ì``_ Ý&& 5 &&

O Arjuna, Mighty Armed One! The three attributes, namely virtue (*sattva*), passion (*rajas*) and ignorance (*tamas*) are born out of insentient nature. These attributes tightly bind individual souls which intrinsically do not perish (the governing deities for these three attributes are Sridevi, Bhodevi and Durgadevi which are forms of Goddess Mahalakshmi). (14.5)

Comments: After describing the interaction between the Lord Almighty and His consort, Goddess Mahalakshmi in the previous verse, this verse outlines the process by which the three qualities of nature bind an individual soul. Goddess Mahalakshmi, in her three forms of Sri, Bhoo, and Durga governs the three qualities, namely virtue (*sattva*), passion (*rajas*) and ignorance (*tamas*), respectively. In general, all living creatures are entangled by these three qualities. Specifically, Goddess Sridevi binds deities (angels), Goddess Bhodevi binds humans, and Goddess Durgadevi binds demons. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that souls who are in *moksha* after liberation are not entangled by these qualities. The binding applies only to beings who are not yet liberated. This is implied using the word *dehina* (those with physical bodies). Liberated souls do not have physical bodies.

Vì gîd {Z_bEdmV àH\$mEH\$_Zm`_ Ý&
g l g“Z ~ÜZmV kZg“Z MmZK Ý&& 6 &&

aOm amJmĒ_H\$ {d{Ō VîUmġ“g_Ød_ ĩ&
V{ýZ~ÜZm{V H\$mýV` H\$_g“Z X{hZ_ ĩ&& 7 &&

V_ñĒdkmZO {d{Ō _mhZ gdX{hZm_ ĩ&
à_mXmbñ`{ZÐm{^ñV{p~ÜZm{V ^maV ĩ&& 8 &&

O Anagha (Arjuna, One without sins)! The quality of *sattva* is pure and hence is ideal for acquiring spiritual knowledge. It removes defects and diseases. It helps connect one with pure knowledge and bliss. (14.6)

O Son of Kunti! The quality of *rajas* creates obsession and attachment. It causes the feelings of desire and expectations with respect to pursuing objects of sense pleasure. It binds one with passion (sensory pursuits). (14.7)

O Bharata! The quality of *tamas* is responsible for covering one with ignorance. It can create delusion in everyone. It is responsible for forgetfulness, lethargy, and excessive sleep. (14.8)

Comments: These three verses describe the impact of the entanglement of the three qualities (*sattva*, *rajas*, *tamas*) on deities, humans, and demons, respectively. It must be noted that even deities who are destined for liberation will be bound by the quality of *sattva* till they achieve divine, spiritual knowledge and attain liberation through the grace of the Lord.

Predominance of the Three Qualities

gîd g I | gO`{V aO... H\$_{U ^maV ĩ&
kmZ_mdĒ` V V\_... à\_mX gO`Ē`V ĩ&& 9 ĩ&&

aOñV_ü{^^` gîd ^d{V ^maV ĩ&
aO... gîd V_ü d V_... gîd aOñVWm ĩ&& 10 &&

The quality of *sattva* leads one to joyful activities. *Rajas* leads one to endless sensory pursuits. *Tamas* leads one to ignorance, obscuring proper knowledge, and leads a person astray. (14.9)

O Bharata! When the proportion of *sattva* in an individual exceeds that of *rajas* and *tamas*, it then dominates over the other two. Similarly, *rajas* and *tamas* will dominate when they are in higher proportion. (14.10)

Comments: After entangling living beings as described in previous verses, the three qualities influence their character and hence their activities. While the three qualities themselves are inert entities, it is their respective governing deities which are responsible for influencing living beings. How do these three qualities influence one who is entangled by all three of them? Verse 14.10 states the three qualities typically will not be present in equal proportions, and the one which is in higher proportion will have the predominant influence.

Impact of the Three Qualities

gdÛmaf Xh@pñ_Z àH\$me CnOm`V ĩ&
kñZ `Xm Vxm {dÚm{ÛdÕ gîd{Ē`V ĩ&& 11 &&

bñ^... àd{Îmamaâ^... H\$_Um_ Ae_... ñnhm ĩ&
aOñ`Vm{Z Om`ÝV {ddÕ ^aVf^ ĩ&& 12 &&

AàH\$men@àd{Îmü à_mXm _mh Ed M &
V_ñ`Vm{Z Om`ÝV {ddÕ H\$éZÝXZ ĩ&& 13 &&

Whenever the light of knowledge emanates from every part and every sense organ of a person, that person is said to have dominant *sattva* qualities. (14.11)

O Superior Among the Bharatas! Greed, indulging in unnecessary activities, restlessness, insatiable desires are all traits of one with the dominant quality of *rajas*. (14.12)

O Scion of the Kuru Dynasty! Delusion, lethargy, laziness, forgetfulness, and ignorance are all visible in a person with a dominant *tamas* quality. (14.13)

Comments: These three verses describe the traits of individuals who are influenced by the respective dominant qualities of the three qualities of nature.

Result of the Three Qualities on Rebirth

`Xm gÎd àdÕ V àb` | `m{V Xh^V Ý&
VXmÎm_{dXm b mH\$mZ A_bmZ à{VnÚV Ý&& 14 &&

aO{g àb` JĚdm H\$\_g{“ f Om`V Ý&
VWm àbrZñV_{g _T` m{Zf Om`V Ý&& 15 &&

When one with dominant *sattva* qualities leaves this world, that person will eventually be reborn in a well-respected family, in an environment conducive to spiritual learning. (14.14)

When one with dominant *rajas* qualities leaves this world, rebirth will be in an environment of actions and pursuits in search of outcomes. One with dominant *tamas* qualities, after leaving this world, will be born in a demoniac environment. (14.15)

Comments: These verses describe the type of families in which an individual will be reborn, based on the activities performed, which are in turn influenced by the three qualities of nature.

H\$_U... gH\$Vñ`mh... gmpîdH\$ {Z_b \b_ |&
aOgñV \b X... I_kmZ V_g... \b_ |&& 16 &&

Actions performed with a dominant *sattva* quality lead to pure and pious outcomes. *Rajasic* activities lead to a mixture of happiness and distress. *Tamasic* activities lead to ignorance and darkness. (14.16)

Comments: This verse describes the resulting outcome of activities performed by living beings, based on their innate nature which is influenced by the three qualities.

gîdmV gOm`V kmZ aOgm bm^ Ed M |&
à_mX_mhm V_gm ^dVm@kmZ_d M |&& 17 &&

The quality of *sattva* results in pure knowledge. *Rajas* creates aspiration for riches. *Tamas* creates forgetfulness and ignorance. (14.17)

Comments: In addition to the influence on attitudes and activities of individuals, the three qualities also impact their intellect. Those with dominant *sattvic* activities are drawn towards spiritual studies and acquire divine knowledge. Those with dominant *rajasic* qualities have their mind and intellect focused on acquiring worldly riches. Ones with dominant *tamasic* qualities indulge in sinful activities out of ignorance and false knowledge.

Qualities and Ultimate Destinations

D\$Üd JÀNpýV gîdñWm _Ü` | {VðpýV anOgm... |&
OKÝ` JUd{îmñWm AYm JÀNpýV Vm_gm... |&& 18 &&

Those with *sattvic* qualities eventually reach the higher, divine worlds. Those indulging in *rajasic* activities will reach temporary heavenly worlds, only to be reborn in this world. *Tamasic* activities lead to downfall into lower worlds such as hell. (14.18)

Comments: The three qualities lead living beings to three different types of awareness and knowledge which cause them to indulge in differing activities. These actions eventually lead them to three different destinations.

The Lord is Beyond the Three Qualities

ZmÝ` JUä`... H\$Vma`Xm Đïm@ZnÍ`{V Ý&
JUä`ü na d{Îm _Ønd gm@{YJÀN{V Ý&& 19 Ý&&

One who realizes that all activities are influenced only by a combination of these three qualities born out of insentient nature, and that the independent Lord Almighty is beyond these attributes, will attain My abode. (14.19)

Comments: In verse 3.5, it was stated that living beings perform activities based on the influence of the qualities of nature. In this chapter, the origin, influence, and impact of the three qualities of nature on living beings were described in detail. This verse clarifies that these qualities themselves are not supreme, and that the Lord is their controller. The Lord is beyond these three qualities, and they act under His control and supervision. This verse also clarifies the difference (*bheda*) between the Lord Almighty and inert nature represented by the three qualities.

JUmZ EVmZ AVrË` ÌrZ Xhr Xhg_ØdmZ Ý&
OÝ__Ë`OamX... I {d_°\$m@_V_íZV Ý&& 20 Ý&&

One who can reach beyond the three qualities created by nature will be able to overcome birth, death, old age, and misery, and achieve liberation. (14.20)

Comments: After having described the influence and impact of the three qualities of nature, the Lord says that one should strive to avoid getting entangled by them. This will help one achieve liberation.

The quality of *sattv* (piety) is pure and influences one to pursue spiritual studies which enables one to traverse on the right path. Why then should one try to reach beyond even the quality of *sattv*? Sri Vidyamanya Teertha in GPM clarifies that some who attain spiritual knowledge can develop arrogance and pride due to their achievements. One should avoid getting trapped in arrogance and pride.

Methods to Overcome the Three Qualities

AOZ CdmM V&

H\${b“ ÓrZ JUmZ EVmZ AVrVm ^d{V à^m V&

{H\$_mMma... H\$W MVmÓrZ JUmZ{VdV V&& 21 &&

Arjuna said: O Prabhu! What are the traits of people who have crossed these three qualities? How do they act? How are they able to cross the three qualities? (14.21)

Comments: After listening to the Lord’s sermon on the origin, influence, and impact of the three qualities of nature on living beings and the need for one to reach beyond these qualities (verse 14.20), Arjuna is naturally curious to learn about the abilities and attributes of such seekers. Arjuna had previously asked a similar question about the abilities of those with mental equanimity (*stita prajna*) in 2.54.

I r^Jd mZd m M Ĩ &
 àH\$me M àdqîm M _mh_d M nmÊSd Ĩ &
 Z Ū{ĩ} gādîm{Z Z {Zdîm{Z H\$m-ŷV Ĩ&& 22 Ĩ&&

The Lord said: O Son of Pandu! One who has transcended the three qualities of nature (*gunas*) neither abhors the light of knowledge, activity, and delusion when they occur, nor craves for them when they cease, OR, On worldly issues, such people do not despise knowledge (due to *sattva*), activity (due to *rajas*) or ignorance (due to *tamas*). But on the issue of the Lord's attributes, they crave for knowledge (due to *sattv*) and activity (due to *rajas*) and abhor delusion (due to *tamas*). (14.22)

Comments: The Lord responds to Arjuna's questions about the traits of those who overcome the influence of the three qualities in the following four verses 14.22 to 14.25. Many of the abilities and attributes stated here have been previously described in verses 2.55 to 2.59, 5.18 to 5.20, 6.7 to 6.9, 12.13 to 12.30, 13.8 to 13.12 etc., while enumerating the characteristics of seekers who are on the right spiritual path. The abilities and attributes described in these verses must be viewed in the context of one's relationship with the three qualities of nature. Sri Rayaru in GV provides the inner meanings of these verses based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB and GTN.

The three qualities of nature exist in two modes – gross and subtle. The gross aspect of the three qualities of *sattv*, *rajas* and *tamas* leads one to indulge in the respective pursuits of spiritual knowledge, sensory pleasure and harmful lethargy. The subtle aspects of these three qualities result in one displaying keen interest (due to *sattv*), some interest (due to *rajas*), and disdain (due to *tamas*) respectively in learning about the Lord's auspicious attributes. One who has conquered the three qualities of nature does not treat with contempt the outcomes of activities related to worldly matters. However, with regard to learning about the Lord's attributes, such a person

desires the impact of subtle aspects of *sattv* and *rajas* and abhors the impact of *tamas*.

Sri Rayaru in GV provides another meaning for this verse: One who has conquered the three qualities of nature does not envy those who have attained divine, spiritual knowledge due to *sattv* and does not wish for the return of lost ignorant knowledge.

CXmgrZdXmgrZm JU`m Z {dMmë`V ĩ&
JUm dVÍV BË`d `m@d{Vð{V Z“V ĩ&& 23 &&

g_X I g I ... ñdñW... g_bmĩmí_H\$m#mZ... ĩ&
Vë`{à`m{à`m YrañVë`{ZÝXmË_gñV{V... ĩ&& 24 &&

_mZmn_mZ`mñVë`ñVë`m {\_Ìm[an j`m... ĩ&
gdmaâ^ñ[aË`mJr JUmVrV... g CÀ`V ĩ&& 25 &&

They appear to be detached towards most activities even while indulging in prescribed activities undertaken only to please The Lord. They are convinced that natural qualities act as per the wishes of the Lord and cannot act independently. They do not indulge in useless pursuits. (14.23)

They treat worldly happiness and distress with equanimity. They look at a piece of gold and a lump of mud the same way. The pleasant and the unpleasant, and praise and insult, are the same to them. (14.24)

For such people honour and dishonour, friends, and foes, are the same. They do not indulge in any worthless activities and focus only on those activities that please the Lord. They are the ones who have crossed the three qualities. (14.25)

Comments: After having described the attributes of those who have crossed the three qualities of nature, the Lord describes their attitudes in

performance of activities that please the Lord. They appear dispassionate and indifferent in performing any activity, but they are quietly performing activities that please Lord Vishnu. (The word *udaseenavat* mean ‘appear indifferent’ due to the use of the qualifier *vat*). They will not stop *vaishnavic* activities even if they ever come under the influence of the three qualities, as they are aware that these qualities do not act independently but are under the control of the Lord.

Likewise, they do not stop propitiating the Lord if they do not see any worldly gains. Similarly, they do not stop engaging in activities dear to the Lord even if some in society consider those activities as unnecessary or undesirable. They are also not impacted by the views of their friends or foes in matters related to propitiating the Lord. In other words, they are steadfast in their devotion to the Lord.

Rewards for Overcoming the Qualities of Nature

ॐ M `m@i`{^MmaU ^{°\$`mJZ gdV ¥&
g JUmZ g_VrĒ`VnZ ~÷^`m` H\$ënV ¥&& 26 &&

One who worships Me with pure, unalloyed devotion will indeed be able to reach beyond the three qualities and attain the abode of Mother Nature - Goddess Mahalakshmi (which is also My abode). (14.26)

Comments: The previous verses describe the characteristics of one who can reach beyond the three qualities of nature. How can a seeker attain such superior characteristics? The Lord states that unalloyed devotion to Him is the surest way for one to reach this state. Such a seeker will be freed from the bondage imposed by sentient nature and will reach the abode of Goddess Mahalakshmi who is the governing deity of nature. As Goddess Mahalakshmi entangles one with the three qualities of nature, one must first please her to get liberated from bondage. As indicated previously (verse 12.6), one must always propitiate Goddess Lakshmi together with her consort, the Lord Almighty.

Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS has identified this verse as a summary of this entire chapter. This verse makes a reference to the three qualities of nature which bind a living being, and states that pure devotion to the Lord is the way to overcome such entanglement. Hence, it is indeed apt to consider this verse as a summary of this entire chapter.

~÷Uṁ {h à{Vđm@h_ A_Vñ`mì``ñ` M ṽ&
eṁceVñ` M Y\_ñ` g I ñ`H\$mpYVH\$ñ` M ṽ&& 27 &&

I am the refuge for eternal sentient nature (Goddess Mahalakshmi) and for liberated souls. It is well known (from scriptures) that I am the abode for eternal righteousness (*dharma*) and pure bliss (*moksha*). (14.27)

Comments: The previous verse states that a devotee who has crossed the three qualities of nature, will reach the abode of Goddess Mahalakshmi, which is also the abode of the Lord. A seeker who is on the spiritual path will first reach the abode of Goddess Lakshmi and with Her grace will be liberated in the abode of Lord Almighty. This is the state where the liberated souls will experience unending, uncorrupted bliss.

Summary of Chapter 14

As indicated in the introductory section, the third set of chapters (from Chapter 13 to 18), provide more details on specific concepts discussed in the earlier sets of chapters. The previous chapter had a discussion on the interaction between inert nature, the individual soul, and the Lord, and indicated the impact of the three qualities of nature, namely *sattv* (piety), *rajas* (passion), and *tamas* (ignorance) on living beings. Activities of living beings are influenced by the three qualities of nature and such activities entangle them. For one to get freed from bondage and achieve liberation, it is important to understand the way that one gets influenced by the three qualities of nature. This chapter provides details on the three qualities of nature in terms of their origin (verses 14.3-14.4),

entanglement (verses 14.5 –14.8), impact and result (verses 14.11-14.18). Verse 14.19 clarifies that the Lord Almighty controls the three qualities of nature and is beyond their reach. The Lord also states in 14.21 that a seeker should strive to traverse beyond these three qualities to achieve liberation. In verses 14.22 to 14.27, the Lord enumerates the traits of those who escape entanglement by these three qualities and eventually reach His abode.

&& B{V MVXe@Ü`m`... &&

End of Chapter 14

n#Xe@Ü`m`... - néfÎm_`mJ...

Chapter 15 – Theology of The Supreme Being

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 20 verses is known as *Purushottama Yoga* (Theology of The Supreme Being). This chapter is principally concerned with the establishment of the principle of the Lord Almighty's supremacy and hence is termed *Purushottama Yoga* where *uttama* means Supreme and *purusha* means Being. This chapter is considered by many to have the core teachings of the entire **Gita**. The **Gita** has 700 verses spread over 18 chapters. Chapter 15 which has 20 verses, interestingly has 700 letters (15 verses have 32 letters each and the remaining 5 verses have 44 letters each)! This gives credence to the argument of this chapter's importance based on numerology. While the Lord had previously described the components of the universe such as living beings, inert objects, and the Lord, in this chapter, He illustrates the interrelations among them using the example of a banyan tree. The Lord had indicated His presence in living beings previously, especially within their hearts in verses 9.4, 10.20, and 13.18. This chapter provides more details on the aspects of His presence in living beings. Further, in the previous chapter 13.24, it was stated that a seeker who understands the relationship between the Lord (*purusha*) and nature will eventually achieve liberation. This chapter provides more details on the attributes of the Lord (*purusha*). In verse 15, the Lord explicitly states His presence in everyone and declares that He is the primary subject matter of the **Vedas**. In verses 16 to 20, the Lord emphatically describes Himself as the Supreme Being, different from all other beings, thereby convincingly establishing the philosophy of dualism (*dvaita*) which was popularized by Sri Madhwacharya and other seers in his lineage such as Sri Jaya Teertha and Sri Raghavendra Teertha.

The Tree of the Universe

Ir^JdZdM Y&
 D\$Üd_b_Y...eI _ AídEW àmhaì` ` _ Y&
 NÝXm{g `ñ` nUm{Z `ñV dX g dX{dV Y&& 1 &&

The Lord said: The eternal banyan tree of the Universe is characterized by the following - The Lord is like the earth that supports the tree, Mother nature is the root of the tree. The 8 principles of nature are the branches of the tree. The tree is eternally transforming like a running stream. The **Vedas** are the leaves of this tree. One who knows these, knows the **Vedas**.

Comments: This enigmatic verse describes the universe using the example of a banyan tree. One must carefully analyze each word to understand the inner meanings in this verse. Sri Rayaru in his GV based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB and GTN provides an excellent interpretation for this verse using the word derivation approach of Sanskrit.

Firstly, the word '*oordhwa*' is derived from '*uttamatvaat*' and means 'one that is superior'. Further, in the **Vedas**, Lord Vishnu is described as '*oordhwa*', hence it refers to Lord Almighty Vishnu. Thus, Lord Vishnu is the foundational component for the tree and hence represents the earth that supports the tree. Sentient nature and its three qualities are governed by the Lord's consort Mahalakshmi who is superior to all other entities in the universe and hence represents the three roots of this Tree of the Universe. The word '*adha*' means inferior and represents the 8 principles of nature (the 5 elements of physical nature and the principles of *mahat* - consciousness, *ahankara* - individuation, and *buddhi* - intellect). These 8 principles and their governing deities are like the branches of this Tree of the Universe. The tree is termed *ashwattha* (continuously transforming) and *avyaya* (eternal). The word '*ashwattha*' can be derived in two ways. (i) *a* + *shwa* + *ttha*, where *shwa* means 'tomorrow' *a* + *shwa* means 'not

tomorrow'. Hence this word means that the state of the tree tomorrow is not the same as it is today, which implies that the Universe is continuously transforming. This is compared to a stream of running water, where water is eternally running as a stream, but the content of water at any place at any time is not the same as it is in a previous instant. (ii) *ashwattha* is derived from the word '*ashwa*' which means 'horse'. A horse is constantly in motion and does not stay still. Similarly, the universe is continuously in motion. It should also be noted that previously in chapter 10 (10.26), the Lord had stated that among all trees, He has a special presence in '*ashwattha*' (the banyan tree). The **Vedas** are like leaves of this tree. Just as the leaves bloom and give rise to flowers and fruits, seekers who learn the **Vedas** will earn the fruits such as worldly riches and ultimately, *moksha* (the Lord's abode).

AYümÜd àgVññVñ` eñ l m
 JUàdÕm {df` àdmbm... Ý&
 AYü _bmÝ`ZgÝVñZ
 H\$_mZ~ÝYr{Z _Zî`bmH\$_Ý&& 2 &&

The branches of this Tree of the Universe are nourished by the three qualities of nature and extend both above and below. The sprouts represent the objects of sensory perception. The roots represent the Lord, sentient nature, and inert nature. Nature along with its three qualities of *sattv*, *rajas*, and *tamas* entangles living beings. Just like the roots of a tree are responsible for the fruits grown, the rewards based on actions in this world are due to the Lord, sentient nature and the three qualities represented by the roots. (15.2)

Comments: This verse continues the description of the Tree of the Universe and is even more enigmatic than the previous verse. In the previous chapter (14.5), it was stated that Goddess Mahalakshmi in her three forms of Sri, Bhoo, and Durga controls the '*gunas*', the three qualities of nature (*sattv*, *rajas*, *tamas*). This verse states that the five basic elements of nature and the three principles represented by the branches of this tree

are influenced by the three qualities of nature (*gunas*). Hence, the roots which represent sentient and inert nature are superior to the branches which represent the elements of nature and the three principles (*mahat, ahankara, buddhi*). The three qualities of nature (*sattv, rajas, tamas*) are like new roots. The three principles and the five basic elements of nature present in a living being are responsible for the objects of sensory perception which are pursued by living beings. This was described previously in verses 14.11 – 14.13. These objects of sensory pursuits are represented by the sprouts which emanate from the branches of the tree. The sprouts have temporary existence just like the experience of sensory pleasures by living beings.

Sri Rayaru in GV states that the above interpretation of the components of the Tree of the Universe is based on the description in the *Bhallava* branch of the **Vedas** which states that the Lord who supports the Tree of the Universe is not part of the tree but is distinct from it. The components of the banyan tree (and their governing deities) in these two verses can now be summarized as follows:

Earth (supporting the tree) = The Lord Almighty
 Roots = Sentient and inert nature
 New roots = The three qualities of nature
 Branches = The five basic elements of nature, and the three principles
 Sub-branches = Physical bodies of living beings
 Leaves = The **Vedas**
 Flowers, Fruit = Worldly desires, Liberation

These two verses appear to illustrate the concepts of gradations among various deities described previously in 3.42 with the help of a Banyan tree.

Z ê\$ñ_ñ`h VWmnbä`V
 ZmÝVm Z Mm{XZ M gâà{Võm Ý&
 AœEW_Z g{dê\$T_b‘
 Ag“eóU ÑTZ {NĒdm && 3 Ý&&

This tree is constantly evolving (like a flowing stream) and does not stagnate; hence cannot be seen. It has neither beginning nor end. One should chop this tree with the sharp weapon of firm detachment (as the tree has very strong roots), to separate the hidden roots from other parts of the tree (one should use the strong weapon of devotion and detachment to understand the distinction between the Lord, Nature and the individual souls). (15.3)

Comments: After having described the structure of the Tree of the Universe in previous verses, this verse states the action that a seeker needs to take to progress on the spiritual path. The tree is constantly evolving as new sprouts, leaves, flowers, and fruits bloom and the old ones wither. However, the earth and the strong roots do not wither. Similarly, the entities in the universe such as living beings and inert objects are constantly changing but the Lord and Mother Nature who are represented by the strong, foundational roots of this tree, are not subject to any change and do not perish. This verse clarifies that the Lord who pervades all and is invisible during the beginning and end of the universe (during the time epoch *kalpa*) continues to be invisible during its lifetime. These concepts were previously stated in 9.7 and 9.10. To completely understand the Lord’s greatness, a seeker must chop this tree with a strong, sharp weapon to be able to separate the tree from its foundation and understand its roots. That sharp weapon is described as *asanga* = *a* + *sanga*. This word can be interpreted in two ways – (i) *asanga* = detachment (as *sanga* means attachment) which implies that one should detach oneself from worldly matters, and (ii) *asanga* = involvement in activities pleasing to the Lord, as the letter *a* represents the Lord. This concept is clarified by Sri Prabhanjanacharya in GM.

VV... na VĚn[a_m{JVì`
 `pñ\_Z JVm Z {ZdVpÝV ^` ... Ý&
 V_d MmÚ néf ànÚ
 `V... àd{Īm... àgVm namUr Ý&& 4 Ý&&

Then one should learn more about the Lord through spiritual studies. Those who attain the Lord never return to this world. One should surrender to the Lord Almighty who is the root cause of this universe and all its activities. (15.4)

Comments: In the previous verse it was stated that a seeker should chop the Tree of the Universe with the weapon of detachment and knowledge. This verse describes the procedure to chop the tree. A seeker should learn about the Lord through the process of studies, contemplation, and analysis of scriptures to develop conviction in divine knowledge. Only when one is aware of the distinction between the Lord and other entities in the universe, will one be able to develop firm conviction in divine knowledge. One should surrender to the Lord to escape from the cycle of births and deaths. Only then will one eventually attain the Lord's abode never to return to this world.

{Z_mZ_mhm {OVg“Xmf
 AÜ`mĚ\_{ZĚ`m {d{ZdĪmH\$m_m... Ý&
 ŪÝŪ{d_°\$m... g l X... l gk-
 JÀNÝĚ`\_Tm... nX\_ì` VV Ý&& 5 &&

One who has overcome pride, ignorance, and worldly pleasures, and who is involved in spiritual pursuits, who performs duties with no expectations, and who treats happiness and distress with equanimity, will indeed reach the destination of eternal bliss. (15.5)

Comments: The previous verses stated that a seeker needs to develop detachment in worldly affairs to imbibe divine knowledge. This verse identifies additional characteristics which enables such a seeker to reach the Lord's abode.

The Lord's Presence in Entities

Z VØḡ`V ḡ`ḡ Z eeḡH\$ḡ Z nḡdH\$ḡ ḡ&
 `ÒÈdḡ Z {ZdVḡV VÕḡ_ na_ __ ḡ&& 6 &&

That destination is illuminated neither by the Sun nor by the Moon nor by fire. One who reaches this destination will never return to this world. That destination is My abode. (15.6)

Comments: The Lord describes the characteristics of His abode. The world that we live in is illuminated by the Sun (during daytime), the Moon (during nighttime), and by fire. The Lord's abode is vastly different. The Lord is self-illuminating, and He does not need any external entities to illuminate His abode.

__dḡeḡ OrdbḡH\$ Ord^Vḡ ḡZḡVZḡ ḡ&
 _Zḡ fḡḡZrpÝḡḡ{U àH\$ḡVñWḡ{Z H\$ḡf{V ḡ&& 7 &&

The eternal individual soul inside the physical body of beings is like an infinitesimal fraction of Me (similar in being eternal but distinctly separate in attributes and capabilities). The individual soul directs the six sense organs (including the mind) towards objects of pleasure, propelled by the qualities of nature. (15.7)

Comments: It was stated previously (verse 5.14) that living beings cannot act on their own and their activities are propelled and stimulated by the Lord. This verse states that an infinitesimal fraction of the Lord is present inside the physical bodies of individual souls. This concept was described earlier in verses 9.4, 10.20, 13.18 etc. This fraction of the Lord is

like the individual soul as both are eternal in nature, but this fraction of the Lord is vastly different and superior to all individual souls. This concept is described later in verses 15.16 – 15.20. Sri Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB states that a fraction or *amsha* of the Lord is of two types – (i) *bhinna amsha* (fraction that is different) and (ii) *swaroopa amsha* (intrinsic fraction, as in the case of the Lord's various incarnations). The fraction of the Lord present in living beings is like the individual soul in the sense that a firefly is like the Sun, as both are illuminating objects but are vastly different in attributes and capabilities.

eara `XdmsZm{V `f mß`EH\$m_Vrœa... ý&
JhrEdVm{Z g`m{V dm`JYm{Zdme`mV ý&& 8 &&

At the time a soul enters a body and at the time it leaves, the Lord carries the sense organs (in a subtle form) into and out of the body, just like a gentle, blowing wind carries the fragrance of flowers. (15.8)

Comments: Does an individual soul by itself direct attention towards objects of sense pleasure? This verse is a continuation of the previous verse and states that it is the Lord Almighty resident in living beings who causes pursuit of sense pleasures. The Lord is always present in living beings. When a soul leaves the physical body, the Lord causes the sense organs of perception to travel along with the soul. Sense organs here refer to their subtle form and not the gross organs that one can see in a physical body. The process of the subtle sense organs carried along with a departing soul out of a physical body is compared to a gently blowing wind that carries the fragrance of a flower. No one can see the fragrance being carried by the wind, but one can smell the fragrance. The flower does not lose its fragrance even though the wind carried a part of it. In the **Brahma Sutra** (3-1- 4), it is stated that when a soul leaves the body and the body is consumed by the elements of nature (such as fire), the sense organs also get consumed. How can this be reconciled with the statement that the Lord carries the sense organs along with the soul? Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies by stating that the Lord carries the subtle sense organs (a fraction of the

physical sense organs) as per this verse and the **Brahma Sutra** is referring to the gross sense organs.

*Iṁī Mj ... ñneZ M agZ KmU_d M ṽ&
A{Yðm` \_Züm` {df`mZngdV ṽ&& 9 &&*

The Lord resides in the sense organs: ears, eyes, skin, tongue, nose, and mind, and verily consumes the (righteous) objects of sense pursuits. (15.9)

Comments: It was stated previously in 9.4, 10.20, 13.18 etc., that the Lord resides within the hearts of living beings, stimulating all their activities. In 11.33, the Lord declares to Arjuna that He has already killed Arjuna's enemies and that Arjuna is only an instrument, thereby confirming that it is the Lord who performs all activities. Further, it was stated in 9.24 that the Lord is the consumer of the fruits of all activities. While earlier verses in this chapter such as 15.1, 15.2 described the structure of the Tree of the Universe, in this verse the Lord who is resident in every living being declares that He is the consumer of the objects of sense pursuits. It is clarified in the next verse that the Lord consumes only the righteous/healthy fruits of activities.

This verse is identified by Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS as representing the core concepts of this chapter. This verse establishes the relationship between the Lord Almighty, the individual souls, and inert objects (sense organs of all living beings). It also establishes the supremacy of the Lord (*Purushottama Yoga*), His doership of activities and consumption of righteous fruits of such activities, thereby establishing the independence of the Lord, and the dependency of individual souls and inert objects. While the sense organs of perception are identified here, they are governed by deities whose order of gradation was identified previously in 3.42. Given the breadth of principles covered in this verse, it is apt to recognize this as the core verse for this chapter.

CĚH\$m_ÝV pñWV dñ@{n ^OmZ dñ JUmpÝdV_ | Ý&
 {d_ Tñ ZñZñí`pÝV nÍ`pÝV kñZM j f... Ý&& 10 Ý&&

Fools will not understand the Lord leaving or entering the physical body or consuming righteous fruits from sensory objects. Only learned ones with the eyes of knowledge perceive these concepts. (15.10)

Comments: Living beings experience both happiness and sadness from indulgence in objects of sense pursuits. Since the Lord is the ultimate consumer of fruits of sense pursuits, does He also experience happiness and sadness? This verse states that the Lord only consumes the righteous/healthy fruits from objects of sense perception as clarified in the use of the qualifier ‘*guṇānvitam*’.

`VÝVñ `ñ{JZüZ nÍ`ÝĚ`mĚ_Ý`dpñWV_ | Ý&
 `VÝVñ@ß`H\$VñĚ_mZñ ZZ nÍ`ÝĚ`MVg... Ý&& 11 Ý&&

Enlightened seekers, through their consistent, concentrated efforts can visualize the Lord Almighty residing within them. Fools and unwise ones will never be able to visualize Him. (15.11)

Comments: Seekers who perform prescribed activities with austerity and self-control can realize the presence of the Lord resident in them. They are also convinced that it is the Lord who powers and propels all their activities, and they can visualize the Lord’s presence.

The Lord’s Strength and Greatness

`Xñ{XĚ`JV VOñ OJX ^ñg`V@{ I b_ | Ý&
 `f ÝĐ\_{g `f m¾4ñ VÎñOm {d{Ō _m H\$ _ | Ý&& 12&&

Know that the energy that powers the Sun, the Moon and the fire which illuminate this universe, is indeed Mine. (15.12)

Comments: The next four verses describe the Lord's presence in specific entities. The Sun provides light and energy to the entire world. However, the Sun is only one among millions of stars and all of them are powered by the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV quotes the **Brahma Sutra** (1.3.22) and **Katha Upanishad** (2.5.15) which state that the light and energy in the Sun and the Moon are due to the Lord. It is interesting to note the example of 3 objects, namely, the Sun, the Moon, and fire in this verse. The Sun as a star is an intrinsic source of light and energy. The Moon does not emanate light on its own but reflects the light of the Sun. Fire in materials such as wood and charcoal are not visible, but when one lights them, they emanate energy. So, these three types cover objects whose light and energy are seen and objects whose light and energy are unseen.

Jm_m{dÍ` M ^Vm{Z Yma`mâ`h_mOgm V&
nîUm{ MmfYr... gdm... gm_n ^Edm agmĒ_H\$... V&& 13 &&

I enter this earth and through My strength support all living beings. I also reside in the Moon in the form of nectar to nourish plant life on earth. (15.13)

Comments: It is well known that plant life on earth depends on the Moon for nourishment. This verse states that it is due to the presence of the Lord that the Moon has this special ability.

Ah dœmZam ^Edm àm{UZm Xh_m{IV... V&
àmUmmZg_m`°\$... nMmâ`P MV{dY_ V&& 14 V&&

I reside in the bodies of living beings in the form of Vaishwanara, and along with the incoming and outgoing breaths, I consume and digest the four types of food. (15.14)

Comments: As stated in verse 15.9, the Lord resides in, and powers the activities of all living beings. This verse describes the process of digesting food powered by the Lord Almighty. Living beings consume four

types of food: food that is masticated and then swallowed, food that is swallowed directly, food that is licked, and food in liquid form that is drunk. Every food article that one consumes belongs to one of these categories. The Lord, in the name of Vaishwanara resides in living beings in the form of *jatara agni* (abdominal fire). Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that the deity Mukhya Prana in the forms of *prana* and *apana*, powered by the Lord, helps in the process of food consumption and digestion which includes distribution of energy in food to various parts of the body.

The Supreme Lord Almighty and the Principle of Dualism

gdñ` Mmh ö{X g{Z{d'iṁ
 Îṁ... ñ{VkmZ_nmhZ M ṽ&
 dXü gdah_d dÚṁ
 dXmṽVH\$X dX{dXd Mmh_ṽ&& 15 &&

I reside in the hearts of all living beings. I am responsible for memory, knowledge, and any loss of knowledge. I am the primary purport of the **Vedas**. I am the author of Vedanta. I am the only one who knows all the **Vedas**. (15.15)

Comments: This is one of the most important verses in the **Gita** as it summarizes many of the key teachings related to the attributes and greatness of the Lord. In this verse, the Lord emphatically declares that He is resident in all living beings (within their hearts) and causes them to attain knowledge and lose knowledge. The **Vedas** are scriptural texts that are vocally passed on from one generation to the next. They are not authored by anyone, human or divine. Various passages in the **Vedas** superficially appear to propitiate deities such as Agni (fire), Varuna (water) etc. The Lord clarifies here that the **Vedas** primarily describe Him alone (and describe other deities secondarily). The Lord does not state that He is the author of the **Vedas**, but states that He is the author of Vedanta. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that Vedanta means *vedanaamanto nirnayo* (the definitive summary of the **Vedas**), in other words, the **Brahma Sutras**. This is

consistent with the historical fact that the **Brahma Sutras** were composed by Lord Vedavyasa, who is another form of the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV also quotes the **Bhagavata** (11.21.42), where Lord Krishna teaches Uddhava that He alone knows the **Vedas** fully.

Ôm{d_m nafm bmH\$ jaÜm ja Ed M Ý&
ja... gdm{U ^Vm{Z H\$QñWm@ ja CÀ`V Ý&& 16 &&

There are two types of dependent souls in the Universe, *kshara* and *akshara*. Those individual souls with perishable bodies are known as *kshara* and Goddess Mahalakshmi, the ever liberated and the one without a perishable body is *akshara*. (15.16)

Comments: After having described the Lord's omnipresence, omniscience, infinite strength etc., in previous verses, the next 5 verses categorically describe the supremacy of the Lord. This verse identifies two types of dependent individual souls. Living beings are described as *kshara* as they have perishable physical bodies. Even liberated souls have had perishable bodies previously. The one without a perishable body (*akshara*) is termed *kootastha* which means space (which is eternal). This was stated previously in 2.17. The only dependent, sentient entity in the universe which is eternal and has no perishable body is the Lord's consort Mahalakshmi. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that the masculine form *akshara* to describe Goddess Mahalakshmi is an acceptable usage based on Lakshmi's strength that exceeds that of male deities. This is as per Sri Madhwacharya's commentary on the **Chandogya Upanishat (3.15)**.

CÎm... néfñĒdÝ`... na\_mĒ\_Ē`XmöV... Ý&
`m bmH\$Ì`_m{dí` {~^Ē`ì`` Bœa... Ý&& 17 &&

There is another entity different from and superior to both the *kshara* and the *akshara*. That eternal, imperishable entity which pervades all three worlds and supports and nourishes them is known as *Paramatma* (The Supreme Among Beings). (15.17)

Comments: After having described the two dependent, sentient entities in the universe, namely *kshara* and *akshara*, the Lord declares that there is another entity which is distinct from and superior to both. Sri Vadiraja Teertha in his BGL states that the word ‘*tu*’ which precedes the word ‘*anya*’ (different) indicates that this other entity is quite different from the other two. This entity pervades all three worlds and provides support and nourishment. Even though the three worlds suffer destruction (at the time of the Great Dissolution), the supreme entity continues its existence as indicated with the words ‘*avyaya*’ and ‘*īśvaraḥ*’. Hence it is logical to describe this supreme entity as *Paramatma* (the supreme among all souls). Sri Rayaru in GV quotes the **Shweta Upanishat** (6.13) to support the concepts in this verse.

`ñ_ṁĒj a_VrVm@h_j amX{n MmÎm_... ĩ&
AVm@pñ_ bṁH\$ dX M à{WV... néfñÎm_... ĩ&& 18&&

I (Krishna), am superior to *ksharas* (individual souls) and to even *akshara* (Goddess Mahalakshmi) and hence am known as *Purushottama* (The Supreme One) of all the worlds and am described as such in the scriptures. (15.18)

Comments: Is the Supreme Soul described in previous verse different from Krishna? The Lord answers by confirming that He indeed is the Supreme Soul. This fact is supported by ‘*loka*’, scriptures that are composed, and the ‘**Vedas**’ which are revealed.

The use of the word ‘*api*’ in *akṣarād api* (meaning - even *akshara*) when referring to the Lord’s supremacy over Goddess Mahalakshmi (*akshara*) is interesting. While one can generally understand the Lord’s superiority over all individual souls, this verse states that He is superior to even Goddess Lakshmidēvi (who is worshipped as the Mother of this Universe). This is to further emphasize the principle of the Supreme Being.

`m _m_d_g_Tm OmZm{V néfîm__ ĩ&
g gd{dØO{V _m gd^mdZ ^maV ĩ&& 19 &&

O Bharata! One who considers Me as ‘The Supreme One’ without any doubt indeed knows Me. Hence that person knows everything and constantly worships Me in all ways. (15.19)

Comments: How does a seeker act after learning about the principle of the Supreme Soul? Such a seeker will not fall under the wrong impression that the distinction between the Lord and individual souls is only transactional (*vyavaharika*) and not spiritual (*paramarthika*) (as per Sri Vadiraja Teertha’s BGL). Based on the evidence in the scriptures, such a seeker would develop deep conviction in the concept of duality (difference among supreme soul and the individual souls) and would propitiate the Lord through all the means (vocal, mental, physical).

h{V JøV_ eó‘ BX_°\$ _`m@ZK ĩ&
EVX ~XÜdm ~{Ö_mZ ñ`mV H\$VH\$È`ü ^maV ĩ&& 20 &&

O Anagha (Arjuna, the one without sins)! I have taught you the most confidential spiritual principles. O Bharata! One who knows this is deemed to have acquired the ultimate spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*) and will be liberated. (15.20)

Comments: This chapter started with a couple of enigmatic verses describing the structure of the Tree of the Universe and ended with a clear, unambiguous characterization of the principle of duality. One who clearly understands these confidential principles will attain direct, divine (*aparoksha*) knowledge and will achieve eternal bliss.

These last 5 verses 15.16 – 15.20 unambiguously establish the relationship between the Lord Almighty, individual souls, and the inert universe with the clear conclusion that the Lord Almighty is supreme among and different from all individual souls and inert objects. The term

Purushottama (the supreme personality) is described in these verses and forms the basis for the title of this wonderful chapter - 'Purushottama Yoga'. Sri Madhwacharya quotes these 5 verses extensively in his works such as **Vishnu Tattva Vinirnaya**, **Mayavada Khandana**, **Sadachara Smriti** in addition to his two commentaries on the **Gita**.

Summary of Chapter 15

This chapter of 20 verses and 700 letters is considered by many to be the most important chapter in the entire **Gita**, and the one that summarizes all its 700 verses. This chapter is principally concerned with the establishment of the principle of the Lord Almighty's superiority and hence is termed *Purushottama Yoga* where *uttama* means supreme and *purusha* means the Being. The relationship between the inert universe, individual souls and the Lord Almighty were previously discussed. In this chapter, these fivefold differences are explained with the example of a banyan tree. Verses 15.1 and 15.2 describe the structure of the tree. This description is enigmatic, and one can appreciate the explanation provided by Sri Rayaru in GV to help understand the real meaning of these verses. The correspondence between the components of the tree and the entities in the universe are as follows: Earth (supporting the tree) = The Lord Almighty; Roots = Sentient and inert nature; New roots = The three qualities of nature; Branches = The five basic elements of nature; Sub-branches = Physical bodies of living beings; Leaves = The **Vedas**; Flowers, Fruit = Worldly desires, Liberation. Using the analogy of a banyan tree, these two verses appear to illustrate the concepts of gradations among various deities described previously in 3.42. Verses 15.3 – 15.5 describe the manner in which a seeker needs to approach the concepts in the Tree of the Universe to understand the nature of the Lord. Verses 15.6 to 15.14 describe some specific attributes of the Lord such as omnipresence and omniscience. Verse 15.15 is one of the most famous verses in the **Gita** in which the Lord emphatically declares His presence in the hearts of all living beings and states that He is knowable through the **Vedas**. Verses 15.16 to 15.20 establish the relationship between the Lord Almighty,

individual souls, and the inert universe with the clear conclusion that the Lord Almighty is supreme among and different from all individual souls and inert objects. These verses are distinguished by their clarity and simplicity, which is different from the enigmatic nature of the initial few verses. The term *Purushottama* (the supreme personality) is described in these verses and forms the basis for the title of this wonderful chapter - '*Purushottama Yoga*'.

&& B{V n#mXe@Ü`m`... &&

End of Chapter 15

f mT>e m@Ü` m` ... - X d m g a g a n { Ū ^ m J ` m J ...

Chapter 16 – The Divine and the Demoniac

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 24 verses is known as *Daivasura Sampat Vibhaga Yoga* (Division of the Divine and the Demoniac). This chapter delves deep into types of human nature. In the previous chapters, there were many references to pious, virtuous people with divine nature and to people with demoniac nature. This chapter provides more details on human traits. These traits are intrinsic to an individual. One cannot judge people based on the external appearance, position in society etc. In the previous chapter, verse 15.5 described the methods to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge and liberation. Verse 15.11 described those who can achieve self-realization and those who cannot. These are the characteristics of divine and demoniac natures, respectively. Some of these characteristics were described in verses 9.11 to 9.14 also. This chapter provides more details on the divine and demoniac characteristics which help a seeker to inculcate divine attributes and avoid association with demoniac ones. Hence this chapter is a logical extension to the previous chapter.

Divine Attributes and Conduct

I r ^ J d m Z d m M Ĩ &

A ^ ` g ĩ d g e { Ō k m Z ` m J ï ` d p ñ W { V ... Ĩ &

X m Z X _ ü ` k ü ñ d m Ü ` m ` ñ V n A m O d _ Ĩ && 1 Ĩ &&

A q h g m g Ē ` \_ H \$ m Y ñ Ē ` m J ... e m p Ÿ V a n e Z _ Ĩ &

X ` m ^ V ĩ d b m b Ē d _ m X d ñ r a M m n b _ Ĩ && 2 Ĩ &&

V O ... j _ m Y { V ... e m M _ A ð m h m Z m { V _ m { Z V m Ĩ &

^ d p Ÿ V g a n X X d r _ A { ^ O m V ñ ` ^ m a V Ĩ && 3 Ĩ &&

The Lord Said: Fearlessness, purity in mind, conviction in the path of divine knowledge, charitable nature, self-restraint, involvement in sacrificial activities, pursuance of Vedic study, austerity, uprightness. (16.1)

Non-violent, truthful, devoid of anger, benevolent, faithful (to the Lord Almighty), averse to fault finding, compassionate, devoid of avarice, gentle, modest, determined (to do good deeds). (16.2)

Valour, patience, fortitude, purity (physical and mental), absence of malice and ego. O Bharata! These attributes are observed in those with divine nature. (16.3)

Comments: The Lord identifies 26 divine characteristics in these 3 verses. Fearlessness refers to one who is not only fearless, but also does not cause fear in others. This was indicated earlier in 12.15 as the characteristic of one who is dear to the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV states that one who is desirous of liberation must inculcate these characteristics.

Demoniac Attributes

Xâ^m Xnm@{^_mZü H\$mY... nméî`_d M ¥&
AkñZ Mm{^OmVñ` nmW gånX_mgar_ ¥&& 4 ¥&&

O Partha! The natural attributes of those with demoniac natures are arrogance, pretentious pride, conceit, anger, harshness, and ignorance. (16.4)

Comments: The Lord now identifies some of the characteristics of those with demoniac natures. More details on demoniac nature and conduct are detailed in verses 16.7 to 16.18.

Resultant Destinations

Xdr gān{Ū_m j m` {Z~ŸYm` mgar _Vm Ÿ&
m eM... gānX Xdr A{^OmVm@{g mÊSd Ÿ&& 5 Ÿ&&

O Son of Pandu! Divine nature paves the way for levels of liberation while demoniac nature pushes one to downfall. Do not despair. You possess divine nature. (16.5)

Comments: After identifying the 26 characteristics of those with divine nature, the Lord comforts Arjuna stating that he does not need to despair as he is of divine nature. Arjuna is an incarnation of the deity Indra and has innate angelic characteristics.

Sri Rayaru in GV draws attention to the use of the word *vimokṣā* while referring to liberation. *vimokṣā* is derived as *vividha* + *mokṣā*, meaning different levels of bliss in liberation based on the innate abilities (*yogyata*) and efforts (*sadhana*) of souls.

Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS has identified this verse as representing the core concepts in chapter 16. Given that this chapter is about divine and demoniac character and the fact that this verse identifies the ultimate destination of the divine and the demoniac, it is apt to consider this as the core verse. In addition, in this verse the Lord also reiterates the divine nature of Arjuna.

Ūm ^VgJm bmH\$@pñ_Z Xd Anga Ed M Ÿ&
Xd m {dñVae... àm°\$ Anga nmW _ eU Ÿ&& 6 &&

O Partha! Divine and demoniac are the two natural attributes of living beings. The attributes of divine nature were explained in detail. Now listen to the attributes of demoniac nature. (16.6)

Comments: There are multifaceted personalities in this world. Previously in chapter 9 (verses 9.11 – 9.14), characteristics of different types of people were described. So, how can there be only two characteristics – divine and demoniac? Sri Rayaru states in GV that the discussion in this chapter concerns those with significantly higher proportions of divine and demoniac characteristics.

Demoniac Nature and Conduct

àdqîm M {Zdqîm M OZn Z {dXamgam... Ý&
Z emM Zn{n MmMmam Z gĒ` Vf {dÚV Ý&& 7 &&

Those with demoniac natures do not have knowledge about performing prescribed activities and about avoiding prohibited activities. They are impure in mind and body. They do not have good conduct and are not truthful. (16.7)

Comments: Verse 16.4 identified few major characteristics of demoniac nature. The following 12 verses (16.7 to 16.18) have a detailed description of demoniac nature and resultant conduct.

The Lord uses the word ‘*na*’ thrice in the second line to indicate the absence of each of the three characteristics (namely purity, right conduct, and truthfulness) in demoniac nature instead of grouping them together. Sri Rayaru in GV explains that the reason for individually indicating their absence is to convey the extent of complete absence of each of these three attributes.

AgĒ`_à{Vđ V OJXmhaZrcea_ Ý&
Anañnagâ^V {H\$_Ý`ĒH\$m_hVH\$_ Ý&& 8 &&

They say that the world is unreal and is not dependent on the Lord Almighty. They do not believe in the Supreme entity controlling the universe. They do not believe in the orderly creation of the universe, which they say is a result of lustful co-existence. (16.8)

Comments: Sri Rayaru in GV provides two interpretations for the first line of this verse:

1. The words *satya*, *pratishta*, and *īśvara* all refer to the Lord Almighty who is responsible for the creation and the dissolution, the sustenance, and the regulation of the universe (respectively signified by these three names). Those with demoniac natures do not believe in the supreme entity with the above attributes (signified by the prefix ‘a’ for the above three terms).
2. Those with demoniac natures believe that the universe is unreal, has no creator, and has no controller.

It must be noted that their nonbelief in the orderly creation of the entities in the universe is inconsistent with the cyclic order of creation described by the Lord in verse 3.14.

Author’s Note: The idea that the world is real has been widely discussed in Hindu philosophical circles [OPM]. One school of thought holds the position that the world is neither real nor unreal. Its proponents use an oft quoted example of a seashell and a piece of silver to make the point. Our Acharyas have pointed out the sheer futility of the argument which is based on totally convoluted and irrational thinking. That the world is real is a position seminal to the philosophy of Sri Madhwacharya, and The Bhagavad Gita itself supports this in its every verse.

EVm Ñ{ĩ`\_dĩä` ZĩmĔ_mZm@ën~Õ`... ĩ&
à^dYĔ`JH\$\_mU... j`m` OJVm@{hVm... ĩ&& 9 ĩ&&&

H\$m__m{IĔ` Xĩna Xă^_mZ_XmpYdVm... ĩ&
_mhX JhrĔdm@gOmhmZ àdVĩV@e{MdVm... ĩ&& 10 &&

{M'V_m_n[a_`m M àb`m'V_m_nm{ I V_m... ' &
H\$m_mn^mJna_m EVmd{X{V {Z{ü{V_m... ' && 11 ' &&

AemnmeeV~Ö_m... H\$m_H\$mYnam`U_m... ' &
Bh'V H\$m_^mJmW_ AÝ`m`ZmWg#m`mZ ' && 12 ' &&

Ignorant people with such viewpoints corrupt their minds themselves; they indulge in risky activities and are born to cause destruction of societies. (16.9)

Addicted to insatiable desire, covered with vanity and conceit, they justify their actions based on misinterpretations of scriptures and indulge in pursuit of temporary, worldly pleasures. (16.10)

Such people, immersed in dangerous activities, endlessly pursue gratification of the senses which they consider to be the goal of life. They are convinced that there is no life beyond this world. (16.11)

Imprisoned by multitudes of unfulfilled desires, overcome by lust and anger, they indulge in illegal and unethical means to earn wealth, primarily for physical pleasures. (16.12)

Comments: These four verses describe the actions of those with demoniac natures and the excuses they provide to justify their actions. They do not just act out of impulse, but rather use the basis of misinterpreted scriptures to justify their actions. Verse 16.12 identifies the passions of *kama* (lust) and *krodha* (anger) as the root cause for immoral activities. This was also indicated previously in verse 3.37.

Attitudes of the Demoniac Natured

BX_Ú_`m bãY` B_ àmñ`_ZmaW_ ' &
BX_ñVrX_{n_ ^{dî`{V nZYZ_ ' && 13 ' &&

Agm _`m hV... eìh{Zî` MmnamZ{n ý&
 Bœam@h_h ^mJr {gÕm@h ~bdmZ g l r ý&& 14 ý&&

AṁTçm@{^OZdmZpñ ‘ H\$m@Ýṁm@pñV gÑem _`m ý&
 `ú` Xṁñ`m{ \_m{Xî` BĒ`kṁZ{d_m{hVṁ... ý&& 15ý&

Those with demoniac natures proclaim as follows: I earned this wealth. I will satisfy all my desires. I will continue to gather more wealth. I will destroy my current opponents and emerging ones. I am the Lord. I have achieved everything. I am strong. I am born in a rich and famous family. There is no one equal to me. I will perform ritual sacrifices. I will donate to charity. I will enjoy myself. Such is their extreme arrogance and ignorance. (16.13) (16.14) (16.15)

Comments: These three verses describe the attitudes of those with demoniac natures. These have been identified previously by the Lord as the attributes that a seeker should avoid. The Lord had proclaimed in many verses ((5.14), (5.15), (15.9)) that no one can act on their own and all actions are due to Him. Yet, those with demoniac nature claim ownership of their successes and achievements. In verse 2.18, the Lord clarified that no one could kill someone else (as the soul is indestructible and even the destruction of the physical body is only due to the Lord alone). Yet those with demoniac natures claim that they alone destroy their opponents. In 6.41, it was stated that one’s future births are based on one’s past sincere efforts. Yet, those with demoniac natures boast about their family and lineage. They also make inconsistent claims. While they claim that they are indeed the Lord Himself, they also claim that they perform ritual sacrifices. If they are the Lord themselves, who do they propitiate in their ritual sacrifices? Their ritual and outwardly religious activities are a sham show to project a favourable image of themselves to society.

Destructive Pursuits of the Demoniatic Natured

AZH\$MÎ{d^YV_mhOmbg_mdV_m... Ý&
àg°\$m... H\$m_ ^mJf nVpYV ZaH\$@eMm Ý&& 16 &&

AmĒ_gâ^m{dV_m... ñVãYm YZ_mZ_XmpYdV_m... Ý&
`OYV Zm\_`kñV Xâ^Zm{d{YndH\$_ Ý&& 17 &&

AhH\$ma ~b Xn H\$m_ H\$mY M g{I V_m... Ý&
_m_mĒ_naXhf à{ŪfYV_m@ä`g`H\$m... Ý&& 18 &&

Enveloped by delusion, such people get entangled in endless, distressful pursuits. Imprisoned by ignorance, they get addicted to self-destructive sense gratification and fall into abominable hell. (16.16)

Such people are complacent about themselves, are deluded by vanity, and are arrogant due to their wealth and success. They perform religious rituals without proper procedures in order to show off. (16.17)

They exhibit ego, arrogance, selfishness, lust, and short temper. They insult Me (Krishna), who is resident in them and in all others, purely out of jealousy. (16.18)

Comments: These verses continue the description of demoniac nature. In verse 16.17, it is stated that they are complacent about themselves. This trait is seen in some, who, under the garb of charity donate money for some cause and expect publicity for societal acceptance and recognition. They claim that they perform activities independently and challenge the Lord to make them perform specific activities that they are not interested in.

Destinations for Demoniatic Conduct

VmZh {ÛfV... H\$amZ ggmaf ZamY_mZ Ý&
{jnmâ`Oò\_e^mZ Angarîdd `m{Zf Ý&& 19 &&

Angat `m{Z_mnp_m_Tm OÝ_{Z OÝ_{Z Ý&
_m_àmb`d H\$mÝV` VVm `mÝË`Y_m J{V_ Ý&& 20 &&

Such cruel, hateful, low lives have hatred towards the Lord. I will banish them into distressful, endless cycles of worldly afflictions or into demoniac births. (16.19)

O Son of Kunti! Such people with demoniac natures experience repeated births in demoniac environments and will end up in eternal hell with no way of reaching My abode. (16.20)

Comments: In these verses, the Lord indicates the eventual destination for those with demoniac natures and actions. Such people harbour hatred towards the Lord and consider that their only purpose of life is physical enjoyment at any cost.

Catalysts for Demoniatic Actions

{Ì{dY ZaH\$ñ`X Ûma ZmeZ_mË_Z... Ý&
H\$m_... H\$mYñVWm bm^ñVñ_mXV Ì`Ë`OV Ý&& 21 &&

Lust, anger, and greed are the three gates to hell and self-destruction. One should get rid of these three harmful characteristics. (16.21)

Comments: In this verse the Lord identifies the main human passions that propel one towards harmful activities leading to self-destruction. These are lust, anger, and greed. Lust is the never-ending desire for physical gratification. Previously in verse 3.37, the Lord stated the negative impacts of *kama* (lust) and *krodha* (anger). In verse 1.38,

Arjuna himself had stated that the Kauravas were blinded by their greed (*lobha*) for a share of a kingdom which did not belong to them. This greed eventually destroyed the Kauravas. Anger occurs when one is not able to fulfil one's desires. Greed is the emotion that causes one to accumulate excess wealth at any cost for fulfilling unending desires. These three emotions are identified as the doors to hell as they stimulate destructive behaviour leading to unrecoverable downfall.

Method to Overcome Demoniac Tendencies

EV{d_°\$... H\$mÝV` V_mÔma{ó{^Za... Ý&
AmMaË`mË\_Z... I`ñVVm`m{V nam J{V_ Ý&& 22 &&

`...eó{d{Y\_ËgÁ` dV H\$m_H\$maV... Ý&
Z g {g{Ö_dmbZm{V Z g I Z nam J{V_ Ý&& 23 &&

Vñ_mÀNmó à_mU V H\$m`mH\$m`ì`dpñWVm Ý&
kñËdm eó{dYmZm°\$ H\$` H\$V{`hmh{g Ý&& 24 Ý&&

O Son of Kunti! A seeker, who is free from these three dreadful afflictions is redeemed and will be on the way to attaining the Lord's abode. (16.22)

One who acts contravening the conduct prescribed in the scriptures will neither achieve enduring glory nor lasting happiness and will never reach the Lord's abode. (16.23)

Scriptures are your guide in performing right deeds and avoiding wrong ones. Therefore, perform your prescribed duties as per scriptural injunctions. (16.24)

Comments: After having described the three main emotions that cause one to indulge in harmful activities, the next three verses describe the method for one to get freed from the clutches of these emotions. The Lord

states that one should resort to scriptures which act as guidelights for seekers on the journey of life. Scriptures such as the **Upanishads**, the **Bhagavata**, the **Ramayana** and of course, the **Mahabharata** contain many episodes to help a seeker discriminate between moral and immoral actions, especially where there are grey areas.

Summary of Chapter 16

Some of the characteristics of the divine and the demoniac were described in chapter 9, verses 9.11-14. This chapter provides more details on these characteristics. People with divine natures typically exhibit the following traits: honesty, straightforwardness, compassion, gentleness, sense control, peace of mind, pleasing personality, helpfulness, anger control, purity in body and mind, charitable nature. These are covered in verses 16.1-3. Those with demoniac natures are characterized by some of these traits: arrogance, anger, obstinacy, attachment to worldly pleasures, disrespect towards teachers and elders, conceit, cruelty, hypocrisy etc. These are described in verses 16.7-18. The destination for those with demoniac conduct (a result of their demoniac nature) is described in verses 16.19-21. Verses 16.22-23 describe the methods for one to overcome demoniac tendencies. This chapter concludes in verse 16.24 with Lord Krishna declaring that one needs to resort to the scriptures to discriminate between right and wrong actions.

&& B{V f{mT:e{m@Ü`m`... &&

End of Chapter 16

gáXe@Ü`m`... - lÕmì`{d^mJ`mJ...

Chapter 17 - The Threefold Faith

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 28 verses is termed *Shraddhatraya Vibhaga Yoga* (The Threefold Faith). In the previous chapters, especially in chapter 14, the nature of individuals influenced by the qualities of *sattv*, *rajas*, *tamas* was stated in many places. This chapter has more details on the concept of threefold faith. In chapter 14, verse 14.19, it was stated that all activities are influenced by the combination of the three qualities of inert nature and that the Lord Almighty is beyond these attributes and hence is not influenced by them. Everyone has faith or belief about the purpose of life. This belief is born out of their innate nature. In this chapter, more details on the impact of the innate qualities of living beings are described, especially on issues such as faith, food habits, austerity, and charitable giving. While chapter 14 dealt with the impact of the three qualities of nature on living beings, this chapter deals with the three types of faith that are intrinsic to all living beings.

The Threefold Faith

AOZ CdmM ÿ&

`eó{d{Y\_ĚgÁ` `OÝV lÕ`m@pÝdVm... ÿ&

Vfm {Zǎm V H\$m H\$îU gîd_mhm aOñV_... ÿ&& 1ÿ&&

Arjuna said: O Krishna! Some worship and perform sacrifices with sincerity, but without knowing scriptural procedures. What is their conviction? Is it *sattvic* (virtuous), *rajasic* (passion) or *tamasic* (ignorance)? (17.1)

Comments: In the last verse of the previous chapter 16.24, the Lord stated that the scriptures are the guidelights for a seeker to discriminate between right and wrong deeds. Arjuna wants to know about those who do

not know about scriptural procedures. If they perform deeds with sincerity, would they be *sattvic*, *rajasic* or *tamasic*?

Outwardly, the phrase *śāstravidhim utsrjya* seems to refer to those who ignore the procedures indicated in the scriptures. Sri Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB states that this phrase refers to those who do not have knowledge about scriptural procedures. After all, not everyone has access to the scriptures, yet they also perform meditation, charity etc., based on their belief system. The question that Arjuna is asking is about the nature of their activities. This will be clear after Lord's response in the next two verses.

Ir^JdmZdM M Ĩ&
 {İ{dYm ^d{V I Ōm X{hZm gm ñd^ndOm Ĩ&
 gmpÎdH\$ amOgr Md Vm_gr M{V Vm IU Ĩ&& 2Ĩ&&

The Lord said: Living beings are predisposed (based on their innate nature) into one of three qualities - *sattvic*, *rajasic* or *tamasic*. Listen to their description. (17.2)

Comments: Every soul has an intrinsic nature that defines its predisposition. The Lord describes such predisposition.

gÎdmZê\$nm gdñ` I Ōm ^d{V ^maV Ĩ&
 I Ōm_`m@` néf` m `ÀNŌ... g Ed g... Ĩ&& 3 Ĩ&&

O Bharata! Everyone's faith is conditioned according to the innate nature of their soul. Everyone has some faith, and that faith defines one's personality. (17.3)

Comments: Intrinsic predisposition in living beings defines their faith. It is this faith that is the basis of one's attitudes, personality, and activities. When one is liberated, one's state will be based on one's intrinsic

predisposition (*sattvic*, *rajasic*, or *tamasic*). Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that despite one's intrinsic predisposition, one may exhibit other characteristics to a small extent based on the impact of one's environment. Intrinsic predisposition in souls is like the feature of magnetism in magnets which naturally attracts iron but no other metals. Magnetism in that sense is an intrinsic quality that cannot be separated from a magnet. Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in his BGS has identified this verse as representing the core concepts in this chapter as it identifies the root cause that determines one's faith.

Types of Ritual Propitiation

`O'V gmpÎdH\$m XdmZ `j a j m{g amOgm... &
àVmZ ^VJUüüÝ` `O'V Vm_gm OZm... Ý&& 4 &&

AemÓ{d{hV Kma VB`ÝV `Vnm OZm... Ý&
Xâ^mhH\$mag`°\$m... H\$m_anJ~bmpÝdVm... Ý&& 5 &&

H\$e`ÝV... earañW ^VJm__MVg...Ý&
_m MdmyV...earañW VmZ {dÕçmga{Zü`mZ Ý&& 6 &&

Sattvic individuals worship godly deities. *Rajasic* individuals' worship *yakshas* (capricious spirits) and demonic forces. And *tamasic* forces worship evil spirits. (17.4)

Some people with arrogance and pride, driven by lust and desire, perform rigorous rituals not approved by the scriptures, ignoring the five basic elements of nature (and their governing deities), Mother Nature (Goddess Mahalakshmi), as well as Myself (Krishna), all resident in their bodies. They are of demoniac nature. (17.5) (17.6)

Comments: The types of spirits worshipped by *sattvic*, *rajasic* and *tamasic* beings are identified in these verses. When the *sattvic* propitiate

deities such as Brahma, Indra etc., due to their faith in Lord Almighty Vishnu, they envision the indwelling Lord Vishnu in these deities, and hence will attain His abode (*moksha*). Others such as *rajasas* who propitiate these deities without considering the indwelling Lord are propitiating other capricious spirits with the same name as Brahma, Indra etc. They will only experience temporary rewards in a heaven like abode. This is clarified by Sri Rayaru in GV.

Habits of Food, Rituals, Austerity and Charity

AmhmanEd{n gdñ` {Ì{dYm ^d{V {à` ... V&
`kñVnñVWm XmZ Vfm ^X{ eU V&& 7 &&

Food preferred by living beings are also of three types. Likewise, are sacrificial rituals, austerity, and charitable activities. Listen to their classification. (17.7)

Comments: The innate nature of living beings impacts their lives in terms of food habits, performance of daily rituals, and even their attitude and approach towards charitable giving. These are explained in detail in verses 17.8 to 17.22.

As per the **Chandogya Upanishat (6.5.1)**, food items have three components – gross, middle part and subtle part. The gross part is normally excreted, the middle part gives nourishment to the body and the subtle part impacts the mind. Hence, the type of food consumed not only impacts ones physical health, but also has an impact on one's mental health.

Types of Food Habits

Am`...gîd~bman½`g l àr{V{ddYZm... V&
añ`m... स्नि½Ym... pñWam öÚm Amhman... gmpîdH\${à`m... V&& 8 &&

Sattvic (virtuous) people like food items that are pleasant, nourishing, sweet, tasty, and are easy to digest. They enhance longevity, vitality, and health, and induce happiness and good nature. (17.8)

Comments: ‘You are what you eat’ is a famous saying which indicates that one’s nature is defined by one’s food habits. Those with *sattvic* nature prefer food items that promote health and longevity. These food items are endowed with four basic characteristics which make them tasty (*rasyāḥ*), juicy (*snigdhāḥ*), nourishing (*sthirā*), and hearty (*hr̥dyā*). An example of nourishing (*sthirā*) food is ghee which stays in the blood stream for a long-time giving strength to the individual. Hearty (*hr̥dyā*) food items are those (ex: sweet dishes) which not only give joy while they are consumed but also create craving. Moderate amounts of such healthy, tasty food promote health and wellbeing, and induce good nature. Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha gives the example of a lamp that requires both the wick (*batti*) and ghee/oil to give light. Similarly, a body needs ghee for nourishment which helps to light one’s intellect.

H\$Qd mābbdUmĒ`îUVrúUê\$j {dXm{hZ... ĩ&

Amham anOgñ`îm X... I emH\$m \_`àXm... ĩ&& 9 &&

Rajasic (passionate) people like food items that are extremely bitter/spicy, acidic, salty, hot, pungent, sour, and burnt. These result in misery and discomfort at the time of consumption, and disease later. (17.9)

Comments: This verse describes the food habits of the *rajasic*. While food items which are sour, salty etc., are also essential for one’s wellbeing, they need to be consumed in moderation. When consumed in excess (*atī*), they result in misery at the time of consumption. Long term ill effects include onset of diseases. For example, while salt is an essential source of sodium for the body, excess intake of salt over a prolonged period is known to result in high blood pressure. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that these food items when consumed in moderation and without resulting in discomfort or disease, can be considered *sattvic*.

`mV`m JVag n{V n`{fV M `V ĩ&
CpÀN'ĩ`\_n Mm\_Ü` ^mOZ Vm_g{à` _ ĩ&& 10 &&

Tamasic (demoniac) people like food items that are stale, decomposed, foul, leftover, leavings of others, and impure. (17.10)

Comments: This verse describes the types of food items that appeal to the *tamasic*. Impure food items include prohibited ones such as alcohol. These food items are unhealthy regardless of the amount that is consumed.

Types of Ritual Sacrifices

A\\$bmH\$m{-{^`k m {d{YÑĩm ` BÁ`V ĩ&
`ĩ`_d{V _Z... g_mYm` g gmpÎdH\$... ĩ&& 11 &&

A{^gÝYm` V \\$b Xâ^mW\_{n Md `V ĩ&
BÁ`V ^aV Iđ V `k {d{Õ amOg_ ĩ&& 12 &&

{d{YhrZ_gĩmP _Ý`İhrZ_X{j U_ ĩ&
I Õm{da{hV `k Vm_g n[aM j V ĩ&& 13 &&

Ritual sacrifices, performed whole heartedly as per the scriptures and as a prescribed duty without any expectations, is *sattvic*. (17.11)

O Superior among the Bharatas! Ritual sacrifices performed with expectations and as an outward show of power and wealth, is *rajasic*. (17.12)

Ritual sacrifices performed without following scriptural procedures, without feeding the needy, without proper chanting of hymns, without donating to charity, and without sincerity is *tamasic*. (17.13)

Comments: *Sattvic* ones perform ritual sacrifices as worship to the Lord. Feeding the needy and charitable giving are integral parts of any ritual sacrifice performed to propitiate deities. Those with *rajasic* nature, perform ritual sacrifices as a show to demonstrate their power in society. Those with *tamasic natures* perform such rituals with ulterior motives and never donate to those less fortunate.

Physical, Vocal, and Mental Austerity

Xd{ÛOJéàknOZ eM_mOd_ Ý&
 ~÷M`\_qhgM M emara Vn CÀ`V Ý&& 14 &&

AZÛJH\$a dñŠ` gĚ` {à`{hV M `V Ý&
 ñdmÜ`m`mä`gZ Md dñL`_ Vn CÀ`V Ý&& 15&&

_Z`àgmX... gmâ`Ěd _mZ_mĚ_{d{ZJh... Ý&
 ^mdge{Ō[aĚ`Vîmnm \_mZg\_À`V Ý&& 16 &&

Respecting and worshipping deities, scholars, teachers and learned ones, purity in mind and body, honesty, celibacy, and non-violence are physical austerities. (17.14)

Using words and speech that do not cause anxiety in others, that are pleasant to hear, that are truthful and aid in spiritual study constitutes austerity of words. (17.15)

Serenity in thinking, pleasant nature, purity in thoughts, an uncluttered mind, and a mind focused on the Lord constitute austerity of the mind. (17.16)

Comments: Austerity is self-discipline that is visible in one's actions. It has three components: physical, vocal, and mental. One's nature is also influenced by one's attitude and approach to austerity. Those with

sattvic nature engage in physical austerity characterized by respect to deities, elders, teachers etc., in addition to internal and external purity of purpose. Their vocal austerity manifests in the words they choose in their discussions, as also the tone and tenor of their voice. Mental austerity is characterized by an uncluttered, tranquil, silent mind which is steadfastly focused on the Lord.

Austerity based on Faith

I Ō`m na`m Vá VnñVpĒİ{dY Za... ĩ&
A\ \$bmH\$m{-{^`°\$... gmpÎdH\$ n[aM j V ĩ&& 17 &&

gĒH\$ma_mZnOmW Vnm Xâ^Z Md `V ĩ&
{H\$`V V{Xh àm°\$ amOg Mb_Yd_ ĩ&& 18 &&

_T\JmhUmĒ_Zm `V nrS`m {H\$`V Vn... ĩ&
nañ`mĒgmXZnW dm VÎmm_g_XnöV_ ĩ&& 19 &&

Austerity sincerely observed by people is also of three types. *Sattvic* austerity is one that is performed as an offering to the Lord, without any expectation. (17.17)

Austerity performed to display one's wealth and position, and to gain adulation and praise from society, resulting in uneven, vanishing rewards is *rajasic*. (17.18)

Austerity performed out of superstitions, with great pain to the self and with the intention of harming others is *tamasic*. (17.19)

Comments: After having identified the characteristics of austerity exercised physically, vocally, and mentally, the next three verses describe the differences in the attitude and approach of those with *sattvic*, *rajasic*, and *tamasic* natures. *Sattvic* ones exercise austerity as service to the Lord,

the *rajasic* approach austerity with an ulterior motive of societal recognition, and for the *tamasic*, austerity is meant to hurt others.

Charity based on Faith

XmVî`\_{V`ÔmZ Xr`V@ZnH\$m[aU`ÿ&
Xe H\$m b M nm Î M VÔmZ gmpÎdH\$ ñ_V_`ÿ&& 20 &&

`Îm àË`nH\$mamW \ \$b_{Ôí` d m nZ...`ÿ&
Xr`V M n[apŠbî VÔmZ amOg ñ\_Ë\_`ÿ&& 21 &&

AXeH\$m b `ÔmZ\_ AnmÎä`ü Xr`V`ÿ&
AgËH\$V_dk m VÎmm_g_XmÖV_`ÿ&& 22 &&

Charity given to the deserved with a feeling of duty, at appropriate places and times and without any expectations is *sattvic*. (17.20)

Charity given unwillingly, as if to return a favour and given with an expectation of returns, is *rajasic*. (17.21)

Charity given to the undeserving, with disrespect and without regard to appropriateness of place and time is *tamasic*. (17.22)

Comments: Charitable donations performed by individuals are also of three types. The *sattvic* donate whole heartedly without any expectation of recognition and consider it their duty. Their only goal is to please the Lord. The *rajasic* donate out of fear (of reprisals afterlife), out of expectations of societal recognition, often with unlawful earnings. The *tamasic* donate with ulterior motives to the undeserving with disrespect.

Concept of Om, Tat, Sat

> VĒg{X{V {ZXeṁ ~÷U{ó{dY... ṅ_V... ṽ&
~ṁ÷UṁñVZ dXṁü `kṁü {d{hVṁ... nam ṽ&& 23 &&

In the scriptures, the Lord is addressed with three principal names- *Om* (omnipresent), *Tat* (one who is known indirectly, through the **Vedas**) and *Sat* (full of infinite auspicious attributes). The Lord made available the **Vedas** and Vedic sacrifices and powered the intellect of priests to perform them. (17.23)

Comments: *Sattvic* living beings perform all their activities, especially ritual sacrifices, austerity, and charitable giving as a worship and offering to the Lord. It is important for one to remember the Lord before undertaking such activities. The next four verses state that the scriptures address the Lord with three succinct, yet powerful adjectives, *Om*, *Tat* and *Sat*. These have special meanings. *Om* which is derived from ‘*otam protaha*’ refers to the one who indwells (and supports) the universe. *Tat* means one who pervades the Gunas (qualities). It also means one who cannot be comprehended by the sense organs and can only be known through the scriptures. *Sat* refers to the Lord who is devoid of any defects and is full of infinite, auspicious attributes.

Vñ_mXṁ{Ē`XṁöĒ` `kXṁZVn...{H\$`m... ṽ&
àdVṽV {dYṁZṁ°\$ṁ... gVṽ ~÷dṁ{XZṁ_ ṽ&& 24 &&

V{XĒ`Z{^gYṁ` \b `kVn...{H\$`m... ṽ&
XṁZ{H\$`mü {d{dYṁ... {H\$`YV _j H\$ṁ{¬{^... ṽ&& 25 &&

gØṁd gṁY^ṁd M g{XĒ`VĒà`Á`V ṽ&
àeñV H\$_{U VWṁ gÀNãX... nṁW `Á`V ṽ&& 26 &&

Hence, the activities of ritual sacrifice, austerity, and charity performed as per the scriptures are always initiated by invoking the primordial syllable ‘*Om*’, as a prayer to the Lord Almighty. (17.24)

Those desirous of achieving eternal bliss and not interested in temporary heavenly pleasures perform sacrifices, penances, and charity as an offering to the Lord described by the word ‘*Tat*’, as one who is to be understood indirectly (through the scriptures). (17.25)

O Partha! The Lord’s name, ‘*Sat*’, is used to represent existence and goodness. It is also used to denote auspicious activities. (17.26)

Comments: These three verses describe the impact of invoking the Lord’s names *Om*, *Tat*, *Sat* at the time of performing activities such as ritual sacrifices, austerity, and charitable giving. Invoking the Lord’s name *Om*, ensures that these activities will be rendered *sattvic*. Before chanting any hymn, one must precede it with *Om*, which renders the hymn fruitful. Likewise, one must complete chanting of hymns with *Om* in the end, else any blessings that would accrue from the hymn would be lost.

When one invokes the Lord’s name *Tat*, one is reminded that the Lord is knowable indirectly (through the scriptures) and that one should perform activities without expectations of temporary rewards.

Invoking the Lord’s name *Sat* will remind a seeker to be aware of the Lord’s infinite, auspicious attributes, and activities such as the creation of the universe.

In summary, invoking the phrase *Om*, *Tat*, *Sat* at the time of performing virtuous activities will help a seeker develop a virtuous attitude and approach to them.

ॐ क वन { g X m Z M pñ W { V ... g { X { V M m À ` V | &
H \$ _ M d V X W u ` | g { X È ` d m { ^ Y r ` V | & & 27 & &

AI Õ`m hv XÎm VnñVá H\$V M `V ÿ&
 Ag{XË`À`V nmW Z M VV àË` Zm Bh ÿ&& 28 &&

The strong conviction that one has in performing sacrifices, penances and charity is also represented by the Lord's name 'Sat', as also activities that are performed as an offering to the Lord. (17.27)

O Partha! Sacrifices performed, charity given, and austerities observed, if done without faith and devotion to the Lord will be counterproductive and constitute 'Asat'. Such activities help neither here nor hereafter. (17.28)

Comments: The Lord concludes the discussion of 'The Threefold Faith' with these two verses by summarizing the characteristics of activities performed with sincerity and those performed without sincerity. Activities performed with sincerity, without expectations of rewards and as an offering to the Lord will indeed help a seeker reach the Lord's abode. Activities that are performed with ulterior motives for societal recognition, without following scriptural procedures and without offering to the Lord are inauspicious and will neither help in this world nor in afterlife. Hence faith and sincerity are very essential when performing activities.

Summary of Chapter 17

In this chapter the Lord identifies the three divisions of faith - *sattvic*, *rajasic* and *tamasic* which influence the attitudes and activities of living beings. These attributes are innate (*swabhava*) to individual souls. The impact of these attributes on activities such as worship, food habits, ritual sacrifices, austerity, and charitable services are described. Verses 17.4 to 17.7 describe the mode of propitiation of living beings. Verses 17.8 to

17.10 describe food habits. Verses 17.11 to 17.13 identify ritual sacrifices based on one's innate attributes. Verses 17.14 to 17.19 describe one's approach to austerity and meditation. Verses 17.20 to 17.22 address the issue of charitable giving. Verses 17.23 to 17.27 describe the approach towards ritual sacrifices and penance performed by *sattvic* beings desirous of *moksha*, with special explanation on *Om*, *Tat*, and *Sat*, the three principal names of the Lord Almighty.

॥ B{V gáXe@Ü`m`...॥

End of Chapter 17

Aikṣeṁ@Ü`m`... - 'mjgÝÝ¶mg¶mJ...

Chapter 18 - Liberation and Renunciation

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 78 verses is termed *Mokshasanyasa Yoga* (Liberation and Renunciation). It starts with a discussion on the subtle differences between renunciation (*sanyasa*) and relinquishment of rewards from labour (*tyaga*). The types of rewards from actions are also discussed. The five prerequisites of performing any action are identified. Different types of knowledge, action, doers, intellect, determination, and happiness are also discussed. Additional details are provided on four societal categories of people which were briefly indicated in 4.13. The concept of liberation (*moksha*) is discussed in detail in this chapter. The first 55 verses contain discussions on the topics identified so far. The Lord concludes His sermon in the next 17 verses. Arjuna responds to Lord Krishna's entire teaching in verse 73. Sanjaya, who has been describing the proceedings in the war to King Dhrutarashtra concludes his commentary in the remaining 5 verses. Arjuna starts by requesting Krishna to explain the difference between renunciation (*sanyasa*) and relinquishment (*tyaga*) as both seem to imply the same. The Lord provides answers to Arjuna's questions with a detailed description of the various aspects of renunciation and relinquishment. This chapter expands on the concept of doership, provides more details on the influence of the three qualities of nature and gives additional explanation on societal categories. There is further an elaborate discussion on the methods to achieve salvation (*moksha*). The Lord also describes the glory of the **Gita**.

Renunciation v/s Relinquishment

AOZ CdṁM Ý&

gÝÝ`mgñ`_hm~mhṁ Vîd{`ÀNṁ{ d{XV_ &

Ë`mJñ` M öfrH\$e nWH\$ H\$e{ZfXZ Ý&& 1 Ý&&

Arjuna said: O Krishna, Mighty Armed One! O Hrishikesha! O Slayer of Demon Keshi! I would like to understand the difference between renunciation and relinquishment. (18.1)

Comments: In verse 5.2, it was stated that renunciation (*sanyāsa*) is essential to attain liberation (*moksha*), and in verse 12.12 relinquishment (*tyāga*) was lauded as a superior means to attain liberation (*moksha*). Arjuna wants to know the difference between these two approaches. The Lord provides a detailed response to Arjuna in verses 18.2 to 18.12.

Ir^JdZdMm Y&
H\$mā`mZm H\$\_Um Y`mg gY`mg H\$d`m {dX... Y&
gdH\$_\bē`mJ àmhñē`mJ {dM j Um... Y&& 2 Y&&

Ē`mÁ` Xmfd{XĒ`H\$ H\$_ àmh_Zr{fU... Y&
`kXmZVn...H\$\_ Z Ē`mÁ`{V Mmna Y&& 3 Y&&

The Lord said: Learned ones say that renunciation is the abandonment of activities performed for the sake of desired outcomes. The experienced say that relinquishment is forsaking of fruits of any action. (18.2)

The wise declare that engaging in desire ridden activities should be relinquished as they entangle a soul. Others say that one should never abandon activities such as ritual sacrifice, charity, and penance. (18.3)

Comments: The Lord identifies four principles in these verses – (i) abandonment of activities performed for mundane desires (ii) forsaking any rewards from action (except the lofty goal of earning the Lord’s grace) (iii) abandonment of activities which entangle one, and (iv) non-abandonment of prescribed activities of ritual sacrifices, charity, and austerity. Sri Madhwacharya in GB and GTN clarifies that all these principles are required for one to make progress in one’s spiritual journey. The use of

terms ‘*kavayo*’ (learned ones), ‘*vicakṣaṇāḥ*’ (the experienced), and ‘*manīṣiṇaḥ*’ (the wise) to describe the proponents of these four principles is proof that all four are desirable qualities in a seeker.

{Zü` eU \_ VÌ È`mJ ^aVgÎm _ V&
È`mJm {h néfì`mK {Ì{dY... gâàH\$s{VW... V&& 4 &&

O Superior among the Bharatas! Listen to My ruling on the issue of relinquishment. O Superior among Men! Relinquishment is of three types. (18.4)

Comments: To clarify that there is no contradiction between renunciation and relinquishment, the Lord states that relinquishment is of three types. However, these three types are not identified in this verse. Sri Rayaru in GV describes the three types of relinquishments as follows -

- As per verse 18.2, relinquishment is forsaking rewards of activities.
- As will be seen in verse 18.6, relinquishment is forsaking ownership in activities.
- As will be seen in verse 18.17, relinquishment is not assuming independent doership in activities.

Another interpretation for the types of relinquishments is classification based on *sattvic* (pious), *rajasic* (passionate) and *tamasic* (ignorant) modes explained later in verses 18.7 to 18.9.

`kXmZVn... H\$\_ Z È`mÁ` H\$m`_d VW V&
`km XmZ Vnüd nmdZm{Z _Zr{fUm _ V&& 5 &&

EVmY`{n V H\$\_m{U g“ È`³Edm \b{Z M V&
H\$Vî`mZr{V _ nmW {Z{üV _V_Îm _ V&& 6 &&

One should never abandon performing prescribed ritual sacrifices, austerity, and charity. These help purify a person. (18.5)

O Partha! One should detach oneself from ego in actions and perform them without expectations. This is My definite opinion. (18.6)

Comments: In these two verses, the Lord mandates that one should never abandon one's prescribed duties and should perform them without attachment to the actions themselves and without expectations. As the Lord states that performing ritual sacrifices, austerity and charity are mandatory for everyone, how does this apply to ascetics, and to those who do not have access to Vedic knowledge? Ascetics are prohibited from performing fire rituals and since they do not earn any income, they cannot perform any charity. Sri Rayaru in GV states that ritual sacrifices are of different types as stated earlier in verse 4.25 etc. The ritual sacrifice, for ascetics, is *jnana yagna* (sacrifice of knowledge) which involves continuous study of scriptures, teaching students, lectures to the lay people etc. Charity, for ascetics, is donating their time and knowledge to those in need. Austerity, for ascetics, is observing strict rituals such as celibacy, fasting etc. Those who do not have access to Vedic knowledge perform ritual sacrifice in the form of prayers and bhajans on the Lord, and austerity for them is being truthful, fasting etc.

Types of Renunciation

{Z`Vñ` V gY`mg... H\$_Um ZmnÚV ĩ&
_mhmîñ` n[aĒ`mJñV_m_g... n[aH\$\${VW... ĩ&& 7 &&

X... I {Ē`d`ĒH\$_H\$m`Šbe^`mV`OV ĩ&
g H\$Ēdm amOg Ē`mJ Zd Ē`mJ\b b^V ĩ&& 8 &&

H\$m`\_{Ē`d`V H\$\_{Z`V {H\$`V@OZ ĩ&
g“ Ē`ŠĒdm`\$b\$ Md g Ē`mJ... gmpîdH\$m _V... ĩ&& 9 &&

Renouncing prescribed duties is never appropriate. Avoiding such actions out of ignorance is *tamasic*. (18.7)

Abandonment of prescribed duties under the pretext of stress and physical difficulty is *rajasic*. No one can earn the Lord's grace through such renunciation. (18.8)

O Arjuna! Performing prescribed duties without attachment to actions and without expectations is *sattvic* renunciation. (18.9)

Comments: In these verses, the Lord identifies the types of renunciation practiced by different people, based on their intrinsic nature. Some completely ignore performing prescribed duties out of ignorance or false knowledge. Such renunciation is *tamasic* (nescient). There are some who are aware of their prescribed duties but find excuses such as bodily discomfort to avoid doing them. Their abandonment is *rajasic* and does not earn the Lord's grace. The *sattvic* consider their prescribed duties as an obligation and perform them without attachment and expectations. Their renunciation of attachment to activities and rewards is *sattvic* and is to be followed by everyone.

Characteristics of Renunciation

Z ŪiçH\$eb H\$_ H\$eb ZmZf ,mV ĩ&
Ē`mJr gĪdg\_m{dī`m _Ym̄dr {Npge` ... ĩ&& 10 &&

Z {h Xh^Vm eŠ` Ē`³V H\$_mĒ`efV... ĩ&
`ñV H\$\_\bĒ`mJr g Ē`mJrĒ`{^Yr`V ĩ&& 11 &&

A{Zi{Ī} { I M {Ī{dY H\$_U... \b_ ĩ&
^dĒ`Ē`m{JZm àĒ` Z V gYĪ`m{gZm ¹{MV ĩ&& 12 &&

A *sattvic* renouncer is one who neither despises unpleasant activities nor craves for pleasant activities, one who offers all activities to the Lord, one who is pious by nature, one who has understood the Lord, and one who has no doubts about the nature of the Lord and the Universe. (18.10)

One with a physical body can never completely renounce all activities (as even breathing is an activity). One who has relinquished the fruits of labour is the ideal *tyagi*. (18.11)

Those who perform activities with expectations will experience either pleasant, or unpleasant, or mixed rewards after they leave this world. This does not apply to those who perform duties without expectations. (18.12)

Comments: These three verses provide more details on the characteristics of renunciation based on the nature and approach of the seeker. As per Rayaru in GV, verse 18.10 identifies five characteristics of a *sattvic* renunciant as one who (i) does not abandon prescribed duties that may be momentarily unpleasant, (ii) does not crave for activities that may be momentarily pleasant, (iii) has a pious nature, (iv) has understood properly the Lord's prowess, and (v) has no doubts regarding the distinction between the universe and the Lord Almighty. Verse 18.11 counters a position that some hold that a renouncer should forsake all activities. This verse states that for a living being, it is impossible to forsake all activities, as even breathing is a type of activity. An ideal renouncer is one who forsakes the rewards from actions and not actions themselves. Verse 18.12 explains the distinction between a seeker who performs activities with expectations of rewards and one who performs prescribed duties with no expectations. The former one experiences three different types of destinations in afterlife: downfall, heavenly rewards, and rebirth in this world (depending on the approach and nature of their activities such as *tamasic*, *sattvic*, *rajasic*). However, one who performs prescribed duties forsaking rewards will not experience these types of destinations. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that those seekers who have

achieved self-realization and do not have any obligations to perform activities, will achieve higher bliss in salvation depending on the extent of their activities. As indicated in 18.2, renunciation is the abandonment of activities performed for the sake of desired outcomes, and relinquishment is forsaking of fruits of any action. Superior seekers who have achieved self-realization have both these characteristics (renunciation and relinquishment).

Pre-requisites for Activities

n#mVn{Z _hm~mhm H\$naUn{Z {Z~mY _|Y&
gm>>` H\$VmYV àm°\$m{Z {gÕ` gdH\$ _Um _|Y&& 13 &&

A{YðmZ VWm H\$Vm H\$aU M nWp%dy _|Y&
{d{dYmü nWŠMîm Xd Md mÎ n#m _|Y&& 14 &&

earadmL‘Zm{^`V H\$ _|àma^V Za...|Y&
Y`mæ` dm {dnarV dm n#mV Vñ` hVd...|Y&& 15 &&

O Arjuna, Mighty Armed One! There are five pre-requisites for completion of any activity as enumerated in the *Sankhya* scripture. Learn them from Me. (18.13)

They are as follows - the place for conducting activity (such as body, earth), the performer (human, divine), the apparatus (sense organs, fire), resulting rituals (meditation, prayer) and divinity (the Lord). (18.14)

Whatever activity one performs through the body or the mind or speech, whether it is right or wrong, that activity will require the above five pre-requisites for completion. (18.15)

Comments: As performance of activities is mandatory for everyone, it is important to understand the prerequisites for performing them. These verses identify the five prerequisites for action. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies

that these are as per the *Sankhya* scripture which was composed by the Lord in the form of Kapila. Verse 18.14 identifies the five prerequisites, and verse 18.15 clarifies that these five prerequisites are essential for performing any activity, be it physical, vocal, or mental.

The concept of prerequisites for activities can be illustrated with an example. Let us take the case of a seeker practicing meditation (*dhyana*). Following are the five prerequisites –

- (i) place = physical body
- (ii) performer = living being (dependent performer)
- (iii) apparatus = living being's mind
- (iv) resulting ritual = focusing the mind
- (v) divinity = Lord Almighty (who powers everyone's actions).

For example, in the case of one cooking rice, these five aspects are – place (kitchen), performer (cook), apparatus (utensils, stove), resulting ritual (rice), and divinity (Lord who powers this activity).

Awareness of Doership

Vìd g{V H\$Vma_ | AmĒ_mZ H\$db V `... V&
nÍ`Ē`H\$V~{ÖĒdmP g nÍ`{V X_{V... V&& 16 &&

`ñ` ZmhH\$Vm ^mdm ~{Ö`ñ` Z {bß`V V&
hĒdm@{n g B_m,,mH\$mP hp'V Z {Z~Ü`V V&& 17 &&

Hence the unwise one, who foolishly considers self to be the sole performer of any action, is indeed devoid of proper knowledge. (18.16)

One who is not under the delusion of being the sole performer and has no expectation on the outcome of action, will not be termed a killer even if that person has killed while performing prescribed duties. Such a person is not tainted with any sin. (18.17)

Comments: These two verses amplify the need for one to be aware of the concept of doership. As there are five clear prerequisites for the creation of any activity, no one should be under the delusion of sole, independent doership. Verse 18.17 goes a step further and states that a seeker who is not under the delusion of independent doership and performs prescribed activities with no expectations of rewards, will not be tainted by any sin, even if that activity involves destruction of population. This statement can raise issues as to how one can be absolved of great sins that normally accompany such destructive activities. Sri Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB and Sri Jaya Teertha's PD clarifies this concept with concrete examples. Lord Rudra (who governs the act of universe's dissolution) and Lord Yama (the deity of death) are associated with destruction. However, these deities perform these activities as directed by the independent, omniscient Lord Almighty and have no delusion that they are performing these on their own. Hence, they are not tainted by any sin. However, deity Indra who kills Vrutasura, was tainted with some sin as his actions were accompanied by ego.

Concept of Doership

knZ k` n[akmVm {İ{dYm H\$_MmXZm İ&
H\$aU H\$_ H\$V{V {İ{dY... H\$_gJh... İ&& 18 &&

The motivations for any activity are three-fold - knowledge about the activity (*jnana*), effort (*prayatna*), and the performer of the activity (*jeeva*). The three main pre-requisites for any activity are - the apparatus, the resulting ritual, and the doer. (18.18)

Comments: This verse describes the concept of doership where the motivations for performing any activity are indicated, along with the prerequisites for such activities. While verse 18.14 described the five prerequisites for performing any activity, these five are summarized into 3 types – the apparatus (which combines the place of operation and the material utilities), the resulting ritual and the doer (which combines the

independent doer and divinity, both referring to the Lord Almighty). In addition to the prerequisites that are essential for one to perform any activity, one also needs motivation to engage in that activity. This verse identifies the 3 motivators as – knowledge about the activity to be performed (*jnana*), effort (*prayatna*) that one needs to put in and the performer of the activity (*jeeva*). The performer of the activity is the living individual who acts based on the power granted by the Lord. The individual being is not an independent doer but acts under the control and supervision of the independent Lord. The concept of doership is explained in detail by Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya's GB and GTN. This topic was covered previously in comments for verse 5.14.

One of the questions that arises is about prescribed duties mandated in the scriptures. Do they apply to the Lord, individual souls, or inert matter? Sri Rayaru in GV explains that by the process of elimination, one can conclude that prescribed duties apply only to individuals. This is because inert matter cannot act, and the Lord Almighty has no obligation or mandate to act (verse 3.22). Now, one can question the feasibility of a living being as a doer, while the real doer is described as the Lord Almighty. Sri Rayaru clarifies that while the Lord is the independent doer, living beings are dependent doers. In this sense, the mandates prescribed in the scriptures apply to living beings who can perform activities based on the material strength and powers granted to them by the Lord. If the Lord as the independent doer is responsible for all activities, what is the role of living beings? Living beings have an intrinsic intent (*iccha*) to achieve salvation which leads them to make attempts (*prayatna*). By the grace of the Lord, they are given the ability to perform actions. Hence, living beings are responsible for their actions.

kṁZ H\$ _ M H\$Vṁ M {İYd JU^XV... İ&
àṁÀ`V JUg»`ṁZ `WṁdÀṂU VṁÝ`{n İ&& 19 &&

As per *Sankhya* scriptures, knowledge, activity, and the doer are of three types and are differentiated based on their natural attributes. Listen to the explanation with attention. (18.19)

Comments: After having described the prerequisites for actions and the concepts of doership, the Lord provides a detailed explanation on the categories of the three aspects of action – knowledge, resulting activity, and the doer. These aspects are influenced by the three qualities of nature, namely *sattv*, *rajas*, and *tamas*. The Lord also states the scriptural basis for this classification as *Vedic Sankhya*.

Threefold Knowledge

gd^Vf `ZH\$ ^md_i``_rjV Ĩ&
A{d^o\$ {d^o\$f VÁkñZ {d{Õ gmpîdH\$_ Ĩ&& 20 &&

That knowledge which is about the nature of the imperishable Lord Almighty as an independent entity residing in everyone and everything, yet different from them, and superior to them is *sattvic*. (18.20)

Comments: *Sattvic* knowledge is one which recognizes the same Lord as being present in different entities in the universe, such as living beings or inert matter. This verse uses the word ‘*bhava*’ (one who is present) to indicate the Lord. Later, in verse 18.61, the Lord explicitly states that He is present in everyone’s hearts. Hence, the reference in this verse to the entity residing in everyone, the Lord Almighty Himself. The concept described in this verse was also stated previously in 13.17 and 5.18.

nW³ĒdZ V `ÁkñZ ZñZñ^mdñZ nWp½dYñZ Ĩ&
d{Îñ gdf ^Vf VÁkñZ {d{Õ amOg_ Ĩ&& 21 &&

That knowledge which teaches that everyone and everything in the Universe is different from each other and from the Lord but does not teach about the supremacy of the Lord is *rajasic*. (18.21)

Comments: Those with *rajasic* knowledge are aware that everyone (living beings) and everything (inert matter) in the universe are different (*pr̥thak*). However, they do not have firm conviction about the supremacy of the Lord. This concept is implied using the word ‘*tu*’ (meaning ‘however’), since the other two components of the universe (living beings and inert matter) were stated explicitly.

Î H\$ËñZdXH\$pr̥_Z H\$m` g°\$ _hVH\$ _ÿ&
AVÎdmWdXën M VV Vm_g_Xmöv _ÿ&& 22 &&

Knowledge that tries to equate the individual to inert matter or to the Lord and is based on misinterpretation of the scriptures is *tamasic*. (18.22)

Comments: Sri Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya’s GTN and the **Padma Purana**, provides three interpretations for this verse based on the different meanings for the word *kṛtsna* (complete). This word can mean either the Lord Almighty or the world. Those with *tamasic* knowledge:

- (i) believe in the identity of the individual soul and the Lord
- (ii) believe in the identity of the individual soul and the inert world
- (iii) believe that the world arose from one individual soul, and hence self-knowledge also implies knowledge about the entire universe

Threefold Activities

{Z`V g“a{hV_amJÛfV... H\$V _ÿ&
A\ \$bàßgZm H\$ _ `V VV gmpÎdH\$ \_À`V ÿ&& 23 &&

`Îm H\$m _ßgZm H\$m _gmhH\$maU d m nZ... Ý&
{H\$m`V ~hbm`mg VÐmOg_Xmöv _Ý&& 24 &&

AZ~ÝY j` qhgm\_ AZdú` M nméf_ Ý&
_mhXmaä`V H\$m \_`ÎmV Vm_g_À`V Ý&& 25 &&

Prescribed activity that is performed without attachment, without arrogance, without aversion, and performed without expectation on the outcome is *sattvic*. (18.23)

Activity performed with ego and with expectation of the outcome, even when performed with great physical effort is *rajasic*. (18.24)

Activities performed without realizing the consequences, not having lasting rewards, with no regard to one's abilities, with potential violent impact on others, and performed with ignorance are *tamasic*. (18.25)

Comments: These three verses describe the types of activities based on the influence of the three qualities of nature, *sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas*. Sri Rayaru in GV, draws attention to verses mentioned in chapter 3 ((3.30) and (3.31)), where the Lord had stated that those who perform activities without expectations, only as an offering to Him, will not be entangled by the effects of activities. This is the nature of *sattvic* activities.

Threefold Doers

_°\$g“m@ZhdmXr YË`Ëgmhg_pÝdV... Ý&
{gÕç{gÕçm... {Z{dH\$ma... H\$Vm gmpÎdH\$ CÀ`V Ý&& 26 &&

amJr H\$_\bàßgbãYm qhgmË_H\$m@e{M... Ý&
hfeH\$mÝdV... H\$Vm amOg... n[aH\$s{VV... Ý&& 27 &&

A`°\$... àmH\$V... ñVãY... eRm ZîH\$VH\$m@bg... ý&
{dfmXr XrKgìr M H\$Vm Vm_g CÀ`V ý&& 28 &&

One who has no attachment to the outcome of actions, who is not arrogant, who is enthusiastic about performing prescribed actions and who is unmoved by success or failure, is a *sattvic* doer. (18.26)

One who performs activities to gain fame, has expectations on the outcome, is miserly, harms others, does not have mental or physical purity, and is impacted by success or failure of actions, is a *rajasic* doer. (18.27)

One who performs activities without offering them to the Lord, who is not strengthened by devotion to the Lord, who is egoistic, who acts with hatred, who performs heinous activities, who is lethargic, who does not act with mental firmness, and who is always procrastinating, is a *tamasic* doer. (18.28)

Comments: These three verses describe the nature of doers who perform activities under the influence of the three qualities of nature. Given that the doers are of three types, it is understandable that the activities performed by them are also of three types as explained previously in verses 18.23 to 18.25.

Threefold Intelligence and Determination

~Õ^X YVüdü JUV{ó{dY eU ý&
àMÀ`\_mZ\_efU nWŠĖdZ YZÄO` ý&& 29 &&

O Dhananjaya! Due to the influence of the three qualities of nature, the attributes of intelligence and determination are also of three types. Listen to My explanations of each of these. (18.29)

Comments: The next few verses provide details about the impact of the three qualities of nature on the attributes of intelligence and

determination (or firmness). These in turn impact one's attitude and approach towards activities – physical, vocal, or mental.

àdôîm M {Zdôîm M H\$m`mH\$m` ^`m^` ý&
~ýY _mj M `m d{îm ~{Õ... gm nmW gpîdH\$S' && 30 &&

`m Y\_\_Y\_ M H\$m` MmH\$m` _d M ý&
A`WmdV àOmZm{V ~{Õ... gm nmW amOgr ý&& 31 &&

AY_Y_{V `m \_ý`V V_gm@@dVm ý&
gdWmZ {dnarVmü ~{Õ... gm nmW Vm_gr ý&& 32 &&

O Partha! Engaging in virtuous activities, avoiding sinful activities and being aware of dualities such as prescribed and prohibited activities, fear and grace, bondage and liberation, are due to *sattvic* intelligence. (18.30)

O Partha! Not being able to discriminate between virtuous and sinful activities, confused between prescribed and prohibited activities is due to *rajasic* intelligence. (18.31)

O Partha! Intelligence covered by ignorance which considers unrighteous activities as virtuous ones and which misinterprets reality as illusion, is *tamasic*. (18.32)

Comments: In these verses, the faculty of intelligence appears to be performing the activities indicated. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that intelligence, being an inert faculty cannot act independently. The activities stated are performed by an individual whose intelligence is either *sattvic*, *rajasic*, or *tamasic*. When someone refers to a strong leader as a lion among people, the implication is that the leader is strong like a lion. It does not mean that the leader is a lion.

YĒ`m ``m Yma`V\_Z...àUṡÝĐ`{H\$`m... Ý&
 `mJZmì`{^Mm[aĒ`m Y{V... gm nmW gmpîdH\$ \$ Ý&& 33 &&

`m V Y\_H\$m\_mWmZ YĒ`m Yma`V@OZ Ý&
 àg“Z \bH\$m→r Y{V... gm nmW amOgr Ý&& 34 &&

`m ñdßZ ^` eH\$ {dfmX_X_d M Ý&
 Z {d_#m{V X_Ym Y{V... gm nmW Vm_gr Ý&& 35 &&

O Partha! Determination that is rooted in devotion to the Lord, which regulates the activities of the mind, the life breath (*pranayama*) and the sense organs, is *sattvic*. (18.33)

O Partha! Determination that leads one to pursue fame, riches, and sense gratification with excessive ego, is *rajasic*. (18.34)

O Partha! The determination with which one is unable to overcome excessive sleep, fear, unhappiness, worry, and arrogance, is *tamasic*. (18.35)

Comments: *Sattvic* determination is a result of one's unflinching devotion to the Lord even under difficult circumstances. *Tamasic* determination leads one to hatred towards the Lord.

The Threefold Happiness

g I pĒdXmZt {ì{dY eU_ ^aVf^ Ý&
 Aä`mgmĐ\_V`ì X... I mÝV M {ZJÀN{V Ý&& 36 &&

`îmXJ {df{d n[aUm_@_Vmn__ Ý&
 VĒg I gmpîdH\$ àm°\$ _ AmĒ_~{ŌàgmXO_ Ý&& 37 &&

O Superior among the Bharatas! Now listen to the three types of happiness. That happiness which increases with practice, frees one from distress, feels poisonous in the beginning and turns out to be nectar like towards the end, is *sattvic*. This is achieved through peace of mind and the express grace of the Lord Almighty. (18.36) (18.37)

Comments: The pursuit of unending happiness is every living being's goal. However, the type of happiness that one pursues is shaped by the influence of the three qualities of nature. In verse 18.37, the phrase '*buddhiprasādam*' seems to imply that *sattvic* happiness arises from peace of mind. The mind is inert. How can the inert mind result in happiness? Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that this phrase is preceded by '*atma*' (referring to the Lord Almighty). Hence the implication is that one can experience *sattvic* happiness only by the Lord's grace, which also leads to peace of mind.

{df`pYÐ`g`mJmX ¶ÎmXJ@_Vmn__Y&
n[aUm_{df{d VĒg I amOg ñ_V_ Y&& 38 &&

`XJ MmZ~Y Y M g I _mhZ_mĒ_Z...Y&
{ZÐmbñ`à_mXmĒW VÎmm_g_Xmöv_ Y&& 39 &&

Happiness arising out of the interaction between the sense organs and the objects of gratification, which initially feels like nectar and turns out to be poisonous in the end, is *rajasic*. (18.38)

Happiness arising out of excessive sleep, lethargy, and forgetfulness, which creates addiction from beginning to end is *tamasic*. (18.39)

Comments: These two verses describe *rajasic* and *tamasic* types of happiness. *Rajasic* happiness is that which is experienced bodily through the sense organs. This excludes the happiness one feels during deep sleep (*sushupti*) as one does not have awareness of sense objects in this state. Examples of *tamasic* happiness are those experienced due to indulgence in

prohibited substances which are known to be addictive as well as unhealthy.

Universal Qualities of Nature

ॐ व॒ख॒र्ष॒न् व॒नं॑ वि॒त॒त॒म॒ द॒म॒ {॒ख॒द॒ ख॒द॒ द॒म॒ न॒ज॒... ४० &&
 ग॒त॒ द॒ह॒स॒वो॒ऽ॒स॒ {॒ख॒^॒ न॒^॒ म॒प॒ई॒ {॒^॒ज॒... ४० &&

There is no entity, among those on earth or among the deities in heavenly worlds that is not influenced by the three qualities of nature. (18.40)

Comments: This verse states that every living being is influenced by the three qualities of nature, although in different proportions. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that this does not apply to liberated souls, as this verse specifically identifies only living beings on earth, and the heavenly deities. The word ‘*punah*’ in this verse, indicating ‘and’ as per Sri Satyadhyana Teertha’s GPC, implies additional aspects not expressly stated in this verse. Sri Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya’s GB and GTN provides details of these additional aspects such as the proportion of the three qualities among living beings (humans, deities, and demons alike). For example, deities have a higher proportion of *sattv*. Sages have a mixture of *sattv* and *rajas*. Ancestral deities (*pitrus*) and heavenly musicians (*gandharvas*) have a mixture of *sattv* and *tamas*. The issue of categorization among deities based on their innate nature was addressed earlier in verse 10.6.

Categorization of Living Beings

ॐ व॒ख॒र्ष॒न् व॒नं॑ वि॒त॒त॒म॒ द॒म॒ {॒ख॒द॒ ख॒द॒ द॒म॒ न॒ज॒... ४० &&
 ह॒स॒ {॒उ॒ à॒ {॒द॒^॒स॒ {॒ज॒ न॒द॒^॒म॒ द॒à॒^॒द॒ज॒... ४१ &&

O Parantapa! The natural attributes of the four categories of people - *Brahmanas* (those with knowledge of the Lord Almighty),

Kshatriyas (the administrative class), *Vaishyas* (those involved in farming and commerce) and *Sudras* (those involved in the service sector) are governed by their innate nature. (18.41)

Comments: Previously in verse 4.13, the Lord had stated that He created four categories of people based on the innate nature of souls and their activities. It must be noted that one is not classified as such based on one's family of birth, as these classes are based on one's innate nature and talent. Details of the characteristics, attributes, and activities of these four categories of people are described in the next few verses.

e_m X_ñVn... e_mM j mpVamOd_d M ý&
k_mZ {dkmZ_mpnVŠ` ~÷H\$_ ñd^mdO_ ý&& 42 &&

e_m` VOm Y{VXmú` `Ō Mmß`nbm`Z_ ý&
XmZ_rcea^mdü j m Ì H\$_ ñd^mdO_ ý&& 43 &&

H\${fJma j dm{UÁ` dí`H\$_ ñd^mdO_ ý&
n[aM`mĚ\_H\$ H\$\_ eĐñ`m{n ñd^mdO_ ý&& 44 &&

Firm faith in the Lord, control over sense organs, celibacy, purity (internal and external), tolerance, straightforwardness, scriptural and special knowledge (wisdom), and righteousness are the natural attributes of those with innate *brahminical* qualities. (18.42)

Valour, brilliance, bravery, diligence, not running away from justified conflict, charity, and excellence in administration, are the natural attributes of those with innate *kshatriya* qualities. (18.43)

Farming, animal (cow) welfare and commerce are the natural attributes of those with innate *vaishya* qualities. Service mindedness is the natural attribute of those with innate *sudra* qualities. (18.44)

Comments: These attributes are not absolute. Living beings normally have different proportions of these attributes. Sri Rayaru states the example of King Karthaveerya Arjuna who by profession was a *kshatriya* ruler but in fact had a higher proportion of *brahminical* qualities.

ñd ñd H\$_Ê`{^aV... g{gqÕ b^V Za... Ý&
ñdH\$_ZaV... {g{Õ `Wm {dÝX{V VÀNÜ Ý&& 45 &&

One who is involved in performing prescribed duties in life as per one's natural attributes will surely achieve liberation (through acquisition of direct, divine knowledge). Listen to the way such a person would attain liberation. (18.45)

Comments: The Lord clarifies in this verse that everyone is eligible for salvation (*moksha*) regardless of their societal category. Everyone can excel in their activities if they focus on performing prescribed duties.

`V... àd{Îm^VmZm `Z gd{X WV_ Ý&
ñdH\$_Um V_ä`À` {g{Õ {dÝX{V _mZd... Ý&& 46 &&

I `mZ ñdY_m {dJU... naY_mV ñdZ{ðVmV Ý&
ñd^md{Z`V H\$_ H\$dpmsZm{V {H\$pe~f_ Ý&& 47 &&

ghO H\$_ H\$mÝV` gXmf\_{n Z Ê`OV Ý&
gdmaå^m {h Xm fU Y_Zm{¾[admdVm... Ý&& 48 &&

The Lord pervades the Universe and powers the activities of all beings. One who propitiates the Lord Almighty through the process of performing one's prescribed duties will achieve liberation. (18.46)

Even if imperfect, it is better for one to perform prescribed activities rather than perfectly perform activities prescribed to others. No one will be

tainted with sin for performing the activities prescribed based on their innate nature. (18.47)

O Son of Kunti! One should not avoid performing prescribed activities, even if there are imperfections. Just like smoke covers fire, all activities will have some imperfections. (18.48)

Comments: In these verses, the Lord stresses on the importance of one focusing on performing one's prescribed duties. The primary motivation for the Lord's sermon to Arjuna is to convince Arjuna that he should engage in the just war to protect his citizens as that is his prescribed duty. Everyone has a specific role to play in society. Performing prescribed duties without expectations is the way for one to earn the Lord's grace. The Lord who owns everything in the universe has no expectations from anyone. There are many situations where one may not be able to perform one's prescribed duties perfectly. The Lord in verse (18.47) states that one should never abandon one's prescribed duty. The Lord recognizes in verse 18.48 that no activity is ever perfect, just like fire is covered by smoke. As no one is perfect, no action can be perfect. Hence one should not avoid performing prescribed duties fearing imperfection. This concept was previously stated in verse 3.35.

Attributes Leading to Liberation

Ag°\$~{Ö... gdÌ {OVmĚ_m {dJVñnh... Ĩ&
ZîH\$â`{g{Ö na\_m gÝÝ`mgZm{YJÀN{V Ĩ&& 49 &&

One who submits all activities to the Lord, having no expectations, and acts with control over the mind overcoming temporary (worldly or heavenly) desires, will reach the sacred abode of the Lord. (18.49)

Comments: In verse 18.47, the Lord stated that one should focus on performing one's prescribed duties even if it cannot be done perfectly. In this verse, the Lord identifies the conviction that should accompany

performance of such duties. Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that one can overcome worldly desires (*asaktabuddhiḥ sarvatra*) by controlling one's mind (*jitātmā*). These are not independent actions but have a causal relationship (as sense control helps to overcome desires). In verse 18.45, the term *siddhi* was interpreted to mean *moksha*. In this verse, the word *naiṣkarmya* is used which also means *moksha*, and hence the word *siddhi* here is interpreted as the means to achieve *moksha*. The means are scriptural study, performing virtuous activities to exhaust *prarabdha karma* (consequences from accumulated deeds from one's prior births that must be experienced) etc.

The Path to Liberation

{g{Ō àám `Wm ~÷ VWm@@BZm{V {Z~mY _|ŷ&
g_mgZd H\$mŷV` {Zđm kmZñ` `m nam ŷ&& 50 &&

O Son of Kunti! The ultimate state of knowledge is spiritual fulfilment. Now, hear in brief from Me about the way a seeker achieves spiritual fulfilment and reaches the abode of Brahma. (18.50)

Comments: In the previous verse, the Lord had identified the approach for a seeker to attain the states that would lead one to liberation. This verse states that such a seeker would first reach Goddess Mahalakshmi, who would then recommend that the Lord should grant the seeker liberation (*moksha*). Sri Rayaru in GV clarifies that '*brahma*', in this verse, refers to Goddess Mahalakshmi (*apara brahma*) and not to the four faced deity Brahma or the Lord (*para brahma*). The meaning of '*brahma*' is based on the context. The interpretation here is consistent with those in verses 14.3, 14.27 and 18.54. As this chapter is about renunciation and liberation, the Lord describes the sequential steps for attaining liberation (*moksha*) in detail. In verse 18.49, it was stated that one must be rid of the effects of all activities before being eligible to attain *moksha*. The next step is to attain the abode of Mahalakshmi, and finally reach the abode of the Lord (which is described in verses 18.55 to 18.57). Given this sequence of

steps, it is also appropriate that Brahma in this verse is interpreted to mean Mahalakshmi.

~Õç {deÕ`m `°\$m YË`m@Ë\_mZ {Z`â` M Ý&
eãXmXrZ {df`mñË`ŠËd mJÛf m`ì`Xñ` M Ý&& 51&&

{d{d°\$gdr b¿dmer `Vdm,\$m`_mZg... Ý&
Ü`mZ`mJnam {ZË`dam½`g_nm{IV... Ý&& 52 &&

AhH\$ma ~b Xn H\$m_ H\$mY n[aJh_ Ý&
{d_À` {Z\_\_... emÝVm ~÷^`m` H\$ënV Ý&& 53 &&

To achieve spiritual fulfilment, one must have the following characteristics: purity of mind, control over the mind with conviction, overcoming sense gratification, overcoming obsession and avarice, avoiding crowded places, eating in moderation, focusing the mind and the body on spiritual pursuits, meditating on the Lord, detaching from worldly matters, overcoming ego, arrogance, greed, pride, lust, anger, and tranquility. (18.51) (18.52) (18.53)

Comments: As this final chapter is titled ‘Liberation and Renunciation’, in these verses, the Lord summarizes the characteristics of a seeker eligible to achieve liberation. These verses consolidate and summarize such characteristics which have been previously stated in many chapters.

Sri Vidyamanya Teertha in GPM delineates the sequence of spiritual progress based on these characteristics as follows. One who performs prescribed duties as per one’s innate nature and abilities without expectations will be able to achieve mental purity. This helps the seeker in controlling the mind and the sense organs. Detachment from sense objects helps one to overcome obsession and avarice. Such a seeker naturally prefers to be alone and avoid crowded places. Consuming *sattvic* food in moderation conditions the seeker to overcome emotions such as arrogance,

greed etc., and withdraw from unnecessary worldly happenings. The seeker is now ready to focus the mind steadfastly on the Lord and meditate. This leads the seeker to develop deep devotion in the Lord and perform activities without any material expectations.

The Lord's Grace is Essential for Liberation

~÷^V... àgbmĒ_m Z emM{V Z H\$m-{-V Ĩ&
g_... gdf ^Vf _Øq°\$ b^V nam _ Ĩ&& 54 &&

One who has achieved spiritual fulfilment by reaching Goddess Mahalakshmi (eventually reaching the Lord) has neither cravings nor regrets and has a contented mind. Such a person treats everyone equally and is supremely devoted to Me (Lord Krishna). (18.54)

Comments: A seeker with the characteristics described in previous verses will treat everyone equally (seeing the same Lord in everyone) and will develop devotion to the Lord. This concept was earlier addressed in verse 5.18.

^ŠĒ`m \_m \_A{^OmZm{V `mdmZ `ümpñ _VîdV... Ĩ&
VVm _m VîdVm kmĒdm {deV VXZÝVa _ Ĩ&& 55 &&

gdH\$_mĒ`{n gXm H\$dmUm \_Ūçnm I `... Ĩ&
_ĒàgmXmXdmsZm{V emœV nX_î` _ Ĩ&& 56 &&

MVgm gdH\$_m{U _{` gÝÝ`ñ` _Ēna... Ĩ&
~{Ō`mJ\_nm{IĒ` _{fÎm... gWV ^d Ĩ&& 57 &&

Any devotee who has understood, to the extent possible, My attributes such as My countless forms and My spatial, temporal pervasiveness in the universe will eventually attain My abode through the power of devotion. (18.55)

Such a person will offer all activities to Me while seeking refuge in Me. By My grace, that person will attain My abode which is permanent and imperishable. (18.56)

Offer all your activities to Me with mental conviction and understand that I am the Supreme One. Focus your mind on Me and follow the path of spiritual knowledge. (18.57)

Comments: In these three verses, the Lord indicates the reward for His devotees. They will achieve liberation because of their unflinching devotion to Him. The Lord expressly states that one can achieve liberation only through His grace. This indicates that while seekers choose many different paths for self-realization, ultimately it is only through the Lord's grace (*matprasādā*) that one can achieve everlasting bliss.

Sri Rayaru in GV explains the context for the use of the word '*matparah*' in this verse. If performing Vedic rituals and submitting them to the Lord can guarantee liberation, is it possible that *trividyas* (those who only go by the superficial interpretations of the **Vedas** to propitiate other deities) can also achieve *moksha*? The Lord answers by including a qualifier in verse 18.57, in the form of '*matparah*' which indicates the supremacy of the Lord Almighty. Hence, one must always have the conviction in the supremacy of the Lord to achieve liberation.

_{f V... gdXJm{U _ÈàgmXmÎm[aî`{g ĩ&
AW Mîd_hH\$mamP I mî`{g {dZ~ç{g ĩ&& 58 &&

`XhH\$mam\_{I È` Z `mĒñ` B{V _Ý`g ĩ&
{Ī`f ì`dgm`ñV àH\${VñĒdm {Z`mú`{V ĩ&& 59 &&

ñd^mdOZ H\$mÝV` {Z~Õ... ñdZ H\$_Um ĩ&
H\$V ZÀN{g `Ý\_mhmV H\${aî`ñ`dem@{n VV ĩ&& 60 &&

If you focus your mind on Me, you will overcome obstacles through My grace. If you ignore My words out of arrogance, you will perish. (18.58)

Out of ego and a sense of independence in activities, if you decide that you will not wage this war, your resolve will be broken. It is by the Lord's will that you will engage in this war. (18.59)

O Son of Kunti! Out of your innate nature, bound by delusion (resulting from attachment to near and dear ones), if you try to avoid performing your prescribed duty (of waging this just war), you will be compelled to act even if you are not so inclined. (18.60)

Comments: After having described the philosophical principles related to prescribed duties, the Lord now gets back to the issue at hand, which is convincing Arjuna about the path forward. In these three verses, the Lord instructs Arjuna on the perils of not performing one's prescribed duties. The Lord had stated that one who focuses on performing prescribed duties will overcome obstacles through His grace. However, if Arjuna were to ignore the Lord's advice, he would experience downfall. The Lord goes a step further and informs Arjuna that he would wage the war even if he were not inclined to do so, as that was His will. Sri Vadiraja Teertha in BGL provides another interpretation for the word '*avaśa*' in 18.60. This word also means 'one who is under the control of the Lord' (as '*a*' means Lord and '*vaśa*' means 'under the control'). In this case, the context is that Arjuna will end up waging the war under the control of the Lord Almighty as that was His will.

Bœa... gd^VmZm öÔe@OZ {Vð{V î&
^m_`Z gd^Vm{Z `Ýîmê\$Tm{Z _m` `m î&& 61 &&

O Arjuna! The omnipotent Lord, residing in the hearts of all machine-like bodies of living beings, propels them to perform various activities through His own free will. (18.61)

Comments: In the previous verses the Lord stated that one achieves liberation through His grace. In this verse, the Lord goes a step further and states that He is present in the hearts of all living beings and propels them into action. The Lord uses the word ‘*yantrā*’ (machine) to describe the physical bodies of living beings. Just as a machine relies on an engine for running, every physical body depends on its heart for proper functioning. The Lord states that He resides in the hearts of all living beings. This concept was also discussed in verse 15.15, where the Lord had stated that He resides in everyone’s hearts.

Sri Vidyamanya Teertha in his GPM states that this single verse can be considered to contain the core principles of the entire **Gita** on the basis of the logic of ‘*sthalee pulaka nyaya*’ (where one needs to examine only one grain of rice to verify if the entire pot of rice is cooked).

Devotion and Surrender

V_d eaU JÀN gd^mdZ ^maV ĩ&
VĒàgṁXmĒnam empYV ñWmZ àmbñ`{g emceV_ ĩ&& 62 &&

O Bharata! Surrender only to Him completely. By His grace, you will develop deep faith and will ultimately reach the Lord’s eternal abode which is full of infinite bliss. (18.62)

Comments: As indicated in the previous verse, the independent Lord causes everyone to act. Hence, it is important for one to get rid of ego and surrender to the Lord. Sri Rayaru in GV states that ‘*śāśvatam*’ (eternal) here refers to *Vaikunta*, the abode of the Lord which is embodied by Goddess Mahalakshmi. Also, in this verse, the Lord uses third person to indirectly refer to Himself. Sri Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya’s GTN states that the use of third person as opposed to using the first person clarifies the concepts much more forcefully.

B{V V kñZ_»`mV JøX JøVa \_`m V&
{d_í`VXefU `WÀN{g VWm H\$é V&& 63 &&

I have imparted to you the most confidential of all confidential knowledge. Contemplate on this completely and do as you wish. (18.63)

Comments: At first glance, the Lord's concluding direction to Arjuna stated in '*yatheccchasi tathā kuru*' seems to indicate that the Lord gave freedom to Arjuna to do as he wishes. Sri Rayaru in GV based on Sri Madhwacharya's GTN states that this is a rhetorical direction from the Lord and is not to be interpreted literally. The real purport of this direction is to ask Arjuna if he will act against the Lord's teachings even after contemplating on them. This will be clear after a review of Arjuna's response in 18.73 where he states that he would act as per Krishna's words (*kariṣye vacanam tava*) and not as per his own wishes.

gdJøV_ ^`... eU _ na _ dM... &
Bïm@{g _ ÑT_{V VWm dú`m{ V {hV_ V&& 64 &&

Listen to some more of this Supreme principle which is extremely confidential. I am continuing My supreme teaching to you as you are very dear to Me. (18.64)

Comments: After having concluded His teachings on the ways and means (*prameya* = principles) for one to traverse the spiritual path, the Lord now gives Arjuna the concrete steps (*sadhana* = actions) that he needs to take to achieve success here and hereafter. Previously in 12.20, the Lord has identified the characteristics of a devotee who is dear to Him. By declaring in this verse that Arjuna is dear to Him, the Lord is confirming that Arjuna has all the desirable traits of an ideal devotee.

The Ultimate Commandment

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय
ॐ द्रिष्टुं भगवत्पदं वासुदेवमुपासीत ॥ ६५ ॥

As you are dear to Me, immerse your mind in Me. Place your devotion in Me. Propitiate only Me. Prostrate before Me. I promise you truthfully that you will reach My abode. (18.65)

Comments: The Lord instructs Arjuna to worship only Him with the four-way procedure – through the mind, through devotion, through propitiation and through salutation. By using the word ‘*satyam*’, the Lord is assuring Arjuna that there should not be any doubt in his mind about him achieving liberation.

Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha in BGS has identified this verse as containing the essence of this entire chapter. Arjuna was asking for specific directions from Krishna as he was indecisive about the war. In this verse, the Lord specifically directs Arjuna to worship Him through the four-way procedure and confirms that Arjuna would achieve *moksha* following this path. Hence this verse can be considered as the core verse of this chapter (which is known as *moksha sanyasa yoga*).

अहं कुरुष्व भगवन् सर्वं त्वं कुरुष्व मे ॥ ६६ ॥
Ah ḥṁ kuruṣṣva bhagavan sarvaṁ tvam kuruṣṣva me ॥ 66 ॥

Renounce all activities (not related to the Lord or performed with expectations of temporary rewards) completely and surrender exclusively to Me. I will liberate you from all your sins and grant you bliss. Do not lament. (18.66)

Comments: This is a continuation of the previous verse where the Lord had instructed Arjuna to engage in exclusive four-way worship of Him. One should not interpret ‘*sarvadharmān parityajya*’ to mean that one

should renounce all activities. The Lord had instructed Arjuna many times to focus on performing the prescribed duty of waging the war (verses (2.37), (4.42), (11.33)). Also, Sri Madhwacharya in GB reminds one that the Lord Himself had stated in verse 18.11 that renouncing activities (*tyaga*) mean relinquishing rewards from activities.

Sri Vidyeshā Teerthā in his book, **Prana Tattva in the Gita [GPH]**, provides an alternate interpretation for this verse based on the word derivation of ‘*māmekam*’ as *ma* + *me* + *kam*, where *ma* = do not; *me* = to Me, *ka* = Vayudeva. In comments to verse 11.40, it was indicated that the word ‘*sarva*’ also refers to the Lord Almighty (based on the Lord’s attribute of omnipresence) and this interpretation is supported by Upanishads and **Vishnu Sahasra Nama**. Hence, *sarva dharma* refers to *Dharmic* activities related to the Lord. The reference to the deity Vayudeva here is in recognition of his status as supreme among all living beings (*jivas*). In comments to verse 1.31, Sri Rayaru in GV interpreted the word ‘*keshava*’, referring to Lord Krishna as one who controls even deities ‘*ka*’ (Brahma, Vayudeva) and ‘*isha*’ (Rudra). Now, with the above word derivation for ‘*māmekam*’, verse 18.66 can also be interpreted as follows – “Do not renounce *Dharmic* activities (related to the Lord), surrender to Vayudeva and Me. I will liberate you from all your sins and grant you bliss. Do not lament”.

Eligibility for Studying the Gita

BX V ZmVnñH\$m` Zm^o\$m` H\$XmMZ ĩ&
Z Mmelfd dñÀ` Z M \_m `m@ä`g`{V ĩ&& 67 &&

Do not impart this knowledge to one who does not practice austerity. Never teach this to one who is not devoted to Me and to one who does not serve one’s teachers. This should never ever be taught to one who has hatred towards Me. (18.67)

Comments: This verse identifies four characteristics of those who are unsuitable for receiving the teachings of the **Gita**. Sri Rayaru in GV provides an interesting interpretation for the use of the word ‘cā’ (which means ‘and’) in this verse to relate these four characteristics. This word implies progressive harm in teaching the **Gita** to such categories of people. Teaching those who are not austere is harmful. Teaching those who do not serve teachers/elders is more harmful than teaching those who are not austere. Teaching those who are not devoted to the Lord is even more harmful than teaching those who do not serve teachers/elders. Finally, teaching those who have hatred towards the Lord is most harmful. The use of the word ‘kadācana’ (meaning ‘never’) indicates that even if someone were to preach the **Gita** to those who may not be sufficiently austere or may not adequately serve their elders/teachers, it should never be taught to those not devoted to the Lord.

Rewards for Spreading the Knowledge of the Gita

ḥ BX na Jø _Ø°\$îd{^Ymñ`{V î&
^q°\$ _{` nam H\$Edm \_m\_dî`Ē`ge`... î&& 68 &&

Z M Vñ _mÝ_Zî`f H\$üÝ \_{à`H\$îm _... î&
^dVm Z M _ Vñ _mX AÝ`... {à`Vam ^d î&& 69 &&

One who imparts this highly secretive knowledge to My devotees will develop deep devotion in Me and will reach My abode. Let there not be any doubt in this. (18.68)

There is none dearer to Me among humans than one who imparts this knowledge to My ardent devotees. No one else in this world will be dearer to Me than such a person even in future. (18.69)

Comments: The Lord indicates that the one who imparts the knowledge of the **Gita** is very dear to Him at the current time and will be so even in future. Such a person will develop deep devotion in the Lord and

will ultimately reach Him. This is the power of learning, understanding, and then teaching the **Gita** to the faithful. The Lord specifically identifies those among humans (*manuṣyeṣu*) who are dearest to Him. Sri Rayaru in GV states that the intention of specifically identifying humans here is to clarify that the deities also impart the knowledge of the **Gita** and they will be eligible for superior rewards.

Rewards for Studying the Gita

AÜ`î`V M ` B\_ Yâ` gdmX_md`m... V&
kñZ`kZ VZmh` Bî... ñ`m_{V _ _{V... V&& 70 &&

It is My opinion that one who studies this noble conversation between us, is in fact, propitiating Me (Dharma) through the sacrificial ritual of spiritual knowledge. (18.70)

Comments: Studying the **Gita** also has its rewards. Sri Rayaru states in GV that the Lord also goes by the name of Dharma as He is the one who supports everyone and everything in this universe. Hence studying subjects related to the Lord is a means to realize the Lord.

Rewards for Listening to the Gita

I ÕmdmZZg`ü eU`mX{n `m Za... V&
gm@{n _°\$. e^mZ bñH\$mZ àñßZ`mV nÊ`H\$_U_ V&& 71 &&

Those who listen to the **Gita** with faith and devotion and without envy towards the Lord will also be rid of sins. They will reach the most auspicious destination and will be in the company of exalted liberated souls. (18.71)

Comments: This verse describes the rewards for eligible seekers who listen to the great conversation (the **Gita**). Sri Rayaru in GV draws attention to the use of the word ‘*api*’ in this verse (‘*api*’ means ‘also’)

which implies that those who listen to the **Gita** also achieve the higher worlds. So, it goes without saying that those who strive harder performing activities such as studying the **Gita** and teaching the **Gita** to devotees will reap even higher rewards such as exuberant bliss in *moksha*.

H\$ f XV IV nmW Ēd`H\$mJU MVgm ĩ&
H\$ f XkmZg_mh... àZi`ñV YZÄO` ĩ&& 72 &&

O Partha! Did you listen to My words with concentration? O Dhananjaya! Has the veil of delusion caused by ignorance been dispelled? (18.72)

Comments: After completing His detailed sermons and answering all of Arjuna's questions, the Lord asks Arjuna if all his doubts have been cleared. The Lord reiterates that Arjuna's delusion and doubts are a result of his ignorance and that He has answered all his questions.

Arjuna's Reawakening

AOZ CdmM ĩ&
Zi`m \_mh... ñ\_{VbãYm ĒdĒàgmXmÝ\_`m@À`V ĩ&
pñWVm@pñ_ JvgÝXh... H\$[aî` dMZ Vd ĩ&& 73 &&

Arjuna said: O Achyuta! My delusion is dispelled. Through Your grace, my sense of duty has been restored. I stand with deep conviction, with all my doubts removed. I will execute Your command. (18.73)

Comments: In this verse Arjuna responds to Lord Krishna enthusiastically by stating that his delusion has dissipated, and he is now firmly convinced about his duty of waging the war to protect his citizens. There are three important points that must be noted here -

(i) The Lord had asked Arjuna in the previous verse if Arjuna had listened to His sermon with attention and got all his doubts removed.

Arjuna states that his doubts have been cleared because of the Lord's grace (*tvatprasādāt*). This implies that in addition to one's effort, one needs the Lord's grace to succeed in any venture

(ii) Arjuna indicates that his sense of duty has been awakened. This implies that Arjuna (who is an incarnation of deity Indra and was well versed in divine knowledge) had knowledge about his prescribed duties, but that knowledge had been temporarily lost. Hence, he is stating that his memory of divine knowledge has returned (*smṛtir labdhā*)

(iii) In verse 18.63, it was stated that the Lord's concluding direction to Arjuna stated in '*yatheccchasi tathā kuru*' was a rhetorical direction from Him. It was by no means granting Arjuna the freedom to do what he wished. In this verse, Arjuna does not state that he would act as per his wishes but that he would act as per the Lord's words - '*kariṣye vacanam tava*'. This confirms that the direction from Krishna to Arjuna in verse 18.63 was indeed rhetorical. Acting as per the Lord's words is the real meaning of *sharanagati* (surrender) indicated in 18.66.

Sanjaya's Euphoric Epilogue

gO` CdM M̃
BĒ`h dmgXdñ` nmWñ` M_hmĒ_Z... Ṽ
gdM{___I mf_AØV am_hfU_ Ṽ&& 74 &&

ì`mgàgmXmV lVdmZ EVX Jø_h na_ Ṽ
`mJ `mJœamV H\$îUmV gmj mV H\$W`V... ñd`_ Ṽ&& 75&&

Sanjaya said: Thus, I heard the amazing, unheard of, electrifying conversation between Vasudeva (Krishna) and Arjuna, the great souls. (18.74)

By the Grace of Lord Almighty Vedavyasa (another form of Krishna), I was able to directly listen to this most confidential spiritual

discourse (*yoga*) from Lord Krishna Himself, the supreme Lord of *Yoga*. (18.75)

Comments: Sanjaya was granted Divine Vision by Lord Vedavyasa so that he could witness the happenings on the battleground remotely and relay them to King Dhrutarashtra. Hence Sanjaya salutes Lord Vedavyasa here.

amOZ gñ_Ē` gñ\_Ē` gdmX{ ‘_ØV_ ĩ&
H\$edmOZ`m... nÊ` öî`m{ M_h_h... ĩ&& 76 &&

Vf gñ_Ē` gñ\_Ē` ê\$n_Ē`ØV ha... ĩ&
{dñ_`m \_hmZ amOZ öî`m{ M nZ...nZ... ĩ&& 77 &&

O King! By repeatedly recollecting this wonderful, sacred conversation between Lord Krishna and Arjuna, I am rejoicing again and again. (18.76)

O King! There is no end to my amazement as I recollect the wonderful Universal form of Lord Almighty Sri Hari. I am repeatedly rejoicing. (18.77)

Comments: Sanjaya is repeatedly rejoicing, remembering the sacred conversation (the **Gita**) and the Universal form of the Lord which he was also able to behold. He describes the event as yielding him ‘*punyaṁ*’ (rewards hereafter). Previously in verse 11.10, Sanjaya had briefly described the wonderful, universal form of the Lord which he was also able to behold.

`ì `mJœa... H\$îUm `ì nmWmYZYa... ĩ&
Vì I r{dO`m ^{VYdm Zr{V_{V__ ĩ&& 78 &&

It is my firm belief that wherever there is the presence of Lord Krishna (the Lord of all *Yogas*) and Arjuna, the holder of the bow, there will be abundance of wealth, victory, glory, and everlasting justice. (18.78)

Comments: Sensing Dhrutarashtra's curiosity about the side that won the war, Sanjaya indirectly answers the king by stating that the side that has Krishna and Arjuna will always be victorious.

This verse can also be interpreted to indicate victory for the side that had the presence of Lord Krishna and deity Vayudeva. HH Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha provides the following explanation for interpreting this verse as indicating primarily the presence of deity Vayudeva along with Lord Krishna. As the **Gita** is a direct teaching by Lord Krishna, only Vayudeva (who is superior most among the individual souls) can comprehend the teachings fully. Arjuna, who has an instance of Indra can receive the teachings in the **Gita** only because of special powers granted to him by Vayudeva. Sri Madhwacharya has stated in MBTN, Chapter 12, verse 129 that Vayudeva had a special presence in Arjuna in the form of 'Veera'. In a conversation between Hanuman (a direct incarnation of Vayudeva) and Bheema (another incarnation of Vayudeva) in the **Mahabharata**, Hanuman assures Bheema that during the Mahabharata war, he would be present on the flag of Arjuna's chariot and destroy the enemies by a mere roar. This is the reason for Arjuna being referred to as '*kapi dwaja*' (verse 1.20). This incident is narrated by Sri Madhwacharya in MBTN, chapter 22, verse 288. The phrase '*yatra pāṛthodhanurdharaḥ*' in this verse can also be derived as '*yatra pāṛtho adhanurdharaḥ*', where *partha* (son of Kunti) can be a reference to Bheema and *adhanurdharaḥ* is an adjective that can be applied to Bheema as one who can fight a war without any weapon (as *dhanus* means weapon). **Atharva Upanishat (4.5)** compares a bow to the primordial syllable *Om* (which is the root of all knowledge), the arrow to the mind of a seeker and the Lord Almighty to the target, implying that one must focus one's mind on the Lord using the wisdom of the **Vedas** to reach Him. Sri Madhwacharya in his commentary on **Taittiriya Upanishat**, interprets Bheema as the holder of all Vedic

knowledge and hence the word ‘*dhanurdharaḥ*’ (holder of bow) can be interpreted to mean Bheema [GPH]

Now, the verse 18.78 can also be interpreted as follows - It is my firm belief that wherever there is the presence of Lord Krishna (the Lord of all *Yogas*), and Vayudeva, there will be abundance of wealth, victory, glory, and everlasting justice.

A{V ‘ ‘ “b ûcH\$M:
 nUmXmf ‘ hm{dîUmJuV ‘ m{ IĒ¶ beV... &
 {Zê\$U H\$V VZ àr¶V ‘ gXm {d^... &&

Concluding Benedictory Verse (Gita Bhashya): Sri Madhwacharya concludes his **Gita Bhashya** with this verse: In this work on the **Gita**, we have described in brief, the defectless Lord Almighty Sri Vishnu who is full of infinite auspicious attributes. Let our Lord be pleased with us.

AefJUnUm` XmfXam` {dîUd &
 Z_... I ràUZWm` ^o\$^riàXm{`Z &&

Concluding Benedictory Verse (Gita Vivruti): Sri Raghavendra Teertha concludes his **Gita Vivruti** with this verse: Salutations to the defectless Lord Vishnu who is full of infinite auspicious attributes, who is the Lord of Sri Mahalakshmi and Sri Vayudeva and who grants all auspicious wishes of His devotees.

Summary of Chapter 18

This chapter has 78 verses. The first 55 verses contain the conversation between Arjuna and Krishna regarding clarifications on concepts previously covered in other chapters. The Lord concludes His teaching in the next 17 verses. Arjuna thanks the Lord in the 73rd verse. The last 5 verses have concluding remarks from Sanjaya. Arjuna begins by

asking Krishna what the difference between renunciation (*saṁnyāsa*) and relinquishment (*tyāga*) was, as both seem to imply the same. In verse (5.2), it was stated that renunciation (*sanyāsa*) was essential to attain liberation (*moksha*), and in verse 12.12, relinquishment (*tyāga*) was lauded as a superior means to attain liberation (*moksha*). Arjuna wants to know about relative merits of these two approaches. The Lord provides answers to Arjuna's questions with a detailed description of the various aspects of renunciation and relinquishment in verses 18.2 to 18.12. In chapter 5 (verses 14, 15) the concept of doership of activities was briefly described. This aspect is expanded in this chapter in verses 18.13 to 18.18. In chapter 2, verse 45, it was stated that a seeker must strive to understand the inner meanings of rituals indicated in the **Vedas** and not just accept the superficial meaning. This point is elaborated in this chapter. In chapter 14, the influence and impact of the three qualities of nature on living beings was discussed. In this chapter, additional aspects of the qualities of nature are elaborated in verses 18.19 to 18.39. Previously, in verse 4.13, the Lord identified the categorization of the society based on the innate nature and activities of individuals. In this chapter, this concept is elaborated in verses 18.40 to 18.48. Verses 18.49 to 18.55 provide details of the methods for one to achieve salvation (*moksha*), as that is the goal of all living beings. Verses 18.68 to 18.71 describes the glory of the **Gita** (more details on Gita's glory appears in Annexure 1). Sanjaya concludes his commentary on the battleground to King Dhrutarashtra in verses 18.74 to 18.78 and indirectly answers the King's question about the side that won the war by stating that the side that has Lord Krishna and the warrior Arjuna will always be victorious.

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End of Chapter 18

Annexure 1 – The Glory of the Gita

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gd XdmíM F\$¶¶m ¶m{JZ... nbJmíM ¶ &
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JrVm ‘ na ‘ m {dÚm ~÷ê\$nm Z ge¶... &
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{MXmZÝXZ H\$îUZ àm°\$m ñd ‘ I Vm@OZ ‘ &
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 g ʔm{V ZaVm‘ ʔmdÝ‘ ÝdVa‘ dgYa && 14 &&
 JrVmʔm... íbmH\$XeH\$‘ gá n#m MViʔ‘ &
 ŪîrZH\$‘ VXY‘ dñ íbmH\$mZm‘ ʔm... nRḡa... && 15 &&
 MÝḌbmH\$‘ dñ\$ZñV dfñUm‘ ʔV‘ Yd‘ &
 JrVmñmRg‘ mʔ°\$m ‘Vm ‘mZfVm‘ dOV && 16 &&
 JrVmāʔmg‘ nZ... H\$Ēdm b^V ‘{°\$‘ îñ‘ m‘ &
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 JrVm‘ m{ I Ēʔ ~hdñ ^Oñm OZH\$mXʔ... &
 {ZYVH\$ë‘ fñ bmH\$ JrVm ʔmVm... na‘ ‘ nX‘ && 20 &&
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 gV CdmM -
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 JrVmV M nRŪñV ʔX°\$ VĒ‘ \$b‘ b^V && 23 &&

Summary: This passage which extols the virtues of the **Gita** is from the epic **Varaha Purana**. Goddess Dharadevi (the governing deity for earth) asks Lord Vishnu how human beings (earth dwellers) can realize the Lord when they are preoccupied with worldly afflictions. The Lord teaches her about the glory of the **Gita** which helps human beings navigate the river of

worldly afflictions. The greatness of the **Gita** as stated by the Lord can be summarized as follows.

- Those who are engaged in the practice of reciting the **Gita** will not be entangled by their actions.
- The place where one finds books on the **Gita** or ongoing lectures on the **Gita** is said to be the home of all great, sacred rivers and pilgrimage centers.
- It is also the place where great sages and *yogis* reside. The Lord also resides there.
- The greatness of the **Gita** derives from the fact that they are the words of the Lord Himself in the form of Krishna, who is full of infinite auspicious attributes.
- One who recites and studies the **Gita** daily will attain liberation.
- One who utters the word ‘Gita’ at the time of leaving one’s body will reach the Lord.
- Even those who have sinned will be rid of their sins if they have read, analyzed, and understood the true meaning of the **Gita**. They too achieve salvation.
- Great emperors such as Janaka reached higher destinations due to their study of the **Gita**.

One must study the glory of the **Gita** after completing the study of the **Gita** for maximum benefit.

ॐ Ir JrVm ‘mhmĒāṇ ‘ gnU‘ ॐ

End of Glory of the Gita

Annexure 2 – The Bhagavad Gita: Philosophical Interpretation

The verses in the **Gita** have multiple meanings, each of them being consistent with the overall narrative. The first and the obvious interpretation is based on the historical meaning of the verses. Another subtle interpretation is based on the philosophical meaning of the verses. Sri Madhwacharya places a lot of importance on the philosophical aspects of the **Gita** by stating in his **Mahabharata Tatparya Nirnaya** (MBTN 2.146) that the **Mahabharata** is not just a historical account of the lives of the Pandavas and the Kauravas; it also is a deeply philosophical work. Sri Pangari Sreenivasacharya's **Gita Vivruti Adhyatma Artha** [GVAA] has examples of multiple interpretations of the verses in the **Gita**.

It is said that the **Bhagavad Gita** is an embodiment of *dharma* (the righteous way of living). This is further confirmed by reviewing the first letter of the first verse (1.1) – *dhar* and the last letter of the last verse 18.78 – *ma*. Thus, the **Gita**, which is encapsulated between the letters, *dhar* and *ma*, is an embodiment of *dharma*.

To illustrate the philosophical interpretation of the **Gita**, Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha provides an interesting interpretation of the first MTNP and last verses which is summarized below -

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__H\$m... nmÊSdmüd {H\$_H\$dV gÄO` ĩ&& 1.1&&

The word *dhṛtarāṣṭra* is comprised of the words *dhṛta* and *rāṣṭra*, where *rāṣṭra* = worldly miseries and *dhṛta* = the one bearing. Hence, the name *dhṛtarāṣṭra* represents a student, and indeed, all of us who are immersed in worldly afflictions. The name *sañjaya* is made up of root words *samyak* and *jayati* (the one who has soundly conquered worldly miseries) and represents a teacher who has overcome worldly miseries.

Thus, this verse represents a conversation between a student and a teacher. *dharmakṣetra* is based on the word *dharma* (derived from the word *dharana*, the one who protects, in other words the Lord Almighty). *kurukṣetra* refers to *kṣetra* with the qualifier *kuru* which refers to the one who is duty bound (as derived from the root word *kru* which indicates action). Hence *kurukṣetra* can mean a person's physical body. The word *māmakā* is used by Dhritarashtra to mean 'my clan' where 'my' signifies ego which represents the demoniac forces in our bodies. In another interpretation, the word '*ma*' represents knowledge and *mamaka* means knowledge that is not evolved (or ignorance). The word *pāṇḍavā* is derived from root words *padi* and *gati* which means moving towards knowledge, and hence is a representation of the angelic forces in our bodies who embody knowledge (*jnana*). Thus, the Kauravas represent ignorance (*ajnana*) and the Pandavas embody knowledge (*jnana*).

With these interpretations, the first verse can now be translated as follows:

Dhritarashtra (one who is enmeshed in worldly affliction) said -

O Sanjaya (the one who has soundly conquered worldly miseries)! In Kurukshetra (the physical body) which houses dharmakṣetra (the Lord Almighty), what was the outcome of the struggle (internal struggle) between my clan (demoniac forces represented by ignorance) and the Pandavas (angelic forces representing the knowledge)?

The central concept in the philosophical interpretation of verse (1.1) is about the internal struggle between the angelic and demoniac forces and its impact on one's activities.

Now, the philosophical interpretation of the last verse follows -

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥ १८. ७८ ॥
Vī I r{dO`m ^{VYd m Zr{V_{V__ V&& 18. 78 &&

This verse is the concluding response by Sanjaya to King Dhrutarashtra's question in verse (1.1). Here, Lord Krishna is described as *yogeshvaraḥ* (the one who controls all paths and ways to achieve liberation) since He has described various paths such as *karma yoga*, *jnana yoga*, *dhyana yoga*, and *bhakti yoga* for a seeker to achieve liberation. Arjuna, an incarnation of the deity Indra with an instance of the serpent deity Sesha (*nara*) in him is knowledgeable about performing prescribed duties and represents living beings. With these interpretations, verse 18.78 can now be translated as follows -

All actions, where there is the presence of Lord Almighty Krishna (the Lord of all yogas), and Arjuna (a representative of all living beings), will through the Lord's grace result in great riches and success, eventually leading to liberation.

In summary, the first verse posed a question about the outcome of the internal struggle between demoniac forces (ignorance) and angelic forces (knowledge) within all living beings, and the last verse answers by stating that all actions where there is the presence of the Lord and Arjuna (one who is aware of prescribed duties) will succeed fully.

Annexure 3 – The Bhagavad Gita and Dvaita Vedanta

Sri Madhwacharya, the great saint, and philosopher of the 12th century was a proponent of Dvaita Vedanta (philosophy of theistic dualism) built on the foundational premise of the difference between individual souls and the Supreme Soul (the Lord Almighty). Sri Madhwacharya has composed over 37 works with seminal commentaries on the **Gita**, the **Vedas**, the **Upanishads**, the **Brahma Sutras**, and epics such as the **Ramayana** and the **Mahabharata**. In all his works, he quotes extensively from these scriptures. In fact, his very first literary work was his commentary on the **Gita (Gita Bhashya)**. Sri Vyasa Teertha (16th century), a great philosopher and scholar from Sri Madhwa's lineage has summarized the philosophy of Sri Madhwacharya in a single verse, popularly known as *nava prameya* (the 9 tenets). In this section, the relationship between these nine tenets and the teachings from the **Gita** are described to emphasize the scriptural basis for Dvaita Vedanta.

Sri Vyasa Teertha's Nava Prameya

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 '{³VZOg I mZ^Va' b¶^³Vü VÊg¶YZ
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The Nine Tenets of Sri Madhwa's Philosophy

1. Lord Sri Hari is the Supreme Being
2. This world is real
3. The differences (between the Lord, the individual souls, and inert objects) are real
4. Individual souls are under the control of Lord Sri Hari
5. Individual souls have gradation in attributes
6. Liberation is the ultimate experience of innate happiness
7. Pure devotion to the Lord leads to liberation

8. Direct knowledge, inference and scriptures are the evidence to establish the truth

9. The Lord is knowable through the **Vedas**

As will be seen, these nine principles are woven throughout the verses in the **Gita**. Following are some selected verses from the **Gita** to establish their correspondence with these nine tenets.

1. Supremacy of the Lord Almighty: Lord Sri Hari is the Supreme Entity

- (i) Verse 7.7: The Lord states *mattaḥ parataram nānyat kimcid asti* – there is no entity in the universe that is superior to Me.
- (ii) Verse 8.20: The Lord states *paras tasmāt tu bhāvonyo* – The Lord is the entity that is independent, superior to and different from everything in the universe.
- (iii) Verse 15.16: The Lord states *uttamaḥ puruṣastvanyaḥ paramātmety udāhṛtaḥ* - the entity known as Paramatma is superior to and different from all other entities.
- (iv) Verse 11.43: Arjuna states *na tvatsamosty abhyadhikaḥ kutonyo* – there is no one equal to You (Krishna) in this universe. How can there be any one more superior?

2. Realism of the world: The world is real

- (i) Verse 9.10: The Lord states *mayādhyakṣeṇa prakṛtiḥ sūyate sacarācaram* – under My direct supervision, Mother Nature creates this world made of movable and immovable objects (The Lord uses the term *ādhyakṣa* which is derived from the word *akṣa* which means seeing. The Lord physically oversees the process of creation of the universe. As the Lord is real, so is the universe).
- (ii) Verse 11.7: The Lord states *ihaikastham jagat kṛtsnam paśyādya sacarācaram* – look at the entire universe (*jagat*) situated in Me (The Lord grants Arjuna divine vision to view the entire universe within Him).

(iii) Verse 16.8: The Lord states *asatyam apratiṣṭhaṁ te jagadāhur anīśvaram*. They say that the world is unreal and is not dependent on the Lord Almighty (The Lord describes the characteristics of those with demoniac nature and states that they view the world (*jagat*) as unreal, thereby clarifying the principle of the reality of the world).

3. The fivefold differences (*Pancha Bheda*) are real

The three entities in the universe, namely, the Lord Almighty, the individual souls, and inert objects are different from one another.

(i) Verse 13.22: *puruṣaḥ prakṛtistho hi bhuṅkte prakṛtijān guṇān*. Individual souls residing in the body, comprised of the elements of nature, experience emotions through contact with the three attributes of nature which are inert objects. This establishes the difference between individual souls and inert objects.

(ii) Verse 13.31: *yadā bhūtapṛthagbhāvam ekastham anupaśyati*. The same Lord resides in multitudes of different (*pṛthak*) living beings. The entire 17th chapter is about the three types of intrinsic faith in living beings as indicated by the Lord in verse (17.2) *trividhā bhavati śraddhā dehinām sā svabhāvajā* - Living beings are predisposed based on their innate nature into one of three qualities - *sattvic*, *rajasic* or *tamasic*. This establishes the differences among individual souls.

(iii) Verses 13.6 and 13.7 enumerated the different components of nature that impact an individual's personality. This establishes the differences among inert objects.

(iv) Verse 7.4: *bhūmir āponalo vāyuḥ khaṁ mano buddhir eva ca | ahaṁkāra itīyaṁ me bhinnā prakṛtir aṣṭadhā||*. The Lord states - Earth, water, fire, wind, space, mind, intellect, and individuation are the eight different parts of inert nature that are under My control. This establishes the difference between the Lord and inert objects, and among inert objects.

(v) Verse 15.16: The Lord states *uttamaḥ puruṣastvanyaḥ paramātmety udāhṛtaḥ* - the entity known as Paramatma is superior

to and different from all other entities. This establishes the difference between the Lord and individual souls.

4. Individual souls are dependent on the Lord (they do not have independent doership - *kartṛtva*)

(i) Verse 5.14: The Lord states *na kartṛtvaṁ na karmāṇi* – living beings cannot act independently.

(ii) Verse 15.9: The Lord states *śrotraṁ cakṣuḥ sparśanaṁ ca rasanāṁ ghrāṇam eva ca| adhiṣṭhāya manaś cāyaṁ viṣayān upasevate||* - The Lord resides in the sense organs - ears, eyes, skin, tongue, nose, and mind and verily consumes the (righteous) objects of sense pursuits. This clarifies that living beings are dependent on the independent Lord Almighty.

(iii) Verse 18.61: The Lord states *īśvaraḥ sarvabhūtānāṁ hr̥ddeśerjuna tiṣṭhati| bhrāmayan sarvabhūtāni yantrārūḍhāni māyayā||* - O Arjuna! The omnipotent Lord, residing in the hearts of all living beings, propels them to perform various activities through His own free will. This further confirms that living beings are dependent on the independent Lord Almighty.

5. Individual souls have gradations

Individual souls have different innate capabilities and eventually attain different states.

(i) Verse 16.5: The Lord states *daivī saṁpad vimokṣāya* - Divine nature paves the way for levels of liberation. *vimokṣā* is derived as *vividha + mokṣā*, meaning different levels of bliss in liberation based on the innate abilities (*yogyata*) and efforts (*sadhana*) of souls.

(ii) Verse 17.2: The Lord states *trividhā bhavati śraddhā dehinām sāvabhāvajā* - Living beings are predisposed based on their innate nature into one of three qualities - *sattvic*, *rajasic* or *tamasic*.

(iii) Verse 3.42: The Lord states *indriyāṇi parāṇy āhur indriyebhyaḥ param manaḥ| manasas tu parā buddhir yo buddheḥ paratas tu saḥ||* - It is said that the sense organs are superior, and the mind is more

superior to them. The intellect is superior to the mind and ultimate consciousness is even more superior to the intellect. Here the entities of the sense organs, the mind and the intellect refer to the respective governing deities. This establishes gradation among the deities.

6. Liberation is the ultimate state of innate happiness

(i) Verse 14.27: The Lord states *śāśvatasya ca dharmasya sukhasyaikāntikasya ca*. Moksha is defined as the state of pure, unending bliss.

(ii) Verse 18.71: The Lord states *sopi muktaḥ śubhāml lokān prāpnuyāt puṇyakarmaṇām* – (the one who listens to our conversations) will be liberated and will be in the world of exalted, virtuous souls.

7. Pure devotion leads to liberation

(i) Verse 8.22 – The Lord states *puruṣaḥ sa paraḥ pārtha bhaktyā labhyas tv ananyayā* - The Supreme One is reachable only by pure, unadulterated devotion.

(ii) Verse 11.54 – the Lord states *bhaktyā tv ananyayā śakya aham evamvidhorjuna* - Only by single minded devotion can one understand Me.

(iii) Verse 12.20 – the Lord states *śraddadhānā matparamā bhaktās tetīva me priyāḥ* - One who observes these methods sincerely, with deep faith and devotion in Me, is indeed very dear to Me.

(iv) Verse 18.68 – the Lord states *ya imaṁ paramaṁ guhyaṁ madbhakteṣv abhidhāsyati| bhaktim mayi parāṁ kṛtvā mām evaiṣyaty asaṁśayaḥ||* - One who imparts this highly secretive knowledge to My devotees will develop deep devotion to Me and will reach My abode. Let there not be any doubt in this.

(v) Verse 14.26 – The Lord states *mām ca yovyabhicāreṇa bhaktiyogena sevate| sa guṇān samatītyaitān brahmabhūyāya kalpate||* - One who worships Me with pure, unalloyed devotion will indeed be able to reach beyond the three qualities and attain the

abode of Mother Nature - Goddess Mahalakshmi (which is also My abode).

8. The three types of evidence are the sources of knowledge

The methods of obtaining true knowledge constitute a fundamental part of epistemology. Sri Madhwacharya defines the means of knowledge (*pramanas*) as *pratyaksha* (sense perception), *anumana* (inference) and *agama* (scriptural). *Pratyaksha* is the contact of a defectless sense organ with a defectless object. *Anumana* is defectless syllogism. *Aagama* is defectless verbal composition (ex: **Vedas**).

(i) Verse 11.5: The Lord states *paśya me pārtha rūpāṇi śataśoṭha sahastraśaḥ | nānāvidhāni divyāni nānāvarṇākṛtīni ca ||* The Lord asks Arjuna to see His infinite forms. The Lord had given Arjuna Divine Vision (which is defectless) with which Arjuna is able to see the Lord (who is defectless). This is an example of *pratyaksha pramana*.

(ii) Verse 7.7: The Lord states *mayi sarvam idaṁ protaṁ sūtre maṇigaṇā iva* - Everything in the universe is supported by Me, just like a garland of pearls is supported by a string. When one sees a garland of pearls, the string which holds the pearls together is normally not visible. But one can infer the presence of the string as the pearls cannot hold themselves together. This is like inferring the presence of fire on a hill just by watching the smoke from a distance, as smoke will be visible only when there is fire. This is an example of *anumana pramana*.

(iii) Verse 16.24: The Lord states *tasmāc chāstram pramāṇam te kāryākāryavyavasthitau* - Therefore, scriptures are your guide in performing right deeds and avoiding wrong deeds. The Lord states that *shastram* (scriptures) are the *pramanas* (means) to understand right and wrong deeds. This is an example of *agama pramana*.

9. The Lord is knowable through the Vedas

- (i) Verse 7.8: The Lord states *praṇavaḥ sarvavedeṣu* - I am the primordial syllable *Om* in the **Vedas**.
- (ii) Verse 15.15: The Lord states *vedaiś ca sarvair aham eva vedyo* - I am the one exclusively described in all **Vedas**.
- (iii) Verse (15.18): The Lord states *atosmi loke vede ca prathitaḥ puruṣottamaḥ* - I am known as the Supreme Being and described as such in scriptures that are composed (*loka*) and revealed (the **Vedas**).

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31. Mahabharata Tatparya Nirnaya Praveshika [MTNP] by Dr. Kambaluru Venkateshacharya (Kannada Translation-Kambaluru Sameeracharya)